

CINEMA OF SINCERITY

SOVIET
FILMS
AND
CULTURE
DURING
THE
THAW

VIKTORIA
PARANYUK



Cinema of Sincerity

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WISCONSIN FILM STUDIES

Patrick McGilligan, *series editor*

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Cinema of Sincerity

Soviet Films and Culture During the Thaw

VIKTORIA PARANYUK

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For my parents and KC

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Note on Transliteration

Slavic first names and surnames that end in *ii* or *ia* are rendered with a *y* or *ya*, such as Gennady, Khrabrovitsky, and Maya Turovskaya. Similarly, names that begin with *Iu* are changed to *Yu*, such as Yuri. For readability, I have eliminated the soft sign in names, for example, Olga Berggolts rather than Ol'ga Berggol'ts. In the endnotes, I have followed the Library of Congress system of transliteration to make it easier for researchers to locate the sources. I transliterated Georgian names using mostly the LC system with some minor exceptions. For example, instead of LC's transliteration of Abulaže, I use a more accepted Abuladze for the letter *ႁ*.

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Introduction

We are convinced that cinema can express anything, from the poster “Quit Smoking” to philosophical ideas. The question is, how to do it?

—E. Shengelaya and A. Sakharov, interview for *Cinéma 60*

In March 1963 film director Marlen Khutsiev and screenwriter Gennady Shpalikov were summoned by Nikita Khrushchev, along with other members of the Soviet creative intelligentsia, to the Kremlin. Such periodic meetings often portended trouble for the assembled guests.¹ Khutsiev and Shpalikov had recently wrapped *Zastava Il'icha* (*Ilyich's Gate*, sometimes translated as *Lenin's Guard*, Gorky Film Studio, 1962/88), a film whose loose narrative involves a trio of twenty-three-year-old friends—in the spirit of Erich Maria Remarque's “comrades”—navigating the dilemmas of social and personal life in 1960s Moscow.² Khrushchev indicted the film for its title, which, by referring to a neighborhood named after Vladimir Ilyich Lenin, implicated the architect of the October Revolution in what the premier perceived as a portrayal of aimless, passive youth.

At the heart of his fury was a scene between one of the three pals, Sergei, and his dead father, who had perished in war but appears to the protagonist at a time of difficulty. When Sergei asks his father for guidance, the apparition abstains from offering it: Now that Sergei is older than his father was at the time of his death the father cannot instruct Sergei on how to live. “Do you want us to believe in the truthfulness of this episode?” Khrushchev fumed. “Everyone knows that even animals don't abandon their young. . . . How is it possible that a father wouldn't answer his own son and give him advice on finding the right path in life?”³ When it was Khutsiev's turn to speak on behalf of the film's team, he asserted: “While making the picture, not for a second did we have an insincere position and do anything against that which we serve, that is, our country, people, and the party. Our intentions were always sincere. . . . We'll do everything so that the film could play an actual, practical role . . . in the fight against the remnants of the past, the legacy of the personality cult, in the fight for our collective future, Communism.”⁴

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Khutsiev's promise to "do everything" to fix *Ilyich's Gate* may have been partially motivated by his fear of being forbidden to return to the film, thereby sentencing it to being either "shelved" or butchered by a journeyman. But even more striking in the filmmaker's defense was his adamant profession of sincerity—so adamant that he repeated variations of the word twice in the space of two sentences—in his fight as creator against the legacies of Stalinism. Indeed, in his appeal to the leadership, Khutsiev seemed to insist on his and especially the film's sincere position in relation to history.

Although one's sincerity is beyond epistemological verification, there is little reason to doubt the director and his creative team's commitment to Soviet ideology. Besides Khutsiev's avowal at the Kremlin meeting, many scenes in *Ilyich's Gate* corroborate this commitment, including the episode with the dead father. But most important—and why I begin with this anecdote—is that the film itself is an example of what I call a *cinema of sincerity*, an aesthetic that the filmmakers adapted to foreground personal experience, play with the medium's possibilities, and dismantle the effects of Stalin's cult of personality.⁵

In the years after Stalin's death in March 1953, the phrase "cult of personality," together with the "varnishing" of reality, often functioned as a shorthand for the previous era's art that glorified the autocrat and created embellished images of Soviet reality. While moderate criticism of the former leader was par for the course, the party never made it explicit how far artists were permitted to go in their pursuit of demolishing celebratory and hollow representations of socialist life, especially the past. The tension and resulting ambiguity between pledging allegiance to Soviet ideology while seemingly *going too far* in the service of devarnishing representation—so far that representation is vulnerable to being construed as compromising the ideology—lie at the heart of an aesthetic of filmic sincerity. For Khrushchev, the dialogue between generations staged in *Ilyich's Gate* implied a misalignment, a chasm, or, worse, disillusionment. But for Khutsiev and his collaborators, it was an honest portrayal of the Soviet youth who found themselves destabilized, often in a moral quandary, questioning the past, feeling nervous about the future, and searching for answers. In fact, the images comprising the scene—most notably, the framing of the figures in a two-shot and the absence of a cut—suggest the film's attempt to reconcile the historical eras sundered by the disclosure of Stalin's crimes and bring father and son closer. The notion of closeness of the on-screen world either to the past, to everyday reality, or to the viewer became a priority. To express oneself candidly and, as a creator, to embed this sense of candor in the visual and sonic registers of film were part of a new cinematic sensibility.

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This book is about a cinema of sincerity—its aesthetic proclivities, thematic concerns, affective potential, and political promise. As a category and cultural mantra, sincerity reemerged after Stalin's death in the sphere of literature as a call to reinvigorate the language of prose and poetry, was embraced to an extent by artists of all disciplines, and took off following Khrushchev's acknowledgment of Stalin's crimes in 1956, the beginning of the era of de-Stalinization and what came to be known as the Thaw, roughly between 1953 and 1968.⁶

Sincerity has a long history of artistic debate and discussion in Soviet culture. And though others have studied the Thaw films, no one has connected them with and incorporated them into this wider-ranging and long-standing conversation about sincerity. While I draw on more contemporary discussions of candid cinema developed by Stanley Cavell and the notions of absorption and theatricality theorized by Michael Fried, of equal or perhaps even more importance are the rich considerations of sincerity in literary circles and aesthetics. In fact, one of the conceits of this project is to posit film as the art form that manifests what was largely a contemporaneous literary concern to its fullest expression. The monograph is the first in Soviet film studies to take the term "sincerity" seriously.⁷

Sincerity is a notoriously slippery term, irreducible, the philosopher Hent de Vries writes, "to any cognitive, normative, or existential register whose criteria or rules would leave us no room for doubt."⁸ For historian Anatoly Pinsky, who has examined sincerity in Soviet diaristic writing of the 1950s, the notion is tied to a newfound subjectivity. Building on the scholarship of Igal Halfin, Jochen Hellbeck, and other historians, Pinsky views sincerity as "a shorthand for the idea that the Soviet citizen was the source of truth."⁹ Historian of Soviet culture Eleonory Gilburd likewise remarks on the elusiveness of sincerity, for it "could not be known, only implied—a shared secret, forever in the eyes or ears of the beholder, rather than in the text, a behavioral code, which had to be recognized by others."¹⁰ In her analysis of Thaw cinema, Oksana Bulgakowa finds sincerity to be a solely literary category, one that is "highly problematic in the realm of nonverbal arts such as music, painting, sculpture, and film because here it was connected with the *materialization* of the individual gaze. Such a focus on individual authorship did not fit the canonical notion of collective identity, which remained unaffected by the Thaw."¹¹

Indeed, sincerity is fundamentally social in that it requires recognition by another. As Ernst van Alphen and Mieke Bal state in their introduction to *The Rhetoric of Sincerity*, it is "firmly lodged both in personal relations and in public and political tensions."¹² One of my claims is that sincerity in

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film modeled a new sense of sociality and represented a promise of a more ethical conduct in everyday life, bridging the public and private spheres. Sincerity is rooted in the tangle of the individual and the collective, so vital to the Soviet context. But what for Bulgakowa is irreconcilable, I see as generating productive tension that gives the cinema of sincerity its emotional charge. The book suggests that cinema took the “sincere” imperative further than any other art, thanks to the medium’s particular affordances, and gave rise to an aesthetic. What is more, I propose that sincerity’s affective and communicative power lies first and foremost in nonverbal forms of expression rather than vociferous declarations, as we have already seen in the episode with Khutsiev’s film and will see in the following pages. Attenuating the authority of dialogue and the word more generally lies at the heart of sincerity—that is why cinema, a medium of multiple modes of signification, became sincerity’s thriving domain in the Soviet milieu and precisely why, as the book argues, it can be located in a film text.

A Multigenerational Affair

At the book’s center are filmmakers of different generations—Mikhail Romm (1901–71), Tengiz Abuladze (1924–94), Marlen Khutsiev (1925–2019), Arūnas Žebriūnas (1931–2013), and Gennady Shpalikov (1937–74)—who did not belong to the same artistic movements or cohorts, as did, for example, the New Wave or the Left Bank group in France. These filmmakers and a constellation of films they produced between 1956 and 1964 constitute the core of the monograph in order to emphasize the multigenerational nature of cinematic renewal as well as the formal and ethical questions characteristic of the cinema of sincerity; to better explore the distinguishing attributes of filmic sincerity in the center versus the periphery; and to shine a light on several names that are either little known, such as Arūnas Žebriūnas and Gennady Shpalikov, or largely overlooked, such as Mikhail Romm, in the post-Stalin-era film historiography.¹³

In the Soviet film industry, these filmmakers occupied different positions in the hierarchy. Romm’s was that of relative privilege: He had started in the 1930s at Mosfilm and solidified his reputation with the duology *Lenin in October* (*Lenin v Oktiabre*, Mosfilm, 1937) and *Lenin in 1918* (*Lenin v 1918 godu*, Mosfilm, 1939). He was a person “with a past,” to use Maya Turovskaya’s phrase, which alludes to someone who belonged to the older, pre-revolutionary generation of the intelligentsia.¹⁴ Khutsiev had several projects under his belt, including a solo feature, *Dva Fyodora* (*Two Fyodors*, 1958), a film produced at the Odesa Film Studio. Abuladze and Žebriūnas were in comparatively similar professional circumstances, working in Georgia and

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Lithuania, respectively. Their position in the periphery of a centralized industry, together with their distinct national identities, meant that the notion of sincerity acquired an inflection that, I contend, would be expressed in the aesthetic resistance to Soviet socialist realism and thus to the center.

While the above filmmakers form the nucleus in my narrative of the cinema of sincerity, other dramatis personae figure as the supporting yet important cast that contributed to the appearances, sounds, and affective quality of this aesthetic. Among them are cinematographers Margarita Pilikhina, Levan Paataashvili, and Jonas Gričius; scriptwriters Natalya Ryzantseva, Daniil Khrabrovitsky, and Shpalikov; and critics Maya Turovskaya, Neya Zorkaya, and Boris Zingerman.

As the opening anecdote shows, the notion of generational continuity was held dear at the highest level and in Soviet culture more broadly. Undeniably, the continuity between the Stalin era and the Thaw existed in the filmmaking community's personnel and three generations of artists and technicians who worked side by side during the 1950s and 1960s. The trio of greats belonging to the old guard—Vsevolod Pudovkin, Dziga Vertov, and Oleksandr Dovzhenko, “prime animators of revolutionary cinema's first dozen years,” as Annette Michelson has called them—died in quick succession in 1953, 1954, and 1956, respectively.¹⁵ However, many of their peers, among them Romm, Sergei Yutkevich, Ivan Pyriev, and Sergei Gerasimov, remained active.¹⁶ They were members of the industry's elite by virtue of their status as so-called master directors, a designation that under Stalin had bestowed upon them the leader's trust to make “quality” films.¹⁷ More importantly, these established professionals championed young talent. Romm, Yutkevich, and Pyriev were instrumental in instituting the organizational committee of the Filmmakers Union in June 1957, which was the first such professional agency in the Soviet film industry with an official budget and responsibilities.¹⁸ Among many initiatives, the committee founded screenwriting and directing workshops at Mosfilm, the country's largest studio, where under the tutelage of an established figure young filmmakers would learn the ropes of film production and often have their careers launched.¹⁹ The cinematographer Boris Volchek, a member of the old guard who had shot all of Romm's oeuvre up until *Nine Days of One Year*, taught an entire generation of directors of photography across the country, including Pilikhina, German Lavrov, Jonas Gričius, and Levan Paataashvili.

Directors Khutsiev and Abuladze, born in the 1920s, belonged to the “generation of lieutenants”: Many from this younger cohort had fought in World War II and made their first films when they were already in their thirties.²⁰ Coming closely behind was the youngest group, those born in the 1930s.

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Shpalikov, Larisa Shepitko, Kira Muratova, Mikhail Kalik, Yuri Illienko, Žebriūnas, and others, buoyed by their older colleagues, would be responsible for the efflorescence of Soviet cinema during the 1960s, recalling the creative surge of the postrevolutionary avant-garde.

What connects the films gathered under the constellation of the cinema of sincerity are the twin and at first glance distant coordinates: a character's interiority and surfaces of ordinary objects and phenomena. Both are traceable to the ideas that emerged in postwar European film theories of realism, most notably those of André Bazin and Siegfried Kracauer. Questions of ontology and the medium's "affinities," to use Kracauer's word, are some of these thinkers' preoccupations, calling on the cinema to reveal, redeem, discover—the verbs often used in their quest—the big and the small, that which usually eludes notice in what we identify as reality.²¹ Francesco Casetti delineates the contributions of the two theorists as "two different formulations of the same need: on the one hand, an *existential realism*, connected with cinema's possibility of participating in the life of the world, on the other, a *functional realism*, connected with the medium's ability to reproduce the outlines and document the existence of things."²² The Soviet cinema of sincerity displays this double need—to participate and model a new form of sociality and to notice things—which formally resulted in moving away from the sanctioned variety of realism.

Lilya Kaganovsky has suggested that the young generation of filmmakers in the 1960s created a "counter-cinema" that "radically broke with Soviet cinematic convention."²³ While Kaganovsky, following an auteurist approach, binds the idea of a Soviet counter-cinema to a director's idiosyncratic vision, I expand the view of film practice to include cinematographers and scriptwriters, moving my study beyond the auteur studies lens.²⁴ A counter-aesthetic was certainly in evidence; the book proposes, however, that it arose in its clearest and most distinctive form in the periphery rather than at Mosfilm or Lenfilm (the main studio in Leningrad) in the works of such filmmakers as Abuladze, Žebriūnas, and Muratova. Moreover, the book focuses on the intersection of contemporary anxieties about the past, navigating the present, and a realist aesthetic that was motivated by the appeal for sincerity in art, an appeal answered to a considerable extent not only by young but by all generations of cineasts. This vernacular realist aesthetic, which I am framing as the distinguishing stylistic feature of the cinema of sincerity, strove to reproduce a sense of spontaneity and immediacy of events and action, of gestures and speech, and of flow of images and sounds, emulating what Kracauer calls "the concept of 'flow of life' . . . which covers the stream of material situations and happenings with all that

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they intimate in terms of emotions, values, thoughts.”²⁵ Soviet cinema of sincerity notices details of physical reality that until now were irrelevant, subsumed by the varnish and demands of ideology. Such films allow for, to quote Kracauer, the capture of “physical existence in its endlessness,” which, given their continuing commitment to narrative practice, even if that practice was being revised, often engenders unconventional form. The films that embrace this aesthetic display formal awkwardness that is distinct from the customary temporal and narrative unity of socialist realist representation. Their untidy shape—formal hybridity, the unresolved, the ill-fitting—is where sincerity reveals itself. Thus, in aesthetic terms, the cinema of sincerity is a cinema of uneven form and open endings.

Messy Life and Distrust of Language

The filmmakers at the center of my story wrestled with realism, particularly with how to expand its communicative and affective reach. Their formal and narrative explorations demonstrate that a mode of realism based on a holistic grasp of external reality, which sits at the core of socialist realism, became deficient and limiting. In the wake of the Second World War and of the revelations of the past crimes perpetrated on behalf of the state, in conjunction with a more global trend toward modernist aesthetics, satisfactory on-screen representations of reality as experienced in the lives of ordinary people could not be rendered in the perfectly coherent manner that socialist realism demanded. There was a sense that reality comprised a multitude; certainly, there was a reality tied to an individual’s perceptions. Realism had to accommodate interior, intimate, experiential states, which at best could offer singular fragments of the real informed by one’s consciousness without claims to forming a unity or totality.²⁶

Throughout the book, I show how the cinema of sincerity sought to codify the impression of artlessness against all odds. It allowed what audiences recognized as the messiness of life, whether it was dialogue that sounded unrehearsed or the jostling of a handheld camera into the convention of narrative cinema, and thereby substantially revised viewer-screen relations established by the official aesthetic method. The cinema of sincerity utilized formal procedures and devices, such as the close-up, the handheld camera, the interior monologue, the devaluation of speech, and the staging of both intimate and crowd scenes. It did so in order to place ordinary characters’ experiences at the forefront, build a connection with audiences and regain their trust after decades of serving the personality cult, and, perhaps most important, create an intersubjective space that acknowledged shared experience affectively. By revising the permitted thematic and aesthetic boundaries

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of realism, Soviet cinema was reasserting its promise as a committed art form and offering up its own sincerity.

For filmmakers, the revision of realism often meant *getting closer to life*, a phrase that resounded in literary and film criticism and was invoked by Khrushchev himself.²⁷ If in official discourse, getting closer to life was framed within the confines of ideology, for the filmmakers I count as animators of the cinema of sincerity, it evoked what Kracauer vividly describes as the desire “to touch reality not only with the fingertips but to seize it and shake hands with it.”²⁸ For Khutsiev and Pilikhina, who lensed *Ilyich's Gate*, a sense of spontaneity created by emulating a live TV broadcast, by capturing the *mise-en-scènes* with crowds, and by embracing the stream of urban reality became as indispensable in their making of the cinema of sincerity as the lightweight, handheld camera was for cinema verité practitioners. Shpalikov, coauthor of the *Ilyich's Gate* screenplay, set great store by fraught and searching characters: He packed their speech with incongruous details, introducing character self-doubt and self-reflection and providing space for intense interiority, an important signifier of cinematic sincerity, as viewers were invited nearer to characters and frequently inside their minds.



May Day parade, 1961, first day of filming *Ilyich's Gate*

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In some cases, especially in films made at peripheral studios, getting closer to life connoted getting away from overtly Soviet emblems and values and instead engaging local narrative and visual traditions in addition to capturing the physical world. Tengiz Abuladze and the cinematographer Levan Paatashvili, similar to their Italian colleagues in the immediate post-war years, turned for inspiration to newspaper stories about ordinary people, which precipitated *Skhvisi shvilebi* (*Other People's Children*, Kartuli Pilmi/Georgia Film, 1959). Set in Tbilisi, the film is about, among other things, a taboo love; it captured the old city and its residents with such exuberance and observation that it rendered them virtually indistinguishable from neo-realist images, leaving Moscow censors uncomfortable. The camera of Jonas Gričius in Žebriūnas's *Paskutinė atostogu diena* (*The Girl and the Echo*, also known as *The Last Day of Vacation*, Lietuvos kino studija / Lithuanian Film Studio, 1964) explores the natural environment in intimate particulars, at one point even descending under the sea. The location of the story is identified by its physiognomy rather than by its geopolitical location, while its temporality, although exhibiting signs of modernity, is potentially ambiguous. Both the Georgian and Lithuanian films, narratively and visually, shut out the intrusion of the dominant mode of representation and storytelling. They adapt cinematic sincerity by refracting it into aesthetic codes that, unlike films produced in the center, attenuate Soviet ideology and reality and offer the potential for resistance, specifically at the level of mise-en-scène and framing. Although initiated from the center, the cult of sincerity nonetheless radiated to the republics, taking on local imperatives and vernacular poetics, which this monograph illuminates.²⁹

Getting closer to life involved not only a seemingly impromptu flow of recorded reality and subjective framing, or the removal of the visual trappings of ideology, but also an examination of the primary role of language as the conveyor of truth over all other forms of signification and affect. Taken as a whole, the cinema of sincerity diminished the value of smoothly delivered dialogue and overall loquaciousness so integral to Stalin-era movies, which reflected a broader distrust of language in Thaw culture. Historians Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd observe that at the core of this epoch was a crisis of language. Soviet “propagandistic language” lost vitality and credence because of “its inability to describe, let alone explain, the central phenomenon in the country’s recent history, the mass violence that now attracted increasingly critical attention. . . . To discuss the human costs of the Soviet past, writers, journalists, and their readers had to find different words.”³⁰ Language had always been at the forefront of the censorship apparatus, a practice that stemmed from the historical importance of the

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word in Russian culture and the long-established privileging of literature among the arts since the inception of the Soviet state.³¹ Soviet cinema, Mikhail Lampolski asserts, is rooted in the literary tradition, emphasizing “the hero’s psychology, the nature of social conflicts or narrative collisions,” and ignoring that film is “also a dance of light, space, sound, face and body on the screen.”³² Soviet cinema’s logocentricity extended to its habitual treatment by critics and censors, which is amply demonstrated by Khrushchev’s attack on *Ilyich’s Gate*; the first party secretary targeted the conversation between father and son rather than other aspects of the scene that were more cinematic and therefore less transparent to interpretation and criticism.³³

The characters of the cinema of sincerity often hem and haw, are silent, play with language, or turn to poetry instead of uttering glib lines of dialogue, particularly when they are at a crossroads or otherwise defining moment. Words often fail them. When one of the protagonists in *Nine Days of One Year* gazes directly and silently at the viewer after a momentous scientific discovery, his look can be read as exculpatory, anxious, or resigned. But most important, the character’s weighted speechlessness suggests an overlap between different modes of thought and invites the spectator both to be *with* the character’s experience and perhaps to reflect in silence on the matter of scientific progress, an especially urgent topic during the Cold War’s nuclear arms race. The cinema of sincerity does not spell things out; instead, it summons the audience to connect the dots. It also strives to create a shared experience, to make itself legible, to be taken seriously—to once again “give significance to the possibilities of film,” to turn to Stanley Cavell’s phrase.³⁴

In some instances, protagonists do not speak much to begin with, such as in the films featuring children, who place little importance in linguistic communication and instead prefer other forms of expression. In a moment that challenges the transparency of language, the young heroine of *The Girl and the Echo*, to cheer herself up, dials random numbers on a payphone, says hello, giggles, and hangs up. At this juncture in the story, she has just been betrayed by a friend in a humiliating fashion, which sends her ambling along the beach and eventually to the protective enclosure of a phone booth, where she invents the game of dialing strangers. While establishing the importance of human connection, the scene—and the entire film—simultaneously impairs the preeminent stature of language and its sense-making function. The cinema of sincerity, with its tendency for communication via nonlinguistic registers, undermines Soviet film’s entrenched logocentricity.

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The Past and the Problem of Realism

On February 25, 1956, in a closed meeting at the Twentieth Congress of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, Nikita Khrushchev famously delivered his so-called Secret Speech, “On the Cult of Personality and Its Consequences.” While the hesitant “thawing” of Soviet culture had begun before this momentous event, the speech was the first instance of the party’s direct criticism of Stalin. In the spirit of the disclosure, Khrushchev alluded to the enormous death toll of the 1930s purges and the devastating military losses of World War II, intimating the former commander in chief’s military ineptitude.³⁵ This was a major blow to the cult of personality, with far-ranging consequences that reverberated beyond the USSR and the Socialist Bloc.

Among the many transformations Soviet society witnessed during the Thaw was the changed attitude toward the past. The premier’s speech unleashed a revisionist impulse toward the formative years of the Soviet state, or, to use Katerina Clark’s classification of temporality in the socialist realist novel, the Heroic Age.³⁶ Now, elbowing into the Great Time of the Past were the atrocities committed by the former leader. While the Secret Speech had a number of objectives, among them the shoring up of Khrushchev’s own power, historian Polly Jones remarks that it was “primarily debated within the leadership and presented to the Party and public as a reckoning with the past.”³⁷ Denis Kozlov describes Thaw culture as “a retreat to the past in search of an ideal,” linking it to a “nostalgia for stability and cohesion in an increasingly pensive and self-critical society. . . . What started as the public re-evaluation of Stalinism gradually resulted in a much broader historical self-questioning.”³⁸ “Stalinism had implied a constant expansion in time and space; it recognized no reversals,” Vladislav Zubok writes. “The past was only the springboard for another leap into the future,” he continues. “In contrast, Khrushchev was now asking people to return to the past. This request meant that despite the bloodshed and sacrifice of millions, the communist ‘train’ had been moving in the wrong direction.”³⁹ This unsettling process of examination, which entailed a reconsideration of history, was imperative to many artists and intellectuals. Its details and extent, however, quickly turned into a battleground, pitting the party’s vision against that of the more liberal segments of society, the creative intelligentsia in particular.⁴⁰

As a consequence of the breakdown of the teleological narrative of Soviet history, judgments about what constituted reality were reevaluated, scrutinized, and reflected upon. Discerning the new rules of engagement with reality also meant working out the new rules of a modern realist aesthetic,

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as the official and solely permitted artistic method, socialist realism, could no longer adequately respond to the world in the age of postwar catastrophes and the disclosure of Stalin's crimes. The stakes at issue in the search for a more pliable form of realism, then, concern a revision of the socialist realist norms of representation and, by way of this revised mode of realism, the vanquishing of the demons of Stalinism. The undermining of forward historical development and its subsequent reorientation toward other temporal modalities had crucial implications for film.

The filmmakers considered in this book were *deforming* realism's previous shape, to use Roman Jakobson's term. For them, realism was not a fixed style but a drive toward a greater verisimilitude that would result in a recurring deformation of convention. When recognition of convention becomes instantaneous and automatic, a new metaphor, an unexpected detail, an unusual composition, or any other element must be introduced to subvert our automatic interpretation of a visual or literary representation and retune our perception and understanding of realism.⁴¹ As such, realism has an intrinsic need for change. Cinema was a space where filmmakers could channel this essential need of codes of realism for innovation into creative ways of engaging with the past and adapting new aesthetic perspectives.

Soviet theorists of art had long upheld realism's epistemological function, despite often inscrutable formulations of what came to be identified as socialist realism, such as that offered by Stalin's chief ideologue, Andrei Zhdanov, at the First Congress of Soviet Writers in 1934: Art should "represent life truthfully," but not "in a dead, scholastic way, not simply as 'objective reality,' but . . . in its revolutionary development."⁴² From the start, then, the bounds of socialist realism were at once set and highly unstable. In the context of historical materialism, similar to science, art was both a means of apprehending the external world and a form of social consciousness. This ideological framework of realism considers external reality primary, while consciousness (artistic manipulation of reality) becomes secondary, which in turn can be seen as an aesthetic analogue of the primacy of content and the ancillary order of form.⁴³ In 1953 Soviet art historian and critic German Nedoshivin reminded his readers that reality, "existing independently from and outside consciousness, serves as art's source of images, of materials, without which art cannot exist."⁴⁴ Thus, the external material world is art's only viable wellspring. When art breaks away from reality, claimed pundits of socialist realism, it distorts reality or, worse, art's content lacks any meaning.⁴⁵ In official rhetoric, the tenets of realism remained the same during the Thaw. As formulated twenty years prior, genuine socialist realist art appealed to and was understood by all, an attribute known as *narodnost'*, or

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of the masses; it upheld ideological commitment (*ideinost'*), served the goals of the party (*partiinnost'*), and educated citizens using these tenets.⁴⁶ But the fact that the Soviets pressed on with insisting that there was an objective, shared reality and that Soviet life should be represented in art without embellishment was a symptom of a culture in crisis.

After the Secret Speech, the metaphor of varnishing (*lakirovka*) was frequently but ambiguously invoked at the highest levels of the cultural apparatus and in the media to criticize Stalin-era art. At this time, cinematic varnish, first and foremost, referred to the superficial embellishment in depicting socialist life, making it shine with an almost grotesque gleam. In cinema, a varnished image par excellence applied to representations enhanced with lavish props and sets, such as in Ivan Pyriev's musical bonbon *Kubanskii kazaki* (*The Cossacks of the Kuban*, Mosfilm, 1950), where the images of plenty in a Soviet village were glaringly misaligned with the perilous state of the Soviet rural economy and the famines.⁴⁷ Surface "coating" of a gloss, however, was just one specific instance of falsification. Arguably, the greater varnishing was the freezing of the filmic portrait of Stalin into a living god in *Kliatva* (*The Vow*, Tbilisi Film Studio, 1946) and *Padenie Berlina* (*The Fall of Berlin*, Mosfilm, 1949), "a transition toward transcendency—a myth," wrote André Bazin in 1950.⁴⁸ The young Soviet critic Yuri Khaniutin noted during the heyday of the varnish debate that substituting false details with more veridical ones was easy, but credible psychological development of characters still presented difficulties to those striving for unvarnished cinematic representation.⁴⁹ Among filmmakers and new critics there was a sense that the varnish of Stalinist realism prevented any closeness, be it closeness to the past, of characters to each other, or to people's experiences of reality. Indeed, there were superficial as well as deeper layers of accumulated polish/untruths that could not always be articulated and hastily "scraped" off.

Fredric Jameson points out two irreconcilable interpretations of realism that have evolved in literary theory and, by extension, film studies. One, elaborated by Georg Lukács and Erich Auerbach, frames realism as a "privileged mode of knowing the world we live in and the lives we lead in it."⁵⁰ This mode is grounded in a particular relationship between reality and representation, where the possibility of such a representation is never in doubt. The proponents of the other interpretation of realism, which emerged with the rise of literary and visual modernisms, the discoveries of relativity and quantum mechanics, criticize the Lukács-Auerbach model, for it presupposes the existence of a commonsense, objective reality "independent of us, and that knowing it involves the relatively unproblematical process of getting an adequate picture of it into our own heads."⁵¹ This second interpretation,

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exemplified in literature by Renato Poggioli and Nathalie Sarraute, though not refuting realism altogether, seeks to redraw its boundaries. During the Soviet Thaw, the modernist account of realism as such did not exist, as modernism remained an undifferentiated, negative category on the official platform, traditionally cast not merely as realism's opposite but as its foremost foe, one that threatened socialist realism and therefore had to be vanquished.⁵²

On the one hand, the party and cultural authorities promoted a kind of realism that rested on what was known as reflection theory and its simplified interpretation of the relationship between reality and image.⁵³ In this framework, Soviet past and present reality could still be explained and rendered coherently—and it was, repeatedly so. On the other, creators' aspiration to strip the Stalinist varnish off filmed images to get closer to reality, whether its external or internal variation, suggested a different form of realism that perhaps diverged from the Soviet episteme.

My book is most interested in how realism was treated in practice; how its enduring demand for verisimilitude and need for aesthetic transfiguration interacted in an era when many categories, such as the past, others, and the self, were being questioned; how the notion of getting closer to life invoked, if superficially, by the establishment and genuinely embraced by the filmmakers came to manifest itself on the screen. Devin Fore has observed that realism, “irrespective of its historical epoch, is typically understood to provide collective codes over personal style, intersubjective communication over individualistic mannerism—in sum, mimesis over poesis.”⁵⁴ As the codes of realist representation were shifting in Soviet culture, “sincere” films seem to have been caught in constant negotiation between the collective and the individual, the universal and the particular, the experimental and the conventional.

The rather traditional narrative of *Me, Bebia, Iliko da Ilarioni* (*Me, Grandma, Iliko, and Ilarioni*, Georgia Film, 1962) displays startling instances of experimentation, such as the scene in which the villagers gather to say goodbye to the men going off to the Great Patriotic War. The perennial wind ensemble, consisting of the locals, the majority of whom are about to depart to the front lines, contributes to the occasion. Once the trucks take the men away, the camera stays on those left behind. A series of shots is composed of the remaining villagers—young and old, in pairs and solo, standing still as if posing for a photograph. They are juxtaposed with the images of the musical instruments lying silently on the dusty road. Following the commotion of the farewell, these stark tableaux deliver an emotional wallop, momentarily halt the narrative's progression, and overstep realism's more conventional form. The scene conveys the pathos of a collective sense of grief as

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experienced by this small community in Georgia. The structure of *Nine Days of One Year*, proceeding from a selection of random days, suggests incompleteness, while the personal voices and free indirect subjectivity of the characters unsettle the authority of the film's disembodied narrator. *Other People's Children* demonstrates a heady mix of French poetic realism, Italian neorealism, the visual poetics of the Soviet avant-garde, and vernacular Georgian style, a combination that comes across as somewhat stylistically incoherent, fragmentary, yet visually and narratively exuberant, creating an affective bond with the audience. The crowd sequences set in actual locations in *Ilyich's Gate*, most notably the Pushkin Museum of Art and the Polytechnical Museum, disrupt any pretensions to contain the film's fictional world. The sun-speckled sea in *The Girl and the Echo* may or may not exist outside the heroine's magical world. In all these instances, in a variety of ways, the films seem to contravene the norms of socialist realism, which stipulated that reproduced reality and a personal experience had to, above all, typify larger tendencies.⁵⁵ The films are unequivocally devoted to realist representation; however, the aesthetic and narrative mode they espouse diverges enough from the previous era's realism to warrant a closer look. And what such looking elucidates is that the Stalin-era varnish covered both the surface of things, to return to Kracauer, and the experiential dimension of reality associated with the subjective, the interior. The cinema of sincerity reveals that perhaps the way to "the evasive contents of inner life . . . leads through the experience of surface reality."⁵⁶ Consequently, to remove the varnish was to expose reality's fragmentariness and brokenness and, ultimately, to question its very existence.

Soviet Sincerity and the Legacy of European Romanticism

Sincerity reemerged as a concern for the creative intelligentsia in the early 1950s after it had fallen out of favor from its introduction in the late 1930s during the campaign for the lyric.⁵⁷ Writing in 1953, the poet Olga Berggolts lamented the absence of the emotional dimension in lyric poetry in her seminal article "A Conversation About the Lyric."⁵⁸ For Berggolts, sincerity was inseparable from the individuality of a poet "speaking from his own 'I'" and expressing "most fully and sincerely his intimate and multifaceted feelings, thoughts, and aspirations."⁵⁹ She implored her comrades in arms to distinguish between *individualism*, seen by Berggolts and her compatriots as "bourgeois" worship of personality, and *individuality*, a designation of a flesh-and-blood person with an inner life. At the center of Berggolts's argument were demands for expression of feeling, recalling English Romanticism and Russian poetry of the early nineteenth century. In her call for the

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expansion of the lyric's thematic and formal aspects, the poet championed a more distinctive and vulnerable authorial voice. Berggolts wished to hear the humanity of that voice, free from the pathos of overfulfilling a harvest plan, milk production, and other typical scenes of Soviet poetry, and thus promoted a new kind of subjectivity.⁶⁰ In a few years, character voices in the cinema of sincerity likewise would claim importance by asserting individuality and revealing the strained relationship between the authority of voice-over commentary and the ordinary person's inner monologue.

Several months later, Berggolts's entreaty echoed in the more urgent notes of "On Sincerity in Literature," a *Novyi mir* article by the little-known author Vladimir Pomerantsev.⁶¹ This text launched a period of volatile debates on the value and meaning of the term that arguably shaped cultural discourse for the remainder of the decade and beyond.⁶²

Pomerantsev criticized the "varnishing of reality," conflict-free narratives, and stock protagonists in much of postwar Soviet prose.⁶³ Sincerity's innermost and confidential aspect emerges in his appeal to writers to strive toward "confession and not only sermonizing" (*k ispovedi, a ne tol'ko k propovedi*), thereby reorienting literary fiction inward and toward more intimate expression.⁶⁴ Pomerantsev's appeal points out that in Soviet culture, in addition to the lack of hypocrisy, sincerity implied a sense of fellowship. Indeed, unlike in English, in the Russian language, sincerity has a connotation of intimacy and closeness. Kozlov notes that, whereas in English, "sincerity," from the Latin *sincerus*, "presumes the absence of hypocrisy or external influence," the etymology for the Russian counterpart, *iskrennost'*, "primarily originates from the Old Slavonic *iskr* or *iskren*, meaning 'close' or 'proximate.'"⁶⁵ Svetlana Boym likewise emphasizes the Slavic root of *iskrennost'*, which "suggests kinship, proximity, closeness; it may be related to the word for 'root'—*koren*'—making Russian sincerity appear more 'radical.'"⁶⁶ Kozlov maintains that Pomerantsev was aware of sincerity's Slavic connotation of closeness in addition to genuineness and that he advocated literature that would establish "not only truth but also an emotional bond between the author and readers, as well as among readers as a community."⁶⁷ Soviet sincerity, then, was never solely a call for individual expression; instead, it sought recognition from the like-minded.

Ultimately, Pomerantsev did not define the term but instead offered several related keywords that, together with Berggolts's call for the lyric, concretize its modes of use in artistic endeavor and that I take up to theorize sincerity as an aesthetic convention in cinema. Pomerantsev drew attention to the fundamental constructedness of a literary text and singled out sincerity as a measure of the reader's engagement with the work. He pointed out,

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for example, that the reason the genre of the epistolary novel had enjoyed great popularity in the eighteenth century was “because a private letter seemed the most candid”; but once readers could sense that the correspondence had been made for their amusement and not for the imagined recipient, the jig was up.⁶⁸ For Pomerantsev, sincerity of an artwork lied in how the creative object engaged and positioned the viewer. He proposed a “degree of sincerity” as the fundamental criterion for evaluating a novel or short story; for him, this measurement resided in the literary text’s “immediacy” (*neposredstvennost’*), which would oppose and be in tension with its inescapable constructedness.⁶⁹

Sincerity’s epistemological unreliability soon thrust Pomerantsev’s article into the political sphere. If the word designated a shared, if approximate, understanding of the specific emotional and intimate aspect in instances of private life (synonymous with truthfulness, lack of hypocrisy, and closeness), then its enactment as an artistic practice was wide open. As such, questions of what a “sincere” literary work or film might look and sound like worried ideologues, so they treated the call for sincerity with skepticism. One such critic labeled it a “recipe from inappropriate sources” without specifying which but alleging its nonsocialist (i.e., “bourgeois”) origins.⁷⁰ The word itself—sincerity—smacked of individualism, auteurism, and thus intellectual independence. It appears as though in the official evaluation the term quickly came to connote an antisocialist attitude.

Having emerged in the milieu of the creative intelligentsia rather than at the top, the call for sincerity was never party oriented. Quite the opposite: Sincerity was associated with an “I” and the rank and file, thereby implicitly placing the official narrative of history (the “we”), with its fixation on the largely anonymous masses and mythologized leaders, under suspicion. In the films considered in this book, characters’ voices, thoughts, behavior, perceptions embody the notion of sincerity while the onrush of reality’s images and sounds construct the world around and inside them that suggests the possibility of a genuine community.

As a critical category and a measure of artistic merit in Western culture, sincerity’s genealogy stretches back at least to the Enlightenment, although Lionel Trilling assigns the quality of sincerity to a number of Shakespearean characters, above all, Hamlet and, unexpectedly, Polonius.⁷¹ In his *Confessions*, Jean-Jacques Rousseau immortalized the cult of sincerity, attempting to recount disinterestedly events and experiences that had shaped him. Herbert Read notes that Rousseau abandoned the manuscript when he found it “too tormenting to himself, too insincere.”⁷² Confession “is not self-analysis. . . . Confession naturally takes the form of a narrative—a narrative

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about oneself.”⁷³ Sincerity implies a person’s unawareness of it, Read observes. “A contradiction exists between self-consciousness and sincerity. To be conscious of a self, vis-à-vis other selves, is already to expose that self to corruption. It is not possible to separate the self from others without creating a false entity.”⁷⁴ In other words, can one fully be aware of being oneself and one’s own sincerity? But when it concerns aesthetic codes, which is one of this book’s main interests, Read locates the source of candidness in the precision of words that are called uniquely upon to describe one’s perceptions and feelings. “The feeling for the value of the words helps to define the feeling itself. . . . The common failure is to allow habitual words and phrases . . . to determine and deform the feelings. The whole exercise is one of exquisite perception and instinctive judgement,” explains Read enigmatically.⁷⁵ He likens this complicated artistic activity to a child’s discovery of the world. A young child’s everyday encounters with the environment are completely absorptive in their newness and a sense of wonder. This experience also involves the newness of words themselves, “the first association of a particular word with a particular thing, the word itself *as a thing*.”⁷⁶ The observation leads Read to poetry as a medium par excellence that allows for the recovery of this primal vision and childlike intensity of experience.

In Romantic poetry, sincerity’s equivalence to ardent conviction expressed through feeling was valued above all else. Connected to passionate expression emanating from the poet, the candidness of Romantic verse was the natural outcome of a “spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings,” as articulated by William Wordsworth and embraced by fellow poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge.⁷⁷ Thus, poetic language arose from intense inner experience rather than from its simulation and fabrication. Such flow could not be manufactured but only captured, revealed, and mediated by the author’s singular choice of words. In his study of sincerity and authenticity in European modern culture, Trilling describes sincerity as “a congruence between avowal and actual feeling.”⁷⁸ The Romantic ideal that the poet “means what he says” nurtured by poets themselves became synonymous with the quality of being genuine, yourself.

Versions of literary Romanticism—English, German, and Russian—formed an important part of the intellectual heritage upon which Thaw culture drew.⁷⁹ Eleonory Gilburd avers that the Soviet sincerity of the 1950s “recycled Romantic tropes. Its synonyms were immediacy and instinctiveness.”⁸⁰ Pomerantsev’s article corroborates this when the author discusses confession as a form of expression of one’s thoughts and its seeming spontaneity that comes off as sincere in a literary work. It is no accident that Berggolts, writing about the lyric and pleading with her colleagues to insert

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an “I” in their verses, invoked the great Romantic poets of early nineteenth-century Russia, Alexander Pushkin and Mikhail Lermontov, and asserted that “excess of the inner subjective element” in their work “is a mark of their humanity.”⁸¹ The Romantic identification of sincerity with a powerful overflow of feelings resonates strongly with how Soviet cinema mobilized its audiovisual possibilities, particularly with the Thaw’s turn to ordinary individuals and their inner worlds.

Pictorially, this Romantic quality of spontaneous emotion—and, crucially, a clear relation between inside and outside—is similar to what Ernst Gombrich calls “a ritualized gesture.” In his lecture “Ritualized Gesture and Expression in Art,” Gombrich discusses the evolution and transformation—ritualization—of action and behavior into art. A ritualized gesture in both life and the visual arts conveys a “correspondence between inwardness and outward sign.”⁸² In art a ritualized gesture is a convention that is meant to compel the beholder to discern an inward disposition in an outward expression. But a convention can harden to the point where it not only is unable to produce emotion but actually fails to express it in the first place. “It takes Rembrandt,” the art historian says, “to repeat a ritualized gesture in a way that is felt to be charged with genuine expression, not *only* a ritual, but a symptom as well.”⁸³ When executed in an inspired manner, a gesture fuses form and content, producing an indissoluble relationship between emotion and its outward appearance.

Gombrich’s recipe for overcoming the *hard* ritualization of emotion in the visual arts recalls Read’s “feeling for the value of the words” in literature. It is the labor of the artist that breathes life into a conventionalized, lifeless gesture. The art historian’s formulation is akin as well to Trilling’s description of sincerity as a unity between avowal and feeling: The signifying power of the form of display is such that it leaves little doubt as to what is expressed; moreover, this expression is candid. Gombrich thus treats a ritualized gesture not as a secure proposition that can be easily reproduced by multiple artists but rather as a mercurial process of alternating conventionalization and renewal that depends on the contingencies of artistic labor.⁸⁴ In other words, it cannot be set forever but undergoes a continual evolution.

The emblematic gestures of the cinema of sincerity that mark it as “sincere” involve a *mise-en-scène* with crowds that function not as a monolithic, geometrically arranged backdrop for the main action but as the main action itself. A crowd as an organism that gives a film the texture of aliveness and spontaneity, characters lost in thought and often unable to articulate their feelings verbally, and the scenes where the image and sound register—by

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way of camerawork, editing, and sound recording—convey the unpolished, unscripted, and immediate qualities of one's being in the world. All or some of these gestures populate to a great extent the films I place in the constellation of the cinema of sincerity.

In elucidating this concept, my book pursues three main objectives. First, it questions the persistent assumption that Soviet cinema was controlled and directed in a top-down manner.⁸⁵ Certainly, the multilevel approval process to get a film made created an obstacle course for filmmakers and reflected the highly bureaucratic system of governance. From 1953 to 1963 the administration of cinema resided in the newly created Ministry of Culture, with functions divided between the Department of Cinema and Department of Film Exhibition and Distribution.⁸⁶ The minister of culture answered to the chairman of the Council of Ministers, but the ultimate authority lay with the Department of Culture and Department of Ideology of the Central Committee of the Communist Party.⁸⁷ After 1963 the oversight of the industry was transferred to the Cinema Committee assembled under the auspices of the Council of Ministers. At the lower rung of the governing structure were artistic councils, a mandatory fixture at each studio. Instituted in 1940, these units of localized censorship consisted of actors, editors, directors, and other studio personnel.⁸⁸ The first step up the tall ladder of production was the approval of a screenplay proposal by the studio's artistic council.⁸⁹ However, activities generated by the community of young film critics, the aesthetic visions that came to fruition on the screen not only in the center but also, most important, in the republics, and individual figures who circumvented restrictions of a repressive environment urge us to look beyond state-bound perspectives. In a reweighing of standard accounts of Soviet film history, my approach diminishes the influence of the centralized Russian state while highlighting the role of individual actors.

Second, my book aims to continue to dispel the presumption that filmmakers' creative pursuits during this period were so constrained by the state apparatus of cinema that individual films do not merit serious analysis. The growing interest in the culture of the Soviet Thaw in the last dozen years has produced exciting scholarship. Among the key contributions that I draw upon in historicizing my examination of film practice and culture are two edited collections, Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd's *The Thaw: Soviet Society and Culture During the 1950s and 1960s* (2013) and Anne E. Gorsuch and Diane P. Koenker's *The Socialist Sixties: Crossing Borders in the Second World* (2013), as well as Gilburd's monograph *To See Paris and Die: The Soviet Lives of Western Culture* (2018). Particularly valuable is how Kozlov

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and Gilburd situate the Thaw: within a wide interpretative context, including Russian history, human rights activism, the sacrifices of the Second World War, transnational cultural exchange, material life, and disintegration of the entrenched literary and propagandistic language.⁹⁰

While there has been a recent swell in research on the Soviet 1950s and 1960s, monographs addressing post-Stalin cinema continue to be scarce in Anglophone scholarship. Josephine Woll's *Real Images: Soviet Cinema and the Thaw* (2000) remains indispensable. Lida Oukaderova's *The Cinema of the Soviet Thaw: Space, Materiality, Movement* (2017) and Marco Dumančić's *Men out of Focus: The Soviet Masculinity Crisis in the Long Sixties* (2021) are two notable exceptions published in the last few years that furnish sustained analysis of Thaw films.⁹¹ Unlike Woll's volume, which provides a survey of post-Stalin cinema and thus necessarily condenses the era and film descriptions into summaries, *Cinema of Sincerity's* narrower scope offers a deeper and more sustained engagement with each film representative of the cinema of sincerity. I show that filmmakers of different generations, in the center and periphery, revised viewer-screen relations and transformed realism into a capacious aesthetic mode. By focusing mostly on individual actors and their work rather than state institutions, the book reflects a crucial shift in post-Stalin culture itself, which witnessed a turn away from the faceless masses or titanic leaders toward ordinary individuals, their experiences and diurnal concerns.

In *The Cinema of the Soviet Thaw*, Oukaderova develops the notion of spatiality as her study's central focus and gives a revelatory close reading of a set of films, enhancing them with theoretical inquiry. Dumančić's research provides a wide-ranging investigation of masculinity and overall changes in gender roles in the Soviet cultural context of the 1960s through a rigorous analysis of plot, story, themes, character psychology, and other narrative elements in popular Soviet movies. In conversation with these invaluable studies, my book contributes several additional dimensions of significance to the period's film culture. It expands the view beyond Russian spaces and central studios to include cinemas of Georgia and Lithuania while attending to the center/periphery problematic, illuminates connections and divergences in critical discourses on realism, theorizes the concept of sincerity in relation to film form, and argues that the Soviet cinema of sincerity temporarily abandoned the tradition of logocentricity. The book is invested in close reading as a method that places sincerity in the sphere of aesthetics and that reveals the category's multivalency rather than shutting it within empty sloganeering.⁹²

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Finally, the monograph treats sincerity as both an aesthetic and a theoretical concept. It does not give sincerity superficial thematic and characterological treatment but delves into how the aesthetic plays out in these films. Though inextricable from the milieu of the Thaw and a vernacular approach to revising the boundaries of realism that hinged on shedding the Stalin-era varnish, sincerity was not merely a parochial, Soviet concern. Rather, it was an appropriation and reworking of a trend in global cinema that sought to bridge the gap between lived reality and the filmed image, which was an increasingly pointed area of unease in the post-Stalin context, since the two realities had obscenely diverged in the preceding decades. As such, it can be productively considered in relation to a trend seen in several cinematic waves that rolled across the world in search of heterogeneous representations of reality, among them Italian neorealism and the Left Bank group in France. Placing Soviet sincerity in conversation with the postwar theories of filmic realism elaborated by André Bazin, whose writings would be familiar, if selectively, to Soviet critics, offers insight into the struggles of a materialist epistemology to define cinematic realism—in particular, cinema's unbridgeable gap between the world and the photographic image.⁹³

I begin with theories of realism and film criticism and proceed to the case studies in a trajectory that moves from the center to the peripheries, where local concerns, in tandem with formal exploration, combined to create what I see as a vernacular accented cinema. Entwined with this centrifugal movement is another principle that guides the book's path: the gradual lessening of the reliance on and importance of verbal expression, in particular, eloquent and smoothly delivered speech, and the increasing dominance of visual and sonic registers.

Chapter 1 highlights both the continuity and misalignments of ideas and aesthetic direction between different generations of Soviet filmmakers and critics, situating them within multivocal, transnational discussions about cinema's role in postwar society and specifically the viability and ethical concerns of realism at this time. The chapter grounds the cinema of sincerity in an international setting of contemporary film developments and conversations and argues that although their sociopolitical circumstances provided limited access to certain films and critical ideas that Euro-American scholarship deems pivotal in the formation of modern cinema, Soviet critics and filmmakers nonetheless found ways to participate in such discussions through improvised circulation of knowledge and contributed greatly to the vibrancy of Soviet film culture.

The writings and film practice of veteran filmmaker and pedagogue Mikhail Romm are the focus of chapter 2. For Romm, the chapter argues,

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the ethics of modern cinema rested on compelling audiences to think. Thematically, to engender such a viewer-screen relation, a narrative film would equally engage issues of history and one's personal dilemmas, which is what Romm attempted in his last fiction feature, *Nine Days of One Year*. Formally, he was interested in recovering multiple functions of montage, especially the interplay of image and voice. His lodestars were Alain Resnais's *Hiroshima mon amour* and Sergei Eisenstein's theories of montage. Although the interplay of sound and image assumes the duty of meaning-making in much of the film, Romm still relied on the steady and eloquent narrator and, thus, the word.

Poetic discourse and verbal muddle that conveys a flow of both thought and material reality are the focus of chapter 3. I turn to the production and reception history of a seminal Thaw film, *Ilyich's Gate* (1962, released in 1965 in a bowdlerized version and finally in 1988 as the director's cut), and focus primarily on two key scenes, the conversation between son and father, with which I opened the book, and the evening of public poetry reading, which epitomizes the dual underpinning of the cinema of sincerity, the individual and the social. The chapter parses the changing aesthetic conventions and political promise of the cinema of sincerity—a possibility of unpre-scribed community, whose shared and individual experiences the cinema of sincerity intersubjectively affirmed and creatively embodied. Arguably, poetry as both a genre of literature and a stylistic approach to filmic story-telling gave cinematic sincerity one of its most salient manifestations, as evidenced by how *Ilyich's Gate* challenged the transparency of verbal language and created the extemporaneous feel of the visual and aural flux of reality on the screen.

Chapter 4 examines Tengiz Abuladze's first feature, *Other People's Children*, in relation to two frameworks: (1) the center/periphery dichotomy within a large, centralized, and technologically challenged film industry, which included the practice of dubbing into Russian films made in native languages of the republics, and (2) vernacular aesthetic imperatives of sincerity in connection with the politics of national identity. I analyze the film's rich visual textures, achieved by the use of a short focal lens, as simultaneously an homage to Italian neorealism and a zone of resistance to the linguistic domination of Russian cinema. When the film was released, accusations emanated from Moscow that it was not Soviet enough. The chapter considers the film's formal exuberance and imaginative visual latitude in relation to the well-established Soviet practice of dubbing films made in the republics into the Russian language. Destined for distribution in a multiethnic empire, such films underwent a rigorous process of being

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not simply overlaid with professionally trained Russian-speaking voices but also reinterpreted and linguistically adjusted to render the operation of dubbing invisible—in effect, to smooth out cultural or any other distinctions.

The interests of the last chapter remain in the periphery of the Soviet cinema industry and continue the pursuit of the weakening of linguistic signification, but this time in relation to historical narratives and visual poetics. The chapter provides a brief overview of the Lithuanian film industry and focuses on two early films by Arūnas Žebriūnas, which, similar to Abuladze's work covered in the preceding chapter, feature children as protagonists, affording childlike intensity of experience and perception that supported the aesthetic of sincerity. Visually, if not narratively, the young heroines in *The Last Shot* and *The Girl and the Echo* are alone, suggesting a different conception of time and space that is misaligned with that of adults. The young characters do not chase social endorsement or submit to others' demands, displaying the vitality of someone who is not mediated by, in the words of Robert Pippin, the "conforming, expectation-generating gaze of others."⁹⁴ More than that, their existence in the world is expressed affectively by the visual and atmospheric sound registers, in particular, the many wordless or near-wordless scenes and sequences that promise a form of sociality uncontaminated by self-declaration of sincerity. In that sense, *The Last Shot*, *The Girl and the Echo*, and to an extent *Other People's Children* may be seen as the exemplars of this form of realist modern cinema.

The coda recapitulates some of the formal expressions of cinematic sincerity developed in the book and posits that a handful of feature films produced in the late 1960s and early 1970s, in particular, those addressing the problematics of the coming-of-age genre, display an "anxious" aesthetic. The coda offers a brief analysis of Kira Muratova's *The Long Farewell* (Odesa Film Studio, 1971) as an example of the dissolution of the idea of sincerity in that, through the application of abrupt editing technique and a breakdown in intersubjective communication, the film forestalls personal closeness and erodes the possibility of an unprescribed community.

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CHAPTER 1

“Cinema for Us Was a Way to Communicate with the World”

In 1961, in a conversation with Luchino Visconti, who that year served as a jury member at the Moscow International Film Festival, Mikhail Romm brought up Federico Fellini's *La Dolce Vita* (1960). Although not in commercial release in the USSR, the film became a cause célèbre in industry circles after it played in Moscow's House of Cinema, made rounds in private quarters of high-ranking party officials, was shown in closed screenings at Mosfilm, and earned the condemnation of the Soviet press for salaciousness. Romm, however, admired the film and was surprised that Visconti did not share his enthusiasm. The Italian director offered: “Fellini never treats life's real problems. He doesn't uncover them. Certainly, some people might be bothered by what he does, but it doesn't concern the fundamental interests of the bourgeoisie.”¹ This excerpt from the exchange between the Soviet filmmaker and his Italian colleague opens onto a larger view of European cinema held by many Soviet artists, a view that was limited both by access to films and by an interpretation informed by a specific epistemology. Where for Romm, *La Dolce Vita* unmasked deceptions of the Roman Catholic Church, for Visconti, the scene depicting a fake religious miracle was an unremarkable occurrence in the Italian context and held absolutely no threat for the institution of the church and the ruling classes.²

This dialogue positions Soviet cinema vis-à-vis its neighboring and more distant film cultures in a way that highlights multidirectional interaction, a degree of misalignment, and an interpretation of cultural production that points to a different cinematic archive in the long postwar period. The conversation between Romm and Visconti was published in the weekly *Sovetskii ekran* (Soviet screen) and thus fully sanctioned, but it nonetheless implies the existence of other more improvised and less official flows of knowledge that never made it onto a printed page. The exchange is also

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Жан Марс на Красной площади в Москве. Этот известный кинорежиссер возглавлял делегацию кинематографистов Франции, которые приезжали в Советский Союз на Неделю французского кино. Сним вместе в нашей стране побывали кинорежиссеры Огюст Берсу, Мари Жозе Нат, Милен Дененко, режиссер Гастар Юн и другие.

МЕЖДУНА- РОДНЫЕ ТВО- РЧЕСКИЕ КОН- ТАКТЫ СОВЕТ- СКИХ КИНЕ- МАТОГРАФИ- СТОВ

Творческие контакты советских и зарубежных кинематографистов имеют давние и глубокие традиции. Много лет назад во время своей поездки по США и Мексике режиссеры Сергей Эйзенштейн, Григорий Александров и оператор Эдуард Тиссе не только создали своеобразный художественный фильм о Мексике, но и, по признанию местных киноработников, помогли заложить основы национального кинематографического искусства страны.

В последнее время география творческого сотрудничества советских и зарубежных кинематографистов охватила весь мир. В орбиту дружественных связей попали такие страны, где до последнего времени информация о советском кино была тенденциозной или бредовой и случайной.

Советские и зарубежные кинематографисты часто ездят в гости друг к другу. Но, пожалуй, самые интересные и представительные встречи бывают на международных кинофестивалях: в Москве, Ганне, Венеции, Сан-Франциско и других. Во время двух Московских кинематографических форумов многие сотни киноработников мира смогли познакомиться с жизнью нашей страны, с советским кинематографическим искусством.

Каждый год в Москве и других крупнейших городах Советского Союза проходят традиционные «недели» зарубежных фильмов. Многие страны мира неоднократно присылали в нашу страну кинемато-

Одно из многочисленных встреч Второго Московского международного кинофестиваля. Режиссер Сергей Югович и артист Евгений Санойлов беседуют с итальянскими артистами Джинной Лоллеллибриджидой и Марией Мерлини в кинотеатре «Россия», где проходил показ фестивальных фильмов

Очень интересным был разговор режиссера Лучино Висconti (Италия) и Михаила Ромма (СССР) на Втором Московском международном кинофестивале. Спорили в оценках мирового кино, в тактике проблем итальянского неореализма и особенностей режиссерского мастерства, они в конце концов во многом согласились друг с другом

Mikhail Romm and Luchino Visconti (*bottom left*), Moscow, *Sovetskii film*, 1961
(General Research Division, New York Public Library)

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situated in a culture in which the public was being increasingly exposed to a range of artistic traditions thanks to renewed efforts in cultural diplomacy, especially with the West, including activities by organizations such as the All-Union Society for Cultural Ties with Foreign Countries (VOKS) and the Union of Soviet Friendship Societies (SSOD).³ In urban centers, Soviet audiences encountered modernist art for the first time in decades. In the words of Eleonory Gilburd, exhibitions of Western art in particular "were a *happening*. There, like-minded people met, and some of the decade's rhetorical battles—most prominently, 'the conflict of generations'—acquired human voices, which turned hoarse in quarrels."⁴ The latter half of the 1950s was marked by several milestone art "happenings." Among the most momentous were the extensive Picasso exhibit in Moscow's Pushkin Museum and Leningrad's Russian Museum in the fall of 1956, the reappearance of impressionists and postimpressionists from the former collections of the Russian merchant Sergei Shchukin and industrialist Ivan Morozov at the Pushkin Museum and the Hermitage, and the multimedia art shows mounted as part of the International Youth Festival in the summer of 1957.⁵ Soviet audiences began to see films from the West more regularly as well. The first Week of Italian Cinema, for instance, took place in Moscow and Leningrad in October 1956, while the Week of French Cinema had been inaugurated in October 1955 and, in addition to the two principal Russian cities, traveled to Kyiv.⁶ Meanwhile, in November 1954 a festival of Polish films took place in Moscow, Leningrad, Kyiv, Minsk, Vilnius, and Lviv ostensibly to demonstrate the successful conversion of Polish cinema to socialist realism. The program included the films made by the older generation of filmmakers, among them, Aleksander Ford, Wanda Jakubowska, and Jerzy Bossak.⁷

However, these cultural developments were not without a backlash. During the Khrushchev era of considerable transnational cultural exchange, keepers of socialist realist values more than ever called for vigilance. For example, the secretary of the party's Central Committee, Dmitry Shepilov, delivering a welcome address at the First Congress of Soviet Artists in 1957, characterized the work of self-proclaimed European realists Yves Klein, Arman, Daniel Spoerri, and Jean Tinguely, which he had recently seen in France, as a rejection of "life, of mankind, of great ideals," a description routinely applied to art from the West.⁸ The growing worry about Western influences culminated in the Manège affair. On December 1, 1962, Khrushchev and a group of senior party officials paid a visit to the galleries at the Manège, where the Moscow Union of Artists (MOSKh) had organized an extensive exhibition in celebration of the union's thirty-year anniversary. The

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visit proved memorable for the choice profanities Khrushchev unleashed on the nonfigurative work of several participants.⁹

In official rhetoric, the Soviets cast themselves as guardians of realism, which represented far more than an aesthetic convention. Socialist realism was grafted onto cultural production of Eastern Bloc countries, as well as a number of recently decolonized African nations, and as such reflected Russia's ambition of global cultural leadership, which was to accompany its postwar superpower status.¹⁰ Authorities in charge of cinema in particular took the lead in the safeguarding of realism, as a number of recent Soviet films had garnered enthusiastic responses at international festivals.¹¹

But rather than rehearsing official pronouncements on the superiority of the Soviet variety of realism, this chapter highlights some of the transnational debates that centered on cinema and realist representation, which espoused ideas commensurate with the ones inscribed in the cinema of sincerity, namely, rethinking the relationship between viewer and screen, reality and the filmed image. I look at the points of contact—in some instances conceptual, in others actual—between the cinema of sincerity and discursive clusters elsewhere to distinguish differences and shared ideas and to situate this vernacular aesthetic within a broader cultural landscape. Although the concept is rooted in the sociopolitical milieu of the post-Stalin years, sincerity's ethical, political, and formal concerns are deeply connected with realism's expansive possibilities as well as its limitations and thus with wider concerns of filmic realism in the postwar era and with a quest for modern cinema in particular. The investigation into some of the common ideas and how they entered discourse also brings to light the various pathways of knowledge circulation.

Far from being the Soviets' exclusive purview and sphere of influence, polemics about filmic realism, its permutations, and its viability in representing a postwar, post-Holocaust, post-Hiroshima and Nagasaki world issued from a number of groups. Among these, two stand out for the key reasons pertinent to the book: their interaction with Soviet cinema and assertions about and innovation of on-screen representation, whether in critical thought or filmmaking practices. These groups can be delineated geographically—Italy and France—as well as by way of their political engagement and stance toward realism and/or Soviet cinema. In Italy, the critics who gathered around the Marxist journal *Cinema nuovo*, out of Milan, had the closest ties with socialist cultures; therefore, their views on realism usually aligned with those of the Soviets. The official and unofficial presence of André Bazin's texts, the moral core and formal search of the filmmakers associated with the Left Bank group in Paris, and the conversations about cinematic modernity

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sounded at the roundtables organized by *Cahiers du cinéma* constitute a more conceptual but no less important node in knowledge transmission between French and Soviet film discourses.

Realism Debates in Italy and France

Visconti's oeuvre was a frequent subject of heated debates that unfurled during the 1950s and into the following decade around cinematic modernity. His invitation to Moscow in 1961 may have well been prompted by the release on Russian screens of *Rocco e i suoi fratelli* (*Rocco and His Brothers*, 1960), a work enthusiastically praised by the Soviet cinema establishment and younger filmmakers alike. At the 1960 Venice Film Festival, the film caused nearly as much controversy for its portrayal of the poor southern Parondi family as *Senso* had six years earlier—an event Moscow could only welcome. The Soviet media praised the film and illuminated the criticism around it in the West.¹² Visconti's artistic vicissitudes proved a flash point for French and Italian critics who, like their Soviet counterparts, polemized on the nature and viability of realism.

It is not surprising that the antennae of many creative minds and intellectuals in France and Italy turned eastward in the immediate post-Stalin years. Many of them sought to grasp the consequences effected by the upheaval of the Soviet regime change for their work, their political position, and, more broadly, the world split by Cold War alliances. Among those who momentarily became embroiled in the heady currents of the early Thaw and entered into a more or less direct polemic with Moscow's critical establishment was the Bolognese critic Renzo Renzi. In June 1956 *Cinema nuovo* published his article titled "Breaking the Vow." By referencing in his title Mikhail Chiaureli's 1946 cinematic panegyric to Stalin, *The Vow*, Renzi made it clear that it was time to take a critical stance vis-à-vis Soviet culture.¹³ His text was a rejoinder to "On the Representation of the People's Life," an article in the Soviet cultural newspaper *Literaturnaia gazeta* (Literary newspaper) that had been published following the revelations of the Secret Speech.¹⁴ "On the Representation of the People's Life" denounced Stalin-era artistic production and called for a return to Leninist principles. The author of the article quoted Lenin's words from decades ago: "Less political chatter. Less intellectual musings. Closer to life. More attention to the way the working and peasant masses actually build something new in their workaday life."¹⁵ However, for Renzi, this piece—and similar articles that followed in the Soviet press—merely adopted an opportune posture and effectively reproduced the previous era's critical standard, which was based on the current ideological value of an artwork rather than rigorous intellectual and aesthetic

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analysis. According to Renzi, it was high time for Italian Communist critics and others of the leftist persuasion to reject their allegiance to the dogmatic brand of criticism coming from Moscow. Renzi lambasted his compatriots for groveling to Soviet cinema during the Stalin years and urged for more rigor in critical thought. Evidently, Italian film criticism as exercised by the Left had to be de-Stalinized as well.¹⁶

Realism as both an aesthetic idiom and a measure of political commitment came to the center of European film debates with a renewed force during the 1950s and 1960s. What is more, the Soviets frequently wound up in the middle of such public discussions, where agreement often proved elusive. In 1963, in the Italian Communist daily *l'Unità*, a dispute unfolded between Jean-Paul Sartre on one side and the paper's editor, Mario Alicata, and Italian leftist intellectuals on the other. The subject of contention was Andrei Tarkovsky's first feature, *Ivanovo detstvo* (*Ivan's Childhood*, Mosfilm, 1962), which had received the Golden Lion at the Venice Festival the previous year. Alicata and his associates called the young Soviet filmmaker a petit bourgeois and claimed that his aesthetic promulgated a Western worldview. The main target of their accusations were the film's dream sequences, which they dismissed because of the techniques of long-outmoded surrealism and expressionism. Sartre, for his part, defended Tarkovsky and his film; for him, it was unequivocally against war and committed to the liberation of humanity. In Sartre's view, the hallucinatory universe of a child damaged by war that the filmmaker created was not derivative of expressionism or surrealism but the product of "a narrative method demanded by the subject itself."¹⁷ The dispute, though certainly politically motivated, is nonetheless instructive in how it treats realist cinematic form and the significance it grants realism in postwar and post-Stalin art. Whereas the *l'Unità* coterie identified the flashes of expressionism and surrealism in Tarkovsky's film as the abandonment of realism, for Sartre, these images indicated that the filmmaker and his work were facing the modern world via an expansion of realist forms of representation.¹⁸

Neorealism as a Site of the Realism Debate

While neorealism's position as the most progressive postwar movement may have weakened by the mid-1950s in Italy and France, as an aesthetic with a clear social mission it nonetheless continued to shape discourse in both the West and Soviet Russia. The debate on the pages of French and Italian journals reached Soviet critics and filmmakers only partially, but its terms demonstrate an affinity with sincerity aesthetics and the concerns in Soviet film culture. When in 1957 Gianni Rondolino, the Italian leftist journalist

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and representative of the Museo Nazionale del Cinema in Turin, gave a speech at the International Film Seminar held at the All-Union State Institute of Cinema (VGIK), he spoke about the crisis of neorealism: "Rossellini pursues a spiritual path in *Stromboli* and the *Flowers of St. Francis* [1950]. De Sica, too, moves away from reality, hiding in a tale, *Miracle in Milan* [1951], while Visconti turns to the theater. . . . Neorealism can no longer get at the contradictions of Italian reality. We need new forms."¹⁹ The "we" might as well have referred to Soviet filmmakers.

Neorealism in the Soviet Union saw an uneven reception in the film establishment and among party bosses.²⁰ As a movement, neorealism had an illustrious origin, emerging from the resistance struggle during World War II and the defeat of Fascism.²¹ Many of its exponents belonged to the Italian Communist Party (PCI), whose leader, Palmiro Togliatti, had very close ties with Moscow.²² However, in Soviet Russia the official attitude to neorealism was guarded. In the framework of socialist realism, the postwar Italian movement did not provide definitive answers to the class struggle that its images so vividly captured. Established film professionals, among them Mikhail Romm and playwright Georgy Mdivani, cautioned against what they regarded as an artificial splicing of the Italian aesthetic with domestic cultural production.²³ But for younger critics and filmmakers during the Thaw there was nothing like neorealism. They embraced it as a model of modern cinema that got close to life, in particular to its materialist surfaces and social depths; it illuminated a path toward different aesthetic possibilities at a time when socialist realist narratives and visual language were in need of revision. Eisenstein scholar Naum Kleiman remembers the profound sense of awakening that the encounter with the films of Roberto Rossellini, Vittorio De Sica, Giuseppe De Santis, and others stirred among his peers at VGIK, where Kleiman was a film studies student from 1956 to 1962. Maya Turovskaya recalled that for many young men and women involved with theater and film, moving images and sounds of postwar Italy that arrived on Soviet screens had a powerful resonance: These young people felt as if they had been "hit by a heavy object."²⁴ While their counterparts in the West debated the crisis of neorealism, for Soviet filmmakers and critics, the Italian aesthetic modeled a varnish-free cinema that would lead to authentic and sincere representation—and to modern cinema.

When the most celebrated film of the early Thaw, Mikhail Kalatozov's *The Cranes Are Flying* (*Letiat zhuravli*, Mosfilm, 1957) was released in the fall of 1957, Romm gathered a group of his students at VGIK for a screening and discussion. Tarkovsky, Vasily Shukshin, and several others present, much to Romm's surprise, branded the film too melodramatic and affected.

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This attitude pertained to the film's story but even more so to the virtuoso camerawork of cinematographer Sergei Urusevsky.²⁵ In his memoirs, Urusevsky recounts the famous story of a private screening of *Cranes* for Picasso at the 1958 Cannes Film Festival, following which the celebrated artist proclaimed that each frame in the film was a visual masterpiece.²⁶ It was this *masterpieceness* that Romm's students found suspect. While stunning, the film's cinematography came across as academic and drawing attention to itself. Tarkovsky and his peers preferred *Dom, v kotorom ia zhivu* (*The House I Live In*, Gorky Film Studio, 1957), codirected by the duo of younger filmmakers, Yakov Segel and Lev Kulidzhyanov. The VGIK students valued the film's restrained, candid, and seemingly spontaneous mise-en-scène and camerawork, which came across as simply flowing out of the filmic space and into the world, qualities the aspiring filmmakers identified with postwar Italian cinema.²⁷

It is telling that two of neorealism's most prominent exponents, Rossellini and Visconti, ignited a spirited debate among French and Italian critics who continued to perceive the cineasts as the standard-bearers of modern film. Following their foundational neorealist works in the 1940s—*Roma città aperta* (*Rome, Open City*, 1945) and *Paisà* (*Paisan*, 1946) for Rossellini and *Ossessione* (*Obsession*, 1943) and *La terra trema* (*The Earth Trembles*, 1948) for Visconti—during the next decade the filmmakers took their artistic program in unexpected directions, which delighted some and incensed others. André Bazin and critics of *Cahiers du cinéma*, on the one side, and the editor of *Cinema nuovo*, Guido Aristarco, and his fellow contributors, on the other, held opposing views and expounded upon realism and modernity in reference to Rossellini's *Viaggio in Italia* (*Voyage to Italy*, 1954).²⁸

For Jacques Rivette, *Voyage to Italy*, with its suspension of the drama of conventional narrative, its essayistic conjoining of the story, and its presentation of characters who do not try to prove anything but simply enact their inner turmoil, exemplified a modern film. With the appearance of *Voyage to Italy*, "all films have suddenly aged ten years," states Rivette in "Letter on Rossellini," published in an April 1955 issue of *Cahiers*.²⁹ The filmmaker's voice, the critic declares, "gives him a new, contemporary tone that speaks to us through our freshest, most vital sensibility; all this affects the modern man in us. . . . All this in fact deals with the *honnête homme* of 1953 or 1954; this, in fact, is the theme."³⁰ The film seems to call into being the figure of the honest human—the person defined by the contemporary moment and thus beset by turmoil. Not only was Rossellini's vision deeply modern, but the *Cahiers* critic also defended the director as a realist artist. Modernity and realism intersect in this work. A genuine realist, according to Rivette,

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is someone who does not construct his artwork through overstatements using imposed aesthetic standards.³¹ Bazin carried on with this interpretation of realism, which he articulated in his text "In Defense of Rossellini" several months after Rivette's "Letter."

Writing the piece as an open rejoinder to *Cinema nuovo*'s Guido Aristarco, who rejected *Voyage to Italy* as retrograde and antineorealist, Bazin announced that Rossellini "has done the most to extend the frontiers of the neorealist aesthetic."³² Bazin's line of adjudication rests on the filmmaker's stylistic integrity, which is manifest in the close connection between his aims and style.³³ It is in this junction that the French critic locates Rossellini's neorealism, repudiating Aristarco's narrow definition, where formal rules are preestablished or designated by a filmmaker's political leanings. "Neorealism as such does not exist. There are only neorealist directors—whether they be materialists, Christians, communists, or whatever," Bazin asserts.³⁴ In a characteristic flight of metaphors, Bazin likens traditional realism to the stones that form a bridge and neorealism—Rossellini's version, specifically—to the stones scattered in a ford. The reality of the stones remains unaffected when they are used to cross the river, but they bring the spectator's "share of ingenuity to bear on their chance arrangement. . . . In the same way, the neorealist film has a meaning, but it is *a posteriori*, to the extent that it permits our awareness to move from one fact to another, from one fragment of reality to the next, whereas in the classical artistic composition the meaning is established *a priori*: the house is already there in the brick."³⁵

For the *Cinema nuovo* group, Rossellini's oeuvre represented at this juncture what they labeled a crisis of neorealism. Documentarian and screenwriter Carlo Lizzani, whose book *Il cinema italiano* (1954) was published in the USSR in 1956, claimed that of all the neorealist filmmakers, Rossellini's artistic crisis was the deepest.³⁶ He noted that Rossellini displayed excessive attraction to the documentary quality of images and to the suffering of characters, which had distinguished *Rome, Open City*, and *Paisan* but greatly damaged *Germania anno zero* (*Germany Year Zero*, 1948) and *Stromboli* (1950).³⁷

According to Aristarco and his associates, the film that redefined realism and brought something qualitatively different to it was not *Voyage to Italy* but Visconti's *Senso* (1954). A sumptuous costume drama set during the Risorgimento, it was adapted from the eponymous novella by Camillo Boito and featured international stars Alida Vali and Farley Granger. The film provoked controversy even within the ranks of Italian leftist critics on several counts, including soaring costs and the treatment of Italy's history.³⁸ When the film was still in production, in late 1953, *Cinema nuovo* dedicated

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virtually an entire issue to Visconti's career, mainly focusing on *Senso* and his first feature, *Obsession*, which at the time of its appearance had catalyzed discussions about realism in Fascist Italy.³⁹

Initially, the critics on the left expressed concern that the filmmaker was now forced to turn to a costume drama, even though realist cinema had still much to say about contemporary life.⁴⁰ But Aristarco launched a series of articles defending both the film and its director. In an editorial titled "From Neorealism to Realism," he declared the realism of *Senso* to be "more advanced than that of *La terra trema*," a film about Sicilian fishermen that had solidified Visconti's credentials as a leading neorealist.⁴¹ The critic, as Millicent Marcus notes, celebrated Visconti's move to historical subject matter as broadening the definition of realism.⁴² Moreover, Aristarco championed *Senso* because it attempted to present a total picture of life during the period of Italy's struggle for unification.

Soviet Criticism and Film Institutions as Sites of Knowledge

In the Soviet Union, neither *Voyage to Italy* nor *Senso* signaled a breakthrough in the remapping of the humanist terrain in postwar modern cinema. A print of Rossellini's film arrived in the State Film Archive (Gosfilmofond) only in 1971, while *Senso* appeared in the collection "off the record" in 1955, perhaps thanks to Visconti's membership in the Italian Communist Party.⁴³ Their absence, however, is significant in that it indicates that the canon on which Soviet artists drew was different. Moreover, it was a matter of only a few years before Marlen Khutsiev, Romm, and Gennady Shpalikov, as well as critics Turovskaya and Neya Zorkaya, saw their own *hônnetes hommes* and *femmes*—or, in the vernacular parlance, sincere men and women—in narrative fiction film. They would become representations of the burgeoning post-Stalin intelligentsia, known as the *shestidesiatniki*—the "people of the sixties" who were eager to engage with history, begin a conversation with the public, and explore the film medium's potential. In the description of the young literary critic Stanislav Rassadin, who coined the moniker *shestidesiatniki* in 1960, this was a community that had "the ability and desire to think, to reflect upon life and its complexities."⁴⁴

The debate taking place in the pages of *Cinema nuovo*, *Bianco e nero*, and *Cahiers* echoed and refracted in the Soviet film community, most notably in criticism. Although arguments of the Italian and French critics and cineasts customarily underwent a local spin, their voices were sought after by their Soviet colleagues, and their influence was at once profound and challenging to official rhetoric of realist art. They reached the Soviet community in a number of ways: via journals such as *Iskusstvo kino* (The art of cinema),

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Voprosy kinoiskusstva (On film art), and *Voprosy kinodramaturgii* (On film dramaturgy); on the big screen in select theaters, especially the Houses of Cinema, which were venues that operated largely for industry professionals; in interviews in the popular press such as *Sovetskii ekran*; and in a run of translated books on film theory and history that issued from the publishing houses *Iskusstvo* (Art) and *Inostrannaia literatura* (Foreign literature).⁴⁵ *Iskusstvo kino* periodically provided space for the Italian leftist critics Chiarini, Lizzani, Umberto Barbaro, and Aristarco in Russian translation. Aristarco's *Storia delle teorie del film* (History of film theories, 1960) was translated into Russian in 1966. Meanwhile, Bazin's "The Evolution of Film Language" came out in the 1965 volume of *Voprosy kinodramaturgii*, with a judicious preface by the film scholar of French cinema Viktor Bozhovich.

It bears remembering that what appeared in the accredited sources, such as those described above, represented a highly selective set of materials. Their reception nonetheless could never be fully managed. Despite the efforts of censorship and careful curation, these materials—along with the local response to them—contributed to the vibrant film culture of the Soviet Thaw. There were other less obvious and semiofficial channels for disseminating the ideas of Italian and French critics and filmmakers. I am

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Contents page showing Bazin's 1965 essay in *Voprosy kinodramaturgii*
(On film dramaturgy)

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interested in how different flows of knowledge mixed and surfaced in criticism, creating a stimulating discursive space.⁴⁶

Arguably, one of the most significant channels, and one that is often overlooked in the accounts of Soviet film history, are the critics, film scholars, and figures adjacent to the cultural sphere who facilitated critics' work. Depending on their status in the establishment, Soviet critics tended to have a relatively advantageous position regarding access to films and other sources that contributed to the formation of film discourse.⁴⁷ Many knew several languages and often specialized in national cinemas according to their linguistic expertise. Figures of such stature as Rostislav Yurenev and Ilya Vaisfeld represented the old guard and mostly, although not always, a conservative style of criticism. They produced texts alongside two younger cohorts, one entering the fray in the latter part of the 1950s, the other in the early 1960s.

The cohort that graduated from the State Institute of Theater Arts (GITIS) in the late 1940s and early 1950s—including Turovskaya, Zorkaya, Inna Solovyova, Yuri Khaniutin, and Boris Zingerman—constituted a vital node in the network of knowledge transmission.⁴⁸ Although they were not trained in film analysis, their command of foreign languages, recently gained access to Gosfilmofond collections, and erudition regarding literature, theater, and visual arts enriched critical writing and shifted it toward aesthetic, philosophical, and generally humanist concerns. Abram Efros, the art history professor at GITIS, generously opened his extensive private library to his students. By way of subscriptions, Efros regularly received books on art and art history from Paris and so kept abreast of the postwar European art scene and criticism.⁴⁹ Trained in Marxist-Leninist aesthetics, the younger critics found formal and informal ways to augment the official curriculum.

The GITIS constellation was compelled to write about cinema because for them, as Turovskaya described decades later, the art form opened up avenues of communication with the outside world that expanded during the Thaw. This sense of possibility to reach out and be in turn reached reflects the thrill that Turovskaya and her colleagues felt at the time. The way they engaged with watching and writing about a wide range of movies demonstrates that they did not regard their work as a quiet, hermetic activity; instead, it involved directing their writing outward into the world, where their ideas would be received, thought about, perhaps transformed, and communicated back to them. To be a critic was a political enterprise, for it entailed having a position on an art object and expressing it through one's intellectual labor.

Turovskaya and her colleagues taught themselves about cinema in the screening rooms of Gosfilmofond, an institution whose role in educating

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generations of critics and filmmakers who came up in the late 1950s through the 1970s awaits a comprehensive appraisal. Gosfilmofond became a more welcoming place after the death in 1958 of Georgy Avenarius, who had been head of the international film collection for decades and who had been reluctant to grant access to the archive.⁵⁰ Turovskaya, Solovyova, and others embarked on regular excursions to Belye Stolby, just outside of Moscow, to Gosfilmofond's veritable treasure trove of features, documentaries, and archival footage from around the world.⁵¹ At the time interested in contemporary Italian film and Antonioni in particular, Turovskaya saw *Cronaca di un amore* (*Story of a Love Affair*, 1950), which at first led to a long-form essay in 1962 about the director and his cinematic preoccupations and eventually a book.⁵² Based largely on their formative viewing experiences at Gosfilmofond, Solovyova published a monograph on postwar Italian cinema, and Boris Zingerman wrote an in-depth article about Italian neorealism for *Iskusstvo kino*.⁵³ Very few had the opportunity to see films by the likes of Antonioni, Fellini, Robert Bresson, Rossellini, and the rest, since most of their oeuvre had not been distributed in the USSR.

For the youngest cohort of film scholars, those who, in the early 1960s, received their VGIK diplomas with the degree in cinema studies, "the worldview and culture of these philologists, theatre scholars, and art historians helped us broaden and deepen our thinking," recalled Kleiman.⁵⁴ GITIS, VGIK, and Gosfilmofond can be seen as locales where unsanctioned kinds of knowledge were disseminated and entered discourse. VGIK remained a bastion of film and humanist education for multiple generations of Soviet cineasts who arrived there from all corners of the union. One could find creative ways to expose oneself to the literature that was officially censored. A strategy arose whereby approved texts on aesthetics and philosophy generously quoted a denounced thinker; these snippets would then be read vociferously and discussed by those who wished to probe beyond Marxism-Leninism.⁵⁵ The school offered a haven to a number of heterodox scholars and practitioners, who found imaginative ways to supplement the prescribed curriculum. For example, under the guise of historical materialist development in a mandatory course on Marxist-Leninist philosophy, a VGIK professor read an abridged course in the history of aesthetics from Aristotle through Giovanni Pico della Mirandola to Boileau, continuing with Gotthold Ephraim Lessing, Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, and Friedrich Schlegel, to conclude with the nineteenth-century Russian thinkers Vissarion Belinsky and Nikolai Dobrolyubov.⁵⁶ Screenwriter Natalya Ryazantseva remembered how in a literature class Professor Mikhail Grigoriev had taught Kant and Freud as well as Boris Pasternak, who was never in the authorities' good

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graces.⁵⁷ The school also functioned as a crucial gateway to other film traditions. Kleiman, for instance, recalled the first time VGIK students had seen Jean Vigo's *L'Atalante* (1934) in 1958: "We simply went mad over it and tried to see the film whenever it was shown in other courses."⁵⁸ Lev Kulidzhanov, a director belonging to the lieutenants' generation, talked about how his teachers Lev Kuleshov and Aleksandra Khokhlova watched the Hollywood films *Queen Christina* (1933), *Night Flight* (1933), and *Stagecoach* (1939) while students hid behind the heavy curtains of the screening room. Kuleshov and Khokhlova pretended not to notice and let the students see the films.⁵⁹ Donatas Pečiūra, studying cinematography at the Film Institute between 1955 and 1960, decades later remembered encountering films of various avant-gardes and of the Polish Film School, as well as American movies, feeling especially bowled over by Gregg Toland's use of the wide-angle lens.⁶⁰ It was also at VGIK, behind the closed doors of an auditorium, that the second part of Eisenstein's *Ivan Grozny* (*Ivan the Terrible*, 1946) had at last been screened in 1958 before it opened in select theaters across the country.

For the VGIK graduates in the 1960s, among them Kleiman, Miron Chernenko, and Viktor Demin, Gosfilmofond provided an intellectual refuge and, as some would propose, created a distinct school of film criticism. After leaving the Film Institute, some graduates obtained posts at the archive as research assistants and continued their education by way of regular screenings of domestic and international films, often long banished from theatrical exhibition or never officially distributed in the Soviet Union. Gosfilmofond operated as a site for critics' education and as a meeting ground for intellectual exchange between generations where the VGIK graduates could listen in on the conversations of their slightly older colleagues.⁶¹

While such accounts of knowledge transmission may not come in the form of tangible documents or be cataloged in archives, they nevertheless point to the presence of a thick underlayer that illuminates contradictions and that was as fundamental a part of Soviet culture as mandatory courses in Marxist-Leninist philosophy. According to anthropologist and historian Alexei Yurchak, "The ethical and aesthetic paradoxes that 'really existing socialism' acquired in the lives of many of its citizens" were integral for the everyday realities of Soviet socialism.⁶²

Many films that never saw distribution on Soviet screens were nonetheless not entirely unknown among critics and other professionals in the industry, creating what I have called elsewhere "a curious absence."⁶³ Such films, among them works by Antonioni, Rossellini, Fellini, and Bergman, left traces of their presence by way of one-off or rare screenings accessible to select audiences, through the publication of screenplays, and through

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descriptions in articles and translated books, interviews, and other discursive material. Encounters with these traces formed a dynamic inside culture that placed critics in a position of narrators and interpreters.

André Bazin as an Interlocutor

Similar to Italian neorealism, around which coalesced moral, social, aesthetic, and philosophical concerns of postwar cinema, the figure of Bazin emerged as an oblique but discernible reference point for Soviet critics of different generations. As John MacKay notes, the work of Bazin "made itself felt in a significant way in the Soviet Union in the mid-1960s," and "critics and scholars with knowledge of the French language had access to Bazin's writings even earlier."⁶⁴ Bazin's semivisible position in local film discourse epitomizes the ways in which official and less official forms of knowledge circulated in Thaw culture. While archives and other instruments of institutional power may have muted Bazin's presence, there is a range of evidence that Soviet critics were aware of at least some of his writings, certainly understood his importance in postwar film thought, and engaged, often polemically, with his ideas.

The Russian translation of "The Evolution of Film Language" was published in the 1965 volume of *Voprosy kinodramaturgii*, an annual launched in 1954 and dedicated to theoretical matters. In 1972 the publisher Iskusstvo issued two books of Bazin's texts: essays on and interviews with Jean Renoir and selections of over three hundred pages from the four volumes of *Qu'est-ce que le cinéma?* (originally published in 1958, 1959, 1961, and 1962). But the French theorist's ideas entered the orbit of Soviet criticism well before their official appearance in these publications. In 1963, for example, Ilya Vaisfeld wrote about Bazin's and Kracauer's thoughts on the relationship between film and reality as the impetus for the tendency of many filmmakers in the West toward a more faithful representation of contemporary life.⁶⁵ Vaisfeld identified these critics/theorists with what he perceived to be the "recently popular slogan" "cinema is reality."⁶⁶ Though he remained publicly critical of Bazin and Kracauer, his analysis shows familiarity with the main arguments of their work.⁶⁷ Significantly, for Vaisfeld, film thought was not a purely intellectual exercise; it had influence on the screen. He noted the ways Bazin's ideas about realism were transported into the aesthetics of the French New Wave and beyond.⁶⁸ While the Soviet critic pays lip service to the tired line of official ideology when writing about films produced in the West, he welcomes the turn toward reality, singling out Fellini's *La Dolce Vita* and Antonioni's *La Notte* as worthy examples of this trend.

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Vaisfeld, an established critic, is but one example of the familiarity with Western film thought and Bazin specifically. Viktor Bozhovich, a young scholar specializing in French cinema, wrote an introduction to and translated "The Evolution of Film Language" for *Voprosy kinodramaturgii*.⁶⁹ He describes Bazin as an intelligent and attentive "analyst of cinema" and provides a well-informed overview and critique.⁷⁰ Bozhovich introduces the French critic to Soviet readers as someone whose thinking displays affinities with Soviet values in art, especially during the post-Stalin moment, such as "freeing cinema from falsity and clichés, opening it to life in all its varied guises," and rejecting art for art's sake. Bozhovich notes that Bazin's theory, despite its shortfalls, has origins in the experience of anti-Fascist resistance.⁷¹ He bases much of his polemic with the French critic on the latter's approach to montage.

The Soviet scholar critiques Bazin's classification of cinematic style into filmmakers who "put their faith in the image and those who put their faith in reality"—those who rely too heavily on editing and plasticity of mise-en-scène to derive meaning versus those who respect duration and thus objective reality.⁷² Bozhovich predictably objects to what he sees as Bazin's unproblematic comparison between German expressionism and Soviet cinema of the 1920s as the exemplars of the first trend, for Bazin ignored the historical circumstances of the two societies that had given rise to their cinematic expression. Taking the French critic to task for his unenthusiastic and, to Bozhovich inaccurate appraisal of montage, Bozhovich comes off as somewhat defensive. He considers Bazin's outlook on the historical development of film style not only as a put-down of montage as such but also, by association, as a denigration of an era of Soviet film history during which filmmakers had theorized and practiced montage's various operations. The avant-garde experiments of Sergei Eisenstein, Dziga Vertov, and their colleagues were gradually, if gingerly, rehabilitated in official discourse during the Thaw, and Bozhovich, in effect, defends not simply montage but also the Soviet avant-garde. As MacKay points out, "The history of previous attacks upon montage, attacks carried out in an infinitely more militant spirit than Bazin's, could not but have generated ambivalence in the minds of Soviet film scholars encountering the French theorist in the 1960s."⁷³ Montage as a technique played a central role in the antiformalism crusades in the history of Soviet art, and here now was a theorist of realism from the West who proffered a dim view of montage aesthetics.

For decades, the gatekeepers of socialist realism dogmatically rejected experiments of the 1920s avant-garde, labeling them *formalist*. Since the mid-1930s, following the vicious antiformalism campaign that had initially

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targeted Dmitry Shostakovich's music and soon extended to other artists and mediums, formalism was seen as modernism's domestic permutation: It epitomized art with a tenuous thread to reality and, crucially, with ties to the prerevolutionary, class-based past, which was alien to socialist values.⁷⁴ Modernism (*modernizm*) officially remained on the list of bourgeois keywords during the Thaw, although, of course, Soviet visual arts and cinematic experiments of the 1920s participated in pan-European modernism and, far from peripheral, made major contributions to its development.⁷⁵

In this particular discourse, formalism was defined in terms of both stylistic flourishes and a hostile worldview, a connection that from the mid-1930s onward became inseparable.⁷⁶ Similar to modernism and sometimes used interchangeably, formalism in the Soviet context stood for a set of attributes in all branches of art that the authorities pegged as ideologically suspect, aesthetically opaque, and antipopular. One of the most influential theoreticians of socialist realism, Georg Lukács, in his 1938 essay "Realism in the Balance," written as a rejoinder to Ernst Bloch's defense of expressionism, had criticized expressionism as "a caricature of something real, namely of a formalist modernism, bereft of content, cut off from the mainstream of society."⁷⁷ In other words, it came down to the tired adage of form versus content.⁷⁸ Although the partial rehabilitation of the avant-garde was under way, the hostility toward modernism and formalism that had marked the late 1930s and 1940s endured in the post-Stalin years, as attested by numerous attacks on instances of formal experimentation and abstract art in particular.⁷⁹

Bozhovich's defense of montage casts light on the contradictions that sit at the core of the Soviet brand of realism, especially in regard to cinema's relationship with reality and explorations into and prescriptions about realist representation in film. How to negotiate the gap between the filmed image and the lived world—and consequently how to define cinematic realism in this new atmosphere of relative tolerance—gets increasingly muddled during the Thaw. The recently emerged possibility to push realism's boundaries further, alongside the pressing imperative in post-Stalin society to reassess history and, consequently, approach the contemporary moment in different, more truthful terms, generated questions and a degree of confusion. Notably incoherent at this time is the enduring prescription of socialist realism to use a "simple form that has clarity and legibility, i.e. an outward expression of the content of an artwork," as the artist must "convey his active attitude to life, his active, progressive understanding of life, and all this always in artistic images [*v khudozhestvennykh obrazakh*]."⁸⁰ As the period's appeal to *get closer to life* emanated from the highest echelons of power and

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was practiced by the cinema of sincerity, socialist realism also always insisted on the filmmaker's presence or, more accurately, the filmmaker's stance toward imaged reality through his or her creative intervention. Bozhovich's discomfort appears to derive from the idea that cinema's foundational property to record and reveal physical reality does not leave much room for the distinct shaping of said reality. This unease becomes patently plain in his brief analysis of the "Ontology" essay, which he had access to, though the text would not be published in a Russian translation until 1972.⁸¹

Bozhovich is troubled by Bazin's apparent delight in the absence of human intervention in the making of photographic and cinematic images, expressed by the French thinker in "The Ontology of the Photographic Image," and takes it to mean, erroneously, the championing of authorial self-effacement. The Soviet scholar and, more broadly, Soviet critical thought could not accept an "aesthetic of nonintervention," as he calls it.⁸² Photographic objectivity is equated with impartiality toward the reproduced piece of reality.⁸³ Bozhovich falls back on Maxim Gorky, "the father" of socialist realist literature, whose sentiment echoes the Eisensteinian postulate that all art is based on conflict. For Gorky, art cannot be impartial, "for man is not a photographic apparatus; he does not 'fix' reality but affirms or alters it—destroys it."⁸⁴ Taking this statement to the extreme, it would seem that "destroying" reality in its representation—or maximally altering it—is preferable to remaining neutral and letting the apparatus reveal what it may.

The Stalin-era varnish, with its ornamental characters, images of agricultural cornucopias, and distortions of the historical past, represented the grossest display of creative interference. Conversely, the aesthetic of non-intervention, where the cinema apparatus is allowed to record the flow of life and seemingly approaches the physical world as closely as the medium affords, could not be accepted in the framework of socialist realism. The paradox, thus, remained. The question that hovers over Bozhovich's critique of Bazin concerns precisely the trilateral relationship between the filmed image, reality, and practitioner. How should the Soviet filmmaker negotiate and creatively bridge the abyss that exists between the world and its on-screen reproduction in a way that dislodges artifice and conveys lived experiences? Exactly how close could filmmakers get to reality—above all, Soviet reality? More than an aesthetic necessity, it was a matter of moral and political urgency. Although Bozhovich refrains from offering a clear theoretical alternative, he claims that the difficulty of artistic endeavor lies in its inherent double mission: to provide a creative interpretation of reality without, however, reducing reality to this single interpretation.⁸⁵ What Bozhovich's encounter with the French theorist further discloses is the underlying tussle

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between realism and the Soviet notion of formalism, with cinematic formalism, historically though not exclusively, attached to montage. In the language of metaphors usefully applied to classical film theory, Bozhovich seems to reject the notion of the screen as a window onto the world, where the window provides an unmediated view of reality (realist theories), and instead embraces the screen as a frame that actively shapes one's view of the world (formalist theories).⁸⁶

The Soviet scholar's engagement with Bazin elucidates the contradictions that abounded in the official aesthetic method and that in practice manifested in a perpetual tension. Never resolved, this formal tension instead became the symptom of cinematic sincerity during the Thaw. Much like many of its characters—if they speak at all—the cinema of sincerity hems and haws or resorts to the plane of poetry, formally processing the tension derived from, on one side, the continuing obsession, at least officially, with objective reality and, on the other, the exigency to respond to this reality by shaping it. Although formalist experiments had been under attack, the principles of shaping the raw material, which the cinema apparatus technologically reproduces, had always been integral to the method of socialist realism.

Facilitating younger critics' endeavors were figures such as translator and polyglot Izabella Epshtein. Initially hired by the Ministry of Cinema, she was then invited to work for the Union of Filmmakers' section on international relations and later became a permanent staff member at the Moscow International Film Festival.⁸⁷ The Filmmakers Union and other official entities had the authorization to subscribe to film periodicals from so-called satellite states and some from the West. Consequently, they had access to the Italian journals *Bianco e nero*, *Filmcritica*, and *Cinema nuovo*, quite probably the French journals *Positif* and *Cahiers du cinéma*, and the Polish journals *Kwartalnik Filmowy*, *Film*, and *Teatr i Film*. Epshtein, who knew English, French, and German, would often survey and translate several issues at a time of the journals within her linguistic purview, sometimes summarizing the content or translating entire articles upon request. On multiple occasions, Epshtein shared with her friends outside the establishment the texts she was tasked with translating. Turovskaya and colleagues referred to Epshtein as the "one who enlightens us" (*nash prosvetitel'*).⁸⁸ In Turovskaya's recollections, they had got hold of the French pages of some of Bazin's essays from *Qu'est-ce que le cinéma?* long before these were published in the Soviet Union.⁸⁹ For the Russian publication of Bazin's four-volume collection, Epshtein translated the essays from volumes 2, 3, and 4, *Le cinéma et les autres arts* (1959), *Cinéma et sociologie* (1961), and *Une esthétique de la réalité: Le néoréalisme* (1962), while Bozhovich translated the writings

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collected in the first volume, *Ontologie et langage* (1958). The hard evidence of which texts precisely Epshtein shared with her critic friends is difficult to ascertain, but the echoes of Bazin's thoughts, such as those expressed in "Cinematic Realism and the Italian School of the Liberation" and "In Defense of Rossellini," for example, are present in several pieces of criticism, one of which is Boris Zingerman's long-form essay "Panorama of Neorealism," published in a 1958 issue of *Iskusstvo kino*.⁹⁰

In many respects, Zingerman's thought is shaped by the Soviet episteme. Echoing the official line of ambivalence, for example, the young critic regards neorealist protagonists as incapable of turning their emotional impulses into social consciousness. Yet the yardstick of socialist realism recedes when Zingerman analyzes narrative structure and the place of material reality in Italian films. Neorealism freed itself from "the magic of cinema" and the tricks of the stage, asserting that the *siuzhet* (plot) of a neorealist film is organized panoramically, as in a Giotto fresco: "Narrative action, instead of moving in depth, spreads laterally. In fact, for the first time, in the most open and naive way, this principle of narrative development was formulated by Rossellini in *Paisan*: The film's action traveled from town to town together with the Allied forces."⁹¹ Zingerman likens this handling of dramatic construction as well to the novel (although not the American novel) and perceives in the succession of the episodes that propel the film's narrative movement a gradual lifting of the "theater curtain," which reveals the reality of post-Fascist Italy. In the place of "the official stage sets . . . emerged a different world, much less decorative but singularly real."⁹² His reading of *Paisan* points to, most likely unknowingly, Rossellini's approach to filming: pockets full of notes instead of a fixed shooting script, a small crew, and a budget that had to be continually dealt with as the filming went on.⁹³

The segment of "Panorama of Neorealism" that provoked the fiercest backlash from the critical establishment deals with the material dimension of Italian image-making. In particular, Zingerman focuses on the stark materiality captured by the neorealist camera. Such images, he insists, showed the "sensual, physical world in which a human has always lived. . . . From the vacuum of false abstractions . . . the person was returned to Earth, to the world of mundane things and relationships."⁹⁴ Eleonory Gilburd observes that for Soviet citizens, objects were "a focal and liberating aspect of new Italian cinema."⁹⁵ For Bazin, the quick neorealist camera often invoked a sense of touch, which he analogized to movements of a hand making a sketch.⁹⁶ This quickness of cinematic touch highlighted the richness of the sensate world. The plate of spaghetti, the spasm of hunger, and the lean body of a fisherman occupy the undifferentiated plane of meaning. And this

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"smile of matter to itself"—the sensual experience of material life as the foundation deserving of deep affection and struggle—is what the Soviet critic identifies as neorealism's "faithfulness to life." These films "go . . . to things themselves, to ask what they manifest through themselves," wrote Amédée Ayfre in 1952 about Rossellini's films.⁹⁷ This attention to the "surface" of life added another dimension to realism that had largely been absent or smothered by the varnish in realism's Soviet variety. It struck a nerve in post-Stalin culture, which art historian Aleksei Bobrikov characterizes as the "poetic rehabilitation of the mundane."⁹⁸ In the Soviet milieu, this rehabilitation can be seen as a response against the allegorical, mythologizing aspects of the official method in favor of a more mutable, attentive aesthetic that reveals the mundane. The camerawork of Levan Paataashvili, Margarita Pilikhina, Jonas Gričius, and Donatas Pečiūra often embodies the poetry of the ordinary in textures of city streets, seasons, everyday objects, and gestures.

Zingerman's reflections on the representation of the physical world compelled him to assert that postwar Italian film was not merely maximally close to but "an *equivalent* of reality," thus granting cinema something similar to the Bazinian existential, indexical bond between the medium and reality.⁹⁹ It looks likely that the Soviet critic was familiar with several texts by Bazin, including the "Ontology" essay, and probably Ayfre's essay on the phenomenology of the neorealist aesthetic, which may have circulated in close critical circles via Epshtein or Bozhovich.

Discourse on neorealism was in part a "coded polemic," as Masha Salazkina has pointed out, of Stalinist cinema and of hopes for film renewal at home.¹⁰⁰ The glorification of the description of materiality in Italian cinema rather than analysis—of putting human beings and things on equal footing without overt judgment—did not escape the guardians of socialist realist values. Zingerman's detractors maintained that the young critic embraced all realisms as equal and therefore tacitly subscribed to the so-called revisionist ideological and aesthetic views, which were among the concerns of the party after the uprisings in Poland in June 1956 and the Hungarian Revolution in October and November of the same year.¹⁰¹ In the volatile atmosphere of the Thaw, the accusation of revisionism constituted a grave offense.¹⁰²

At stake in the debates on realism happening in the USSR, France, Italy, and elsewhere is cinema's relationship to the real and cinema's social responsibility in a world that found itself irreversibly changed. Sincerity discourse resonates with the debate on the *honnête homme* of the 1950s, who faithfully "bears witness to the period."¹⁰³ No less central to these discussions

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are structural questions: What form are cinema’s realist representations to take, and what techniques should they employ? How was the medium to organize the new codes of film language and narrative around the sincere character that emerges at this time? Was the form a solid brick house or a sketch of an edifice, “outlined in broad essential strokes, clumsy and hurried yet epitomizing twenty fully rounded studies”?¹⁰⁴ It was as though filmmakers in the Soviet and other contexts needed to rehumanize realism to grasp fully how the human figure fits in the filmed image amid the rubble and devastation of the recent past.¹⁰⁵

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CHAPTER 2

Montage mon amour, or a Thinking Film

Nine Days of One Year

In Romm's film *Nine Days of One Year*, there is a scene near the end that epitomizes the director's vision of modern cinema. After receiving a probably fatal dose of radiation, Mitya Gusev, a nuclear physicist, is ordered to rest at home. Worried that his ongoing experiment might not be handled correctly, the dedicated scientist gets dressed and sets off for the lab. On his way, he slowly walks by an enormous wall of the research institute where he works. The wall commands the composition, and the hero, positioned at the bottom of the shot, traverses horizontally the length of the frame in fifteen seconds, each step measuring nearly a second. Reinforced by the stillness of the camera, this stark mise-en-scène, consisting of a small dark figure marching against the expansive white surface, embraces solidity and monumentality. The image conveys an idea of wholeness. The two main elements, the man and the wall, although of vastly different scales, cohere into a representation that is instantly available to the eye in its entirety and comprehensible on the symbolic level as that of the scientist's determination. But at the same time, the image, which is split into two primary figures, pointedly contrasts the human scale with the immeasurable physical world, highlighting the unequal relationship between them. The wall spreads beyond the bounds of the cinematic frame. The shot creates an abstract, rather flat space wherein the human form appears under threat and generates a sense of dread inscribed in object relations and the ascetic details of the composition; it is "a moment isolated from the totality in an abstract and over-intense manner," to use Georg Lukács's description of modernist art.¹

The image of an expansive white surface calls to mind Jacques Rivette's 1955 article, "Letter on Rossellini," devoted to *Voyage to Italy*, a film, as we have seen, that was a flash point in the debate between French and Italian critics. Rivette famously defended Rossellini as a true realist who stayed open

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The physicist and the wall in *Nine Days of One Year*

and responsive to “the attraction of the white page pregnant with a single sign, virgin sands awaiting the invention of the precise trait.”² The white page is both a metaphor and a medium as supple and full of potential as sand. In Romm’s *Nine Days of One Year*, the metaphor of the white page, materialized as a wall, likewise opened itself up to the filmmaker’s invention. During the post-Stalin years, Romm actively rethought his practice and engaged with questions of what it meant to create a modern, realist, and sincere film. In this shot, Romm seems to have finally let go of his unease about modernism. Preconceptions of what constitutes realism have also been dropped. It is as though this arresting minimalist composition, reminiscent of the visual language of the 1920s avant-garde, exemplified Romm’s personal ambitions, which could now be projected onto the blank wall-screen. The labels “modernist” and “realist” lost their meaning, dissolving into the white surface, which promises a cinema of intense engagement and formal rigor.

The Filmmaker, the Mentor, and the Thinker

Mikhail Romm presents a critical case study of a cultural establishment figure who acutely felt the weight of history and in whose ugliest manifestations he grasped his and his colleagues’ implications.³ The filmmaker’s

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often painful professional and personal self-evaluation is emblematic of the uncertainty and sense of culpability with which many members of the creative elite wrestled in the wake of Stalin's death and Khrushchev's Secret Speech.⁴ Seeking to come to terms with the past and reflecting on the role of art in representations of a changed perspective on history and the world became the twinned preoccupation of authors, visual artists, and filmmakers during the Thaw.⁵

Romm was hardly an ideological rebel, holding dear a romantic view of the Soviet cinematic achievements not only of the 1920s but also of the following decade. Although the 1930s were characterized by the establishment of the doctrine of socialist realism, the vicious antiformalist campaign, and the purges, it was also the formative time for Romm's career, which he associated with the formative period of Soviet cinema itself. When in the mid-1950s the filmmaker found himself in crisis, he wished to salvage the classics of socialist realism, such as *Chapaev* (dir. Georgy and Sergei Vasilyev, Lenfilm, 1934) and *We Are from Kronstadt* (*My iz Kronshadtta*, dir. Efim Dzigan, Mosfilm, 1936). He insisted that the films that had laid the foundation for socialist realism, produced between 1935 and 1938, were some of the best examples of truly Soviet cinema.⁶ Romm's desire to see a renewed modern cinema was inseparable from Soviets' past achievements, which he saw as a great tradition.

Romm distinguished himself in the 1930s when he made the diptych *Lenin in October* and *Lenin in 1918* and joined the rank of master directors.⁷ In 1940 Ivan Bolshakov, head of the Committee of Cinema Affairs at the Council of People's Commissars (the USSR's main regulatory and executive governing body between 1923 and 1946), appointed Romm to the post of artistic director (*khudozhestvennyi rukovoditel'*) of the Feature Film Department of the cinema administration, where he stayed until 1943.⁸ He made films consistently throughout the 1940s and early 1950s, up to Stalin's death, and was awarded the Stalin Prize five times, the highest honor at the time. By the 1950s Romm had established himself as an ally to the young filmmakers who would transform the look and reputation of Soviet cinema in the 1960s and beyond and would become global auteurs—Tengiz Abuladze, Arūnas Žebriūnas, Grigory Chukhrai, and Andrei Tarkovsky among them. As a mentor both at Mosfilm, where he made all of his films and was involved with training future directors and screenwriters, and at VGIK, where he had taught since 1949 and was made professor in 1958, Romm shared his anxieties and hopes about the art form and its future.

Romm's most fertile years of writing and lecturing, if not practice, fall between the late 1950s and mid-1960s—precisely when he reassessed his

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own body of work and, by extension, Soviet cinema as a whole and when the question of modern cinema arose most pressingly. The ideas about changing film language surfaced for Romm out of an urgent desire to understand the tragedies of war and of Stalinism and, to an extent, atone for the latter. His thoughts and work on *Nine Days of One Year*, a feature that marked a turning point in his career, reveal his idea of modern film, which pursued several aims: to reinstate Soviet cinema's leading place on the global stage, to dismantle Stalinist mythologies through visual and narrative strategies, to assert the professional independence of the filmmaking community from state bureaucracy insofar as this was possible, and finally—and perhaps most importantly—to expand and specify the perceptual and intellectual purview of cinema using a modern realist aesthetic.

The goal of creative independence and professional self-governance was largely enacted through various activities of the organization committee of the Filmmakers Union, of which Romm was a founding member. A greatly respected member of the industry, Romm used his status to rein in bureaucratic authority over the art form. The director advocated a more collective approach to decision making at his home studio, Mosfilm, and attempted to wrest a measure of professional autonomy by creating a more empowered artistic council. His tactical call was not for creative independence but for more collective responsibility among colleagues.⁹

During work on the melodramatic thriller *Ubiistvo na ulitse Dante* (*The Murder on Dante Street*), the director entered a period of self-questioning that grew into a full-scale crisis upon the movie's completion. Released in 1956, its story and visual style came across as outdated in comparison with the harbingers of change that appeared the same year, Marlen Khutsiev and Felix Mironer's *Spring on Zarechnaya Street* (*Vesna na Zarechnoi ulitse*, Odesa Film Studio) and Grigory Chukhrai's *Sorok pervyi* (*The Forty-First*, Mosfilm).¹⁰ When Romm screened *Dante Street* to his VGIK students, they rejected it.¹¹ He regarded his next effort, *Nine Days of One Year*, to be a profound break from his previous oeuvre. From the construction of the story to the use of sound, from visual composition to the choice of actors, *Nine Days* represents a kind of summation of the five years of reckoning and creative stewing. The film also manifests the formal awkwardness that is part of sincerity aesthetics, which shies away from the academism of classical narrative and formal techniques. In Romm's own words, the rigorous reexamination of ethical and artistic outlooks "untied my hands, allowing me to . . . scratch off the old scabs of professional habits and convictions."¹² Above all, the director considered it to be a modern film.

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Cinema Is on the Screen

During a 1962 discussion at the Filmmakers Union that focused on contemporary film, Romm mentioned the recent Soviet pictures *The Ballad of a Soldier* (*Ballada o soldate*, 1959), *Serezha* (1960), and *Ivan's Childhood* (1962), all made by young directors and all, incidentally, Romm's students, as examples of welcome change.¹³ None displayed much care for a clear cause-and-effect narrative progression and conventional character development. Instead, they were "reconsidering the arsenal of cinematic weapons."¹⁴ A different kind of cinema was in evidence elsewhere as well. In fact, it is the films from abroad that Romm gave most attention to during the Filmmakers Union discussion. Though he conceded that some of them suffered from ideological flaws, his curiosity as creator got the better of him, compelling him to praise their exploratory courage. One of the films that stands out in Romm's reflections and repeated references is Alain Resnais's *Hiroshima mon amour* (1959), which screened at the Moscow International Film Festival in August 1959 out of competition.¹⁵

In his analysis of the film, the Soviet cineast admitted to finding the juxtaposition of the burnt bodies of the atomic bomb's victims with those of the story's lovers distasteful and offensive. Yet his enthusiasm is undeniable, especially concerning the ways in which sound and image play off each other in intellectually exciting ways, providing "magnificent lessons in montage."¹⁶ The filmmaker singled out the sequences where the episodes taking place in the French town of Nevers are severed from the heroine's recollection of it, thereby creating an intricate texture of past and present.¹⁷ This technique, which Romm called *asynchronicity*, exhorts the audience to think. Perceptual or intellectual laziness is not an option when viewing *Hiroshima*. As a result of "the daring handling of the material," he notes, including "violation of all canons of dramaturgy, incisive juxtapositions, . . . and subverting the customary ways of joining shots," Resnais's film forces viewers to reflect, see, and hear "on a big scale" and not simply what is in front of them.¹⁸ The asynchronous relationship between sound and image was something Romm sought to implement in his own practice, rather tentatively in *Nine Days of One Year* and more resolutely in his compilation documentary, *Obyknovennyi fashizm* (*Ordinary Fascism*, 1965). *Hiroshima* seems to have allowed him to articulate these ideas.

On the second viewing of Resnais's film, Romm attempted to record on paper the film's visual and sonic registers—to make a filmic score of sorts—but without much success.¹⁹ Alluding to the age-old tension between directors and scriptwriters in the Soviet film industry, he remarked that it was of

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little relevance who had the top spot in the hierarchy: “What matters is that cinema is neither literature nor theater. It is what we see on the screen and not what we read, not what we draw, and not what we shoot.”²⁰ In this gesture of spreading responsibility—who dominates in the creative process, the director, the writer, the actor?—Romm in effect called attention to the unique alchemy that culminates in a finished object, materializing on the screen during the act of watching and experiencing—and not before. He found the impossibility of transposing *Hiroshima* by way of words and drawings thrilling. It served as powerful evidence of the cinema’s singularity, its irreducibility to one genre or even medium at a time when he and many of his colleagues were invested in delineating and extolling cinema’s unique capacities. “The best shot,” Romm wrote at this time, “is the one that’s very difficult and sometimes impossible to describe.”²¹ He saw in Resnais’s work unequivocal proof that film possessed attributes entirely its own that could not be claimed by the other arts or reduced to descriptions. In his position of relative authority, Romm used *Hiroshima* to promote a new modern cinema in which he discerned a new stage of development.

When André Bazin championed in his 1952 essay “For an Impure Cinema: In Defense of Adaptation” film’s involvement with theater and the modern, especially American, novel, he treated cinema as securely established, possessing its own evolved language. The French critic considered stage adaptations of literature and drama to be the evidence of film’s progress. “The reason,” writes Bazin, “film today is capable of effectively taking on the domains of literature and theater is because, first of all, it is master in its own house and has enough confidence in itself to yield to its subject. Finally, it can lay claim to fidelity . . . through an intimate understanding of its own structures, which is a necessary precondition for respecting the works of literature it adapts.”²² For Bazin, film’s interaction with literature and theater no longer subordinated it to the other arts. On the contrary, by adapting literary and stage compositions and techniques, the medium claimed its autonomy.

Romm perceived the situation with Soviet cinema to be substantially different. He exhorted his colleagues to rediscover and innovate film language, to acquire “an intimate understanding” of cinema’s own structures.²³ At stake in his reflections was film’s claim to artistic autonomy and, by extension, Soviet filmmakers’ freedom of creative exploration. Romm addressed this insistent refrain of cinema as a fully grown art as much to cultural authorities as to his colleagues, established and novices alike. His concern was the old question of the nature of cinema. If in postwar European debates film had been regarded as a fully evolved art form with its own laws

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and set of expressive possibilities, the seemingly established position of film's status was not shared in Soviet cinema but emerged as vital and highly relevant in post-Stalin discourse.²⁴ It is not a stretch to assume that at the heart of this push was the anxiety that film might be steered again into the straitjacket of Stalin-era realism. While at this time his peers, among them Iosif Kheifits and Ivan Pyriev, adapted Chekhov and Dostoevsky, respectively, Romm stayed away from literary and stage works.²⁵

It was only recently, in the immediate postwar period, that Soviet film production witnessed a sharp downturn in quantity, to say nothing of quality, resulting in what came to be known as "film anemia" (*malokartin'e*). Stalin's and Zhdanov's masterpiece policy precluded younger directors from entering the industry and older ones from experimenting with the medium.²⁶ The kinds of works that studio and cultural authorities allowed into production deplorably underused the range of aesthetic possibilities of cinema: At best, they were grandiose historic biopics; at worst, they were recordings of ballet performances and stage plays.²⁷ A month after Stalin's death, in April 1953, in a letter addressed to the party secretary, Khrushchev, and the minister of culture, Panteleimon Ponomarenko, a group of prominent filmmakers that included Romm rued the practice of making filmed theater: "We don't wish to besmirch the idea of shooting the best stage plays for their popularization. However, it's impossible to imagine that this method would satisfy Soviet audiences' interest in the art of cinema, to say nothing of advancing it."²⁸ The letter's signatories made a case for taking the medium in new directions, away from the proscenium arch. Romm's exhortations several years later show that he considered this still a relevant concern.

Resnais's film guided the Soviet director through developing his ideas about cinematic modernity, which in great measure involved viewing experience, implicitly reconsidering the relations between spectator and film. A key characteristic was "trust in the viewer," their inclusion in the "laboratory of artistic thinking."²⁹ Romm's conception of new modern film rested on reciprocity; after all, film is "what we see on the screen." Granting such an active role to the audience designates this new cinema as not simply modern but modernist. In this, as well as in his attempts to map out the medium's boundaries of representation, the Soviet director nears Clement Greenberg's definition of modernism as an autonomous, self-reflexive, medium-specific movement where each art form delineates its "unique and proper area of competence."³⁰ In the Greenbergian tradition of modernism, the beholder—or "the cultivated spectator"—is compelled to reflect upon the initial impressions of a Picasso painting in contradistinction to

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enjoying the “predigested” effects of a Repin canvas.³¹ Nancy Condee has pointed out that the antipathy toward modernism constituted “the central paradox” of the Khrushchev Thaw, which provided “the political conditions for a tentative reemergence of modernist values—whose overlapping characteristics include radical novelty, an impulse to extreme individuation, and the valorization of inaccessibility.”³² Certainly, Romm did not define cinema in terms of modernism as it is understood in the Greenbergian sense or otherwise. As someone whose views were indebted to a particular epistemology, the Soviet director never questioned realism’s supremacy, and as such, his conception of modern cinema was inseparable from an expanded understanding of realism. This is precisely what Romm’s reflections on *Hiroshima* and description of modern film suggest: a reweighting of realism that might still support what he perceived as important themes but could also offer active engagement through narrative construction and formal elements. An updated realist film should demand an effort.

Among the qualities that Romm lauded in *Hiroshima* and in several other films from abroad that he counted among the exemplars of true modern cinema were their *difficult* aspects, the intellectual work they required of the viewer—in other words, the viewer’s participation.³³ When *Nine Days of One Year* came out, Romm was delighted that young intellectuals embraced it. Among the letters in response to the film is an enthusiastic note of gratitude from a group of students of the Khabarovsk Institute of Railway Engineers to the film’s creators describing the film as “natural, truthful, relaxed, contemporary!” and (in roman letters) “Modern!!!”³⁴ Romm especially prized this segment of the educated audience. His reflections on the medium and his reactions to the reception of *Nine Days* raise a question as to whether his vision of modern Soviet cinema was still intended for the mass public, as stipulated by the tenets of socialist realism.

The director also maintained that modern film, in addition to challenging audiences, should be able to show the processes of thinking and feeling on-screen. A cinema of thought, as he envisaged it, was attentive to duration, which did not necessarily refer to long takes. It was rather a sense of duration, whether full or fragmented, spanning time or cut up into slices. Rhetorically, thinking was to be the structural nucleus of a narrative, which, in turn, would activate the intellectual and emotional involvement of the viewer. The beholder was invited—indeed, summoned—to connect the dots between images, sounds, and ideas, between the now of sitting in the movie theater and the now depicted on-screen. Therefore, formally, the cinema of thought had to figure out the principles of linking such images, which would

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now be divorced from the logic of action and instead follow the rhythm of thinking, feeling, and other internal processes.

Montage mon amour

To put into practice this notion of modern cinema as a cinema of thought meant primarily two things for Romm. One was a conscious return to the Soviet avant-garde, specifically, the theory and practice of montage. (The figure of Eisenstein in particular towered during this period with the publication of selected essays in 1956 and the release of the second part of *Ivan the Terrible* in 1958.) The other was an engagement with contemporary cinemas, exemplified by *Hiroshima*. These two aesthetic coordinates helped Romm find his bearings in a moment of crisis.

Romm's knowledge of Eisenstein had roots in a material, intimate encounter with Eisenstein's work in the late 1920s. As a research fellow in the Film Department of the Institute for Methods of Extracurricular Activities (Institut metodov vneshkol'noi raboty, IMVR), an early Soviet enterprise created for the study and improvement of the lives of children, the young Romm watched films on the editing table countless times, memorizing them at the level of the frame. Among these was *Battleship Potemkin*.³⁵

It is worth recalling that montage as an avant-garde practice had largely fallen out of favor under Stalin. But as early as 1950, in a meeting of film professionals gathered at the House of Cinema, Romm delivered a lecture in which he diplomatically defended montage by mentioning a successful example of it in a scene from *The Fall of Berlin*, a panegyric to the military genius of Stalin, who saves the world from Fascism. The film contains a lengthy sequence that collides with another equally lengthy sequence on the basis of contrast.³⁶ Romm was careful to say that in sound film, montage should be built out of greater sections than it was in silent cinema, that is, in the cinema of Eisenstein and the rest. However, describing transitions such as dissolves, fade-ins, and fade-outs as tired and ineffective, Romm championed the power of sudden cuts from a long or medium shot to a close-up. An unexpected sharp cut can create new ideas, new meanings, new feelings, which is precisely the notion behind intellectual montage, though of course he did not make this explicit in 1950.³⁷ The director closed his lecture by comparing film to mosaic, a medium made up of discrete elements. If the mosaicist makes the junctions invisible, it is no longer a mosaic but a drawing. An artist must not be afraid to preserve the uniqueness of a medium and foreground its most essential character, concluded Romm. Since cinema by its nature is discontinuous, filmmakers should

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make “this discontinuity into a working principle,” which of course was montage as practiced by Eisenstein.³⁸

In another speech at a film industry conference delivered eight years later and thus in a different political moment, Romm discussed Eisenstein primarily as a master of staging mass scenes, focusing on *Potemkin*, *October*, and *Aleksandr Nevsky*. The powerful scenes in which masses constitute the narrative and visual center are what distinguishes Soviet cinema as a whole, claimed Romm. The centrality of the crowd requires innovative mise-en-scène and montage techniques and therefore goes hand in hand with mass compositions.³⁹ This time, Romm unabashedly described Eisenstein as the innovator whose experiments were to help restore the visual daring to Soviet film by returning to montage, striking camera angles, and the close-up.⁴⁰

In 1958 Romm called for restoring the various meaning-making capacities of montage to Soviet cinema. “We must unite,” he declared in a speech at the same conference, “that which we found during the period of sound film with that which had been found during the silent era” in order to discover new cinema.⁴¹ This exhortation indicates an approach to the visual and sound fields on their own terms; it links them in ways that belie the transparency of illusionistic realism.⁴² Montage in the history of Soviet cinema was never exclusively about narrative editing—and at times it was against it. Romm, then, called for recovering the visual language of the Soviet avant-garde and combining it with sound technology.⁴³

To a great extent, Resnais’s film served as Romm’s mediator of Eisenstein and as a site where many ideas the Soviet director had been thinking about throughout the 1950s came together.⁴⁴ Resnais’s film demonstrated how to reclaim many operations of montage—how to utilize it to generate thoughts, ideas, and affect and to render characters’ inner worlds visible. At the same time, it did not shy away from larger themes of historical violence and collective memory. As for *Cahiers* critics, for Romm, too, *Hiroshima* was a model film both for its innovative montage form and for its preoccupation with history, shifting his notions about modern film.

At a 1959 *Cahiers du cinéma* roundtable discussion devoted to *Hiroshima mon amour*, Jean-Luc Godard and Jacques Rivette located Resnais’s legacy in Eisenstein’s montage. They pointed to Resnais’s reassembling of unity through fragmentation but “without concealing the fragmentation in doing so.”⁴⁵ Crucially, this was not a unity of “classic continuity” but of “contrasts.”⁴⁶ This unity in large measure was produced by what Romm described as asynchronicity of sound and image when he saw the film. Another *Cahiers* critic, Eric Rohmer, identified Resnais as “the first modern filmmaker of the sound film” on the basis of the director’s work with the powerfully associative

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joining of shots, of which sound, especially words, was an integral element. Rohmer explained his reasoning for ascribing this title to Resnais: “There has not yet been any profoundly modern cinema that attempts to do what cubism did in painting and the American novel in literature, in other words a kind of reconstitution of reality out of a kind of splintering which could have seemed quite arbitrary to the uninitiated.”⁴⁷ Scholar of French film Sam Di Iorio, citing Rohmer’s recognition of *Hiroshima mon amour* as modern, has noted that Rohmer “envisioned the modern as a return to montage, a term, which, in the wake of Griffith, Eisenstein, and Vertov, had moved beyond the straightforward concerns of narrative editing to designate a broader combinatory activity dedicated to the production of ideas.”⁴⁸

If the recovery and rediscovery of montage functions in sound cinema were marks of modernity in European film of the 1950s, Romm also, as we have seen, celebrated the delicate interplay of sound and image in *Hiroshima mon amour*. Whether he was aware of the *Cahiers* debate is unknown, but when he watched the film he saw that the cinematic wholeness presented by Resnais respected the profoundly fractured nature of the source material: memories. The asynchronous combining of images and sounds assembled a compelling universe of intimate memories against the backdrop of an unimaginable tragedy.

In Resnais Romm saw precisely what his avant-garde peers had advocated decades ago in the “Statement on Sound”: the emancipation of editing from the dialogue and often characters’ actions to yield affect and meaning. Using the technique of asynchronous or contrapuntal relation of voice and image in *Nine Days*, Romm made it a structural element in several scenes. As per his own declaration, the director attempted to organize sound and image material not according to the laws of dramatic development and suspense but according to the logic of the characters’ thoughts.⁴⁹

Defining Sincere Modern Film: History and Inner Experience

In a 1957 lecture at Mosfilm Studio’s training program for directors, Romm lamented that his young colleagues seemed to throw overboard what he considered great revolutionary cinema—the cinema that treats important historical themes and is not afraid to espouse and put big ideas up on the screen. He longed for it among the flood of movies about quotidian (*bytovye*) problems. The mentor pleaded with his students: “But, comrades, this [everydayness] was never the general line of Soviet cinema. And until we restore Soviet cinema to its highest form, in all its depth, with all its temperament, our struggle won’t stop.”⁵⁰ This desire to embrace a breadth of thematic

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possibilities without foreclosing representation of the crucial junctures in Soviet history pervades Romm's idea of modern realist film.

At the same time, he embraced the more intimate facets afforded by the film medium. The next year, at a national industry conference in Moscow, he delivered a speech in which he referred to two distinct modes of cinematic vision, one corresponding to the optics of the telescope, the other to that of the microscope. The director went on to say that contemporary filmmaking in the USSR required both: observation of life in a drop of water and observation of life from a satellite circling the earth.⁵¹ The metaphor might strike one as trite; its potential implications, however, are important. In a sense, the filmmaker encouraged his colleagues to explore cinematic techniques and styles, to play with form, to take the medium further because it had stagnated during much of the 1940s and early 1950s. It was also a reminder to the younger crop of filmmakers not to forsake the most valuable aspects of the Soviet cinematic tradition: its revolutionary temperament and great ambition to generalize, to paint a large canvas. "A film artist today," he declared, "must be able to master both devices."⁵² By the time Romm embarked on the project that would become *Nine Days of One Year* in 1962, he had elucidated his framework of modern cinema in a kind of double thematic reference that models this dialectic vision expressed via the telescope/microscope metaphor: in reference to history and to inner experience, with both of these approaches hinging on a self-referential exploration of the medium.

Romm insisted that the calamitous course of the twentieth century necessitated deep thinking about history and the present, which, consequently, demanded a new filmic form. He exhibited what Paula Amad, writing about the turn to archives in film practice in postwar European cinema, has termed "the intensified historical consciousness that developed around archival films and the representability of death after the Second World War."⁵³ For Romm, a sense of historical awareness was inseparable from modern film. When reflecting on cinema's role in contemporary society, the veteran director returned time and again to momentous events of the past and present: the newly established independence of several African nations, first photographic images of the lunar surface captured by the Soviets, the French nuclear test in the Sahara Desert in 1960, and many others.⁵⁴

The amount of archival footage grew exponentially in the wake of the Second World War, which was documented by the film units embedded in the military forces on both sides of the conflict. The amount and availability of archival material allowed critics and filmmakers, Amad writes, "to negotiate more confidently new modes of cinematic memory."⁵⁵ In examining

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the relationship between film form and history, film scholar Antoine de Baecque identifies what he calls “irruptions of history” in the elements of mise-en-scène in 1950s European cinema. He distinguishes the direct look to camera—“a singularly unbearable image, almost a formal signature” in the footage shot by the Allied forces’ film crews over the course of the liberation of the concentration camps—as the key formal element that transferred into modern film. “The looks-to-camera—in Bergen-Belsen and Buchenwald, in *Night and Fog*, *Europa ’51*, and *Hiroshima mon amour*—tells us that cinema had to change because nobody could remain innocent after these images, neither filmmakers nor spectators, neither actors nor characters,” Baecque writes.⁵⁶ “The eyes staring into the lens and at us are part and parcel of the century and its films, the highest evidence of the encounter of history and cinema.”⁵⁷ For Baecque, the look-to-camera signifies the “interpenetration of form and chronology” and represents “cinematographic forms of history.”⁵⁸ In effect, the history of the twentieth century created what we call modern cinema. This cinema had an unmistakable expiatory and accusatory edge. It also summoned the viewer to engage with the look and reckon with its range of meanings.⁵⁹ Baecque names Rossellini, Bergman, Chaplin, Resnais, and the French New Wave circle among filmmakers who now, in the long postwar era, “had to find forms that, in the films themselves, would give expression to the end of innocence and to experimentation with the modern.”⁶⁰

Romm undoubtedly belongs to this group. Although in his reflections the Soviet director never explicitly drew such a solid line between form and history as Baecque does, he nevertheless indicated so in practice in his two films made in the 1960s, *Nine Days of One Year* and especially *Ordinary Fascism*, the compilation film about Hitler’s rise to power and Romm’s own meditation on violence and evil.⁶¹ During his research for the latter project, Romm visited several concentration camps that had been turned into museums. At Auschwitz he came across a long wall covered with a myriad of small photographs taken by the camp police to create a record of the prisoners, each image depicting a face in three orientations: looking straight out, in profile, and a three-quarter view. To see the photographed faces clearly, one had to walk up close to the wall and confront these physical traces of evidence representing the unimaginable. The filmmaker was particularly struck by the eyes staring out, all possessing a shared expression. He described it as an expression of death. Romm went on to incorporate many of these photographs in the final sequence of *Ordinary Fascism*, which he considered to be the strongest in the film.⁶² In effect, he articulated cinematic modernity in terms of its relationship to the past.

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That Romm at this time turned to nonfiction, largely using archival footage and other documentary materials, gives an important clue to his ideas about the shape, affective power, and meaning of modern film and its imbrication with history.⁶³ However, it is not *Ordinary Fascism* but the director's last fiction work, *Nine Days of One Year*, that the rest of the chapter examines in detail. In many respects, this film is a distillation of Romm's reweighting of realist aesthetics, late career thoughts about modern cinema, its role in a fast-changing world, and its importance as a kind of tool for historic imagination and comprehension.

The film, which Romm began writing with the much younger scriptwriter Daniil Khrabrovitsky in 1960, and the documents pertaining to its production give us a peek into a creative laboratory where the director tested out the new interplay between image and voice, documentary footage and narration, the associative connection of shots that no longer presumed organic unity, all the while keeping in view a historical consciousness and exploring how film can access inner experience. He recognized that disjuncture between voice and image was at the heart of the modern cinema he wished to pursue: It could no longer ethically justify smooth, coherent, enclosed forms. At the same time, the director aimed to clear out "space for arguments and thinking."⁶⁴ The film's structure itself bears witness to the cracks in cohesion and wholeness, evidencing the formal and narrative tension characteristic of cinematic sincerity. During the writing process, Romm confessed to battling the deep-seated habit of inserting a showy dramatic turn here and there into the screenplay. As a result, the finished film embodies his struggle to steer clear of the well-worn ruts and fumble toward a modern intellectual cinema. It spotlights the tension between the pull of habit and the desire for renewal, between tradition and innovation.

The microscopic and telescopic optics shape the formal and thematic dualism of *Nine Days*, fulfilling Romm's efforts to create a modern film that accommodates historically significant themes and personal experience—nesting, as it were, the drop of water within the implied satellite vision that grasps the whole. Given that his formative period as a filmmaker occurred during the 1930s, it is hardly surprising that he framed this dialectic solely in realist terms. Romm never directly called for the expansion of realism by the inclusion of modernism. When discussing *Hiroshima mon amour*, he admitted that there was too much "modernism in it," which on the whole left him "with a certain foul aftertaste."⁶⁵ But his reflections and practice suggest that realist representations must embrace both visions, no matter the label, in order for Soviet cinema to blossom into a modern art form.

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Duality of Form: Caught Between Visions

Romm's dual vision raises the specter of totality. A concept elaborated and used by different philosophical traditions, totality is, of course, at the heart of Marxist thought.⁶⁶ Socialist realism as a method of artistic practice was founded upon the idea of a holistic perception of reality. In particular, Lukács based his interpretation of realism on a grasp of the complexities of the world that could formally be presented as an organic unity. The famous conflict among the leftist intellectuals in the 1930s, historically known as the Brecht-Lukács debate, illuminates Lukács's and, by extension, socialist realism's notion of the closed totality of an artwork.⁶⁷ In "Realism in the Balance," Lukács translates the importance of the socioeconomic totality into the realm of aesthetics:

If a writer strives to represent reality as it truly is, i.e. if he is an authentic realist, then the question of totality plays a decisive role. . . . Lenin repeatedly insisted on the practical importance of the category of totality: "In order to know an object thoroughly, it is essential to discover and comprehend all of its aspects, its relationships and its 'mediations.'"⁶⁸

Romm's twinned optics suggest something along the lines of representing an object thoroughly. But they also suggest different aesthetic regimes, realism and modernism, pointing to the blurring or perhaps even the mutual dependence of the two in his construction of *Nine Days*.

The film's formal equivocation registers a thematic dualism of scale—the global and the intimate. It swings between a love-triangle melodrama, wherein the hero risks his life for the sake of humanity and science and his survival is left uncertain, and a meditation on challenging questions about the moral complexities inherent in scientific progress. Romm appeared unable to choose which to pursue: Should the story be told via a conventional plot-based narrative, or should the material be organized according to a different principle? He answered yes to both questions.⁶⁹

The story of *Nine Days* takes place in two locales, Moscow and a small Siberian town built around an institute for research in nuclear physics.⁷⁰ The plot concerns a love triangle between young scientists: the experimenter Dmitry (or Mitya) Gusev (Aleksei Batalov), the theorist Ilya Kulikov (Innokenty Smoktunovsky), and Lyolya (Tatiana Lavrova), whose last name or branch of physics she studies we do not know. During an important experiment, Mitya receives a dangerous dose of radiation; when he comes to Moscow for medical observation, he is warned that another such exposure

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would be fatal. Lyolya, in love with Mitya but weary of his all-consuming dedication to science, decides to marry their mutual friend Ilya, who, unlike Mitya, is practical, has no martyr complex, and holds a less than flattering view of humanity. Once Lyolya, however, learns that Mitya may have only one year to live, she realizes that she still loves him. They marry and depart to the research lab in Siberia, where Mitya continues his work while she mostly mopes around and wonders if she made the right decision. The brilliant men embody the grander ambitions of *Nine Days*, exceeding the ménage à trois premise. They lock horns in the rarefied province of intellectual discourse, debating the worthiness of humanity and the ambivalence of scientific progress. Lyolya, on the other hand, can be seen as the catalyst of the melodramatic angle of the plot. There is also the narrator, whose role as an explicator is complicated by his voice's interaction with the images and in particular with the voices of the protagonists.

The figures of Mitya and Ilya arise from a specific context of the Soviet 1950s and early 1960s during which a debate unfolded about the social value of art, on the one hand, and of science and technology, on the other. It came to be known as the “physicists and lyricists” debate, a description taken from Boris Slutsky’s eponymous poem, published in 1959 in *Literaturnaia gazeta*. For many among the Soviet intelligentsia, the natural sciences exemplified not only progress but also a different way of existence that was free of shameful compromise, had more integrity, and was not confined, at least in theory, to a particular political-cum-economic worldview. Furthermore, the rigorous language of science—and, by extension, of scientists—never risked descending into monstrous relativism, at least in the popular imagination, as happened with literature and other arts during Stalinism and after. It could provide at once an incontestable and spellbinding interpretation of the physical world. Petr Vail and Aleksandr Genis note some of the reasons behind the towering status of scientists during this time: “The table of multiplication possessed the properties of absolute verity. Hard scientific knowledge seemed the equivalent of moral truth. Between honesty and mathematics there was the equal sign. After it had turned out that words could lie, formulas elicited more trust. Scientists were neighbors. Scientists were simple Soviet citizens. And yet they were different.”⁷¹

What eventually became *Nine Days of One Year* had a series of titles in the course of multiple rewrites, reflecting the changing form of the film. Out of the three versions of the literary script, the first two were known as “August–July,” while the third, “365 Days,” was often preferred in official correspondence between Mosfilm administrators and other parties. During the initial stages of the production, the title of the director’s script (*rezhisserskii*

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stsenarii) changed to the somewhat awkward “*Ia idu v neizvestnoe*” (I walk into the unknown).⁷² Midway through the shoot, Romm and his team came up with the term *fil'm-razmyshlenie* (film-meditation), a notion that would steer them for the remainder of the process.⁷³ Josephine Woll notes that Romm and Khrabrovitsky “developed a script driven not by plot but by ideas.”⁷⁴ The contemporary film scholar Viktor Demin considered the film to be structurally unconventional, without the cause-and-effect mechanism, giving spectators the opportunity to connect the discrete episodes on their own.⁷⁵ The reconceptualization of the film as a meditation perhaps prompted rechristening the project *Nine Days of One Year*.⁷⁶ This conceptual shift, which resulted in the different name, put a more precise emphasis on the form itself—away from the narrative movement evoked by “I Walk Toward the Unknown” to a more discrete perception of both profilmic and filmic material, with random episodes plucked out of time’s linear flow.⁷⁷ Such a narrative design allowed more freedom in ways of connecting the episodes and assembling the entire work.

On-Screen and Off-Screen Voices: Order and Chaos

The events in the film, the off-screen narrator instructs the viewer from the get-go, are less important than the thoughts and behavior of the characters. The voice of the narrator—always male in Soviet cinema—does not belong to a character in the film. His is the voice of authority. After the film’s title appears on the screen, he informs the audience that what they are about to see perhaps has never actually happened. “In fact,” he admits, “we allow that experts in nuclear physics will say that these events could never happen. . . . But the people about whom we will tell you, their relationships with each other, their attitude toward science, toward life, all this is true.” Immediately, the voice-over invokes the notion of totality embedded in the aesthetic of socialist realism by claiming to show enduring human behaviors and proclivities, the typical rather than the particular. Lukács summarized this dimension of the official aesthetic thus: “The realist must seek out the lasting features in people, in their relations with each other and in the situations in which they have to act; he must focus on those elements which endure over long periods and which constitute the objective human tendencies of society and indeed of mankind as a whole.”⁷⁸ The film’s narrator claims that the particulars are almost beside the point.

The narrator’s even-keeled delivery is heard against the whirring engine of a helicopter soaring above the dense taiga, whose otherworldly, not immediately recognizable texture fills the surface of the screen. As the viewer observes the land from the descending aircraft, the narrator concludes his

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preamble: “The events take place over the course of a year. . . . We will select only nine days. Why these days specifically? You will understand later. In any case, it begins far from the capital in a small town that consists of a couple of streets built around a large physics research institute.” The chopper glides over the roof of a modern building.

The narrated introduction is followed by a five-shot interlude prior to the credit roll: a long shot of a U-shaped, ultramodern console with two scientists in white smocks, a man and a woman, sitting behind it. A series of close-ups follows in silence: the man’s hand moving toward the woman’s hand on the console’s surface; the close-up of the man’s face on the left of the frame, his eyes intently concentrating on the data issuing from the console’s instruments; the woman’s face occupying the right side of the frame—she is watching him. This episode concludes with a medium shot of both scientists seen from the back as the man squeezes his colleague’s hand. The sequence unfolds in complete silence and acts as an interlude between the narrator’s setup, the sudden piercing siren that announces that an accident has just occurred somewhere in the core of the research facility, and the film’s credits. The precise framing and rhythmic joining of the shots unfolding in near silence recalls experiments of the Soviet avant-garde,



A bird's-eye view of the taiga in *Nine Days of One Year*

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Eisenstein in particular. As the siren disrupts the quiet, canted camera angles and dramatically oblique framing of faces and of scientists scurrying up and down metal staircases, in combination with quick editing, continue to evoke 1920s cinematic language. It most certainly jolts viewers out of their comfortable seats.

The opening suggests a certain degree of instability between a traditional presentation of the story and a more formally daring exposition, as shown by the bold visuals after the voice-over introduction. The extradiegetic voice, whose omniscience is rhetorically emphasized by the “we” and visually concretized through the aerial perspective, was heard less and less in Soviet fiction films during the Thaw. Instead, interior monologues and close-ups of faces and gestures—markers of subjective perception and interiority—were becoming increasingly requisite in representing individual experiences. Romm, however, still seemed to need the rhetorical device of voice-over to explain the structure and direction of the story. It returns a dozen more times to establish the importance of each day—“Day four. On this day, absolutely nothing happened. We chose it because, just like raindrops, this day resembled all the others”—and to frame sequences that highlight the passage of time.

The presence of voice-over commentary raises several questions, including those of control over meaning, of the narrator’s relation to the characters, and of authorial involvement. Why did Romm think a narrator necessary? Does it not render *Nine Days* less modern, which would be in contrast to his insistence that a modern film should invite viewers to think for themselves? He may have been too apprehensive simply to allow spectators to observe the visual register without structuring their perception. After all, the director was distressed when the State Film Distribution Agency (Glavkinoprokat) did not heed his wishes to roll out the movie gradually. Fearing that the film would not be understood, Romm thought that it should first be shown in a few central movie theaters accompanied by critical commentary in newspapers in order for the public to become adjusted to it and to grow a following.⁷⁹ Just as cineasts were tasked with searching for new forms, audiences, Romm contended, likewise needed to be reeducated in order to embrace and enjoy this new kind of cinema.

The acousmatic narrator—the voice disengaged from a body and having a tenuous connection to the filmic reality—is certainly in tension with the embodied voices of the characters.⁸⁰ The tension arises from two distinct temporalities: One rests with the narrator’s advantage of knowing what has happened, commenting upon what Michel Chion has called “the past-tense images,” while the other belongs to the protagonists, who lack such

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knowledge.⁸¹ Their temporal mode is that of the diegesis, of the private drama of their unfolding lives. While the commentator is not the film's author, he functions as an incontestable interpreter of narrative and image. He is framed as a classical narrator, which Soviet cinema had found indispensable for decades—a familiar voice that guides and edifies, keeps the viewer on the right path, and itself does not belong to anyone who inhabits the world on the screen.

Mary Ann Doane, in her analysis of voice and image via the technologically reconstituted body in cinema, has noted that voice-over, “capable of interpreting the image, producing its truth . . . is . . . beyond criticism. . . . [It] censors the questions ‘Who is speaking?’, ‘Where?’, ‘In what time?’, and ‘For whom?’”⁸² Significantly, it is this authoritative voice in *Nine Days* that asserts that the characters, their relationships, and their behavior are all true. In other words, it promises truth—no more, no less.

The claim to truth allies the use of the voice-over device with the persuasive function of speech in documentary mode.⁸³ From the outset, Romm had planned to insert in his film newsreel and other documentary footage that address the recent past. The fourth draft of the script lists 104 meters out of the total of 2,900 set aside for newsreel images (*khronika*), which amounts to about three and half minutes of film.⁸⁴ On the screen, these quickly edited inserts would frame several events in the narrative drama. For example, following the funeral of Mitya's mentor, the older physicist who dies of radiation poisoning, the narrator would say, “Enormous events took place in the world during these months. Humanity stood on the brink of war.” While Romm's team was in the process of obtaining permission to access newsreel footage at the Central Studio of Documentary Cinema (Tsentral'naia studiia dokumental'nykh fil'mov, TSSDF), the screenplay indicated placeholder descriptions such as “The newest destroyers are descending from the slipway. Giant aircraft carriers plow the waters of the ocean. Bombers with nuclear cargo rise from concrete airfields.” And this: “Precise content of text and images will be determined after the selection of footage.”⁸⁵

Much like the archival footage in the beginning of *Hiroshima mon amour*, the documentary supplements in *Nine Days* were to tear through the film's narrative as rhetorical punches, addressing the historical world and, by doing so, elevating the fictional drama. However, at a discussion of a rough cut by the artistic council at Mosfilm, several colleagues questioned the appropriateness of the newsreel footage. Yuri Khaniutin, for example, found it to “disrupt the rigorous stylistic unity” and undermine the depth of possible meanings.⁸⁶ Romm abandoned the conceit in the final cut, but in *Ordinary Fascism* he fully embraced archival material.

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It is not a stretch to assume that the filmmaker saw the narrator of *Nine Days* as his proxy—his own voice as author. Romm had recently gone through a crisis that changed his filmmaking. As his lectures and writings evidence, these changes mainly concerned sound-image relations. When in 1965 the director embarked on *Ordinary Fascism*, not only did he return to a narrator, he used his own voice. While at first it may seem like a classical disembodied and omniscient voice—a voice-of-God commentary, as it is known in documentary film theory—on closer look it is something else. Although the filmmaker never appears in the film, his voice possesses powerful corporeality. The specific vocal undulations, occasional hoarseness, and break-age typical of a longtime smoker undergird Romm's commentary upon the images flitting on the screen: Hitler and his cronies, sleepy German villages, parades, children, concentration camps. Kaganovsky likewise notes that the voice-over “is closely miked and spoken in a conversational, intimate style.”⁸⁷ The veteran filmmaker “created a new genre of documentary realism and historiography, a chance, as Romm put it, to have a cinematic ‘conversation’ with the viewer.”⁸⁸ Moreover, because it belongs to Romm, who literally controls the material through selection and editing, the voice has a concrete and personal relationship to the reappropriated and rearranged archival footage. Though authorial, his is decidedly not the voice of God. The merging of narrator and director in this way points to Romm's deep investment in the subject matter and rethinking of his own responsibility as author and artist.⁸⁹ Taking control of the material and of his own voice is something that the director seemed to have struggled with in *Nine Days*.

The narrator's extradiegetic position—outside or above the story and its protagonists—aspires to the status of omniscience, which is allied with the general, the total. But several formal strategies that Romm employs undermine the ostensible totality—and with it, cognitive intelligibility—exemplified, first and foremost, by the voice-over perspective.

One such strategy stems from the narrator's interaction with the image. In the opening shots, when he informs the audience about what to expect, the image of the lush northern forest fully covering the rectangle of the frame initially registers as an abstraction. The all-knowing and all-seeing narrator is identified with the aerial perspective, and his words serve an explanatory function, but a good twenty-five seconds elapse before spectators are able to discern for sure what lies before them. This suggests a degree of freedom of interpretation that is independent of the narrator, despite his purported reliability and omniscience. Moreover, the decoupling of voice and image, which Romm so admired in *Hiroshima mon amour*, implies that the world behind the filmic reality reconstituted in this way may

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also lack organic unity: After all, the days seem to be randomly selected and composed into a filmic shape. This disjunctive interaction between the aural and the visual fulfills Romm's directive to himself for more deliberate, asynchronous voice-image relations that create tension within the overall structure of the narrative. But especially provocative is the voice-over commentary's interaction with the film's characters.

A Woman as the Chaos of the Mind

The representation of Lyolya, the only female character of note in *Nine Days*, undercuts the notion of totality and authority. Although in comparison with her male counterparts she has less screen time, Lyolya is the only one who gets to have interior monologue. In one instance, as the heroine potters around the kitchen, she muses about what happened to her marriage: "He [Mitya] doesn't even notice whether I'm here or not. . . . I'm just a cold, empty-headed, mean, spoiled woman." In another, the heroine, her face filling the frame, intones, "I must get up and make him breakfast. Breakfast every single day. Breakfast every single day. I just want to sleep. Why do people eat? I'm a terrible wife." It is productive to consider these brief, gendered interior monologues in relation to the voice-over.⁹⁰

Doane notes that in the interior monologue "the voice displays . . . what exceeds the visible: the 'inner life' of the character. The voice here is the privileged mark of interiority, turning the body 'inside out.'"⁹¹ The privileged mark of interiority divulges mundane, gendered thoughts. However, by voicing Lyolya's interior activity, the film positions her opposite the voice-over: The heroine embodies a world of private anxieties, interior mystery, and fractured relations. As such, her anguished "he doesn't even notice whether I'm here or not" is no less valid than Mitya's defense of mankind or Ilya's historical overview of the pernicious use of science. In other words, Lyolya represents an observation of life in a drop of water, whereas the disembodied commentator exemplifies something akin to a totalizing view, and the male protagonists aspire to the narrator's position of authority. Mitya and Ilya are concerned with humanity, often speaking by way of generalities. Lyolya, in contrast, is interested in the singularity and details of a human life, no matter how trivial.

More frequently than her male counterparts, she is framed in a close-up, a sign of much desired interiority on the post-Stalin screen. The images of Lyolya, together with the brief instances of her monologic reflections, dislocate these parts of the film from the story's philosophical coordinates and more global vision and into the private, feminine landscape of self-observation and questioning.

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Close-up of Lyolya in *Nine Days of One Year*



God, they are both so smart.

Lyolya is alone with her thoughts in *Nine Days of One Year*

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The materialization of Lyolya's interiority can be read as that which is internal, concealed from the faculties of perception. Her position as a woman in the Soviet 1960s allows this internal perspective. On the one hand, the film trades on gender stereotypes, portraying Lyolya as unreliable and unfathomable, standing between the high-minded scientists, herself unsure of her role in the narrative. We see Lyolya only once perform the intellectual labor of a physicist, although she is ostensibly one of the boys. Preoccupied chiefly with domestic concerns ("Breakfast every single day"), she might as well not be there; except, of course, she is—through the weighted close-up, keeping her thoughts largely to herself. Thus, on the other hand, the close-ups of Lyolya signify interiority, suggesting a different organization of time and space, which, in turn, suggests another form of reality, that of the unknowable, the unbounded, that which cannot be organized into an ordered whole.⁹² Put another way, the visual and sonic registers that shape Lyolya's representation intimate the presence of chaos associated with minute movements of emotion and the human mind. And chaos in the realm of art was a term that keepers of socialist realist values routinely ascribed to modernism.

Socialist realism hinged on depicting reality "in artistic images" (*vkhudozhestvennykh obrazakh*), which, above all, equated representation with intelligible form.⁹³ Modernism, in contrast, dealt in formlessness. Marxist-Leninist experts in aesthetics maintained that modernists approached the world as an unknowable chaos. As such, representation with a basis in figuration was inadequate for this other, *alien* conception of reality. After all, modernism's purview, Soviet critics insisted, was "the tormented inner world of a bourgeois intellectual [*intelligent*]." ⁹⁴ But the intricacy of subjective perception by itself did not constitute art. A Soviet scholar of aesthetics asserted that "an inner world without the support of 'external' plastic, figural (or representational) expression turns out to be ambiguous, murky, expressionless, diffuse, and fruitless in the end."⁹⁵ Marcel Proust and James Joyce were routinely offered up as the exemplars of modernist authors who animated a reactionary theory about the unknowability of reality, which led to chaos.⁹⁶ In Kracauer's theory of film realism, such fragmented representations of consciousness and of the world are undergirded by the modern condition of the loss of ideology. Such a world has no "wholes"; rather, it consists of bits of chance events whose flow substitutes for meaningful continuity.⁹⁷

Form and its opposite, formlessness (or figuration and nonfiguration), sit at the heart of Soviet theory's anxiety about modernist art. As interpreted by socialist realist critics, nonfiguration alluded to formlessness and the unknowability of both consciousness and external reality. But rather than

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potentially pointing beyond verbal or visual meaning, formlessness was defined as a phenomenon close to nothingness—a negative value. The breakdown in literary form or visual figuration suggested the breakdown of consciousness. “Chaos,” Lukács remarked during the expressionism debate, “constitutes the intellectual cornerstone of modernist art.”⁹⁸ As early as 1927 the venerable Maxim Gorky wrote to his younger colleague Boris Pasternak: “It often seems to me that in your verse the link between impression and image is overly thin, almost elusive. To imagine means to introduce form, image into chaos. Sometimes I sense with sadness that chaos of the world overpowers the force of your creativity and is reflected in it precisely only as chaos, disharmoniously.”⁹⁹ This passage continued to be cited in the 1960s as evidence of mishandling artistic expression, blasting modernism wholesale, despite modernism’s heterogeneity.

In this particular framework, the device of voice-over in Soviet cinema does not merely edify, it staves off ambiguity of images, the potential for disintegration of form, and, ultimately, chaos. It provides definition to the images that enfold the world. But during the Thaw, extradiegetic and acousmatic voice-overs and other modes of totalizing narration began to compete for interpretation of images and expression of truth with interior monologue, which emanates from an embodied consciousness. In this tug-of-war for meaning and form, Lyolya stands as the most radical character in *Nine Days*. Her presence upsets the equilibrium of the grander narrative of historical and scientific progress, exemplified by the men and especially by the acousmatic narrator, who strives to explicate and shape the form of the story and hold it together.

Narrative Form and the Camera: Thought and Feeling

While the device of interior monologue creates tension and undercuts the authority of the narrator, other elements in the film likewise exist in an unstable relationship with one another. Although the narrator assures the audience at the outset that the events depicted in the film might be a con-fabulation, one can easily call into question their professed unimportance. The narrative moves along the surface of the chosen days, on some of which, the narrator informs us, nothing happens. But the main plot points are almost sensational—Mitya’s initial exposure to radiation; the second, more serious exposure in the latter part of the movie; and a wedding reception in between. What is interesting, however, is that although the dramatic elements of conventional cinematic narrative are in attendance, the director rearranges them to create something a shade less recognizable.

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The wedding, which concludes a protracted exposition and occurs forty minutes into the story, barely focuses on the newlyweds; instead, it becomes an occasion for Romm to stage a series of conversations among the carousing physicists around matters of nuclear science, the solar system, and galaxies beyond. During a Mosfilm discussion of a rough cut, Khaniutin lauded these conversations as an attribute that ushers *Nine Days* into the realm of “intellectual drama.”¹⁰⁰ Structurally and rhetorically, then, the wedding scene bucks classical convention: It is wedged roughly in the middle rather than at the end and decides little. Perhaps the old habits and the microscope/telescope dialectic held Romm back from innovating the form to the extent that he might have wished. Where he undoubtedly succeeded is in the intricate staging of several chamber scenes, whose internal structure is built on the movement of thought and emotion—his attempt at a cinema of thought.

One such scene occurs prior to the wedding party in the Georgian restaurant Aragvi, where Lyolya, Ilya, and Mitya go after Mitya has been discharged from the clinic. This key scene, lasting ten minutes, can be broken down into several emotionally tense episodes whose composition hinges on reshuffling character combinations: All three are at the table; as Mitya leaves to have a word with the maître d’, Lyolya and Ilya quietly argue about telling Mitya that they have decided to get married; Mitya returns and asks about his friends’ uneasy silence; while Ilya is off to speak to a colleague in an adjacent room, Mitya and Lyolya reconnect and rehash fragments from their past love affair; and finally, the men duel in an exchange about scientific progress and humanity while Lyolya looks on from the sidelines. Surgically staged and directed, with close-ups inserted at precise moments of pathos, the restaurant sequence epitomizes Romm’s desire to make characters’ thought processes and emotional states the organizing principles of the narrative. The filmmaker was very specific about the kind of acting he wanted, for he imagined modern cinema with actors whose faces and bodies could convey thinking to the camera and the viewer. If in the first minutes of the film the older scientist who perishes from radiation—in effect, he acts out a dramatic death scene—is played by an actor who had mastered his craft in the realist theater of the Stanislavsky system, then the rest of the story is told through the younger cast’s body language, which is subdued and has a more intimate interaction with the camera.¹⁰¹

The scene begins with a crane shot, grasping the commotion of a busy restaurant, a pattern of round tables dotting the rectangle of the frame. From a high angle, the camera precipitously pulls in to the table with the trio. This swooping motion of the camera through which the viewer enters the

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The crane shot: entering the restaurant scene in *Nine Days of One Year*

restaurant sets up the intense narrative space for the whole sequence, unrelentingly focused, with precise framing and subtle camerawork that scrutinizes the characters' faces, body language, and shifts in dynamics from different perspectives. The occasional, slightly comic interludes of the balletic blocking by the waiters interrupt this intensity, but such interruptions are like quick intakes of air: They give the viewer just enough relief, followed by the camera's return to its main subject—the inner turmoil of the protagonists.

When Mitya first leaves the table to convince the *maître d'* that his companions are distinguished guests and must be treated accordingly, the tight two-shot of Lyolya and Ilya is charged with intensity. They do not look at each other. Their physical closeness in the frame, the inward curving of their bodies, the camera angle away from the prying eyes, and the proscenium arch of the stage at the back of the restaurant offsetting the characters dramatize their states of mind. When Mitya returns to the table, a quick dolly out shifts the spectator's attention onto him as he sits down, framed by the bright opening of the arch. Mitya immediately notices his friends' awkward silence. The sudden comings and goings of waiters serving the table alleviate the tension for several seconds. When it resurges, it is mostly in the

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close-ups and two-shots, which cut up the space occupied by the threesome. Mitya recognizes that he might be the reason behind his friends' quiet. Lyolya is about to tell him the truth at the moment when Ilya spots a colleague and wanders off. As he leaves the frame, the camera moves in for a close-up of Lyolya, her face a map of unease, to introduce the next part of this emotional drama.

The following episode parses the play of feelings that pass between Lyolya and Mitya not only through dialogue but also through an unhurried movement of the camera making a half-circle along the table from him to her. The erstwhile lovers are always in the frame: The single take begins with Mitya facing the camera and ends on the other side, with Lyolya's face in view. The movement of the camera tracks Lyolya's mind—upon its completion, she made the decision not to marry Ilya. In addition to the protagonists' body language and looks, the gentle crescent that the camera traces separates the couple from the rest of the *mise-en-scène*, which is deep-staged. Their eyes remain on each other, with Lyolya sensing that Mitya's hurtful words are a mere facade. A cut to Ilya walking toward the table announces the next segment. To continue this fraught game of musical chairs, now Mitya briefly departs as the camera dollies in closer to concentrate on the two left at the table: It is their turn to register their emotions. Sensing that something has changed in Lyolya's mood since they last spoke, Ilya seems momentarily disoriented. When Mitya returns, Ilya shifts his attention to his friend, and an intellectual repartee ensues.

The camera moves in once more, this time to section off the men from Lyolya. The conversation between the two physicists takes place while they are in a static frame, Mitya in profile, eating with great concentration, and Ilya facing him and the audience. Ilya suggests that Mitya join his laboratory. The position, presumably in Moscow, comes with an apartment, which would be a very tempting proposition in the post-Stalin period, given the housing shortage in the capital. Mitya declines. He says that he must finish what he had started, that is, his experiments in nuclear fusion research, which prompts Ilya to ask, somewhat challengingly, "You '*must*'? Who says you *must*?" Continuing to eat, Mitya calmly replies, "Humanity. Is that good enough?" In response, Ilya fires off a litany of scientific achievements and casts a damning light on the human race: "Science created the most perfect chemistry: The Germans made poisonous gases. The internal combustion engine was developed: The English built tanks. Finally, the chain reaction was discovered: The Americans dropped the bomb on Hiroshima. All this doesn't make you want to stop and think?" But humanity and scientific

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Lyolya and Mitya reconnect in *Nine Days of One Year*

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progress find a defender in Mitya, who dreams of harnessing thermonuclear reaction for peace.

Within the context of Romm's pursuit of the cinema of thought, the repartee between the physicists can be understood as cinema of thought's rhetorical aspect. Quite simply, such cinema would allow space for intellectual discussions to occur on-screen without being restricted by the demands of a plot. Ilya, with his recitation of historical facts, stands in for the documentary footage, the inclusion of which Romm eventually abandoned. Similar conversations multiply throughout *Nine Days*, channeled through men in white smocks at the Siberian research institute, where Mitya returns after the wedding to resume his groundbreaking work. Romm and his younger coscriptwriter aimed to clear out "space for arguments and thinking."¹⁰²

During the 1950s and 1960s the nuclear arms race and scientific progress preoccupied many minds. While at work on the screenplay, Romm and Khrabrovitsky paid a visit to Igor Tamm, a nuclear theorist and one of the 1958 Nobel laureates in physics, who in the postwar years had successfully headed the hydrogen bomb project in the Soviet Union. During their conversation, Tamm, unprompted, raised ethical concerns that at present troubled him and his colleagues.¹⁰³ To strive for scientific achievements became inseparable from pondering humanity's ability to cause catastrophes and potential self-annihilation. It was imperative for Romm that his characters wrestle with the weight of such heavy questions, answers to which had far-reaching implications and could change the course of history. Putting them front and center also meant continuing realism's promise and, crucially, restoring the general line of Soviet cinema to its former renown. Modern cinematic realism needed to wrestle with grand, consequential issues, a goal that Romm, despite his search for formal innovation, set for himself as well.

During this intellectual exchange-cum-duel, it is once again Lyolya who seems to throw off-balance the film's attempt at momentousness. She is spatially excluded from the conversation between the two men, depicted in close-ups, and lost in thought. She is miles away. Moreover, she does not belong to this scene generically. While the men debate the big issues, her interior monologue focuses on Mitya. In effect, her presence and deliberate distance vis-à-vis the men in this sequence bring *Nine Days* to the other side of Romm's formal equivocation: The stylistic treatment of Lyolya shepherds the film into a melodramatic narrative. She is the heroine of the melodrama in *her head*. And whereas Ilya is pulled into it via the circuitry of glances between them, Mitya remains grounded in his own space, momentarily cut off from the vicissitudes of this plotline.

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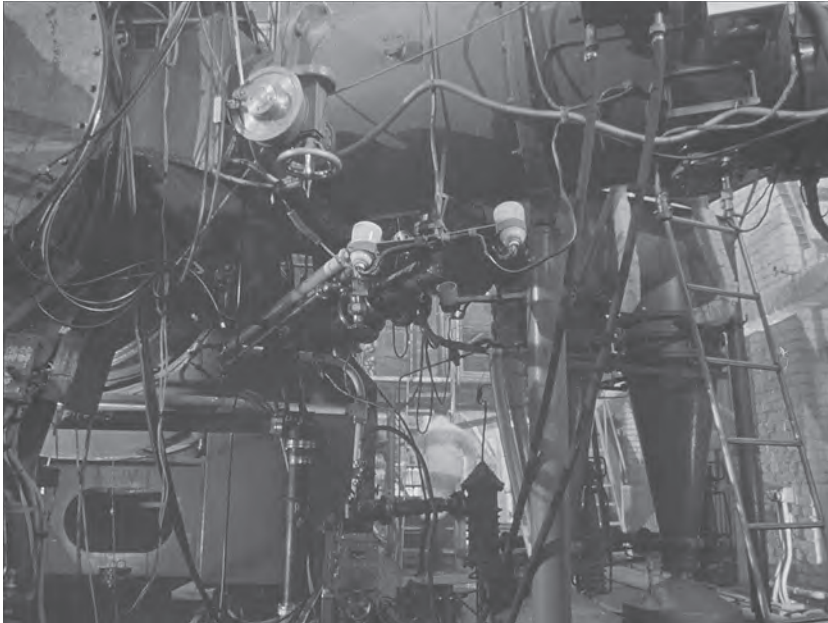
We leave the restaurant the way we entered: A crane shot, swiftly moving out and up, closes the sequence. The visual symmetry suggests an enclosed form, but the camerawork in the segment that captures Lyolya and Mitya realizes a stirring of thought and feeling. In one measured motion, the camera slices through the safeguard of Mitya's cynical words, suggesting vulnerability underneath. Film form itself registers a depth that is behind explanations of behavior and action.

Man and Machine

Unlike his younger colleagues and his peer Mikhail Kalatozov, as well as numerous filmmakers in the West, Romm did not identify modern cinema with the shift to the outdoors, although he praised the authenticity and spontaneity it brought to realist filmmaking, especially Italian neorealism.¹⁰⁴ Of the total 2,900 meters of film in *Nine Days*, only 576 were used for shooting on location.¹⁰⁵ The environments created by the film merely serve to frame the characters' mental states and conversations, as the restaurant sequence shows.¹⁰⁶ The environment is key in one respect only: the research institute, a warren of rooms stuffed with ultramodern, enigmatic machinery where Mitya and his colleagues spend most of their waking hours. The visual deliberateness of this temple of thought gestures toward a form of realism that is both retrospective and avant-garde. As a space that constitutes Mitya, it is an extension of his inner world.

Romm considered the thermonuclear laboratory and the industrial machinery therein to be an attraction in the sense of Eisenstein's attractions. In an essay written in the mid-1960s, he refers to Sergei Tretiakov and Eisenstein's 1924 staging of Tretiakov's play *Gas Masks* (Protivogazy) at an actual gas plant. The production, which Romm had witnessed firsthand, stimulated his imagination during the filming of *Nine Days* and to an extent guided his vision toward the kind of ultrarealism achieved by Tretiakov and Eisenstein decades earlier, where the staging included an appropriate gas stench to boot.¹⁰⁷ However, Romm could not realize such vision: It was impossible to shoot in an actual thermonuclear facility.¹⁰⁸ Instead, inspired by the Institute for Nuclear Research in the town of Dubna, near Moscow, Romm had his Mosfilm crew build a complicated set, which dominates the screen space of the film's second half, alternating with the chamber compositions set in Lyolya and Mitya's apartment.¹⁰⁹ The camera angles, framing, and shapes of the impressive scientific equipment in these scenes recall the visual poetics of the Soviet avant-garde as well as the 1930s films that take place in factories and other industrial spaces, portraying the proletariat doing their part.

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At the Institute for Nuclear Research in *Nine Days of One Year*

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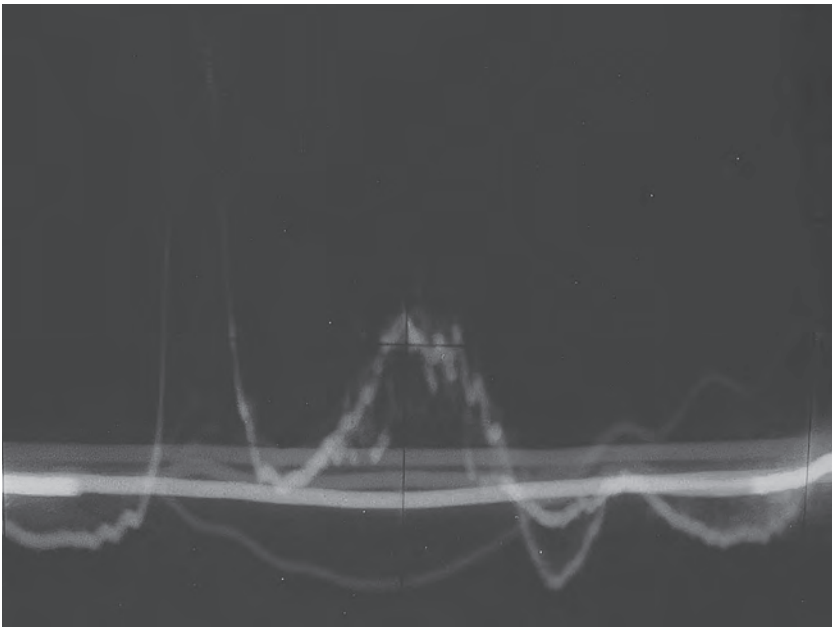
Here, however, the labor is intellectual; its manifestations are less conducive to cinematographic forms. The images of the lab invite interpretation beyond the political exigency of Soviet realism. By making scientists and, by extension, the labor of science one of the main subjects of the story, the director fulfilled his wish to create a film whose narrative progresses by taking into consideration characters' thought processes. At the same time, the mass of wires and tubes, as well as the sleek metal contraptions stretching into the depth of the screen space, frequently obscure the human subjects or press them to the edges. There are moments when the humans no longer constitute the visual point of interest in the texture of a shot.

The anthropocentric realism associated with the Soviet realist aesthetic veers into another articulation. The film humanizes the scientists' work. It often shows Mitya and his team fiddling with sophisticated equipment, sometimes on the artisanal rather than the industrial level, as when one researcher, for instance, uses a soldering iron to fix a technological problem. But this act of humanization only goes so far. The film's images create a chilling equilibrium between technoscience and human beings.

The team installs a brand-new system on which the hero pins all his hopes. Indeed, success comes, but at a high cost. The scene in which Mitya at once achieves long-desired results and receives radiation exposure hints at this sinister balance, materialized via a shot / reverse shot sequence—the scientist peers at the screen of the system through a visor, and the system stares back. Its penetrating gaze registers in the changing expression of the man's eyes; there is nothing human about the look that stares back. This nonanthropocentric articulation of realism hints at another form of consciousness. The gaze of the inanimate apparatus holds a vulnerable human in tight view.

The exchange of looks between man and machine produces thought on-screen. It is visualized in Mitya's concentrated expression, mediated by the oculus of the system, which echoes the shape of the human eye, and by way of the electronic waves pulsing on the apparatus's screen. Presumably, the screen communicates significant information about nuclear energy, evoking the conversation between Ilya and Mitya in the restaurant: Once a momentous discovery has been made, what happens next? This scene has a moral resonance with the hospital sequence in *Hiroshima mon amour*, part of the opening montage, which shows victims of the atomic bomb looking into the camera and turning away. This brings me back to Baecque's "irruptions of history" and to Romm's articulation of modern film in relation to history.

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Man and machine in *Nine Days of One Year*

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Mitya's look into the camera/machine is a descendant of the fixed stare that migrated after 1945 from documentary footage into fiction film in the 1950s and gave modern cinema its shape. The heroine Irene Girard and her fellow residents at a mental institution in *Europa '51*, the survivors of the atomic trauma in *Hiroshima mon amour*, and Mitya in *Nine Days*—their look-at-the-audience shares in a powerful sense of humanity.¹¹⁰ Conjuring up anguish, this look can be read as accusatory, bewildered, or resigned. It manages to combine an awareness of the present and ethical questions for the future with the weight of the past. Shots such as these reveal a reality in which history impresses “itself into the filmic material, into the mise-en-scène.”¹¹¹ Through the cinema apparatus, a shared history of humanity extends across time and space and connects these characters to each other and to the spectator. Not shy of such pathos, Romm demands the audience's involvement, trusting it to ask difficult questions. What does Mitya see or imagine? Does the machine mediate for him the actual horrors that, in the words of Kracauer, “we do not, and cannot, see . . . because they paralyze



The film stares back in *Hiroshima mon amour* (dir. Alain Resnais, 1958) and *Europa '51* (dir. Roberto Rossellini, 1952)

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us with blinding fear; and that we shall know what they look like only by watching images of them”?¹¹² Does he glimpse the horror of nuclear annihilation and his own role in such a possibility? Significantly, Mitya hardly speaks during his interaction with the machine, with the exception of a countdown. While his colleagues triumphantly yell “Hooray!” he remains silent. The pregnant pause from language marks this moment of reckoning as an ethical predicament for both Mitya and the audience, his silence a mark of sincerity.

The images of Mitya and the machine’s interaction further support Romm’s microscopic and telescopic modes that constitute a modern Soviet film, where a graspable totality—a perspective “encompassing immense temporal and spatial categories” that is able to see “an era, a country, a people”—and the chaos emblematic of a closer, more internal view have a place.¹¹³ Both optics are present, if only philosophically, as the physicist makes a big discovery in an intimate exchange with a machine while the spectator bears witness. Most important, Romm understood that if Soviet cinema were to be taken seriously by audiences—not as a mouthpiece of the state but as genuine artistic expression, free of the edifying enthusiasm of such films as *The Fall of Berlin*, which mythologized Stalin, or *The Cossacks of the Kuban*, which grotesquely embellished life on a collective farm—then it needed to reconfigure the beholder-film relation. This new cinema had to reflect audiences back to them in a way that would model a new kind of fellowship, one founded on a collective self-examination and shared history.

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CHAPTER 3

Staging Sincerity and a Promise of Community

Ilyich's Gate

When in 1959 author Viktor Nekrasov compared *Poema o more* (*The Poem of the Sea*, dir. Yulia Solntseva, Mosfilm, 1958), based on Oleksandr Dovzhenko's screenplay, to Khutsiev's *Two Fyodors* (1958), his critique hinged on the viewer-film relation. Nekrasov objected to the overwrought, declamatory speech of the characters in *The Poem of the Sea* and commented that the film "always talks, explains, justifies either through the heroes or through itself," betraying its anxiety about trusting the spectator to "read" a character and, by extension, the image.¹ Contrariwise, "in *Two Fyodors* the characters speak little. But when they are silent, I know what they are thinking."² The possibility of sincerity in the cinema of the Thaw was predicated on the turn to intimate, frequently inarticulate, verbal expression and away from the prescribed forms of the previous era's collectivity. A sense of solidarity experienced by characters during these years did not derive from the myth of the Great Family but from distressed and "broken" people in search of warmth and connection.³ We see it in *Two Fyodors*, where a young orphan and a lonely soldier adopt one another, and in *Me, Grandma, Ilike, and Ilarioni* (dir. Tengiz Abuladze, 1962), which paints a moving portrait of a small Georgian village where familial ties extend beyond one's immediate relatives, including eccentric elders. By turning stories inward and placing an ordinary person at the center, the cinema of sincerity sparked formal renewal of the medium that hinged on reinventing, to use Svetlana Boym's description, "the culture of friendly intimacy," which was "opposed to the official collectivity, the Soviet family, and even the nuclear family."⁴ Nekrasov and others who were engaged in criticism understood that film needed to, above all, reconfigure viewer-screen relations.

To restore cinema's social function, the medium's ritualized gestures, to recall Ernst Gombrich's phrase, had to be thematically rethought and

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aesthetically renewed. One avenue was to deheroicize characters and organize mise-en-scène in a way that permitted them to be wholly absorbed in their “unheroic” activities, which resulted in the refigured position of the viewer vis-à-vis the action on the screen.⁵ Romm wrestled with the voice of authority, was wary of relaxing the narrative structure, and attempted to bring forth the interiorities of his characters in *Nine Days of One Year*. The creators of *Ilyich's Gate* did not appear to face such struggles, although they, too, aimed to restore the revolutionary ideals through their earnest characters. The story takes place in contemporary Moscow and follows the lives of three working-class young men, Sergei (Valentin Popov), Nikolai (Nikolai Gubenko), and Slava (Stanislav Liubshin), who represent the generation that in the 1960s was trying to come to terms with the country's past while facing everyday ethical dilemmas. A scene early in the film exemplifies formal exploration that decenters a single voice of authority, plays with language, and serves as an introduction to the characters.

In a long shot, the camera glides along Chistye Prudy, a park in Moscow, gathering the atmosphere of an autumnal evening. The voices of the three pals are heard off-screen. A traveling shot and Nikolai's recitation of Aleksandr Pushkin's poem “October has arrived—the woods have tossed / Their final leaves from naked branches” are launched simultaneously. The images sailing by accord with the rhythm and mood of Pushkin's verse: The camera moves at the pace of a brisk walk, catching the tree trunks, the bleary glow of streetlights, and the mist rising from the ground. At the end of the poem's first rhyming unit, Nikolai's voice fades out, and Sergei's thought enters the soundscape with prosaic questions addressed to himself: “What's going on? How much time passed? . . . Yes, three months since I returned, but I feel as if I had never left. I am constantly waiting for something, but what?” Nikolai's declaiming of Pushkin returns, now in midpoem. Four lines of the lyric once more yield to Sergei's interiority, confessing his confusion in the face of civilian life: “In the army, everything is clear—it's a military service. Rev-eille!” All the while the tracking shot keeps pace in a long take, now catching up with the trio briskly walking through the park. It becomes clear that the off-screen voices are interior, hovering over the cityscape, unattached.

When the film finally cuts to the medium shot of the young men, the camera continues to travel, while Nikolai's and Sergei's inner voices swap. The formation of the figures visualizes the aural interlocking when Nikolai weaves himself from the middle ground through his friends' bodies and onto the foreground. Pushkin's poetry cascades into everyday language all in one breath as Nikolai thinks: “The blood flows free and easy in my heart, / Abrim with passion; once again, I'm happy, young / I'm full of life—such

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The three friends: a long tracking shot in the park in *Ilyich's Gate*
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is my organism. . . . What's with him? Must've fallen in love. Lucky. I can't remember the last time it happened to me." The interior conversation is momentarily interrupted by an outburst of trivial phrases said aloud about the weather and then retreats once more into the interior world of each character, where Pushkin's verse reappears and mixes with mundane language.⁶ Slava, whose voice has so far been absent, registers his thoughts: He is working out the probability of his favorite hockey team, Spartak, winning in this season's playoffs. This is no language of slogans or prefabricated pronouncements. Instead, in commingling poetry with everyday speech, a deheroicized character expresses himself in deheroicized thoughts: "What's with him? Must've fallen in love. Lucky" or "If Spartak wins in Moscow, has a tie in Minsk . . ."⁷ To simply write in the script, as Gennady Shpalikov did, "They walked in silence, each with his thoughts," and subsequently vocalize thinking on-screen with the characters' own voices amounted to a fundamental shift in form and consciousness.⁸

Marlen Khutsiev and script coauthor Gennady Shpalikov relinquished tight, cause-and-effect storytelling, constructing episodes that threatened to branch off into multiple narrative trajectories; permitted the characters to express their thoughts, no matter how inarticulate and trivial, emphasizing subjective perspectives; and staged large crowd scenes that not only manifested the impression of spontaneity but also acknowledged and enveloped the film audience in the act of creation, thereby dramatically reshaping how spectators related to the projected reality. The characters' immersion in their own world in particular signaled a crucial change in the relationship between the filmed image and the audience.

Absorption, Interiority, and the Past

Inspired by Denis Diderot's art criticism in his study of French painting of the mid-eighteenth century, Michael Fried proposes an evolution of the art of painting on the basis of the opposing concepts of absorption and theatricality, which surprisingly strikes at the heart of the Soviet aesthetics of sincerity.⁹ Fried compares the mannered depiction of subject matter in many paintings in the age of Diderot with canvases by Jean-Baptiste Greuze and Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin, which, by contrast, show figures utterly consumed by everyday tasks. They appear so involved that their disposition and conduct disinvite the observer from their pictorial world. For Fried, such images represent models of this alternative conception of painting where the absorption of painted figures is opposed to the "theatricality" of the rococo tradition.¹⁰

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Persons engrossed in action, be it peeling turnips, nodding off, or blowing soap bubbles, do not ingratiate themselves to the viewer. They do not pose—and are not posed—for an audience. Their state of unselfconscious immersion in the narrative of which they are part precludes the straightforward picture-beholder relation. This conception of painting, Fried explains, rests on “the fiction of the beholder’s nonexistence in and through the persuasive representation of figures wholly absorbed in their actions, passions, activities, feelings, states of mind.”¹¹ In such artworks the acknowledgment of the beholder is denied or considerably diminished, rearranging how the beholder is integrated into, excluded from, or otherwise summoned to relate to what is depicted on a canvas. Fried calls this viewer-picture relationship the “insuperable problem for painting.”¹² The detheatricalization of the relationship between spectator and screen was reworked in Soviet Thaw cinema to great effect, creating the aesthetics of sincerity right in front of the spectator, as we will see later. But at the moment I want to focus on this insuperable problem, which gets to the core of the cinema of sincerity, namely, its changed audience-screen relation through *mise-en-scène* and narrative.

In Stalin-era movies, protagonists possessed little personal desire; their existence was usually bound up with matters of the state, even if veiled as personal pursuits. They were oriented outward—toward the spectator, toward the propagandizing function of socialist realism, and, ultimately, toward the benevolent gaze of the leader, who was always watching. If film heroes looked directly into the camera, such as in Dovzhenko’s *Aerograd* (Ukrainefilm/Mosfilm, 1935), Lev Arnshtam’s *Podrugi* (*Girlfriends*, Lenfilm, 1936), or Grigory Aleksandrov’s *Svetlyi put’* (*The Radiant Path*, Mosfilm, 1940), it was to include spectators in the narrative of socialist progress, exhort them to be vigilant, or, in the words of Anne Eakin Moss, imply “the sublime, illuminated presence of Stalin himself.”¹³ In the majority of the movies made during the Stalin epoch, elements such as the commanding male voice-over, the pontifical quality of address (even if direct), the body position and language that were supposed to connote fidelity to the party, and the dramatic unmasking of the enemy insisted upon the viewer’s attention and even awe.¹⁴ By contrast, many Thaw films feature characters firmly rooted in a contemporary moment whose behavior disregards social endorsement and submission to others’ demands; they seek answers to pressing questions and are fully absorbed in their own life, pursuits, and states of mind, which marked them at the historical juncture as sincere, not false—as not pretending.

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The controversial scene of the heart-to-heart between Sergei and his father, which Khrushchev famously condemned, is one such example. The episode is even more pointed in terms of how it threads the past and the theme of time into the newly found sense of character absorption and introspection. The scene illuminates how a character's inner struggle and expression of feeling encourage the possibility of engaging with the past on a more personal, intimate scale where resolution is far from certain. Lilya Kaganovsky has noted that one of the key themes of the films made during the 1960s is memory "(specifically, traumatic memory, the memory of the war) and its relationship to the generation that came after, the generation that did not live through Stalinism or the Second World War but that nevertheless felt itself to be responsible for the events of the past."¹⁵ The cinema of sincerity's interest in the personal opened up the potential for manifold narratives, narratives whose trajectories parted ways with the sacrosanct mythology of historical events or resisted the linear movement of time.

The past inhabits the surfaces and the recesses of *Ilyich's Gate's* reality. The forgotten ration card from the war years or the trio of military figures whose measured steps echo through the streets of Moscow in the opening and closing of the film are only a pair of instances of such proximity to history. The characters enter into a frictional relationship with the Great Time of the Past, to recall Katerina Clark's categorization of temporalities in the socialist realist novel, where there "was an absolute cutoff between actual historical reality and the 'reality' of these official Great Times." Clark writes: "No event of the present time could transcend its profaneness unless it could be dignified by some identification with a moment either from the official Heroic Age or from the Great and Glorious Future. The meaning of all present-day reality was derived from its relationship with these mythic times."¹⁶ The inviolability of the mythic temporality was greatly compromised after Stalin's death. Khutsiev and Shpalikov's protagonists have to work through the confusion caused by the misalignment between the official narrative of history and splintered personal stories, complicating the dual sense of time, which results in a new treatment of film form. Alexander Prokhorov maintains that *Ilyich's Gate* "is central for reviving Soviet political mythology during the Thaw, and above all the myth of the Great Family."¹⁷ I have a somewhat different reading in this regard. Struggling to recover and apprehend fragments of the past, rescuing the present from its profaneness, and making sense of their own lives are what *Ilyich's* characters are after. Analogously, the struggle between the allegorical dimension of socialist realism and a renewed, nonallegorical form of realism is embodied in this operation of recovery of the past.

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The encounter between father and son takes place toward the end of the film, when Sergei returns home from a party where he just had an upsetting argument with his peers about what their generation should take seriously in life. Sergei sums up his position thus: the Revolution, “The Internationale” anthem, the year 1937, the Second World War, soldiers. The list gives equal weight to ordinary people (soldiers), the Great Terror, symbolized by 1937, and the events associated with the Mythic Time of the Past.¹⁸ Now at home, in virtually complete darkness, Sergei lights a fire with bits of paper in an ashtray. Its flame remains the only diegetic source of illumination throughout the scene. As Sergei paces he has an internal conversation: “Wait, wait, wait, keep calm. . . . Listen, I have to calmly figure this out. . . . I don’t want to go on like this. . . . One can’t just swim with the tide. . . . I don’t want to grind time into nothing, grind days into nothing. . . . Nothing exists separately, nothing. Not love, not life, nor the time in which you live.” When he leans over the ashtray to light a cigarette, his body momentarily covers the quivering flame, immersing the space in darkness. The camera pulls back a little to reveal a pair of hands in close-up moving across the fire as if trying to warm themselves up; they belong to a young soldier in whom Sergei recognizes his perished father. The two have a man-to-man talk for the next nine and a half minutes.¹⁹

At the prodding of his father, who notes his son’s turmoil, Sergei tries to explain, “You know, there is life, normal life. . . . Well, I don’t want to be using some high-flown words. . . . But, you see, there are moments in life,” Sergei hems and haws, visibly embarrassed by the solemn turn the conversation has taken, “when you face yourself, your . . . [a long pause] conscience.” To which the soldier, neutralizing any hint of solemnity, replies, “In that case, let’s have a smoke.” The language of the hero and of his father’s specter, as well as their delivery, remains faithful to the spirit of candidness. Sergei is tongue-tied, an attribute that in the Russian literary imagination suggests honesty and sincerity.²⁰ Moreover, because of the Thaw’s distrust of smooth speech, which was associated with official pronouncements, “youthful inarticulateness temporarily came to bear a mark of authenticity,” as “muffled and faltering voices supplanted the perfect diction of the 1930s and 1940s,” write Kozlov and Gilburd.²¹ The protagonist’s embarrassment at evoking conscience and asking big questions about how to live now that the moral code is more ambiguous than during wartime is aligned with the rest of the film’s tonality, which is hypersensitive to the slightest falseness of expression. “I really need you to explain things to me,” pleads Sergei. He poses questions on behalf of the entire generation. And the father, who has emerged from darkness, is unable to lead Sergei to light.

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Ilyich's Gate's script is beholden to the Thaw's concern with honest language. In September 1960 Khutsiev invited Shpalikov, a poet and novice screenwriter, to join the project, likely after reading the latter's unrealized script "Prichal" (The pier), which explodes a closed narrative structure, implies alternative trajectories, and frequently pauses to describe the density of material reality.²² Though as yet unpublished, Shpalikov enjoyed somewhat of a cult reputation: His verses were known to many among Moscow's young intelligentsia through word of mouth, gatherings with a guitar, and an exchange of handwritten notes. Khutsiev detected in the young writer, still a screenwriting student at VGIK, an authentic voice of the generation the film was about.²³ Once Shpalikov joined the team, a sense of "new reality" entered the project, recalled a colleague.²⁴ "He wrote wonderful dialogues in the manner of Chekhov and Hemingway," Naum Kleiman has observed, "where everything was said between the lines . . . and direct outpourings of feeling happened only in climactic moments, which was atypical for Soviet dramaturgy."²⁵ Khutsiev considered Shpalikov a true collaborator, but his key contribution to the screenplay was dialogue.²⁶ The young poet's penchant for overloading the dialogue with incongruous details highlights characters' uncertainty and vulnerability and gives their worlds a concrete yet messy shape. His writing style was what Soviet film critic and scholar Viktor Demin called "the mutiny of details" in reference to a trend he noticed in certain Thaw films. Shpalikov's characters who are loquacious and silver-tongued are suspect, such as Anya's father, who offers his daughter and Sergei platitudes about their generation's responsibility. Conversely, those who search for words or speak in poetic lines of Mayakovsky and Pushkin, especially if those lines are figured as freely pouring out, are to be understood as authentic. They struggle to find the right shape for their inner experience.

Is Sergei sincere in his behavior during the exchange with his perished father? Does the outward express the inward without dissimulation? To Khrushchev, the entire premise was inadmissible, as we saw in the introduction: The dialogue between father and son implied a profound disconnection between generations. But framed by the Thaw discourse of the past as both a collective and an individual reckoning, the stakes of Sergei's conduct as sincere are high. Not only does he engage with the past, he does so by exposing his inner tumult. This kind of intimacy, where the viewer listens in on a character's private world, had only recently reappeared in Soviet cinema. By confronting—and contacting—the past in such a corporeal and personal way, *Ilyich's Gate* creates a kind of interiority that both questions the existence of the external reality and stays firmly connected to

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it. A dreamlike state, combined with interior monologue, allows for the possibility of accessing consciousness. If the character's self-conscious search for words might suggest a pose—in the sense that Rousseau found crippling when writing his *Confessions*—in the framework of sincerity discourse, it indicates the opposite. Sergei does not hide behind eloquence or clichés; rather, he reveals himself to be candid through pauses and gaps, through his inability to find the words that would match how he is feeling. The scene, moreover, can be understood as taking place in Sergei's head, framed by his thoughts.

Interior monologue is a device par excellence for the cinema of sincerity in view of the Thaw's articulations of the term, the notion of absorption in particular. Interior monologue speaks in a character's voice, presuming complete involvement in that character's state of mind.²⁷ Conventionally, as an aesthetic representation of consciousness, it is meant only for the one forming the words in their head. By nature, it is private. Moreover, in the case of Sergei, this is no longer the voice of the ubiquitous, disembodied (male) narrator who steers audiences through the potential ambiguities of the image track in Stalin-era and numerous Thaw films. The extradiegetic narrator, such as the one found in *Nine Days of One Year*, who was fighting to get through the thoughts of the female protagonist, has no place here. Instead, this voice firmly resides in an individual's body, abjuring the language of slogans.²⁸ Berggolts's appeal for a genuine "I" in lyric poetry and Pomerantsev's desire for more confessional rather than *professional* art found their full expression in the images and sounds of *Ilyich's Gate*.

But what is especially crucial in light of the cinema of sincerity's move away from smooth verbalism is that the scene can be read as sincere beyond language. Who is Sergei's father, ontologically speaking? Is he a benevolent spirit with a secret? A hallucination? An illusion manifested by wishful thinking? Khutsiev was adamant about dispensing with optical tricks such as the dissolve that would mark the visitor's appearance. He insisted that the figure arrive in a "completely real" manner.²⁹ Prokhorov also remarks on the unnoticeable transition between the two spaces/modalities, contemporary reality and this other state.³⁰ Against the flicker of the flame—an allusion to the eternal flame that had first been lit at the Field of Mars in Leningrad in 1957 to commemorate those who perished in the war—the camera reveals the soldier's body, placing it in the same shot as Sergei's. The absence of a cut in how the ghostly presence appears can be understood as Sergei's desire to find continuity between past and present, between his world and his father's. Throughout the encounter, the two, in profile, often share a mobile frame, the camera traversing the dark in-between space as

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it pans from one to the other. This foregrounding of the camera movement acknowledges the separation between father and son and gives poignant significance to the film's attempt to reconcile the historical eras and generations riven by Stalin's crimes. Instead of the abandonment that Nikita Khrushchev inferred from the dialogue, the visual register—the framing of the pair and absence of a cut in particular—emphasizes an urgent wish for connection. At the same time, the black space that divides the characters is full of the reminders of history: figures (sleeping soldiers on the eve of battle) and events (war, revolutions). The dark space, spreading across, absorbs the past, rendering it both full and invisible. The only way to the past's fullness, including the sensorial fullness, is through the dead father. This persistence of darkness may also give rise to a shared feeling of mortality, especially as it is followed by a pan over the bodies of the sleeping—and soon to be killed in combat—soldiers.

Shpalikov's script and Khutsiev's direction render the departed father exceedingly corporeal, present, in possession of habitual gestures. In his typical manner of layering a scene with a collection of incongruous phrases and details, Shpalikov has the dead soldier wistfully say to Sergei, "Too bad it's autumn. . . . Could've gone for a swim. You like swimming?" Such abrupt turns in the conversation diminish the communicative capacity of words and instead point beyond their limit—to the unexpressed that yet must be transmitted. The night visitor smokes and drinks. His substantial footfalls reverberate in the room, recalling the steps of the three guards that frame the film. The scene's combination of material and immaterial qualities walks a thin line between the solid physical world of a communal apartment and a more unreliable realm conjured by the shadows the flame casts around the room. The steady tick of a clock and a sudden dissonant chord ringing in the night when Sergei bumps into the keys of a piano intrude on the metaphysical nature of the meeting. As the ordinary apartment gives way to a dirty dugout lined with sleeping soldiers, the off-screen dripping of water at once counts out the seconds and asserts materiality in a scene that exists in an undefined temporal aspect. The only way to connect with the past, the film seems to imply, is through such phantasmal and personal interludes.

The evocation of *Hamlet* here is significant. Similar to poetry's importance for the renewal of linguistic and other modes of expression, Shakespeare's tragedy assumed the role of a key text in the post-Stalin period. Alexander Etkind has pointed out that many intellectuals and artists during the Thaw found "in Shakespeare an adequate cultural idiom."³¹ Stalin's alleged dislike of the play caused its disappearance from the theater repertory. He ostensibly perceived a character likeness between the pensive, melancholy,

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dithering hero and the Soviet intelligentsia.³² But soon after the autocrat's death, the intelligentsia embraced "a man they had been forbidden to celebrate," making him into a cultural icon.³³ Marko Dumančić notes that Shakespeare's tragic hero gave the name to a condition besetting 1960s Soviet screen protagonists who were "more interested in the journey than in the destination and questioned the existence of a shared national ideal. Their search was often labeled 'Hamletism' (*gamletizm*). Sixties heroes were men perpetually in search of meaning."³⁴

The play returned to the Soviet stage in 1954, most notably at the Pushkin Theater in Leningrad and the Mayakovsky Theater in Moscow, directed, respectively, by Grigory Kozintsev and Nikolai Okhlopkov, both established professionals of film and stage. Writing about his approach to the production, Okhlopkov shared that he had to abandon the volumes of celebrated academic commentaries on Shakespeare's tragedy in favor of daily newspapers, whose pages were "filled with vibrant voices of life itself."³⁵ In the unfolding of current events, Okhlopkov discerned "clearly and sharply . . . immeasurable suffering . . . caused by 'the world of Claudius [*klavdieva mira*],' calling for an earnest and sacred struggle against it."³⁶ Although the director did not specify which events inspired him, a connection between, on the one hand, Hamlet's brooding and the heavy air of murder and betrayal in Elsinore and, on the other, recent and present-day Soviet reality was not difficult to trace.³⁷ For his part, Kozintsev, who in 1962 was in the process of adapting the tragedy for the screen, jotted down in his diary, "Hamlet is a person before 1937," referring to the year of the Great Terror and implying the hero's freedom in thought and action.³⁸ In the revisionist and hopeful air of Thaw culture, the play was understood as a kind of code to grasping the tragedy of power excesses at home.

In the notes on his translation of Shakespeare's plays undertaken in the 1940s and early 1950s, Boris Pasternak defined the rhythm of the English bard as that of "a free historical individual who did not create idols for himself and, as a result, was sincere and concise."³⁹ This rhythm and sense of freedom that inhere in Shakespeare's oeuvre are most evident in *Hamlet*, observed Pasternak. To recall Trilling, this work was exemplary for Trilling's tracing of sincerity by virtue of how the playwright deployed the word to mean "the absence of dissimulation or feigning or pretense," or to be true to oneself.⁴⁰

There is another important connection between the Thaw's penchant for self-examination and Shakespeare's tragedy. In the September 1964 issue of *Novyi mir*, Turovskaya published a piece entitled "Hamlet and Us." It is both a review of Kozintsev's film released the same year and her meditation

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on the play's role in Soviet culture. She observed that *Hamlet* ushered in a new theme in Soviet art, "the theme of time."⁴¹ In all of his suffering, the prince of Denmark frets the most about whether he would be able to repair the broken line of time, of paternity: "The time is out of joint—O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!" (1.5.190–91). If the spirit of Hamlet's father has much to impart to his offspring, *Ilyich's Gate's* twenty-one-year-old soldier fallen in action has no message for his. This loss of paternity in the cinema of the sixties, writes Kaganovsky, is metaphorical as well: "It speaks to the unbearable trauma of the loss of paternal authority, of masculinity as absence."⁴²

In a companion scene that occurs earlier, Sergei meets his girlfriend Anya's father. The bitter man berates his daughter, Sergei, and their peers for being restless and dissatisfied, for what he perceives as immaturity: "What nonsense fills your head? What do you need?" He desperately seeks a sense of continuity where there could be little: between his generation and his daughter's. "Why," he asks Anya and Sergei, "do you separate yourselves from our generation?" In contrast to Sergei's conversation with his soldier-father, this paterfamilias is eager to dispense bromides: "Life consists not of empty talk but of concrete deeds." Under the pretense of wanting to



An uncomfortable conversation: Sergei and Anya's father in *Ilyich's Gate*

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understand the young people's searching, Anya's father pontificates, attacking them with platitudes. Neither she nor Sergei believes his smooth talking. As Anya puts it, "All your life you've been saying one thing and thinking another." This line of authority is equally severed.

Sergei and his dead father are absorbed by darkness and conversation, reconfiguring how the film relates to the viewer: not being posed for us, not seeking our approval. The flickering light and the dark screen, furthermore, can be read as the evocation of cinema's material conditions and generative power. Not only can cinema bring son and departed parent together, but for a brief moment it promises to restore the past and the present to a temporal order that had been broken. Sergei's father, a martyred figure, is perfectly set up by the convention of socialist realism to leave the baton to his successor, who will continue the mission of fighting the enemy, of protecting peace, and so forth. *Ilyich's Gate* abstains from that. The soldier—a symbol of paternity lost to terror, camps, and war—cannot explain to the descendants how to live. He cheerfully nods to his offspring and disappears behind a creaky door. The familiar radio signal, like the crow of a rooster in *Hamlet*, shoos away the night with its nightmares and restores present-day reality to Sergei.

A formal rather than narrative and thematic companion scene, which was excised from the 1962 version of the film, finds Anya and Sergei at a crowded party in a friend's apartment.⁴³ Chet Baker's crooning gives way to Franz Schubert's "Ave Maria" as the couple sways to the melody, holding candles. Soon, the surroundings melt away, and the screen space is submerged in darkness illuminated by the candlelight that flickers with the music. The characters' voices repeat over and over: "Anya: Do you love me? Sergei: And you me?" While the formal construction of the scene has a narrative logic—the lovers separate themselves from the rest of the revelers—Anya and Sergei also become part of another temporal and spatial order, one that answers to a personal perception of reality and not to the socialist realist tradition. Similar to that in the scene of the father's visit, the darkness here suggests mysterious power that has a potential to take the narrative along a different trajectory.

In Prokhorov's reading, the scene between father and son "incorporates the communal experience of the fathers' generation into the collective memory of the sons, giving a sense of dynamism to the Thaw-era version of the Great Family myth revitalized in the process of de-Stalinization."⁴⁴ Certainly, *Ilyich's Gate* is still heavy-handed with allegory and thus beholden to the socialist realist tradition. After all, it closes with the camera tracking the changing of the guard at Lenin's Tomb, which rhymes with the three soldiers

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in the beginning of the film. Three sentries, three soldiers, three friends safeguard peace on earth, revolutionary ideals, and cycles of life. When the movie was in midproduction, on October 31, 1961, Stalin's embalmed body was removed from the mausoleum on the Red Square. Exit the Father.⁴⁵

However, the encounter between the two generations also raises issues with respect to socialist realism and history. The sense of loss of the generational continuity and of a secure horizon creates a disjuncture for which the film was punished. Not only does this episode reflect on the human condition in a more universally humanist light, it relinquishes the strictly "materialist" framework of storytelling.⁴⁶ It suggests a different temporal modality from the forward-moving one.⁴⁷ The kind of intimacy portrayed, where the viewer eavesdrops on the character's private world, had only recently been permitted again in Soviet narrative film. Using a subjective mode of narration constructed through the camera, mise-en-scène, and soundtrack, the father-and-son encounter affords us a peek into Sergei's interior life. By intellectually and materially engaging with the past—by asking questions of a spirit or an illusion of consciousness—*Ilyich's Gate* creates a new kind of interiority. Whether the protagonist dreams the entire visit or his father's ghost calls on him in the middle of the night, he is in the throes of existential doubt. The past is intimately enmeshed in how Sergei relates to himself, his friends, his beloved, and history. A dreamlike state or a vision, combined with inner speech, allows for the possibility of access to his consciousness.⁴⁸ Such focus on inner life bordered on what pundits of socialist realism claimed to be a modernist obsession with making individuals too mysterious and irrational. But here, the absorption of the protagonist in his reverie and self-reflection renders the inner struggle legible.

Nekrasov, who vociferously defended the film during the censorship campaign, noted his gratitude to the filmmakers for "not dragging in the old proverbial worker by his graying mustache, the one who understands everything and always has exactly the right answer for anything you ask him. . . . As long as you are searching, asking questions, asking yourself, asking your friends . . . you are alive. When there are no more questions, there is no more you."⁴⁹ The conviction that on-screen characters mean what they say, however ineptly, which Nekrasov and other supporters of *Ilyich's Gate* asserted, raises a question of cinema's capacity for readability, for keeping meaning on the surface rather than hidden. Sergei, while in turmoil, remains legible. Whether phantasmal or subjective, the moment of introspection when the protagonist meets his parent is inseparable from the world Sergei inhabits and whose shifting codes of deportment he desperately wants to get right.

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The intelligibility of representation was always an essential ingredient in Soviet socialist realism, particularly when it concerned the clarity of a correct idea a movie communicated.⁵⁰ One of the three central tenets of official art was its striving to appeal to and be understood by all.⁵¹ But Nekrasov seems to indicate a modified variety of legibility. What is at stake for him in his appreciation of the absence of clichéd answers is the possibility of a Soviet cinema that recalibrates the relationship between audience and screen from one where the audience is told what and how to think to one where they at once must acknowledge the inherent ambiguity of the film image and have faith in its intelligibility. Nekrasov went further in his elaboration of a different kind of film: By seeing characters being absorbed in their activities, states of mind, or feelings, we can intuit what they are thinking.

The cinema of sincerity, with its turn to the inner, brokers the balancing act between characters retreating into themselves and remaining accessible, between the urgent need to relax the boundaries of realism and stay firmly connected to the external world and its ordinariness. By recording one's struggle to express oneself, by conveying a spontaneous flow of emotion, the cinema of sincerity reconciles realism with modernist elements that jeopardize but never shatter the illusion of projected reality. The task of sincerity was to accommodate interior, experiential states, which at best could suggest a character's perception of fragments of the real, as we observed in the father-and-son encounter, without professing to depict totality and certainty, such as socialist realism offered. The purpose of such enriched filmic realism was not to negate the existence of external reality but to provide a common idiom with which to try and work through the horrors of Stalinism, reengage with audiences and the larger world, and reclaim the present.

Stanley Cavell, Candid Film, and Thaw Cinema

Soviet cinema never lost sight of its teaching responsibility, even while it was revising its realist identity by allowing a fragmented representation of subjective experience. Conveying a movie's imperviousness to the beholder was important for cinematic sincerity at the level of *mise-en-scène*, as we have seen. A film and its characters should behave as if they live independently of the trappings of the camera, projector, screen, and spectator. Arguably, every film, by virtue of the temporal distance between production and viewing experience and because of its technological apparatus, is impervious to us. As Stanley Cavell puts it, "The screen is metaphysically unbreachable; the abyss between actor and audience is as bottomless as time."⁵² For Cavell, these limits of cinema—"its outsideness to its world, and my absence from it"—provide precisely the conditions of the medium's

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“candor, of its fate to reveal all and only what is revealed to it, and of its fortune in letting the world exhibit itself.”⁵³

In *The World Viewed*, Cavell rues the fact that the new modernist film of the 1960s disavowed these limits and, as a result, lost its candor. He is particularly critical of movies that display “the narcissistic honesty of self-reference”; for him, the self-referentiality of “the politically modernist counter-cinema represents a retreat into the self, into the technology, and away from the world.”⁵⁴ Jennifer Fay notes that the philosopher “took seriously the pleasure and reality of narrative cinema, and he marveled at the ease with which Hollywood had maintained a conviction in its genres and a connection with its audiences . . . without the self-consciousness associated with the condition of modernism.”⁵⁵ According to Cavell, Hollywood created a common culture in the United States, facilitating “a connection to history and a collective attention to the myth of community and the promise of the *demos*.”⁵⁶ Cavell’s philosophical inquiry into the withdrawal of candor from the movie screen was animated by his concern with the failures of America’s political potential.

Cavell, however, does not dismiss cinematic modernism outright. When it uses its investigations into the medium’s powers to give meaning to these powers, there remain aesthetic and political possibilities.⁵⁷ He objects to modernist film’s baring of techniques not merely because by displaying its own apparatus it denies viewers the pleasure of narrative cinema but also because, as Fay points out, such a cinema weakens our “faith both in the communicative capacities of art and the knowability of the world it projects.”⁵⁸ As opposed to Cavell’s candid movies, radical modernist film is uncertain “of its ability to allow the world to exhibit itself.”⁵⁹ Modernist art hinges on a profound doubt about the existence of the world outside oneself and therefore promotes the idea of the illusion of reality. For Cavell, however, such a stance “dims the differences in the role of reality posed in painting, in theater, and in film, and it closes out the wish of art to address reality in order to combat, or suspend, our illusions of it.”⁶⁰

Soviet films are hardly part of Cavell’s candid canon.⁶¹ But his defense of narrative films casts a new light on the Soviet cinema of the 1960s, which reclaimed its candor at a moment when many modernist films were turning away from it. Soviet cinema accomplished this, on the one hand, through the reconfiguration of the viewer-screen relation in response to de-Stalinization and, on the other, through film’s acknowledgment of the audience vis-à-vis a projected reality and, by extension, reality at large. When, in the father-and-son conversation, the camera crosses the black passage of the filmic space, it is not to assert its presence but to look the past in the

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face, as it were. Filmmakers such as Khutsiev often used self-conscious strategies associated with modernism to integrate the audience into the projected world in a way that was neither overtly didactic nor awe-inspiring, qualities that would be expected from Stalin-era movies, where the leader's off-screen presence would be implied. While the image and, consequently, the relationship between audience and image became detheatricalized, characters, crucially, assumed deeper psychology animated by ordinary motivation. Unlike a character in a radical modernist film who is depersonalized in terms of everyday emotion and motivation, and equally unlike vacuous figures in Stalin-era confections who possess little psychological depth, Thaw protagonists remained intelligible as people inhabiting a recognizable reality.⁶² In effect, their interiority and engagement with everyday life were two crucial conditions of cinematic sincerity.

Khutsiev, along with several colleagues in the industry, envisioned a Soviet cinema that took the politics of sincerity seriously. Had Cavell seen *Ilyich's Gate*, he would have likely added it to his candid list, for it belongs to a cinema that "requires belief, relation to one's past, conviction that one's words and conduct express oneself, that they say what one means, and that what one means is enough to say."⁶³ Khutsiev and Shpalikov, as well as some of their colleagues, believed in the revolutionary ideals, and for them, a cinema formally invigorated by an aesthetic of sincerity demanded characters who loved their country and wished to understand its tragic past; who were not perfect but were clear about their ethical position; who possessed interiority and were motivated by ordinary emotion; and finally, whose behavior and thinking would teach audiences about themselves and what mattered.

Faith in the knowability of the external world showed cracks in the work of several Soviet directors, including Khutsiev, as the father-and-son scene implies, but conviction in the power of art was never in doubt. Nor was responsibility to reality. Realism, after all, remained their main idiom. For a Thaw film to confront the viewer the way a Godard film does would suggest not simply a capitulation to modernism but also a statement that reality, just like its projected equivalent, is an illusion. Yet for the cinema of sincerity, whose expansion of realism rested on its social promise to reestablish a connection with the audience, an acknowledgment of the audience was key. The foregrounding of technique in Soviet narrative film was not deployed for the purpose of mere self-reference, of exposing the workings of the image technology and undermining the premise of a filmic reality, or for an exploration of the medium's possibilities as an end in itself. Rather, I contend, this particular form of retheatricalization of viewer-screen relations, which were based on trust, was to acknowledge the audience and a

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state of shared uncertainty affectively, a strategy that arose from the promise of sincerity to create a new form of sociality. The social aspect was what Pomerantsev in his pivotal text “On Sincerity in Literature” advocated through sincerity’s connotation of closeness and communal orientation while at the same time pleading for a shift in art away from preaching, or professing, and toward a confessional inclination. The ambition of the cinema of sincerity went beyond representation of characters and their inner lives, expansion of thematic concerns, and documentation of material reality. This act of retheatricalization is Soviet cinema’s proclamation of faith in its own potential to not merely notice the contours of reality but also effect actual change. It is as though Soviet cinema offered up its own “sincerity” and reasserted its social and pedagogical promise that had been debased in the previous decades.

If the father-and-son episode exemplifies this acknowledgment of the viewer through the act of private, absorptive invocation of the past, several sequences in *Ilyich’s Gate* show how the staging of crowd scenes strengthens a romantic view of collectivity and a sense of spontaneity that acknowledges an audience by drawing its attention to the filmmaking process and thus including it in the act of creating a filmic reality.

Sincerity, Poetry, and the Camera

It is hard to overestimate the importance of poetry in Soviet society of the post-Stalin period.⁶⁴ Beth Holmgren has noted that the Thaw, “which commenced as a public call for emotional sincerity and fresh individual expression, fomented a poetry revival of massive and public proportions.”⁶⁵ Writing about the poetry rage that took hold of the Department of Journalism at Moscow State University, historian Elena Zubkova paints an evocative picture: “In the early 1950s, the entire department was seized by the epidemic: Everyone started to write poetry. There were different poems—good and not, derivative and original, and the amateur poets soon broke into two camps, those who wrote lyrical (i.e., ‘nonideological’ [*bezideinye*]) and those who wrote patriotic (i.e., ‘ideologically minded’ [*ideinye*]) verses.”⁶⁶ Young poets such as Evgeny Evtushenko, Andrei Voznesensky, Bella Akhmadulina, and Robert Rozhdestvensky, as well as their older colleagues David Samoilov, Mikhail Svetlov, and Boris Slutsky, commanded large audiences in the 1950s and early 1960s at public readings. Evtushenko, for example, famously filled Moscow’s Luzhniki Sports Arena to capacity in the late 1950s.⁶⁷

The first official Poetry Day was held in September 1955, when a series of Moscow bookstores hosted readings and book signings. The following year, the publishing house Moskovskii Rabochii launched what would

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become the annual almanac *Den' poezii* (Poetry day). Its inaugural volume included works of Marina Tsvetaeva and Eduard Bagritsky, authors long in disfavor. The revival of public poetry gatherings was oriented retrospectively, to the heady 1920s and Vladimir Mayakovsky's arresting performances in particular, thus making an association with a purer, more genuinely revolutionary era.

Mayakovsky's verses in particular, at first of his late and then early futurist periods, became a beacon for several generations of poets. It was in the authorities' interests to support the surge in poetry's popularity. In order to regulate crowds and facilitate the identification of potential ideological insubordination, in July 1958 the government unveiled the statue of Mayakovsky in the center of Moscow. The monument at Mayakovsky Square became a symbol of revolutionary romanticism for those who frequently gathered around it to recite verses. (These gatherings became known as convening *na Mayake*, a play on the poet's name and "at the beacon.")⁶⁸ Since publishing one's writings had always been an uncertain enterprise for many Soviet authors, public readings assumed a vital role in disseminating new texts. Meetings at the monument often exceeded their original function and spilled into debates about politics and society.⁶⁹

Why poetry? Why this highly conventional language rather than prose? And, more precisely, why the lyric? There are several interconnected answers. Poetry was a source of linguistic renewal in a culture that had for nearly two decades suffered from the pompous bureaucratese of the mass media and, to a great extent, literature.⁷⁰ Unlike prose, it was less contaminated by the sins of Stalinism; after all, newspapers and speeches are written in prose. During the Khrushchev Thaw, the drive to "replace the presumably ossified, compromised language with a 'living word' became widespread," observes Kozlov.⁷¹ Furthermore, poetry has historically been anchored in two different traditions, belonging both to the more permanent sphere of the written word and to the ephemeral, more immediate realm of orality, which, since Plato, has been regarded as closer to the truth.⁷²

In addition to being a source of inspiration for language renewal, another answer to "Why poetry?" lies in the breakdown of the long-held authority of a biographical narrative in Stalinist culture. As a literary genre and a concept, the biographical narrative applied to the overall Soviet project, particularly in its purport of wholeness and completeness.⁷³ The Stalin era privileged the biographical film, which became, as Evgeny Dobrenko puts it, "the meta-genre."⁷⁴ The biopic abstracted the figure of the protagonist and instead aimed to allegorize historical events according to a geopolitical moment.⁷⁵ Thus, the person at the center of the story either dissolved into nothingness

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or solidified into a myth.⁷⁶ The only legitimate interpreter of historical events was Stalin, “the master of the word” himself.⁷⁷ The genre of Stalinist biography, then, aspired to a wholeness and, paradoxically, lacked the experiential aspect.

A lyric poem, by contrast, offers fragments of experience that are distilled through the narrator or a character’s psyche and conveyed by the idiom of feelings, as opposed to the claims to wholeness of the biographical narrative or a piece of socialist realist prose. During the Thaw, the lyric especially came to be prized for an “outpouring of emotions” (*izliianiia dushi*), as championed by the poet Olga Berggolts and others. Such personal utterance needed to be not polished or loquacious but sincere, springing forth from within. Importantly, the poets who emerged to prominence in the late 1950s were identified both by the differences in their compositional techniques and by their distinctive recitation styles.

Poetic discourse, particularly when shared in public, was invested with the ability to communicate a complete alignment between verbal affirmation and feeling, recalling Trilling’s formulation of sincerity as harmony between avowal and felt emotion. When young Voznesensky declared in a 1957 verse,

Farewell life in the sticks!
Life is a series of burned-out sites.
Nobody escapes the bonfire:
If you live—you burn

his authorial sincerity, bolstered by the pathos of his poetic utterance, was perceived by many as aligned with his feeling.⁷⁸ The view echoing the English Romantics that poets must mean what they say was powerful during this time. There was a sense that a candid flow of feeling could withstand the turgid language of functionaries and even effect change.

Khutsiev and his crew made the most of poetry as the currency of sincerity, capturing its aesthetic form most vividly in the scene of the poetry performance. The episode suffered greatly during the censorship campaign: It was cut down from twenty minutes to six and stitched into another part of the version of *Ilyich’s Gate* that was renamed *Mne dvadtsat’ let* (*I Am Twenty*) and released in early 1965. The original sequence epitomizes the spirit of the early 1960s, the importance of new modes of expression, verbal and otherwise, and represents a “Who’s Who in Soviet Poetry.” Poet after poet—Akhmadulina, Svetlov, Evtushenko, Voznesensky, singer-songwriter Bulat Okudzhava—take the stage to declaim their verses or, in the case of Okudzhava, sing to a guitar accompaniment to the rapt crowd.⁷⁹

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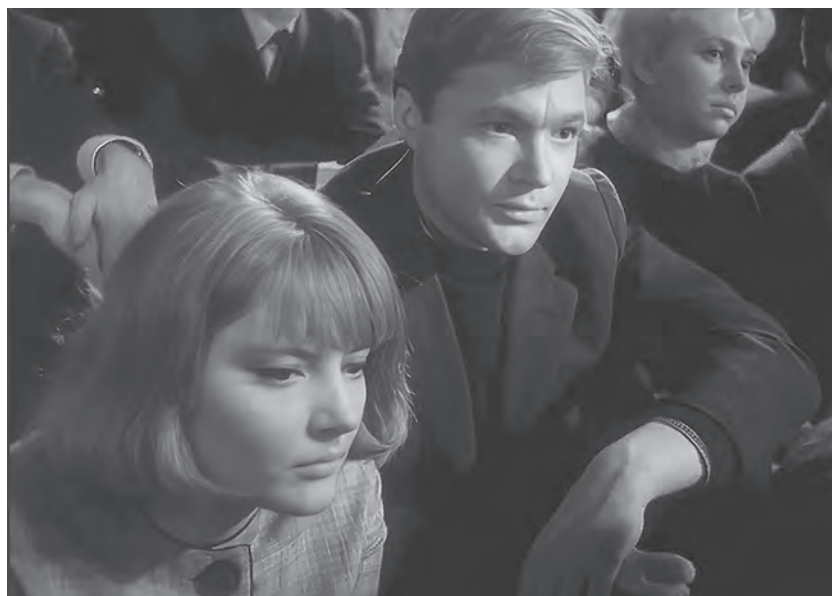
Replicating mass poetry readings popular at the time, Khutsiev organized the event at the Polytechnical Museum specifically for the shoot. Lacking a sufficient number of friends and professional extras to fill the vast lecture hall, the filmmakers posted fliers around Moscow promoting the event, while the museum administration sold tickets to the public.⁸⁰ As a consequence, most of the audience comprised regular Muscovites who had learned about the gathering of poets and thronged to the museum, a place with a rich literary history.⁸¹ The scene took several eight-hour days to shoot. The audience quickly grew, overflowing into every inch of free space, which made the crew's job difficult. In the end, the spellbound "extras," afraid to miss a single word of poetry, ignored the filmmakers, a mood caught by the cinematographer.⁸²

Margarita Pilikhina's dynamic camerawork, alternating between smooth and jerky pans and close-ups of faces, roving between the audience and the stage, is instrumental to the scene's iconic status. Its freedom and vitality became an aesthetic shorthand for the Thaw. Toward the end of the episode, a handheld camera somersaults just above the audience as if propelled by its energy. The filmmakers produced a potent hybrid of fiction and nonfiction that came to be known as an aesthetic of "documentaryness"



An enthusiastic crowd at the Polytechnical Museum in *Ilyich's Gate*

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Sergei and Anya among the crowd in *Ilyich's Gate*

(*dokumental'nost'*) in 1960s Soviet cinema.⁸³ Certainly, the mobile camera, the choppy editing style, and the profilmic reality of the poets and the riveted audience at the storied venue created an aesthetic of sincerity in the sense that images and sounds possess an unpolished spontaneity. However, what magnifies the aesthetic of sincerity—what, I argue, transforms it into a stirring ritualized gesture rather than consigning it to the realm of clichés and asserts its social potential—is the presence of television cameras, as if the event were being televised. Khutsiev had the television equipment planted around the auditorium specifically to generate the illusion of life unfolding in the moment.⁸⁴ This simulation of an on-air broadcast has noteworthy implications for my discussion of Soviet cinematic sincerity, its formal investment in seemingly unrehearsed representations of the surrounding world, and its ability to acknowledge audiences using a realist ethos while employing modernist techniques of exposing technology.

In the contemporary discussion of television, Soviet commentators emphasized what they saw as its essence: the ability to broadcast live. Similar to early TV elsewhere, the Soviet variant was touted as a medium of truth. As one enthusiastic critic asserted, live television possesses “‘perfect pitch for truth,’ *podlinnost'* (authenticity) was in its very nature, and for this reason any false note or inconsistency was immediately apparent on the screen.”⁸⁵

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TV cameras, operators, and lights in *Ilyich's Gate*

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In post-Stalin society, this aspect perhaps had an especially pointed resonance. Kristin Roth-Ey communicates the spirit and widespread ideas of the contemporary debate about the medium in her remark: “There was general agreement that TV, if true to itself, was natural, spontaneous, and sincere.”⁸⁶ These characteristics were inseparable from its live, that is, true, nature.

Khutsiev’s idea to have the televisual equipment for the poetry shoot cleverly played with the new medium’s capacity to catch the flow of life. In addition to the crowd’s enthusiasm for the action on the museum’s stage, the conspicuous presence of the TV cameras, if not effaced, then certainly attenuated the presence of the film crew. Moreover, the makers of on-screen sincerity themselves dissolve among the audience members, many of whom can be spotted documenting the proceedings with their own photographic or amateur movie cameras. The observant viewer in the know can spot amid the throng of people the cinematographer herself, wielding a small camera with which she must have been capturing some of the most iconic images of the Thaw.

How should we read this profusion of cameras on the screen? Is it a modernist gesture similar to Cavell’s “assertion of techniques” made in reference to the new modernist cinema? Does this foregrounding of the



Documenting the event: amateur cameras in *Ilyich's Gate*

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apparatus hinder our pleasure in being absorbed in the film world, and, more important, does it still hold the potential for political change? Finally, what does this conspicuous presence of the broadcast technologies and the “media of indexical traces,” such as photography and film, do for the politics of sincerity and for its aesthetic display?⁸⁷

The illusion of a live TV broadcast, together with audience members’ acts of documenting the poetry performances, materializes a recharged gesture of sincerity on the movie screen. Critiquing modernist film, Cavell claims that in narrative cinema the “camera cannot in general merely declare itself: it must give at least the illusion of saying something.”⁸⁸ What the presence of the technologies indicates here is that one witnesses an authentic moment. For many of the 1960s generation, the Polytechnical Museum scene represents an authentic fragment of the era. Film critic Elena Stishova is not alone in granting it the status of a “great document.”⁸⁹ Substantially excised from the 1965 version, the episode nonetheless holds the potential to exist in multiple iterations in the public and private realms—as a home movie, as documentary footage in another film, or as photographs in an album. Indeed, it has had a significant afterlife in the Soviet popular imagination, being cited in other fiction and nonfiction films.⁹⁰ Stishova imputes unique qualities to the scene, describing it in Benjaminian terms as that of an unreproducible work of art, emphasizing its power to invoke the communal spirit of the moment: “It’s impossible to re-create its aura of a nonreligious collectivity [*netserkovnoi sobornosti*].”⁹¹ Whether the public who came to hear and see the poets during the shoot knew that the TV gear was there merely for show is not the point.⁹² As props, the cameras and operators behind them nonetheless mediated the experience of the event for those in attendance and the experience of viewing the film for future spectators in the movie theater.

The centrality of the poetry performances and of the image technologies seems to be a self-reflexive move incompatible with sincerity. The very *dispositif* of the event—the lecture hall, the stage, the performers, and the audience—could not be any more theatrical. The film seemingly goes counter to sincerity’s promise of intimate filmic spaces, with characters turning inward and disregarding the beholder—in other words, not performing. But in fact, this scene illustrates perfectly the paradoxical nature of sincerity: It rests on the connection to interiority, which is elusive at best, and on being recognized—interpreted—by another, which is sincerity’s social aspect. If one reflects on one’s own sincerity, one’s sincerity is compromised, yet sincerity wants to be read, making performativity part of its nature. Literary scholar Angela Esterhammer has noted in reference to Romantic

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poetry and theater that “spontaneity guarantees the objectivity and purity of the audience response; it forestalls contamination by second thoughts or ulterior motives. . . . Sincerity does not just collaborate with performativity; instead, it manifests itself only under the conditions of explicit theatrical performance.”⁹³ The cinematic representation of the crowd in the poetry scene codes the audience members not as self-conscious but as fully absorbed by and highly responsive to the energy of the action. At one point, they join Okudzhava in a song, a gesture that registers as an impromptu display of solidarity. The spontaneity of the camerawork, of the *mise-en-scène*, of the filmed audience’s response to the poets reads as sincere.

Ilyich’s Gate retheatricalizes its relationship to viewers, bringing them into the filmed space while baring the act of making the aesthetics of sincerity. Yet this disclosure, which resembles a modernist move, is not in the service of debunking the illusion of filmic reality; nor is it in any way identical to theatricalized compositions and characters’ body language of most Stalin-era films. Instead, I suggest, this complex act of retheatricalization does something else: It attempts to achieve an antitheatrical effect by breaking through the unbreachable abyss of the screen while maintaining a realist ethos by acknowledging us, the film’s audience, via the operation of doubling.⁹⁴ The visible cameras in the hall function as a double of the invisible film apparatus. This doubling effect changes how the screened images acknowledge the spectator. For Prokhorov, the poetry event “epitomizes the power of communal identity as the creative force in the film.”⁹⁵ Even more so, it models a new kind of cinema, one that can be created, *Ilyich’s Gates* seems to suggest, through collective action. The apparently spontaneous flow of images and sounds in the poetry gathering forgoes the strictures of narrative economy and instead communicates immediacy and candidness of verbal and visual expression—as if made on the fly. Likewise, the on-screen audience doubles for those watching the film on the other side of the abyss. Such form of acknowledgment enfolds them into an experience of shared literary-political intimacy in a kind of secular fellowship referenced by Stishova where the singular voices demonstrated by each poet have a place. At the scene’s closing, the exhilarated audience spills down the staircase, flooding the foreground while Voznesensky’s off-screen voice recites his poem “Farewell to the Polytechnical.”

On-screen crowds played a crucial role in the renewal of sincerity gestures in Thaw cinema. The masses had been integral to moving images of the 1920s avant-garde and what Romm and his older colleagues considered to be Soviet cinema’s general line. Between the mid-1930s and the early 1950s, however, crowds on Soviet screens were arranged chiefly in the

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formation of a mass ornament.⁹⁶ Parades and other state-sponsored celebrations replaced the representations of congregations of people found in the 1920s works of Eisenstein, Vertov, and Pudovkin and the sound films of Eisenstein.⁹⁷ However meticulously framed and edited, shots featuring crowds seethe with an explosive energy. All three avant-gardists used this quality for dramatic ends.⁹⁸ An interaction between a crowd and a camera always brims with tension: On the one hand, there is a careful arrangement of content constrained by the rectangle of a frame; on the other, there is the intrinsic threat of the loss of control by said content. It is precisely this irrepressible, impulse-charged attribute of the crowd on film that imparts a sense of chaos and spontaneity to the image. In such scenes, fiction and reality touch most clearly. For Kracauer, the masses and cinema have a special affinity, allowing the medium to realize itself fully.⁹⁹ Deftly framed and staged by Khutsiev and Pilikhina, the many mass scenes in *Ilyich's Gate* rejuvenated the ritualized gesture of the on-screen crowd, which is as old as the medium itself, and rescued it from Stalin-era visual configurations of a monolithic mass or geometric arrangement of human bodies.¹⁰⁰

Organizing people in large numbers and having them interact with each other and poetry while plunging the camera in the middle generated a rough-hewn, vigorous look that gave the impression of spontaneity rather than meticulous artfulness.¹⁰¹ Integrating the poets reading their work at the Polytechnical Museum into the texture of *Ilyich's Gate* was a daring move on its own, but Khutsiev went further. His decision to flood the space with nonprofessional actors, outfit it with television cameras, and pretend that they were broadcasting live (and perhaps truly recording) poetry to millions of citizens breathed new life into the sails of sincerity, incorporating it into the process of filmmaking itself. Khutsiev turned Pomerantsev's plea for rendering artifice in literary fiction less detectable—what Pomerantsev saw as the degree of sincerity in art—into the opposite: The film foregrounded the creation of sincerity aesthetics through poetry performance, simulation of a televisual broadcast, and a restoration of the crowd on film to its inherently spontaneous and unpredictable nature.

Movies That Matter

Ekaterina Furtseva, the minister of culture, approved the final cut of *Ilyich's Gate* in autumn 1962. Ostensibly acting on anonymous letters from the Gorky Studio, which produced the film, the head of the cultural sector of the Central Committee requested to see it. Soon thereafter, one of the main ideologues of the Khrushchev administration and chair of the CC's ideological commission, Leonid Ilyichev, summoned Khutsiev to his office. Among

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a host of questions and concerns, the functionary demanded to know why Tarkovsky appeared in the film and why the footfalls of the Red Guard soldiers in the opening resonated so loudly.¹⁰² This was the first in a series of similar visits to the Central Committee in the winter months of 1962–63. Then, on March 7, 1963, ten years after Stalin's death, Khrushchev called a meeting with the creative intelligentsia during which he fulminated against the film while Khutsiev avowed his and the film's sincere position.

Eventually, the director was permitted to return to the reels, having to cut drastically the poetry evening and the exhibition sequence at the Pushkin Museum of Fine Arts and to reshoot other scenes deemed problematic, including the father-and-son conversation.¹⁰³ Khutsiev replaced the gaffer, who had worked on the set and played the father in the original version, with a professional actor. Shpalikov altered the dialogue to eliminate what the premier condemned as the abnegation of generational responsibility. Gone is Sergei's difficulty to fit the words to his feelings. Gone is the mobile camera that traced the abyss, which at once separated and joined the two, enacting the son's desire to find clarity in the present through the past. Now, during their substantially truncated encounter, the camera stays on the father's face, keeping Sergei off-screen—essentially cut off from his father's generation. Before the night visitor departs, the pair toast each other as the father reassures the son and disclaims any guilt. At last, in January 1965, Soviet audiences saw the new version of the film, renamed *I Am Twenty*. In a cruel twist of irony, the picture came out after its most fierce critic, Khrushchev, had been ousted. When it screened at Venice later that year, it received the Special Jury Prize.

As for its beleaguered antecedent, *Ilyich's Gate* finally premiered in January 1988 at Moscow's House of Cinema and shortly after was broadcast on television. It was among more than 250 banned films that the so-called Conflict Commission of the Union of Filmmakers rehabilitated during perestroika. This restored work was not quite the original but, rather, the director's cut: Khutsiev took this opportunity to improve on the 1962 film and stitched into the new version a couple of reshot or redubbed scenes from *I Am Twenty* that he considered superior.¹⁰⁴ The body of *Ilyich's Gate* bears the scars of the vicissitudes of history. It is not one or two but three films in one. For many among the intelligentsia who came of age in the 1960s—for those who had “the ability and desire to think, to reflect about life and its complexities,” to recall critic Stanislav Rassadin's description—the sound of poets' voices and poetic expression, the eschewing of bombastic language, the focus on character interiority, the camera capturing the spirit of old city streets and the excitement of crowds—in other words, the aesthetic of

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sincerity Khutsiev and his unit created—the film has remained an authentic portrait of an era in the historical imagination. But the film’s narrative and often visual framing—in the opening, the three Red Army soldiers dressed in the clothing that marks them as fighters of the revolution, and in the final shots, the ceremonial change of the guards at Lenin’s Tomb in contemporary Moscow—casts the entire film in a romanticized glow and is firmly situated in the revisionist thinking of the early 1960s.

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CHAPTER 4

Child's Play on the Periphery

Other People's Children

Khutsiev's *Ilyich's Gate* might be the cornerstone of Soviet sincere cinema and the film that arguably captured most vividly the phenomenological fluidity of experience during the Thaw in the capital. The verses of Russian-language poets such as Pushkin, Mayakovsky, and their compatriots in the post-Stalin era served, as we have seen, as a wellspring of contemporary language renewal and of a deepening relationship with the past and history.¹ The use of poetic discourse, together with the plasticity of images and planes of sound, gives access to characters' restless interiority and embeds them in a concrete world, creating an "audiovisual polyphony" that had been absent in Soviet cinema since *Ivan the Terrible* (1944–46).² The Soviet cinema of the Thaw was learning—or rediscovering—how to "speak" polyphonically using all of the medium's affordances.

However, even poetry, valorized as arguably the most fitting medium for the candid flow of feeling during the Khrushchev era, gives way, in the peripheral productions featuring children, to the poetry of images and sounds. Released from linguistic interpretation and pressures, these films take the new cinema in a direction of wordlessness and ideological ambiguity. The film at the center of this chapter, Tengiz Abuladze's *Skhvisi shvilebi* (*Other People's Children*, sometimes translated as *Someone Else's Children*, Georgia Film, 1959), breaks with a romantic vision of the revolution, Soviet values, and, indeed, official ideology. The film exists in the province of post-war international cinema that features children as guides into the dark, splintered world of grownups, where the significance of language as the unproblematic conveyor of truth is not simply eroded but undone by the visual and sonic environment. Words are spoken, but their significance is equivalent to that of the spare mise-en-scène and camerawork. Historian of Georgian cinema Rusudan Tikanadze notes that *Other People's Children*

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contains “a lot of air, spatial depth, a deliberate exclusion of objects in order to expose perspective.”³ The surfeit of air, together with the scant dialogue, creates an atmosphere where the characters exist without having to justify themselves, certainly not with language. Likewise, the viewer is invited to move alongside them, wordlessly, in an expansive, breathable world without evaluating their actions.

Other People's Children is also an aesthetic space where several styles commingle and sometimes collide, giving it a syncretic dynamism that often marks film practice in the union's republics. I propose that it is in the films featuring children, which are to be distinguished from films made for children, that the cinema of sincerity embodies its perhaps most crucial articulation—suspicion toward transparency and fluency of language—and arguably achieves its aesthetic potential to the fullest. Manifesting in verbal and behavioral affect and visual experimentation and creating a model of ethical everyday conduct, this articulation in particular connects the notion of Soviet sincerity to the creative and political imperatives of so-called Soviet peripheral cinemas.⁴

This book is not concerned with the genre of children's film, in which the Soviets had invested since the 1930s.⁵ Rather, it distinguishes a set of works made during the 1950s and 1960s that address adults but center on young protagonists, with adults often either absent or, if present, ineffectual.⁶ Such dispensation of narrative import weakens the logocentricity of socialist realist cinema both because children have yet to develop the capacity to express themselves in perfect or even complete sentences and because images and nonlinguistic sound material take on greater prominence. Desiring to connect with each other and with the few grownups in their lives, the young characters at the heart of these films use a range of modes to communicate, among which language comes off as the weakest mode. *Other People's Children*; *Lurja Magdani* (*Magdana's Donkey*, dir. Revaz Chkheidze and Tengiz Abuladze, Georgia Film, 1955); *Chelovek idet za solntsem* (*Sandu Follows the Sun*, dir. Mikhail Kalik, Moldova-Film, 1962); *Ia kupil papu* (*I Bought a Dad*, dir. Ilya Frez, Gorky Studio, 1962); the anthology film directed by a new generation of Lithuanian filmmakers, *Gyvieji didvyriai* (*The Living Heroes*, Lietuvos kino studija / Lithuanian Film Studio, 1960); and *Paskutinė atostogu diena* (*The Girl and the Echo*, dir. Arūnas Žebriūnas, Lithuanian Film Studio, 1964) all deflate the power of the word typical of Soviet cinema and instead offer a film language that joyfully attends to “a dance of light, space, sound, face and body on the screen,” to recall Iampolski's description.⁷ With their long, dialogue-free stretches, lively mobile framings, and images and sound-scape grounded in a child's perception, these films embody the cinema of

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sincerity's key ethical characteristic: Sincerity does not declare itself but is recognized by those who seek and engage with it. In this respect, the films belonging to the subgenre can be viewed as the exemplars of this new aesthetic trend.

Correlated with such an articulation of cinematic sincerity is the flowering of the cinemas in the republics across the USSR, in particular, stylistic experimentation and establishing their voice with respect to the center. Did the Thaw cinema of sincerity operate differently outside Moscow and Leningrad? Did it exhibit diverging impulses and emphases when it came to peripheral productions? What were its vernacular variations within the power imbalance underlying the imperial relations between center and periphery?

Center and Periphery

In March 1953 the Supreme Soviet of the USSR launched an extensive reform of the government. After dissolving the Ministry of Cinema, which had overseen all aspects of the industry since 1946, the leadership transferred the reins to the recently created Ministry of Culture.⁸ This move substantially diminished film professionals' authority over the multiple sectors of their own industry and to some extent undermined the industry's status as a whole. The following month, a group of distinguished actors and directors informally united under the banner of what would soon become the organizational committee of the Filmmakers Union and penned a lengthy letter to Khrushchev and the newly appointed minister of culture, Panteleimon Ponomarenko. They described a wide range of grievances that had long afflicted the industry—from the chronic underdevelopment of young talent to the highly bureaucratic process of script approval to the inexpedient organization of labor to the dreadful state of Mosfilm Studio.⁹ The letter's main focus was Mosfilm. Established in the 1930s, the central studio saw appreciable material improvements when in 1955 Ivan Pyriev took administrative control. The category of complaints about technology dominated the letter. Inadequate acoustic insulation of sound stages, insufficient electricity for more than two concurrent productions, noisy lighting, poor ventilation, and outdated audio technology were just a handful of the problems to which the filmmakers drew the attention of the senior officials.¹⁰

Joshua First notes that during the 1950s, "the national cinemas of the union republics remained in a decisively peripheral position in relation to central studios." Most of the human and financial capital were directed toward three major studios in Moscow and Leningrad: Mosfilm, Gorky Studio, and Lenfilm.¹¹ Indeed, in the document cited above, the signatories concentrated their attention on the center. Although they conceded that it was

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important to improve the state of cinema and resources in the republics, they stressed that Mosfilm “would always remain the principal base for the industry in our country, where due to a variety of historical circumstances” there was the largest “concentration of the most significant acting, writing, directing, and technical cadres.”¹² In terms of up-to-date equipment and shooting facilities, the republican (and regional) outfits were unquestionably marginalized.¹³ Nonetheless, as early as March 1953—in other words, immediately after the formation of the Ministry of Culture—the Lithuanian party leadership petitioned the Kremlin for financial assistance to reorganize and expand the Lithuanian Film Studio in Vilnius. The ministry supported the petition and turned to the Council of Ministers to request necessary approval. Soon after, Estonia, Belarus, Armenia, and other republics appealed to cinema’s new governing body with similar requests.¹⁴ Only a few years later, several republican studios underwent significant refurbishment of the old premises, expansion, or saw completely new construction, which led, by 1960, to a significant rise in feature production, accounting for two-thirds of the total number of films made in the USSR.¹⁵

Without minimizing the urgent conditions of the republican studios across the union and the imperial mindset of superiority that engendered such a state of affairs, I suggest that within the centralized structure of the Soviet film industry, the studios’ status was nonetheless more complex than being at a disadvantage across the board at all times.¹⁶ A geographical remove might have proffered some benefits. Without adequate technology and sufficient personnel, these studios were also, crucially, without the Central Committee and other Moscow censors nearby. Between 1953 and 1963 the cinema industries in the republics were governed by party functionaries from a local culture ministry.¹⁷ At the local level, some found sympathetic bosses who desired to uplift their national cinema, modernize facilities, and see production thrive.¹⁸ During the Thaw, such a state of affairs was in large part why the studios in the republics sometimes produced the most innovative, provocative, unusual films that would have been all but unthinkable in the center.¹⁹ Naum Kleiman makes a similar point, noting that from the mid-1950s through much of the next decade, Moldova, Belarus, Lithuania, Ukraine, Georgia, and other republics saw an outburst of creativity.²⁰

Other People’s Children, made at the Georgian Film Studio, exemplifies this unparalleled spell of creativity while concretizing the relations between what I call a *peripheral play* and the external pressures of having to fit in the imperial pattern of national or ethnic representation. For decades, the directive for republican productions—“national in form” and “socialist in content”—haunted cinematic works outside the center.²¹ The dictum

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belonged to Stalin, but as Miron Chernenko points out, it survived well into the 1960s, giving rise to pseudonational films that displayed the necessary ethnographic emblems yet lacked the genuine national aspects of a culture.²² However, in a number of instances, reconciliation of the national with the Soviet in the cinemas of the Thaw was often more rhetorical than actual. *Other People's Children* reveals frictions and undermines a smooth integration of the national question within the broader imperatives of the Soviet multinational project. In particular, responses of Moscow's critics and cinema establishment to the film evidence that its creators failed to fulfill the enduring official directive of "national in form" and "socialist in content." Put another way, the aesthetic forms that the film played with could not be comfortably subsumed by the entrenched narrative of a big multinational family and they went against aspects of Soviet ideology.

Each republican studio in the USSR comes with a history, a set of cultural and material conditions that brought it into existence; thus, each studio should be studied individually to develop an understanding of how it fit into the configuration of a multiethnic cinematic empire. For example, the studios in the territories that had been annexed toward the end of the Second World War, most notably, the Baltic states, had a standing within the Soviet historical narrative that was different from that of a studio such as Georgia Film in the Georgian capital of Tbilisi, which had been around since the early 1920s and long regarded as an integral part of the multinational film industry. What allows for some broadness of characterization and a regionalist approach to the union's republican studios is the understanding that all of them, to one degree or another, were involved in creative attempts to establish and celebrate cinematically their national identity and cultural heritage while elaborating a specific foundational narrative that would reconcile the national and the Soviet, the local and the universalist—difference and sameness. In other words, these institutions had to negotiate their place in terms of human and material resources as well as artistic self-expression vis-à-vis the imperial center.

The relationship of the outlying film studios to the metropole replicated the tensions and power relations that inhere in a multiethnic empire that is ruled by a centralizing polity.²³ This relationship should be considered within the broader context of the so-called nationality question, which had always been at the core of the narrative of the Soviet state, as its ethnic diversity presented particular challenges.²⁴ As Francine Hirsch has shown, through a series of land and language policies, mostly during the state-building process in the late 1920s and through the 1930s, as the regime launched a brutal program of rapid industrialization, collectivization, and

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social transformation, nationalities were consolidated into the administrative structure of the Soviet state.²⁵ Historian Erik Scott has characterized the USSR as a “peculiar imperial state; it was avowedly anti-imperialist in its ideology, and its leaders often denounced racial and ethnic hierarchies. Yet the Soviet state ultimately privileged the center over the periphery, and a politically enlightened Communist Party, with its central institutions in the capital, over the rest of society. It was a state heavily engaged in what historians Jane Burbank and Frederick Cooper call the ‘politics of difference,’ an imperial mode that contrasts with the nation-state’s emphasis on homogeneity and lateral ties.”²⁶ The films under consideration in this and the following chapters can be fruitfully considered as the products of the politics of difference.

Georgian Cinema

In his analysis of Georgian literary modernism, which flowered during Georgia’s brief period of independence between 1918 and 1921, literary scholar Harsha Ram offers two orientations of modernity within which peripheral modernisms can be productively examined. One is temporal and concerns what he calls, paraphrasing Leon Trotsky, a “posture of *empowering belatedness*,” which is partially attributable to the uneven development of modernity and being in the position of playing catch-up with the West.²⁷ In Ram’s example, the appearance and coexistence in Georgia of political modernity and artistic modernisms collapsed a more sequential and defined temporality of the development of modernism in the West. The other orientation Ram notes is spatial, which illuminates a particular geography of modernity and inspects with great attention modernity’s centripetal impulse and operations of deterritorialization. Ram’s conceptualization of the relationship between belatedness, geographic distance, collapsed periodization, and aesthetic practice provides a fruitful theoretical framework for approaching the creative outburst of post-Stalin cinema outside the center. It compels us to look closely at the centrifugal movement of filmmakers and their practice as the result of this movement while institutionally and politically having to pay attention to Moscow. Keeping in view this double orientation allows us to approach the center/periphery dichotomy during the rush of creativity in Georgian and to an extent other national cinemas in the Soviet peripheries during this period in a more nuanced way—in particular, as Abuladze and his colleagues were responding to other artistic idioms, repurposing and recombining aspects of these idioms and mixing them with local traditions, national aspirations, and personal artistic vision.

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Georgia and Georgians possibly enjoyed preferential treatment in the big multinational Soviet family. Georgia's almost mythical status in the Russian cultural imagination that had formed during the Russian imperial expansion in the nineteenth century persisted into the postrevolutionary decade and much of the Soviet period.²⁸ This elevated position was a result of the long history of Russo-Georgian literary relations, many "high-placed Georgian elites in Soviet institutions, the frequent visits of the Soviet leadership to Georgian Black Sea vacation spots and other factors."²⁹ The perception of the special status, writes historian Claire Kaiser, "emboldened Georgian nation-building elites (in both Moscow and Tbilisi and in Abkhazia's capital, Sukhumi) to pursue a series of policies designed to further strengthen Georgians' position in their own republic, as well as expand their influence beyond Georgia's borders."³⁰ Scott has argued that the Soviet Union was "an empire of diasporas," which stimulated "domestic internationalism."³¹ In this imperial space, Georgians often moved beyond their native land to gain prominence in Moscow—with Joseph Stalin being the most notable example—"yet remained a distinctive national community."³² They were what Scott calls "familiar strangers" vis-à-vis Russia. In his characterization,

Georgians employed strangeness in ways that met the demands of the Soviet state, but they did so largely for their own benefit. They succeeded because their cultural repertoire emphasized recognizable difference, because their networks stretched beyond the Georgian Soviet Socialist Republic (SSR) to intersect with central institutions, and because their homeland was firmly within Soviet borders, able to provide a steady supply of ideologically sanctioned cultural and material resources. Georgians had a distinct set of skills and a cultivated mythology that fit those skills. The Soviet authorities used, promoted, and sometimes resented Georgian success, while Georgians capitalized on it, negotiating between imperial prominence and local self-assertion.³³

A state-sponsored network of intellectual and cultural exchange invited aspiring artists, including filmmakers, from the republics and Soviet autonomous regions to study in Moscow. Thus opening the center to citizens of the periphery, a cultural space remained, in the characterization of Mary Louise Pratt, within a context "of highly asymmetrical relations of power."³⁴ But the centripetal force of the established system of film education reversed once the graduates of the All-Union State Institute of Cinema (VGIK) and Mosfilm's Higher Workshops, which had been instated by Pyriev in the mid-1950s, completed their studies. Often sent to work in the republics after exposure to a range of cultures and artistic idioms during their time in the

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capital, young directors, actors, cinematographers, and art designers were able to play with their collaged and fragmented knowledge, refracting it through a vernacular sensibility. In some cases, these filmmakers were strangers in a place to which they had been assigned and would sometimes leave their imprint on the development of a given studio's product.³⁵ But more often they were coming home. Their new experiences would be brought to bear on a local film aesthetic for generations. This was the case with the director Tengiz Abuladze and the cinematographer Levan Paataashvili, who, after graduating from VGIK in 1953 and 1954, respectively, returned to their native Tbilisi to work at Georgia Film, a studio with a storied history.³⁶

The film studio in Tbilisi, or Tiflis as the capital was known until 1936, was founded in 1921, immediately after Russia's Red Army had invaded Georgia, following a brief interlude of Georgia's political independence after 1917.³⁷ First under the auspices of the Georgian People's Commissariat of Education (Narkompros), reformed two years later into a joint stock company under Goskinprom (the Georgian SSR agency in charge of the local film industry), it was one of the oldest among the republican studios.³⁸ The rigorous exchange of acting, directing, and technical talent between Russia and Soviet Georgia in the early days of the industry's establishment paved the way for Tbilisi's studio in the 1920s and 1930s. The fare it produced during the first decade mixed themes and images steeped in the local folklore and history with the heroics demanded by the immediate postrevolutionary years of the Soviet state, such as highlighting the struggle of the Georgian people against the repressions of the tsarist regime.³⁹ Ivan Perestiani, a film and stage actor who had worked in Russia with Evgeny Bauer and other leading artists in the 1910s, joined the Georgian outfit in 1921 and soon brought it to prominence. Perestiani's 1923 *Tsiteli eshmakunebi* (*The Little Red Devils*) arguably launched the adventure genre of the civil war film that validated the new Bolshevik regime. Perestiani directed several films that could be considered first psychological dramas of Georgian and Soviet cinema.⁴⁰ His historical features *Arsena Dzhordzhiashvili* (1921), *Suramis tsikhe* (*The Suram Fortress*, 1922), and *Sami sitsotskhle* (*Three Lives*, 1924) turned to the Georgian past and folklore while responding to the spirit of the turbulent present. Commissar of Education Anatoly Lunacharsky declared *Three Lives* a work that "is not only equal to the best foreign offerings, distinguishing itself by its deep realism, but it also leaves far behind all Soviet cinema."⁴¹ At the closing of the silent period, in 1929, Goskinprom produced *Chemi bebia* (*My Grandmother*, 1929), a film by the young director Kote Mikaberidze that was famously banned, rediscovered in 1967, and at last seen after the Georgia

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Film restoration in 1976.⁴² For the Georgian filmmakers who embarked on their careers in the 1960s, *My Grandmother*, combining the visual language of surrealism, German expressionism, constructivism, and other modernist influences of the 1920s, became somewhat of a fetish.⁴³ Two other significant Georgian figures began their careers at Tbilisi's studio in the 1920s and then moved fluidly in the Soviet empire of diasporas to great success: Mikhail Kalatozov and Mikheil Chiaureli.⁴⁴ The younger Marlen Khutsiev, for his part, assisted in the studio's art department in the 1940s before moving to Moscow and applying to VGIK.

The downturn in the Soviet film industry during high Stalinism impaired the Tbilisi Film Studio, as it was known until 1953, at which point it was renamed Kartuli Pilmi, or Georgia Film. Between 1945 and 1955 it produced very few features, and, similar to other Soviet studios, the fare consisted mostly of historical epics and biopics, such as *Davit Guramishvili* (1946), *Bashi-Achuki* (1956), and *Eteris simghera* (*Song of Eteri*, 1956).⁴⁵ Georgian filmmakers and historians of Georgian cinema regard *Magdana's Donkey* as the beginning of a new wave in Georgian film.⁴⁶ I would argue that the short heralded a change in post-Stalin Soviet cinema more broadly. Codirected by Abuladze and Revaz Chkheidze, who had already shared directorial credit on several documentaries, *Magdana's Donkey* received the best fiction film



Village children washing a donkey in *Magdana's Donkey*

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award in the short film category at the 1956 Cannes Film Festival.⁴⁷ Perhaps it was this unpretentious film—a story of a poor widow, her three kids, and a donkey—that launched a cycle of Soviet films with children at the helm.⁴⁸

The dusty country road on which a lot of important action happens set the stage for an aesthetic thread in Georgian cinema of the 1950s and 1960s that favors wide shots of the environment, most notably, those that open onto the Georgian landscape or a panorama of Tbilisi.⁴⁹ In 1962 Neya Zorkaya described Abuladze's first films in terms that bring to mind Italian neorealism, in particular, its affection for the material details of the world inhabited by the disempowered. In *Magdana's Donkey*, observes Zorkaya, the young filmmakers turn not to the heroic figures of the past but to "a peasant widow who doesn't know if she can provide for her three kids, to village children, and to the elderly from an impoverished Georgian settlement. There are no mighty fortresses perched in the mountains, no formidable castles of feudal lords, but there are destitute shacks, earthenware pots with yogurt, pathetic implements of peasants. A small story . . . a simple episode from life became the basis . . . of Abuladze and Chkheidze's film."⁵⁰ Zorkaya's description of what is not in the film suggests the picturesque visions of Georgia that derive from the Russian imperial imaginary; only here, they are subsumed under the Thaw's exigency for ordinary characters and common stories. The critic commends the authenticity of the *mise-en-scène* and performance.

Other People's Children was Abuladze's first solo feature and Paatashvili's debut as principal cameraman. Made away from the center, the film nonetheless wound up in the crosshairs of Moscow's critical establishment, earning the dubious distinction of a talented but problematic debut. It was not the first time a movie from the periphery caught the attention of the capital. Most striking in this instance is that the negative discussions of *Other People's Children* were commonly premised on the notion of authenticity—national, aesthetic, and, above all, Soviet. The detractors seemed to mark the film as lacking in all those forms of authentic representation. How could a film set and shot in Georgia and created by young Georgians suffer a loss of authenticity and its close cousin, sincerity? It is in these terms, especially the questioning and undermining of the film's authenticity in critical discourse, that I consider the place of *Other People's Children* in the constellation of "sincere" films.

A Heady Mix of Styles

Other People's Children is based on an eponymous newspaper item that Abuladze had come across in 1955 in the Soviet daily *Komsomol'skaia pravda*. The piece told the story of a young woman who became involved in the

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lives of and eventually adopted two motherless children. Soon after, the children's father abandoned them for his lover, while the new stepmother decided to stay with the kids. In the Georgian film, the protagonists of the newspaper article become Dato the father (Otar Koberidze), Nato the young woman (Tsitsino Tsitsishvili), Teo the lover (Asmat Qandaurashvili), and Gia (Mikho Borashvili) and Lia (Nani Chikvinidze) the brother and sister, respectively, while the action is transposed from a Russian locale to Tbilisi. Abuladze began filming in 1956 and finished sometime in 1958.⁵¹ The film had a careful director's script, as was customary in the Soviet industry, with a shot-for-shot description—*raskadrovka*, or the “shooting script”—of camera angles, composition, and blocking.

Other People's Children does not stay true to a single representational mode, instead displaying a stylistic incoherence and a certain aesthetic discord among the styles that mark the work as formally “sincere.” The visual field of the film is unsettled and exuberant. In many instances, shot composition looks back to avant-garde photographic practices, while the dark sensibility and stylistic choices of the racy secondary plotline echoes French poetic realism and Georgian studio films of the 1930s. Paataashvili, during preproduction research, watched a host of Georgian movies from that decade, arguably the most prolific period of the studio. They gave the cinematographer the idea to play boldly with high contrasts in the black-and-white image, something that Abuladze was after.⁵² However, it was the accusations of imitating Italian neorealism that resounded the loudest in the din of reviews and commentary emitting from Moscow upon the screening of the film. The mixing of a national identity with a decidedly foreign style was a particularly unwelcome commingling; it implicitly sidelined the role of the center, Communist ideology, and the Soviet character of the material. What is more, the film seemed to lack what was expected from a national cinematic constituent of the multinational image empire: specific ethnographic symbols and supposed national characteristics by which the imperial center came to identify a non-Russian culture.

Reworking a real-life event reported in the newspaper into a film script is what Giuseppe De Santis, Cesare Zavattini, and the rest of the writing team, five in all, famously did on *Roma, ore 11* (*Rome, 11:00*, 1952), a picture that saw Soviet distribution in 1954 and was uniformly lauded.⁵³ *Rome, 11:00* took as its premise a tragic event that occurred on via Savoia in Rome in January 1951. In answering an ad for a secretarial position, so many women showed up for the interview in hopes of work that the building's staircase collapsed under their weight, causing injuries and killing one person. De Santis's film restages the incident and then, in an episodic structure,

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follows several of the women's lives posttragedy. What Abuladze and his coscriptwriter, novelist Revaz Japaridze, did—shaping the factual material into a script—is the kind of creative act that Zavattini made the core of neorealist storytelling. Zavattini's notes on neorealist principles were published in *Iskusstvo kino*, of which one key principle was the bridging of reality and spectacle: "Whereas in the past, in cinema one event/scene gave rise to the next and the next . . . today, creating a scene we feel the need to 'linger' inside it, since we know that it hides enormous possibilities, that it can have the widest resonance. . . . Today we can calmly say, 'Give us any ordinary fact, and we will use it to the fullest to make a cinematic spectacle out of it.'" ⁵⁴

The social commitment of *Rome, 11:00*—the investigation conducted by De Santis and his scenario team into the complex matter of who was to blame for the tragedy and the interviews with the actual participants—takes a backseat in *Other People's Children*. The Georgian film is not committed to "presenting evidence" to the jury-audience, as the critic Inna Solovyova characterized neorealist narratives: It does not accuse the father character of leaving, nor does it especially glorify the stepmother's decision to remain with the children. Although Japaridze declared that the story was about "the high morality of the Soviet person," the film seems much more interested in exploring and playing with the repertory of techniques identified with a neorealist visual style than making a point about the rectitude of Soviet citizens. ⁵⁵ These techniques are worth recalling, particularly as they are to be considered in the context of the Soviet Thaw. Solovyova's 1961 book, *Kino Italii, 1945–1960* (The cinema of Italy, 1945–1960), the existence of which is greatly indebted to her trips to Gosfilmofond and its foreign film collection, describes the distinctive visual style of neorealism as follows:

Neorealism fell out of love with the sound stage. Neorealism rushed to the streets, where everything was genuine. It rejoiced at the similarity with documentary film. It even feared professional actors, perceiving [them] as a sort of forgery; it preferred the conjunction of hero and performer to the art of acting. . . . The cinematographers of the first neorealist films . . . opted for revealing things as they are seen in everyday life. This is how Tonti shoots a dusty square, lazy dogs, a person strenuously moving a cart. . . . This is how Arata photographs alleyways and courtyards in the Prenestino neighborhood, the tired face of a pregnant woman, an empty lot. . . . The neorealists consistently preferred medium and long shots to close-ups, allowing us to discern the link between hero and background, "plug" the acting person into the "acting" physical world. A taste for long takes developed that by the time of *Bicycle*

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Thieves and *The Earth Trembles* established itself as one distinguishing feature of the neorealist film language: The camera for a long while lingers on one object, letting life itself stir on camera. Dynamics is created only through this movement.⁵⁶

Apart from the two films she identifies by name, Solovyova's descriptions refer to Visconti's *Obsession* and Rossellini's *Rome, Open City*. Her characterization of their visual style does not distinguish among the different production conditions of the films, which led to markedly different looks. De Sica's *Bicycle Thieves*, for example, enjoyed a relatively generous budget and a large crew as well as a detailed shooting script, while Rossellini made *Rome, Open City* fast and on the cheap.⁵⁷ On his next film, *Paisan*, Rossellini frequently rewrote the script while he and his crew shot, later confessing in an interview that he "never really understood the need for a shooting script unless it's to reassure the producers."⁵⁸ The distinctive creative process gave *Paisan*, "the neorealist film at its purest," its narrative and visual style.⁵⁹ Thus, neorealism covered a considerable aesthetic ground, or, to put it another way, several forms of neorealism coexisted, associated with different directorial or writerly visions, which in the Soviet circumstances represented more of an amalgamation.

Other People's Children was shot almost entirely on location, and Abuladze and his crew decisively proclaimed their allegiance to what they knew of the neorealist aesthetic and tropes. Deliberately avoiding familiar streets submerged in lush foliage and choosing instead the outskirts of Tbilisi, they sought to present a different image of the city.⁶⁰ Although professional actors played the adult characters, the two children in the film can be seen as that artless element—"the conjunction of hero and performer"—that the neorealists, especially in the early days, so valued.

Brother and sister Gia and Lia steer the viewer through the hilly topography of a southern city. The coordinates of streetcar tracks, electric cables, outdoor stairways, balustrades, and angles of buildings, together with the sun and shadows, produce an urban geometry that organizes the mise-en-scène into a graphically energetic design.

The short focal lens, which Paataashvili preferred when shooting figures in a cityscape, cuts the composition into distinct planes, creating a rich visual texture circumscribed by the perspectival grid and enhancing the sense of compositional depth. Moreover, working much of the time with the sun high in the sky, the cinematographer was able to stop down the aperture considerably, giving the multispatial image sharpness. Dark shadows on street surfaces and walls enliven the images. According to Paataashvili,

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Nato meeting brother and sister Gia and Lia in *Other People's Children*
 (production still, National Archives of Georgia)



Gia and Lia in pursuit of Nato in *Other People's Children*
 (production still, National Archives of Georgia)

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Lines and shadows in *Other People's Children*

Abuladze asked for static compositions underpinned by classical symmetry.⁶¹ While static in many scenes, the film nonetheless feels kinetic: Shots brim with motion inside the image, and Paataashvili used mobile framing to follow patiently the young subjects, who hardly know stillness. Their language of expression is physical movement, and it is this movement that gives the *mise-en-scène* and the overall form of *Other People's Children* a sense of being taken over by spontaneous energy rather than being submitted to meticulous choreography.

At some point in darting around Tbilisi, Lia and Gia slow down by a wall overcrowded with posters and announcements. The image constructs an environment with a multitude of overlapping cultural sources—a collage of offerings from dance to cinema—in which a poster for a neorealist movie arrests one's attention. In a romantic drive toward accessibility of culture during the Thaw, cultural authorities managed to deliver new Soviet and even Western films, albeit with several months' delay, to the country's distant areas.⁶² This display of overlaid traces of events seen in the playbills and announcements clearly marks Tbilisi as a cultural hub. Lia is stopped in her tracks in front of a film poster depicting a striking woman. The face, larger than life, stares at her and the viewer for several seconds. The girl comments to her brother on the resemblance of the movie star to Aunt Nato: Nato is

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Italian movie star Silvana Pampanini in Tbilisi in *Other People's Children*

just as beautiful as the 1950s European sex symbol Silvana Pampanini, the star of *Un marito per Anna Zaccheo* (*A Husband for Anna*, 1953), a drama by De Santis recently released on Soviet screens.⁶³

With this playful gesture of affection in which Italian neorealism directly addresses the Georgian film, as it were, *Other People's Children* once more declares its aesthetic and social alignment with Italian cinema.⁶⁴ The materiality of the wall, as well as of Tbilisi, also epitomizes the interest of the filmmakers in that particular aspect of neorealism: attention to the physical world, for which Boris Zingerman got in trouble when he claimed that neorealist films did not merely achieve an astounding proximity to reality but were its equivalent.⁶⁵

The patient neorealist camerawork is interspersed with fleeting, static shots reminiscent of the legacy of Soviet avant-garde photography. The two aesthetics, one anchored in a humanist tradition, the other in a convention valorizing technology and the machine, create a syncretic visual dynamism in the film. For Bazin, the neorealist camera displayed first and foremost humanness: "Almost everything is done at eye level or from concrete vantage points such as windows and roofs. . . . An Italian movie camera preserves something of the humanity of the Bell and Howell newsreel camera.

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It is inseparable from the hand and the eye—almost identical to the person behind it and in tune with their attention.”⁶⁶ *Other People's Children* observes this unspoken rule for much of the film. It also makes the most of the high vantage points afforded by the topographical and architectural particularities of the local landscape to arrange careful shots that are traversed by figures and vehicles.

The children's exuberant interaction with the various textures of the urban landscape constitutes the substance of the film. They run around Tbilisi, selling empty bottles to buy a gift for their new friend Nato or searching for her. On the bus, going on a rare outing with their mostly absent father, Lia and Gia trade seats and communicate verbally and through glances with other passengers as the camera observes the social micromilieu. In these scenes, “the dense texture of life” is “the only true measure of beauty,” to use the description penned by the French critic Amédée Ayfre about neorealist cinema.⁶⁷ The secondary narrative—the intrigue, as such—is almost a throwaway. Despite the taboo subject of illicit love, it is what permitted the creators to say that their film was about the Soviet person's unimpeachable morality. It is also what gives this narrative line a dark undercurrent of poetic realist sensibility.



The doomed lovers in *Other People's Children*

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The passion between Dato and Teo, the woman with whom Dato broke relations in the story's opening because she refused to be a stepmother to his children, plays out mostly in low-lit, shadowy interiors. High-contrast lighting and close-ups, edited using eyeline match, shut the characters out from the outside world and create an atmosphere of desolation.

The interior scenes portraying the encounters between the lovers take on a fatalistic mood, which strikes an incongruous note with the chaotic, lively streets of Tbilisi. During these moments, the couple seem to belong to a different film, perhaps even a different epoch. Inside Teo's space, with a bed, chair, and shaded window, the story and aesthetic shift markedly—lowlight and spare detail throw the narrative into the abstract, poetic universe of shadows and dreams, aided by a dramatic musical score. Teo is uninterested in motherhood and domesticity. Her nonjudgmental portrayal as an openly sexual being and an assertive woman had no equivalent female character in Soviet cinema at the time. If in the outdoor sequences, no matter how deliberately composed, city life intrudes upon the filmic reality, here, the presence and placement of every object in the frame are carefully calculated. It is a different visual language whose geometricity and lighting create a hermetic enclosure for the narrative plight of the lovers. Their predicament relies on image and body language rather than dialogue.

Recalling the character of the anguished painter in Marcel Carné's *Les quai des brumes* (*Port of Shadows*, 1938) who dissolves into the thick, seemingly permanent fog, Dato by the end of the film disappears into the night, unable to fight his passion. Not originating in the textual source, the heavy tone and steamy features emerged during production. It is likely that as former students at VGIK, Abuladze and Paatashvili were exposed to the aesthetic of French poetic realism.⁶⁸ But the aesthetic of high contrasts also leads to silent cinema and the Georgian films of the 1930s that Paatashvili had watched for creative guidance. Davit Rondeli's *Dakarguli samotkhe* (*Lost Paradise*, 1937), in particular, can be considered a model for the cinematographer in crafting the dramatic texture of the image through the bold manipulation of light and shadow to distinguish this part of the story. The visual register of *Other People's Children*, with its harsh, graphic contrasts, especially in the scenes with Dato and Teo, countered the 1950s cinematographic palette of Soviet films.

Inauthentic Voices

The question of language vis-à-vis sincerity/insincerity comes to a head in the practice of dubbing films made in the USSR's republics. "Peripheral" films created in languages other than Russian were more often than not

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translated and dubbed by professional Russian-speaking actors.⁶⁹ Destined for distribution in a multiethnic empire, films from Georgia, Lithuania, Uzbekistan, and other republics underwent a rigorous process not simply of being overlaid with Russian-speaking voices but also of being reinterpreted and linguistically adjusted in order to render the operation of dubbing invisible—in effect, to smooth out cultural or any other distinctions. As James Steffen notes, “Given the significant role that nationality occupied in Soviet political discourse, dubbing could . . . be seen as a literal homogenization, even suppression . . . of the voice of non-Russian peoples.”⁷⁰

In the Soviet Union, film dubbing was considered an art and in the 1950s the superior form of film translation.⁷¹ Only dubbing, one commentator insisted, “based on the live voice of an actor, can impact the spectator emotionally and deliver the film’s message.”⁷² In contrast, subtitles, although a cheaper and less demanding option, disrupted visual composition and proved distracting and confusing for audiences, claimed many critics and industry professionals.⁷³ As Gilburd points out, subtitles were a form of censorship that “distribution officials used to ‘restrict’ audiences ‘artificially.’ The general understanding among cinema bureaucrats was that few people would enjoy a subtitled film.”⁷⁴ If Moscow decided to buy a foreign film for commercial release, it usually invested in dubbing.

Neorealist films in Soviet distribution in the early 1950s such as *Bicycle Thieves*, Mario Camerini’s *Molti sogni per le strade* (*The Street Has Many Dreams*, 1948), *Il camino della Speranza* (*Path of Hope*, 1950), and others were regarded as examples of the most successful dubbing work. This translating practice, said the film director and dubbing expert Vladimir Legoshin, was best when it went unnoticed.⁷⁵ On the other hand, the majority of the offerings at the Italian Cinema Week in 1956 were subtitled, save for Luigi Comincini’s romantic comedy *Pane, amore e fantasia* (*Bread, Love, and Dreams*, 1953), which the Soviets bought for wide release.⁷⁶

All three central studios—Lenfilm, Mosfilm, and the Gorky Film Studio—had dubbing facilities during this period, but it was the Gorky Studio that became the leader in the dubbing business and developed the model approach to the operation, which involved translation, painstaking phonetic analysis of dialogue, and study by translator and actor of the interaction between image, lip movements, dialogue, and the image’s emotional charge.⁷⁷ While focusing on and scrutinizing on-screen speech in particular, dubbers treated “the soundtrack as a unity” and restaged and rerecorded all sound effects as well.⁷⁸ The more controversial aspects of dubbing started to crop up in the industry and media in the early 1960s, as reflected in an *Iskusstvo kino* article, with many cinemagoers bemoaning the convention in their letters to

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the journal. One spectator implored the studios to permit him the pleasure of hearing the actual voices of Simone Signoret and Giulietta Masina. Another rued her disappointing experience of seeing the long-anticipated film by René Clement, *Gervaise* (1956), only to discover Maria Schell speaking perfect Russian in a dispassionate voice.⁷⁹ To many viewers, dubbed films came across as lacking, incomplete, or worse—false, inauthentic. Nonetheless, the practice remained dominant throughout the Soviet era.

Films made in the union's republics with local acting talent were virtually foreign commodities from the perspective of the Soviet marketplace. While distributors, translators, and dubbing experts might not have had to worry about modifying an ambiguous or worrisome message of original republican productions through translation, they treated films such as *Other People's Children* the way they would any foreign-language film.⁸⁰ Dušan Radunović, taking up Félix Guattari and Gilles Deleuze's theory of minor literature, conceives of Georgian cinema as minor within the transnational context of the Soviet state. What "ensured Georgian cinema's entry into major Russophonous culture-political space" was precisely its dubbing into Russian—which can arguably be said about other cinemas of the union.⁸¹

On the one hand, dubbed films from Georgia and other republics could vie for larger audiences throughout the country and especially in the Soviet Union's urban centers; on the other hand, these films' original voices, native language, inflections, articulations, and even breath were overlaid and dissimulated. It is true that the Soviet sound recording technology was inadequate in the capture of dialogue on the set; thus, dialogue would be recorded and mixed in postproduction at this time. The original language of a film would, however, be preserved. But the Soviet dubbing technique, which involved translation, overlaid the entire original soundtrack, not just the dialogue, thereby creating a "new and fundamentally recontextualized product in the process."⁸² Film scholar Antje Ascheid has argued that in a dubbed film, "new characters are uttering a *translated*, which always also means interpreted, appropriated, and recreated *new* text, thus undergoing fundamental shifts in the construction of their national and cultural identity and context."⁸³ Doing this kind of sound violence to films that came from within the multiethnic state arguably rendered them *more* foreign, not less. They took on the characteristics of productions made abroad: With the visual field unchanged, the resulting image incongruities with the overlaid soundtrack gave it the stamp of a non-Soviet film, of an other.⁸⁴

Perhaps the majority of Soviet audiences did not desire to hear the actual voices of Georgian actors in *Other People's Children* as they would those of Italian and French stars; however, a sense of authenticity was largely lost

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through the loss of the soundtrack; thus, the resulting film contains a sense of loss not only at the level of the story with the father departing but also at the level of metaphor. Although not directly addressed, this partial sacrificing of national authenticity in Abuladze's film elicited strong responses from filmmakers and critics that touched on the question of the national and the familiar, of the Soviet and the local. I would argue that the language issue inflects the notion of sincerity as it surfaced in and was assimilated by the national cinemas of the Soviet state.

"Imitation" of Italian Neorealism

Although made away from the center, Abuladze's picture wound up in the center of the critical debate about the future of Soviet cinema and its dangerous receptivity to neorealist and other foreign influences. Perhaps due to the republic of Georgia's place within the multiethnic ranking of the Soviet state as a "familiar stranger," *Other People's Children* elicited especially heated responses from the media and some of the most powerful voices in the cinema industry. Their commentary registered unease with the depiction of Tbilisi and its inhabitants: The film rendered both as less familiar. In particular, a number of commentators complained that the typical traits that came to be associated with the Georgians—hospitality, a sense of communal bonds, social openness—were absent in Abuladze's film.⁸⁵ It lacked the habitual colonizing gaze.⁸⁶

Other People's Children rattled many. A doyen of the industry, director Sergei Gerasimov, wrote a lengthy piece in *Iskusstvo kino* dedicated to the question of the "fake and genuine" (*poddel'noe i podlinnoe*) in which he chastised Abuladze for being a talented forger who mimics an alien aesthetic.⁸⁷ Rather than taking life as a source of inspiration, Gerasimov claimed, the young director and his crew turned to Italian neorealism, thus copying the representation rather than the model.⁸⁸ Such an inauthentic approach closed Abuladze's eyes to the national specificities, to say nothing of socialist content, insisted Gerasimov. In other words, the director lacked a proper worldview.⁸⁹ Many hewed to the Gerasimov line in their criticism. Although far more nuanced in her evaluation, Neya Zorkaya discerned what she called a "confusion of life" in *Other People's Children* that she attributed to the filmmakers' imitation of Italian cinema.⁹⁰ Abuladze was accused of copying the superficial features of neorealism, which became clichés: laundry drying outside and neighbors yelling across a courtyard.⁹¹

However, what is more interesting in these assessments of the film as a neorealist simulacrum is how critics perceived the image of Tbilisi, an old, dynamic metropolis where the people and their cultures, customs, and

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Кинорежиссер Омар Коберидзе в фильме режиссера Тенгиза Абуладзе «Чужие дети» (1958)

Молодые кинематографисты Грузии

Киноактриса Лия Элава в фильме «Костры горят» (1961)

10



Молодые грузинские кинематографисты, продолжая лучшие традиции стоявших у истоков советского киноискусства в Грузии прославленных мастеров Ивана Переставани, Николая Шенгелая, Наты Вачагадзе и других, принесли в искусство свой талант, свои чувства, свой почерк.

В течение ряда послевоенных лет жизнь на Тбилисской киностудии, казалось, протекала спокойно без особенных взлетов и падений, в действительности же творческая мысль кинематографистов напряженно работала.

На съемочных площадках один за другим появлялись новые режиссеры, операторы, сценаристы, актеры, росло число интересных фильмов, которыми молодые грузинские кинематографисты выходили к зрителям.

В 1955 году выпускники режиссерского факультета Всесоюзного государственного института кинематографии Тенгиз Абуладзе и Резо Чхеидзе показали свой дипломный фильм «Пурдиза Магланя». Эта работа начинающих кинематографистов была отмечена такой полнотой изображения мира, такой неистребимой любовью и заботой, что о ней заговорили. И эта, казалось бы, незатейливая, простая короткометражка стала определенной вехой в дальнейшем развитии послевоенного грузинского кино.

В 1958 году Тенгиз Абуладзе выступил с фильмом «Чужие дети». Режиссер погружал нас в мир глубоких психологических переживаний, заставлял задуматься над причинами, по которым самые простые ситуации превращаются иногда в жизни в тяжелые драматические коллизии.

Проблемы «сосуществования» разума и инстинкта, слитности добрых и злых начал в душе человека — такой круг вопросов, волновавших Абуладзе в фильме «Чужие дети».

Персонажи фильма немногословны: герой и героиня обмениваются на протяжении всего экранного действия последние считанные колечками слов. Смеются, плачут, говорят и умоляют с экраня души дети, — и тем не менее фильм красноречив и полон экспрессии.

Сейчас Абуладзе заканчивает работу над новым фильмом. Его «Сельский пареня» — это своеобразнейшая из комедий, в которой смешное и патетическое переплетаются столь тесно и органично, что вы, с невольным волнением наблюдая за перипетиями сюжета, право, не знаете — плакать вам или смеяться, грустить или радоваться. Шестнадцатилетний Зурико, его старая бабушка и два друга дома — старики-крестьяне — главные герои комедии. Их взаимоотношения, повседневные радости и заботы в мирное время и в дни войны — такова канва фильма. Но его подлинным пафосом

A 1962 issue of *Soviet Film* (*Sovetskii film*), a magazine promoting Soviet cinema abroad, profiles Georgian cinema (General Research Division, New York Public Library)

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languages, “without merging, nonetheless existed in amicable aesthetic proximity and mutual agreement. The largest cultures were Georgian, Armenian, Persian, Turkic, Russian, Polish, Jewish, and Kurdish.”⁹² From reviews, it emerges as a place that the dominant Russian culture is not used to seeing. The city that usually “astounds a traveler with its distinctiveness, flavor,” Zorkaya writes in the language that reveals the othering of Tbilisi, is unrecognizable here. Put differently, the usual *otherness* with which an outsider gazes at the place is absent. The image of the city created by the filmmakers, moreover, was unfettered to Soviet reality and instead was presented through specific narrative strategies and a neorealist vision. This vision, mediated by Georgian landscape and architecture, made Tbilisi not merely strange in the eye of Moscow critics but also unknowable. In fact, it rendered the entire film more Georgian—and even European, as some noted—than Soviet and thus alarmingly unidentifiable. One of the earlier Soviet commentators on neorealist film described it approvingly in antipicturesque terms: “We look in vain for blooming gardens, orange groves, the azure sky exalted by poets. This cinema throws down a challenge to all traditional ideas of Italy.”⁹³ Similarly, *Other People's Children* removed the Soviet varnish as well as the familiar trappings of a scenic postcard that many from the Russian center had cherished and been accustomed to. Instead, it presented something else—a vibrant old city in the South Caucasus that would not submit to the exoticizing rhetoric of the imperial center.

Commensurate with the perceived un-Soviet space, the film also lacked clear signals that the protagonists belonged to the Soviet milieu. One reviewer rued the introverted, brooding father character, who went against what the reviewer perceived to be the “cheery nature and sociability of the national disposition” of the Georgian people.⁹⁴ Besides, where were the sympathetic neighbors? Why the isolation of the protagonists, a device that many considered, once again, grafted from neorealism? Two years later, upon reflecting on *Other People's Children*, Zorkaya argued with her own review written immediately after the film's release. She still found faults but now offered more nuance: The movie failed to reveal the multidimensional connections between milieu and individual.⁹⁵ Several critics remarked that the citizens of Tbilisi in their complexion called to mind Italian faces. This, too, seemed to confirm the “wrong” kind of otherness of Abuladze's images. The filmic reality of *Other People's Children* on several counts appeared at once too *Georgian* and too *neorealist* and most certainly not Soviet enough.

Being spatially decentered (if we think of Moscow as the center in relation to the republican studios within the imperial hierarchy of the Soviet Union) allowed Abuladze and his colleagues to obtain a stamp of approval for the

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script by the local studio's artistic council without difficulty; to shoot around Tbilisi virtually unimpeded (the main impediment was the outdated technical equipment at Georgia Film, according to Paataashvili); and to have the film commercially released avoiding *pererabotka* (bowdlerization). Judging by the controversy it incited, *Other People's Children* would not have passed muster at any number of approval stages had it originated at Mosfilm or the Gorky Studio.⁹⁶

Abuladze and his crew made a film that experimented with visual strategies of neorealism and looked for inspiration to 1930s Georgian cinema and, quite possibly, French poetic realism. Although Gerasimov described *Other People's Children* as imitative and thus, in his view, a forgery, for Abuladze's colleagues, the film's search for a new cinematic language represented a step in the right direction. Its young protagonists dramatized a new way of seeing that defamiliarized images of the city, landscape, and people. The children became the vehicle for a vision of cinema that was concerned with a sense of emotional honesty and unaffected expression.⁹⁷ The visual language of the film is the language of the children, who, following their curiosity and immediate response to a situation, imbue the work with physicality and movement. Soviet ideology is sidelined; instead, the poetic urgency of a child's perceptions takes over. Although the reception of neorealism in the Soviet Union was highly ambivalent for the reasons examined in this chapter and elsewhere, Soviet filmmakers' embrace of some of its ethical and formal aspects significantly shaped an aesthetic of sincerity and articulated it in the republican films by engaging with physical reality and withdrawal from linguistic signification.

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CHAPTER 5

A Space for Experimentation

The Last Shot and The Girl and the Echo

Moscow critics and the film establishment questioned the authenticity of *Other People's Children*, declaring the work an imitation of Italian neorealism. Its representation of spaces and behaviors seemed foreign—neither Georgian nor Soviet—and certainly did not comply with the collective pathos of socialist living. The immediate responses to the world of the young protagonists, Lia and Gia, root the film in affective rather than verbal dimensions. Arūnas Žebriūnas's films *Paskutinis šūvis* (*The Last Shot*, 1960) and *The Girl and the Echo* cover similar ground.

Five-year-old Laima and preadolescent heroine Vika in the Lithuanian films are Lia and Gia's kindred spirits.¹ Spending the summer at her grandfather's house on the coast, Vika collects shells, roams the craggy landscape, and swims naked in the sea. She has a secret: She knows how to communicate with the surrounding mountains by way of an echo. The young heroine shares the secret with Romas, a boy she meets at the beach. The two strike up a friendship. Eager to be accepted by a pack of boys, Romas betrays Vika by revealing her secret to them, only to be humiliated by the mountains: They refuse to answer his calls. This summarizes the plot, such as it is, of *The Girl and the Echo*, loosely based on Russian author Yuri Nagibin's short story "The Echo" ("Ekho," 1960) and shot in Crimea in the summer of 1964 as the Lithuanian Film Studio was undergoing reconstruction. The film relies even less on verbal signification than *Other People's Children*. Many sequences have no need for dialogue, yielding instead to the magnificence of the Crimean peninsula's southeastern landscape, with its ancient rock formations towering over the Black Sea, as well as to the young protagonists' explorations of the environment. When they do speak, their language is straightforward. The visual and sonic experimentation is supported by the narrative; while containing a moral, the film is in essence about children

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moving in and communing with nature. Stripping the short story to the bare essentials gave Žebriūnas and cinematographer Jonas Gričius, who had just finished shooting Grigory Kozintsev's adaptation of *Hamlet* (1964) at Lenfilm, an aesthetic license to play—not unlike their young characters.² Žebriūnas's film can be understood as a model of the cinema of sincerity in that the children in his movies do the work of emanating spontaneity and a sense of immediacy. Moreover, the images of nature that his films, *The Girl and the Echo* in particular, convey project a degree of social indeterminacy that stood at odds with much of the cinematic fare made during the Thaw. Similar to Abuladze's early work, Žebriūnas's openness to alternatives to the ossified language of socialist realist cinema—alternatives that transcend verbal expression—bears close attention for its political implications.

Working at the Lithuanian Film Studio, Žebriūnas dedicated almost his entire career to making films in which a child's perspective recalibrates and often questions adults' conduct.³ Anna Mikonis-Railienė has noted that for the director, placing children at the heart of a cinematic reality was a strategy: It propelled his quest for an individual visual poetics while saving him from having to concede to sanctioned themes, storylines, and heroes.⁴ A cinematic reality that the purported innocence of children permitted the filmmaker



The young heroine surveying her land in *The Girl and the Echo* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

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to explore was above all a reality not beholden to official ideology. If the Soviets fostered, as historian Violeta Davoliūtė describes, “a cult of youth in order to reshape young people in the image and likeness of the future and by the same token to promote their role as harbingers of social change,” it seems that Žebriūnas strove to remove identifiable Soviet trappings from his young characters as much as possible.⁵ The assimilation of national Lithuanian identity into the Soviet cultural paradigm held little interest for him, and the visual poetics the filmmaker espoused actively resisted such an assimilation. Historically situated, this aesthetic of resistance can be understood as emerging out of a broader context following the 1944 Soviet reoccupation of the western borderlands, of which Lithuania was part.

It is fair to contend that widespread hostility to Sovietization undertaken in the annexed territories in the wake of the Second World War partially animated the drive of native filmmakers to explore alternative stylistic approaches to their practice.⁶ I see the withdrawal from reliance on language as a key aspect of cinematic forms of opposition and resistance, marking the stylistic choices of directors, cinematographers, and other film creators. Mikonis-Railienė points out that not only films themselves but also scripts and correlating documentation produced at Lithuanian film studios were translated into Russian. “What is painful,” she acknowledges, “is that today we do not have the outtakes and material (negatives and phonograms) in Lithuanian.”⁷ With the establishment of an industrial basis in the republics across the Soviet Union, filmmakers could create films in their mother tongue; however, it bears remembering that such work would routinely be dubbed into Russian for distribution in the USSR and, most likely, screenings at international festivals.⁸ I suggest that sentiments of ethnic pride, authenticity, self-determination, creative freedom, and ideological indeterminacy manifested themselves in a version of what Hamid Naficy has termed “accented cinema.”⁹

Naficy identifies endemic dislocation and exile in a globalizing world as conditions for the emergence of particular forms of an accented film practice that stands in contrast to the style, narratives, and production mode of Hollywood. Although the position of native filmmakers working in the union’s republics during the Thaw was not usually that of physical dislocation or exile, it was never a position of political autonomy, and it required a delicate balance. The conflicting demands on filmmakers’ oeuvre, especially in recently annexed Lithuania (on the one hand, as always, subordinate to Moscow, and on the other, obliged to the politics of ethnic representation by local communities and by elaborating their own visual poetics, which often clashed with socialist realism), generated an array of accented films vis-à-vis

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the central studios' product. First and foremost, these films eschewed the overreliance on language.¹⁰ It is in the context of such aesthetic resistance, which emerged from the conditions of filmmakers' peripheral status, that this chapter considers Žebriūnas's early films as prime examples of the cinema of sincerity.

The Strangers

The Baltic states had first been occupied by the Soviet forces in 1940, a provision in the Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact, which divided the territories of eastern Europe between Germany and the USSR and then allowed them to be reoccupied by the USSR four years later, following the German defeat by the Red Army.¹¹ Lithuania had little in the way of its own film industry, unlike its neighbors Estonia and especially Latvia.¹² Due to the poor local infrastructure, the larger objectives of the Sovietization project in the western borderlands, and the overall crisis of Soviet cinema under Stalin, which was exacerbated by the masterpiece policy and lack of funding, the film industry in Lithuania was forged gradually. It concentrated, Violeta Davoliūtė and Lina Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė explain, "first of all on the formation of the administrative and institutional basis, secondly, on the establishment of cinemas, distribution, and only then on the actual production of films."¹³ For the Soviet regime, one of the priorities was to put in place an executive structure that drew largely on the reliable local party cadres, albeit always with Moscow's oversight, thus accomplishing two objectives at once: Sovietization and nationalization of the cultural sector. The first "Lithuanian" film, *Marytė*, based on the real-life heroine Marytė Melnikaitė, who had fought on the side of the Soviets against Nazi Germany and had been killed by the occupying force in 1943, was produced in 1947 by Mosfilm.¹⁴ Founded soon after the Soviet reconquest in 1944, Lithuania's Dokumentinių ir kronikinių filmų studija (Documentary and Film Chronicle Studio) made documentary fare, including newsreels and short educational and propaganda films.¹⁵ The petition from the Lithuanian Communist Party leadership in 1953 to reorganize the existing outfit into one that would have the capacity to produce both documentaries and features was approved by Khrushchev. The Lietuvos kino studija (Lithuanian Film Studio) in Vilnius was re-formed in 1954 but made its first fiction film, *Žydrasis horizontal* (*The Blue Horizon*, dir. Vytautas Mikalauskas), only in 1957.

Due to the "unusual imperial relationship between Moscow and Tbilisi," as we have seen, Georgia held a special place in the Soviet cultural imagination.¹⁶ Georgians—"familiar strangers," to recall Erik Scott's characterization—were able to place themselves in the highest echelons of power and

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achieve widespread prominence in the cultural sphere, including cinema. Lithuania too attained a distinctive standing within the imperial imagination, albeit due to a different set of cultural, historical, and political circumstances. Its geographic position as a frontier region—one of the westernmost in the USSR—oriented Lithuania, along with neighboring Estonia and Latvia, to the West.¹⁷ Unlike the Georgians, the Balts “did not hold important positions in the government, the military, or the diplomatic corps” under Stalin, and after his death they “won symbolic recognition, receiving for the most part appointments to ceremonial positions.”¹⁸ Culturally, however, during the Soviet era the Baltic states held a dubious honor: They represented the idea of “the West” and “our abroad.”¹⁹

To ordinary Soviet people, the region became a proxy for what lay beyond the Iron Curtain. Writing in the mid-1970s, Stanley V. Vardys noted that “it is rare that a Soviet citizen can reach ‘the real’ West, and the Baltics serve as a close substitute for a trip to Western Europe. The Soviet discovers ‘the West’ in Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania, in the gothic towers of Riga, in the Hanseatic old town of Tallinn, in the baroque churches of Vilnius, in the modern coffee shops, restaurants, music, and more fashionably dressed women.”²⁰ Providing a long view on the formation and perpetuation of a particular image of the Baltics in the Russian Empire and the USSR, historian Karsten Brüggenmann explains that the region “was perceived on the one hand, especially during the Soviet times, as a consumer’s paradise, where ‘European’ habits of the inhabitants proved their ‘Western’ roots of civilization, where you actually can breathe more freely and enjoy your cup of coffee in one of the numerous ‘Western-style’ cafés. . . . On the other hand, the Balts are just the usual suspects in cases of political disloyalty, obstinately rejecting everything good that was brought to them from the East, ungrateful especially to the Red Army that ‘freed’ them from Nazi-occupation in 1944.”²¹ These ambiguous “discursive perceptions” lodged in the popular imagination, incorporating such sentiments as enchantment, suspicion, and danger, persisted throughout the Soviet period and lingered long afterward.²²

The Soviet screen reflected, exploited, and furthered the rhetoric of otherness of the Baltic countries by frequently turning them into representations of foreign, more specifically capitalist, adversarial spaces. The cinematic convention of substituting one geographical locale for another is nearly as old as cinema itself; nonetheless, it is worth pausing to consider it within the unequal power relations inherent in an imperial setting. It was, for example, customary to shoot stories set in Western Europe and the United States at Soviet Baltic studios and in existing locations across the region.²³ With regard to Lithuania, the old streets and architecture of Vilnius and

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Kaunas regularly stood in for the decadent, sinful milieu of the capitalist West.²⁴ If the cinema establishment anticipated the characters and the city of Tbilisi in Abuladze's *Other People's Children* to be readily identifiable as both Georgian and Soviet, films by Lithuanian cineasts may have aroused different expectations in the metropole. To some extent, they were expected to look unfamiliar, strange, un-Soviet. The framework of this chapter allows us to consider Lithuanian cinema both as a part of the Soviet context and as a cinema that forged a singular aesthetic language that is more akin to cinemas of neighboring central European nations.

A Young Cinema

In terms of cinematic inclinations, the youngest generation of Lithuanian filmmakers looked westward, finding more affinity with Czech and especially Polish film cultures than Russian. The Polish documentaries of the so-called black series (*czarna seria*) announced a new cinematic wave in 1950s eastern and central Europe. The unstable political mood across Poland—with the anti-Communist labor protests in Poznań in June 1956 and the reinstatement of the formerly imprisoned Władisław Gomułka to power as the first secretary of the party in October of the same year, known as the October Spring—worried Moscow. Not only were Polish filmmakers geographically close, their aesthetic explorations and thematic preoccupations, especially with recent history, resonated in particular with their Lithuanian colleagues.²⁵ Evgeny Margolit, although without elaborating, states that the Polish Film School had an especially strong impact on young Lithuanians.²⁶

The majority of the filmmakers who established and placed new Lithuanian cinema on the international map were formally educated at VGIK, where they came in contact with a host of artistic traditions and forged long-lasting relationships with fellow students from the Soviet Union as well as neighboring European countries. Vytuatas Žalakevičius, who studied directing during the first half of the 1950s under Mikhail Chiaureli and Grigory Aleksandrov, became friends with Márta Mészáros as well as Jerzy Hoffmann and Edward Skórzewski, who in 1955 initiated the black series of social documentaries with the twelve-minute *Uwaga chuligani!* (*Look Out, Hooligans!*). Meanwhile, student of cinematography Donatas Pečiūra bonded with Polish cameraman Roman Farat, with whom he shared a dorm room.²⁷ Although artistic influences cannot be readily identified, much less summarized, it is nonetheless important to point out a diversity of potential sources of creative and intellectual stimulation that the filmmakers experienced in a context that, as a rule, rejected and suppressed the plurality of aesthetic and ideological perspectives. Sure, the institution that provided

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film education was entrenched in the system and beholden to the conditions of the Soviet episteme; however, utterly discounting the interpersonal exchanges that contributed to the development of these young artists overdetermines historical interpretations. Mikonis-Railienė shifts the view of Lithuanian cinema under state socialism as solely a product of Soviet culture and shows that it displayed strong ties with Polish, Hungarian, and Czechoslovak cinemas, particularly during the 1960s.²⁸ The chapter endeavors to keep in view both positions from which young Lithuanian filmmakers worked.

Trained as an architect, Žebriūnas joined the recently formed Lithuanian Film Studio in 1955. The aspiring filmmaker had initial informal training at the studio from both his older colleagues and his peers, among them actor and director Balys Bratkauskas and cinematographer Algimantas Mockus.²⁹ Unlike many of his contemporaries, Žebriūnas did not study at VGIK; instead, he opted to attend a yearlong directing course at Mosfilm Studio under the tutelage of Mikhail Romm. Upon returning to Vilnius, the novice received an invitation from Vytuatas Žalakevičius, an already accomplished fellow filmmaker of the same age, to contribute a short to the anthology project *Gyvieji didvyriai* (*The Living Heroes*, 1960).³⁰ A directive came from Moscow when Igor Rachiuk, head of the film administration under the Ministry of Culture, communicated to the Vilnius studio that it needed to include in its 1959 production plan contemporary stories about Lithuania.³¹ Three young directors—Žalakevičius, who coordinated the project, plus Žebriūnas, Marijonas Giedrys, and the slightly older Balys Bratkauskas—signed on.³² The quartet of shorts, or novellas as they are called, feature children as protagonists, and all but the final one take place in the past, constructing an overall narrative trajectory of social transformation, progress, and a shining Communist future.³³

Thematically, *The Living Heroes* exemplifies a typical cultural product made outside the imperial center during the Soviet Thaw: It tackles the topic of patriotism and the historical past, strives to inscribe local national identity within Soviet historiography, and attempts to create a common Soviet culture.³⁴ Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė write that the main idea was to present “‘portraits’ of the most important periods of Lithuanian history: the bourgeois era (short story I), German occupation (II), postwar years (III), and ‘happy’ Soviet realities (IV).”³⁵ Soviet film scholar Georgy Kapralov, in the introduction to the collection of essays *Molodye rezhissery sovetskogo kino* (Young directors of Soviet cinema, 1962), pointed to the film’s “rich subtext,” which he read as reflecting the profound “social changes experienced by postwar rural Lithuania that stemmed from the intrusion by

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a new, sunny world and . . . a retreat of the dark forces of the old, bourgeois Lithuania.”³⁶ As a whole, *The Living Heroes* achieved a favorable ideological balance as film critics and cultural pundits in Moscow and Lithuanian artists alike viewed it as a harbinger of a new beginning.³⁷ It became the calling card of Soviet Lithuanian cinema of the post-Stalin years, receiving the FIPRESCI Prize at the 1960 Karlovy Vary International Film Festival, which made it the first Lithuanian film to be recognized abroad. The omnibus film broke new ground aesthetically. Although its thematic material was unremarkable on the surface, the depiction of the Lithuanian past in Žebriūnas’s short, in particular, displayed ideological ambiguity and nuance and, I propose, registered by way of the mise-en-scène and cinematography the presence of widespread antipathy toward the Soviet regime.

The Last Shot was Žebriūnas’s cinematic debut. The fifteen-minute film is set in the Lithuanian countryside during the tragic and chaotic time at the end of the Second World War when, in the wake of the Nazi occupation, the Red Army returned to Vilnius to install a new government and begin the process of incorporating Lithuania into the USSR.³⁸ The bitter division among the local population—those who accepted Russian rule and those who fought against it—fell largely along city/country lines.³⁹ The majority of inhabitants in rural Lithuania joined the anti-Soviet resistance movement and went deep into the forests to wage a guerrilla war of independence that would endure into the early 1950s.⁴⁰

Set in the Lithuanian countryside—the epicenter of insurgency—against the harsh reality of war, the story of *The Last Shot* hinges on a meeting between an exhausted, famished resistance fighter hiding in the marshland and five-year-old Laima, who is left to her own devices and whose playground consists of the surrounding swamps, where she looks after a pair of swans and their nest.⁴¹ We first find her underneath a defunct tank that assumes the shape of a monster. This outright contrast between the frailty of a child’s body and the deformed heap of war machinery sets up a parabolic quality of the imagery and narrative that, although rooted in a specific historical circumstance, seems to also transcend such specificity. Such a minimalist visual poetics would become Žebriūnas’s signature.

Similar to *Ilyich’s Gate*, the short film stages an encounter between generations in which the young seek answers from the old, a device that introduces complexity into this portrayal of Lithuanian history during the immediate years of the Soviet reoccupation: “Mister, do you know why they killed our teacher?” And later “Our Jonas was killed . . . but you weren’t. Why?” No answer, or no meaningful one, comes from the insurgent. The film does not make it explicit to which side Laima refers, the Soviets or the resistance.

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A tracking shot along a tank reveals Laima underneath it in *The Last Shot*
(© Lithuanian Film Centre)

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For the five-year-old, the brutal war materializes only as the violence that lays waste to her immediate community—who *they* are does not enter her consciousness. Laima's uncle and teacher might be among the insurgents, or they might support the new occupiers. The moral ambiguity, thus, is part of the discourse that the short establishes at the outset.

So is the diminished importance of language. The communication taking place between the young child and the partisan consists of either incomplete sentences, non sequiturs, or a brief string of questions and answers. When he asks Laima whether the bread she shared with him and the land around them belong to her people, she says yes. "And what is mine?" he inquires of no one in particular. The loss of land and private property haunts this disgruntled question, which suggests that perhaps he used to be a farmer, or in the Soviet parlance of collectivization, a *kulak*, a rich farmer.⁴² Again, the film remains ambiguous. Laima's response, "Our Jonas was killed," is both a reference to historical violence and an indication of the break in logical communication. But this exchange suggests the association between violence and the distribution of wealth.

The mismatch between the two figures—in size, physical power, and certainly moral character, which is bound up with the "right" and "wrong" sides of history—speaks loudly. The girl is all light and air, her hair and body often aglow from what little sun there is in the bleak landscape. Soviet critic Vera Shitova notes that Gričius's lighting gives the impression that Laima emits luminosity.⁴³ In concordance with the overall imagery that is initially established by the contrast between the girl and the tank, she plainly stands for innocence. On the contrary, the frequent low-key lighting that warps the insurgent's facial features, his unsavory action of throwing away the swan eggs, and the final bullet he releases, seemingly by accident, that kills Laima appear to paint him as being on the wrong side of history. Cinematically, he is rendered as a conventional villain.

Nonetheless, the antihero's desperate situation, communicated through his interaction with the harsh nature, an occasional close-up full of anguish, and the tragic demise of both protagonists, offers a pause for reckoning—in particular to the Lithuanian viewer of the 1960s who lived through the dark years of Sovietization and insurgency. In the end, it is not the enemy that kills the anti-Soviet partisan. Instead, entrapped by the tall grasses, he is swallowed by the marshland. The girl is likewise claimed by the landscape, but she appears to melt into the atmosphere. This absorption of the characters into the surroundings—the local landscape that witnessed the most ferocious fighting—can be understood as equalizing them in the face of history and thus perhaps equalizing the opposing forces, although Laima

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The anti-Soviet partisan in *The Last Shot* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

is not affiliated with either. Both are part of this physical place and the history inscribed therein. The imagery of nature is invested with national identity.

Regarded on its own, apart from the collection *The Living Heroes*, Žebriūnas's film makes slight concessions to the correct management of the past. With its aesthetic choices and narrative hesitancy and by placing at its core a young child not yet possessing the verbal capacity of an adult, *The Last Shot* fosters ambiguity in relation to Lithuania's past and post-Stalin present. But because the short constitutes a part of the larger whole, the way it is framed in particular supplies a more appropriate meaning to the story, a meaning that conforms to the project of the continual Sovietization of Lithuania, "an attempt," as Davoliūtė and Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė write, "to consolidate Soviet rule through cultural propaganda."⁴⁴

The Last Shot (and, by extension, the previous two shorts in the anthology) is revealed to be a film within a film. The final image of Žebriūnas's novella—a pair of swans in flight—turns out to be a moving image on a television set in 1959 as it is being watched by a group of contemporary schoolboys, tears rolling down their stricken faces. They are the young heroes of the closing film in the omnibus, *The Living Heroes* (directed by Žalakevičius), who are reacting to the novella *The Last Shot* and discussing

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Integrating history in the present by way of mass media in *The Last Shot*
[© Lithuanian Film Centre]

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the punishment they wish they could deliver to the “bandit.” Within the broader frame, this troubling piece of history fits unproblematically into a larger whole, the present, where the youth adjudicate the past and shape the future of Soviet Lithuania. The prolonged fighting against the new regime, poetically epitomized in the counter of Laima and the member of the resistance, no longer presents a threat to the Soviet project of imperial expansion: It is made into a small picture domesticated by modern technology. Television in this instance also stands for the progress that the Communist regime brought to the largely rural population in postwar Lithuania.

The Last Shot, similar to many films of the cinema of sincerity, engages with history in a way that refrains from vociferous pronouncements. Here, the past is filtered through the figure of a child who is unable to understand the complex circumstances that led to the fighting or to distinguish the “right” and “wrong” sides of that fight.⁴⁵ It can be said that the child’s verbal deficiency gives way to the cinematic surplus of nonlinguistic signification with respect to history. While the level of the heroine’s speech suits her age, her character makes room for uncertainty. Laima can be read at once as a victim of this history and a medium for historiographic ambiguity at a time when such ambiguity was not tolerated. Instead of dialogue and explanation, Žebriūnas and Gričius often direct the audience’s attention to the natural scenery: The camera lingers on the wetlands, the clouds, moonlight on the water, the black figures of women in mourning gliding by in a skiff. The sounds of the landscape—the crying of birds, noise of the marsh waters, rustling of the reeds—take over much of the soundtrack and overpower what dialogue there is. These seemingly irrelevant details constitute the diegetic world of the child and of the history of which she is part. The images and sounds bear the weight of tragedy, while the film could not be clear about its stance, given the political context.

The Last Shot displays affinities with the films of the so-called Polish School generation, in particular the themes of heroism, the status of the outsider, the occupation period, and the chaotic days at the end of the war.⁴⁶ In his appraisal, Polish critic and screenwriter Bolesław Michałek notes that his countrymen’s films of the 1950s “managed to establish contact with the psychological realities of their own time” and win the support of their audiences through “reviving memories” of the recent struggles.⁴⁷ Through the repeated revisiting of the past in the 1950s works of Andrzej Wajda and Andrzej Munk, a singular tragic situation emerged: “the inability of the individual to discover a place for himself in his own national community.”⁴⁸ This direction in particular established trust with the public. Similarly,

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The Lithuanian countryside in mourning in *The Last Shot* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

Lithuanian films had to win their audiences in the post-Stalin years, for their beginnings were inauspicious, as we have seen.

But Žebriūnas moved on from historical themes after his debut. Already in *The Last Shot* through the persistent, unhurried capturing of the physical landscape, the director was developing a rigorous style and minimalist poetic palette that would arrive in full force in his first feature, *The Girl and the Echo*, also photographed by Gricius. The film's young heroine inherited the polka-dotted dress of Laima, the talent to commune with nature, and the ideological ambiguity of her surroundings.

The Girl and the Echo

Žebriūnas admitted years later that his films were about but never for children: "When I started filming children, I was able to avoid ideological issues. Kids were pure beings, devoid of the false image of propaganda."⁴⁹ A degree of confusion about his films' intended audiences at once played to the director's advantage during production and hindered access to his work afterward. During multiple meetings in the Department of Fiction Cinema under the Ministry of Culture, the screenplay of *The Girl and the Echo* was discussed as a movie for kids.⁵⁰ The designation of the second category for

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theatrical release as a film for children and young adults relegated *The Girl and the Echo* to a smaller number of prints and limited circulation.⁵¹ This fact, however, did not shield the film from controversy.

Žebriūnas's strategy to circumvent direct involvement with Soviet ideology in his images and sounds often failed to please members of various censorship bodies, and the path to realizing his films often proved arduous. The process to get the screenplay of *The Girl and the Echo* greenlit for production took nearly two years, and permission was granted only after Yuri Nagibin had been summoned to help with script revisions.⁵² The editorial board of the State Committee on Cinema (Goskino) had deemed the literary screenplay, initially coauthored by Žebriūnas and Ukrainian scriptwriter Anatoly Cherchenko, too enamored of "the associative style and the abstractly humanist treatment of issues."⁵³

The Girl and the Echo concentrates on the drama in children's encounters with the world, which is depicted as alternately magical and mundane, populated by innocent characters who are attuned to nature, like Vika and her grandfather, and by a band of boys obsessed with power and hierarchy. This world does not offer shelter in built environments—it is almost entirely exterior. When the heroine meets Romas, a lonely boy who just moved from Moscow, the two explore the surroundings aboveground and underwater. In the scenes of exploration, rather than providing a child's perspective, the film often presents the point of view of the nature that watches the children.

In her analysis of *The Unsent Letter* (Mosfilm, 1959), a film directed by Mikhail Kalatozov about a group of geologists, all but one of whom succumb to the brutal Siberian environment, Lida Oukaderova demonstrates that the film searches for a connection between humans and nature that exceeds the socialist human/nature binary. Cinematographer Sergei Urusevsky accomplished this potential form of spatial knowledge through unfamiliar framings and compositions of the figures in the landscape, where the operation of mimesis compels the dead bodies of the geologists to take on the topography of the surroundings.⁵⁴ The film's narrative is situated in Khrushcheva rhetoric of the subjugation of nature and the conquest of space, but *The Unsent Letter's* construction of "nature's gaze" and "acts of spatial integration," Oukaderova argues, offer the possibility of "a new epistemological principle, one that seeks to perceive the environment through a mimetic approximation of it: to gain access to space by being *like* it on the most direct level."⁵⁵ It is not that nature is simply indifferent to the actions of the humans; rather, through this mimetic form of interaction, a new avenue for an understanding has been conceived.

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Nature's gaze in *The Girl and the Echo* sometimes follows the children, sometimes forgets them. The formidable rock formations and gorges seem to take on the keen senses of the young protagonists and reflect the mysteriousness back at them. Quick and often sudden zoom-outs and pans of the camera reveal the magnitude of the ancient terrain and animate it. In the context of the children's world, these geological formations are represented as sensate creatures: They perceive and are perceived by the young characters. They exist in a zone of mutual perception, in a communion of their own. Vika, who is singularly attuned to the landscape, knows *it* as *it* knows her. Such cinematic materialization of nature and its relationship with humans is at variance with Soviet representations of nature in fiction cinema of the Thaw and its rhetoric of conquest.

The communion with nature in Žebriūnas's film occurs on the sonic level as well via the phenomenon of echo, which is the secret Vika shares with Romas. Gričius's camera works in tandem with the sound design, which enlivens the landscape through a range of aural effects seemingly emanating from the rocks. Talking with the mountains is an intimate act for the heroine, and she instructs Romas on how to behave at each spot of contact, where to be quiet, what questions to ask or sounds to make.



Vika and Romas explore in *The Girl and the Echo* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

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This form of connection does not depend on language, even though a few times Vika uses full sentences to address the mountains: “Do you remember me?” and “I hear you!” The mountains answer with the reverberating “remember . . . remember” and “hear . . . hear.” Nature breaks down the linguistic signification in favor of the affective experience, which is made up of sounds vibrating through space and demands attentive listening as well as respect for the environment.

The environment—the mountains, the sea, the steppes of the eastern coast of Crimea—is central to *The Girl and the Echo*. In some sequences, the film forgets about the drama of the human characters and fills the screen with natural phenomena to the point where it almost transforms into a poetic nature documentary, with the exception of the penchant for formal excess. For instance, in a sequence following the disclosure of the secret, for more than three minutes, the film alternates between panoramic vistas of the mountain range and surrounding landscape; in rapid zoom-ins and zoom-outs, it displays the anthropomorphic rocks against the sky, roves about the landscape, and ends with observing the different textures of the



The rock formations in *The Girl and the Echo* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

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surf up close and at a distance, all at a rather frenetic pace and with no human figures in sight.

This formal excess comes across as out of place, even in a minimalist narrative such as *The Girl and the Echo*, where it can be explained as children's interaction with nature. The director and his team adopted the conventions of nature documentaries and fairy tales. The surplus sequences that play with sound and optical techniques constitute the element of incongruity and irresolution that distinguishes the cinema of sincerity from other fiction films of the period. The process of play and experimentation is integral to the film's fabric, however awkward it makes the whole. Moreover, the film's narrative logic and Gričius's cinematographic construction of the environment do not adhere to the traditional socialist view of nature or what Oukaderova has called "the politics of conquest" during the 1950s and 1960s.

The filmic landscape and to an extent the characters of Vika and her grandfather exist outside such conception or indeed outside any contemporary Soviet frame of reference. In this, the film is similar to how *Other People's Children* handles the representation of Tbilisi, which the Moscow establishment found difficult to digest. But Žebriūnas and Gričius's images of the natural environment go even further in their embrace of social indeterminacy and abstraction. Undoubtedly, *The Girl and the Echo* bears several markers of a cultural product conceived during the Soviet Thaw. It exhibits a degree of formal experimentation and search for an individual vision. It is also a product of a burgeoning film industry struggling to define itself in relation to socialist realism and a larger, centralized, and highly repressive system of film practice.

This brings me back to Žebriūnas's strategy, which by making films about children would permit him, as much as possible, to evade prescribed subject matter and style. The director's prelapsarian view of children as innocent can be understood more in terms of imagining a reality unmarked by Soviet ideology and symbolism—in avoiding Soviet reality, he created a visual poetics virtually free of specific identification beyond the obvious environmental and topographic description.

The film identifies the geographic location only in passing, and then not clearly. At one point, Vika names the Devil's Finger and tells Romas a story about a man who during World War II climbed the rock and prevented the Germans from crossing into the peninsula, a reference to history that was added in the script and is absent from the short story. This brief mention of the Devil's Finger perhaps provides a sense of the idea of national landscape, but fleetingly. Nagibin set his short story in an invented place called

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Sinegoria, or a land of blue mountains; in his text, there are also mothers and a town with streets, which have no traces in the film.⁵⁶

Indeed, *The Girl and the Echo* contains few discernible signs of civilization that connect this semiutopian space with a wider world: a bus stop and a truck that eventually conveys Vika and her father to an airfield; the phone booth the heroine happens upon, located under a series of cement supports of what might be an overpass; the radio playing a popular tune and carried by the leader of the boy pack; and a copy of the film magazine *Sovetskii ekran* (Soviet screen) left on a bench at the bus stop that briefly draws Romas's attention. This last emblem hints at situating the film within a particular era and reads as a self-conscious gesture of the filmmakers' own participation in the history of cinema. Nonetheless, the pull between geographical and thus ideological precision versus ambiguity of space and time defines the overall character of *The Girl and the Echo*.

The filmed world is almost utterly devoid of adult interference. The grandfather, with whom the heroine is shown to have a strong bond, presents an unlikely figure of authority, especially by Soviet standards, as he is absent for much of the film. He briefly appears in the beginning and final minutes. The world the grandfather inhabits is only vaguely sketched out—it is more of an idea than anything materially realized. It lacks the concreteness of work, larger societal ties, and overall Soviet situatedness. His figure seems to have stepped out of an antiquated romantic story about a sea dog whose better days are behind him: He is a literary trope. The old man wears a sailor's striped shirt and hip boots and has two concerns: his granddaughter and his trade. His trade, however, other than it having to do with the sea and possibly fishing, is never explicitly demonstrated. The camera, which takes on the agility of the young protagonist, follows the grandfather in the beginning of the film as he sets off to check the fishing nets. But we do not see the trappings of a fishing industry or otherwise his connection to concrete, let alone Soviet, labor. He has the role of the girl's guardian in the summer months, although Vika never shares with him Romas's humiliating betrayal and her encounter with the boys, who take her clothes while she goes for a swim. We never step inside his house, perched atop a hill overlooking the sea. The old man's fleet of skiffs, all named "the *Dolphin*," sit half-submerged in water in apparent disuse. In a scene near the film's end, the heroine greets her grandfather as he disembarks and presents his granddaughter with a large shell. Perhaps he is a collector of shells? The two begin to listen to seashells together, and while he is unable to hear anything, she tells him about the worlds contained inside them. Rather than enforcing

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Playing a game in a phone booth in *The Girl and the Echo* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)



Soviet Screen at a bus stop in *The Girl and the Echo* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

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some form of discipline on his granddaughter, the old man enables her investigations of nature and of self.

Vika and Romas in *The Girl and the Echo* and the brother and sister in *Other People's Children* are wanderers, explorers who go about unsupervised; they are dislodged from the socialist regime of surveillance, such as pioneer summer camps or Young Pioneer Palaces, and instead have a connection with the figure of the orphan in postwar European cinema. The characters' orphaned state, if not actual, is certainly narrative, visual, and sonic. Both films attenuate the presence of adults. In *Other People's Children*, the young characters are rejected by their own father and his lover, while the woman who eventually adopts them is a young college student. In *The Girl and the Echo*, the heroine spends the summer at her grandfather's, who represents elderly benevolence rather than an authority figure who provides supervision and life lessons. Her father arrives in the end only to take her back to the city as the summer holiday draws to a close.

This configuration of relations between children and adults signals the detachment of the young protagonists from the social universe occupied, structured, and governed by the older generation, including their language, which is compromising at best. Both films construct a sense of time and



Listening to seashells in *The Girl and the Echo* (© Lithuanian Film Centre)

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space that may not accord with that of the adults. Instead, the representation of the young protagonist and her interaction with the natural environment in *The Girl and the Echo* encourages a promise of an imagined community that rests on genuine bonds rather than on prescribed collective formations. Paradoxically, if read in such a way, the film fulfills what the Goskino functionaries wrote about the final draft of the screenplay before approving it: The story's main idea is "the struggle for the purity of our people, cultivation of high ideals of friendship and loyalty, and condemnation of banality in human relations."⁵⁷

Writing about children in eastern European fiction films through a lens of socialist subjecthood and Communist governance, Constantin Parvulescu submits that the figure of the orphan came to articulate a "discourse of the vulnerable individual, who can achieve immunity only by being part of a tight social organism."⁵⁸ This argument certainly applies to a host of Soviet films featuring kids, among them *Two Fyodors* (dir. Marlen Khutsiev, Odesa Film Studio, 1958), *Ty ne sirota* (*You Are Not an Orphan*, dir. Shuhrat Abbosov, Uzbekfilm, 1962), and to a certain extent *Me, Grandma, Iliko, and Ilarioni* (dir. Tengiz Abuladze, Georgia Film, 1962).⁵⁹ It does not apply to either *Other People's Children* or *The Girl and the Echo*.⁶⁰ These young characters withstand the pressures of a social group and, rather than being portrayed as vulnerable beings in need of protection, come across as wise individuals who school adults. Their individuality, particularly in the case of Žebriūnas's work, is celebrated. While the group of boys in *The Girl and the Echo* constitutes a social organism, bullying tactics included, and Romas longs to be accepted by them, Vika actively spurns them.

The children in these films are not innocent in the way Rousseau envisioned childhood to be, as "the sleep of reason," the notion that Helena Goscilo identifies as "the root metaphor of childhood as a prelapsarian paradise of timelessness and uncontaminated innocence."⁶¹ They are knowing subjects; they understand the power relations of a group, even though they may reject it; they worry about being abandoned; they know how to hurt others. Nonetheless, these young people possess no self-regarding attitude, recalling the Romantic assertion of sincerity that the "very consciousness of innocence is at the same time a consciousness of experience" and thus insincere.⁶² More than that: Their lack of self-reflexivity, disregard for social endorsement, and relation to the world around them can be seen as analogous to an aesthetic that similarly comes across as not seeking others' approval but rather as existing in a dynamic state of experimentation and becoming.

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Coda

“Who Are You?”

The cinema of sincerity, although inevitably political, did not constitute a systematic political program, much less emerge from a state-sanctioned agenda. I have shown how a number of Soviet filmmakers took up the calls for sincere expression first sounded in literary circles and generated aesthetic codes that answered these calls with films that espoused spontaneity, open-endedness, and sometimes “difficulty” of form. This cinema adopted sincerity’s ambiguous, elusive, and multivalent nature to engage audiences and restore their trust in on-screen representation of the material world and in the promise of a genuine sociality. Some filmmakers, among them Romm, Khutsiev, and Shpalikov, found it imperative to participate in discourse against Stalinist dogmas, reconnect with the past or address important historical concerns through personal experience, and, on the whole, revitalize socialist principles. Shpalikov’s text, allergic to falseness but sensitive to pathos, supported the characterological expression of candidness. Thus, in the final sequence of *Ilyich’s Gate*, the off-screen voices of the three friends express love and gratitude to each other as the camera moves along Moscow streets and then witnesses the ceremonial change of the guard at Lenin’s Tomb, the multivalent symbol of the return to the revolutionary ideals of both transformation and continuation.¹ Although the film’s beginning and end strive for an allegorical gesture asserting socialism’s incontrovertible progress, the film’s narrative does not always stay the course; it lurches forward, at times suggesting—as in the scene of the candlelight dance and of the father-and-son conversation—that darkness might absorb all images and sounds and offer an alternate trajectory to the one everyone knew by rote.

Crucially, in their attention to the surface of things, to the rehabilitation of the mundane, these filmmakers strove to diminish the gap between the filmed image and what they experienced to be their reality. The images of

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city life—Moscow streets, caught by Pilikhina’s camera, often hidden in a shopping bag, and the views of Tbilisi, shot by Paatshvili’s wide-angle lens—sought to do precisely that.² They wished to break closed forms of film plot so that life could appear in its “suggestive indeterminacy.”³ In *Other People’s Children*, Lia and Gia, abandoned by their father, run after the train that carries Nato, the college student with whom they forged a bond. Nato jumps off, and the three walk back to the city, with the panorama of Tbilisi stretching below. The final sequence, which shows off the melodramatic side of the film, dissolves into the closing shot: a bird’s-eye view of the streetcar carrying the trio away, presumably as a new family, into the “dense texture of life” and openness reminiscent of the endings of many neorealist films.

A number of national cinemas of the Soviet Union enjoyed an efflorescence during the Thaw years, especially in the first part of the 1960s, which, Evgeny Margolit remarks, paradoxically coincided with their decline.⁴ The cinemas of non-Russian spaces came to be identified in particular with a poetic trend. There was what Elizabeth Papazian and others have called “an ethnographic tendency” that “develops in 1960s cinema, an impulse to record, and thereby preserve, a specific local culture, inspired by Oleksandr Dovzhenko’s practice in *Earth* (1930) of embedding his filmmaking crew into a particular locale and including the members of the community as



A panorama of Tbilisi in *Other People’s Children*

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extras in the film.”⁵ Soviet art films belonging to this category combine, as Papazian shows, the poetic and the ethnographic in order to reveal “the contradictions among temporalities and spatialities in post-Stalin culture, and therefore among opposed sense-making projects and representational modes, creating the possibility of subverting the colonial function of Soviet cinema.”⁶

Though *The Girl and the Echo*, *The Last Shot*, and *Other People's Children* do not follow this poetic trend, they are nonetheless concerned with national expression and manifest temporal and spatial misalignments that reshape representations of history, landscape, space, objects, and self-perception in each distinct national context. The linguistic and aesthetic transformation performed by the imperial technology of dubbing, which these films would be subjected to, in effect created new media objects once the voices of professional Russian-speaking actors overlaid the voices of both adult and children characters. The procedure emphasized the jarring perceptual mismatch, especially in the case of younger protagonists, since the voices of children would, as a rule, be dubbed by those of adults. There is a connection, if not a correlation, I have suggested, between the act of dubbing republican film productions into the Russian language and the visual idiom they elaborate. The procedure of dubbing undermined the linguistic meaning-making, moving the center of gravity to the affective and embodied registers of cinematic representation. The abandonment of language as the primary conveyor of meaning and ideology in these films signals a certain measure of political resistance, since in Soviet culture the word had long predominated. Moreover, the dubbed and reconfigured soundtrack in many republican films situates them in a particularly dynamic relationship to sincerity. The performance of dubbing, while turning a film into a more easily consumable product in the Soviet imperial marketplace, disassembles in a fundamental way and thus can never lay claim to fully authentic representation, especially with respect to national cinemas' aspirations to aesthetic, let alone other, forms of autonomy.

I have framed the notion of sincerity in several ways: as connected to character subjectivity, as an “indispensable *affective* (hence, social) process between subjects,” and as an aesthetic convention that turns to particular techniques and formal configurations.⁷ In particular, I have focused on figurations of interiority, constructions of immediacy, and the modeling of spontaneous, genuine communality that are variously encoded in the form of the cinema of sincerity. Historically situated and contextually specific Soviet sincerity, as we have seen, also adopted the Romantic traits of immediacy and of lack of affectation. At the level of form and representation, the films analyzed and touched upon in the book re-create what can be

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termed the problem of sincerity and expose the contradictions inherent in the conundrum that self-awareness and sincerity are incompatible—an old paradox that troubled Rousseau and many Romantics alike. Theorizing the term in relation to Romantic poetry, Angela Esterhammer notes that the “scandal of sincerity” is that it “is inimical to performativity; however, it must be read in or on the body, and through the semiotic systems by which body language gets interpreted, and in that sense it is coextensive with performance.”⁸ What better medium to address this profound contradiction than narrative cinema that is committed to realism and in need of regaining legitimation in a fluctuating political context? Sincerity must make itself known; it must perform itself. It does so in many Thaw films through staging absorption and unselfconsciousness, foregrounding the flow of reality and spontaneity of gesture, the withdrawal from language and moderate play with narrative conventions.

At stake in the performance of sincerity is realist cinema’s assurance of ethical representation of the visible world and its inhabitants, which is bound up with the question of realism: What form should it take after the unprecedented tragedies of the twentieth century’s first half, a question that recalls Stanley Cavell’s defense of candid movies that reveal rather than hide meaning and have a political potential to effect change. Another and, I submit, the most crucial aspect implicit in Soviet filmic sincerity is a possibility of unpremeditated collective formations that could proffer resistance in the face of a hostile environment, which could include an oppressive political regime. We have seen such formations in the films discussed in the book: the poetry gathering in *Ilyich’s Gate*, the nontraditional family unit in *Other People’s Children*, the professional community of physicists in *Nine Days of One Year*, and the familial union of the two eccentric elders and young protagonist in *Me, Grandma, Ilika, and Ilarioni*, for example, where all provide reconfigured forms of collectivity. The oppositional ethos of the cinema of sincerity thus takes aim at the status quo but also offers an alternative soci-ality. On its face, this cinema seems somewhat naive, guileless.

The defeat of the Prague Spring by the Soviets in 1968 marked the political finale of the Thaw. What was most conspicuous in the political shifts that followed, note the authors of *Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii* (History of the film industry in Russia), is that the USSR’s leadership, unlike most of its counterparts in the European countries under state socialism, did not try to “adjust, even minimally, the dogmatic doctrine in accordance with the recent experience and realities.”⁹ At the decade’s closure, the Central Committee began the process of removing and reshuffling functionaries in charge of cinema. The top organ of the Communist Party drafted several decrees regarding the film industry that primarily targeted the Thaw’s slackening

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of ideology and sought to regain control from the Cinema Committee, which had operated under the Council of Ministers beginning in 1963. One such decree stated that during the Thaw those governing the industry had neglected “natural development of socialist realism” and allowed for “uncritical assessment of immature works that step away from the ideological and aesthetic principles of Soviet cinema.”¹⁰ Nonetheless, the political end of the Thaw did not spell out the end of creativity in filmmaking practice, at least not immediately. Beginning in 1965 and through the rest of the decade, more and more films were shelved, banned, or otherwise impacted by the changing political environment.¹¹

In the late 1960s, the cinema of sincerity broke down formally into an aesthetic that began to manifest something akin to anxiety. In a number of fiction films, it played out most clearly in the reclaimed importance of language and in a narrative and visual aesthetic that favored discontinuity. Among these works are *Dolgie provody* (*The Long Farewell*, dir. Kira Muratova, Odesa Film Studio, 1971, released in 1987), *Maža išpažintis* (*The Small Confession*, Algirdas Araminas, Lithuanian Film Studio, 1972), *Rotsa akvavada nushi* (*When Almonds Blossomed*, dir. Lana Gogoberidze, Georgia Film, 1972), and *Liubit* (*To Love*, dir. Mikhail Kalik, Moldovafilm, 1968).¹² The word reclaimed its importance, but not in the way that Iampolski has characterized Soviet cinema—as constantly “striving for verbalization” and neglecting “the sensual contact with the world on screen created by the richness of sight and sound, the rhythmic structures, and so on.”¹³ Rather, this handful of films center verbosity as the potential for communication and even community only to dismantle it through repetition, camera techniques, various vocalizations of speech or sometimes nonsensical word-making, and especially operations of montage.

Coming-of-age films in particular manifest this simultaneous foregrounding and discrediting of language, where, given the subject matter, conflict forms an essential element of the structure: a young protagonist caught between establishing his or her own “I” and the pressures of social conformity. Conventionally, in this genre, a parental figure (family or not) represents the social norms that the young person is compelled to challenge, thus raising, once again, the issue of generational misalignment, a fault line that in some manner had to be acknowledged. These films readjust the use of both verbal and film languages, montage in particular, to reveal the transformation—or disintegration—of the cinema of sincerity into the aesthetic codes that foreclose any spontaneous and genuine form of sociality.

The remainder of the coda touches upon several scenes in Muratova’s second solo feature, *The Long Farewell*, based on Natalya Ryazantseva’s

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screenplay.¹⁴ The thematic crux of the film is the relationship between the middle-aged divorcée, Evgenia (Zinaida Sharko), and her sixteen-year-old son, Sasha (Oleg Vladimirsky). Sasha has a secret: He plans to join his archaeologist father, with whom Sasha has recently resumed contact, in Novosibirsk. Evgenia, once abandoned by her husband, is unable to understand Sasha's need for independence and fears being abandoned again. *The Long Farewell* is ostensibly about, as Helen Ferguson observes, communication and the failure of language, which are pivotal to the film's "study of relationships."¹⁵ The film centers language but forestalls its communicative capacity at every turn: The main and secondary characters talk past each other; appeals are met with silence or an inadequate response; the operation of communication technologies such as the telephone and telegraph is frequently thwarted either by a malfunction or by a character's fear of expressing their emotions. What is more, the film embodies at the level of form the qualities of incompleteness, interruption, and disjunction, or what Eugénie Zvonkine has called in her study of Muratova's oeuvre "cinematic dissonance."¹⁶ I would argue that through these qualities the film also precludes facile interpretation.

Zvonkine grounds her analysis of *The Long Farewell* in the notion of the unfinished, given that most of the expectations set up by the narrative never come to pass: "The love story between Evgenia Vassilievna . . . and Nikolay, whom she meets at a friend's place, is doomed; the telephone call between Masha and Sasha, who is in love with her, won't take place either, because he asks his friend to speak on his behalf. These 'disappointments' orchestrated by the filmmaker prepare us for the final plot twist: the adolescent's promised departure doesn't occur—Sasha decides not to leave his mother after all."¹⁷ The incompleteness does not stop at the narrative, Zvonkine shows, but extends to the entire structure of the film, where nearly all sequences come to an abrupt end and the piano melody we hear throughout remains harmonically unsettled. Even objects and gestures "struggle for completion. Thus, the ink pen used by Evgenia . . . to write a telegram to her ex-husband rolls off the post office desk several times when she tries to put it down. This entire scene is significant because the heroine attempts several openings—'Leave us alone,' 'Please . . .,' 'If you don't . . .—before giving up on the very idea of sending a telegram."¹⁸ Incompleteness, together with repetition, creates at once a sense of narrative frustration and a surplus of meaning, both of which are reflected in the form, which is governed by breaks and interruptions.

Visual and sound montage in *The Long Farewell* undermines the possibility of steady story progression, which in turn repeatedly threatens the

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attainability of stable familial bonds and other modes of sociality. The play of images and the soundtrack often break up rather than repair the film's narrative fabric in favor of affective modalities and semantic excess. Evgenia and Sasha take a day trip to the seaside on the outskirts of the city, where their friends are caretakers of an old summer house. The Chekhovian sequence comprises multiple episodes that, through the depiction of the protagonists' seeming legibility, which they themselves constantly foil, and through the use of startling cuts, preempt resolution and the potential for an unprescribed form of community or its private alternative, a romantic relationship. Two entwined episodes in particular assert the narrative and pictorial forms of dissonance. One involves the awkward flirtation of Evgenia and Nikolai, a guest to whom Evgenia is introduced upon her arrival; the other focuses on the interaction between Sasha and Masha, the hosts' slightly older daughter and the object of Sasha's infatuation. The older couple engage in heavy-handed, seductive chatter that goes nowhere as they wander in the autumnal landscape: Evgenia sings a song in English with the lyrics "I sing a song of love to you" and tells Nikolai about her love of mutts and a story about a barefoot foreigner dressed in "artistic rags" she once encountered on a city street ("I don't understand!" she exclaims three times). At one point, she teaches Nikolai archery at a target stand positioned against the background of the sea. Evgenia's incessant talking is laced with nervousness. The flirtation between Sasha and Masha, on the contrary, "is conducted not through dialogue, but in gazes, the proximity of hands, the tone of voice, and displacement (Masha runs her hand through the dog's long, silky fur to suggest to Sasha the sensual pleasure of caressing her body)."¹⁹ Masha does all the talking; when she teases, "Sasha, Sasha, say something," he remains silent.

These segments of the couples' flirting—of what comes across as the anguished efforts on the part of Evgenia and Sasha to engage and connect with others—are fragmented by cuts and repetitions that obstruct the characters' efforts and the flow of the dominant storylines associated with mother and son. The long shots of a dozen guests who are milling about create an atmosphere of merriment. However, there are several miniature shot assemblages inserted into the already-fragmented unfolding of the extended sequence at the summer house that are incongruous; they demand attention but discourage simple narrative or affective interpretation.

A boy on the beach lovingly handles an injured seagull. He stands up into the frame from below—into an image of the sky covered with flying and squawking seagulls. He holds the bird with both hands as the camera, in close-up, traces from top to bottom a fanned wing and closes on the

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Evgenia and Nikolai contrasted with Sasha and Masha in *The Long Farewell*

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drooping head of the animal. In the following shot, the camera starts to perform a circular motion, nearly touching the bird's feathers and the boy's face, then goes down to the webbed, slowly moving feet. The last shot in this miniature sequence is the close-up of the bird's head lying on the sand, dead now, propped up by a pair of hands.

Who is privy to this sad dance of the camera, the injured seagull, and the boy, to whom the film will never again return?²⁰ This vignette is preceded by several images of a pensive, love-struck Sasha, who, in total silence, strokes and smells Masha's hair, then gazes into the distance. It is also followed by a close-up of Sasha, his face in profile. Is the adolescent protagonist witness to the dying seagull?²¹ *The Long Farewell's* recalcitrance to conventional narrative techniques muddles the spatial-temporal bearings in such a way as to make an accurate determination of the sight lines in many instances impossible—and ultimately immaterial. But what such miniature sequences as the one analyzed do is intervene with the progression of the dominant storyline and thus mediate possible meanings and the affective disposition of the film. They make connections and misconceptions manifest, enacted by the film form.

Montage and sound function as the complementary key strategies for elaborating the aesthetic not only of incompleteness but also of disconnect-
edness, suggesting a different audiovisual and perhaps even epistemologi-
cal regime to the one offered by a story that logically proceeds from scene
to scene. Repetitions with variation—in dialogue, editing, frame composi-
tion, musical score, or physical gesture—structure much of *The Long Fare-
well*.²² During gym class, which takes place outdoors, the teacher asks Sasha
to perform a high jump. Rather than showing the action of Sasha running
and jumping in its entirety as the convention of narrative continuity would
dictate, the film cuts three times to the same shot of his running start, but
every time from a slightly different point in the action.

The film finally shows us the resolution, the jump, as Sasha crashes into
the bar. This sequence is accompanied by absolute silence, similar to the
one during which Sasha touches Masha's hair; the silence is interrupted
only after the unsuccessful jump. In another scene, Evgenia confronts her
boss—incidentally, she works at an organization as the head of the depart-
ment that translates scientific-technical literature—about an assignment
that entails interpreting for foreign visitors; instead of giving the assign-
ment to Evgenia's department, the boss outsourced it.²³ The same conversa-
tion, with slight variations in performance and dialogue, is shown several
times from a variety of angles and camera positions.

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A close-up of love-struck Sasha in *The Long Farewell*



The boy with the seagull in *The Long Farewell*

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Sasha's high jump in *The Long Farewell*.

The scene of the high jump chops up the temporal flow through the repetitive gesture of the cut, which also emphasizes, precisely because of the repetition, the impossibility of stopping time. On the narrative plane, the moment signals trouble: Sasha's jump is preceded by the images of Evgenia lurking behind the drying laundry and spying on her son, as she now suspects he is hiding something from her. This desperate gesture is accompanied by an equally desperate soundtrack, a high-pitched whine whose origin might be either human or animal. The scene of the conversation between Evgenia and her boss relies on editing as well, but in a different manner. It consists of what appears to be the outtakes, or different versions, of the scene. The repetitive gesture here originates in the custom of fiction film practice to shoot multiple takes of the same scene for coverage and performance; these scenes would then be edited into a unitary whole. However, instead of choosing the best versions and combining them according to the principles of continuity and discarding the rest, the director included all attempts in the final work, which shapes the aesthetic of disruption and discontinuity. Not only do various repetitions—of performance,

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montage, gesture—undermine continuity and produce affective and semantic excess, they also precipitate the effect of fragmentation that disturbs the whole. The act of repetition destabilizes the problematic of form and content, blurring the allegedly distinct domains.

During her work on *The Long Farewell*, Muratova's relationship to editing seemed to have changed. In an interview, she confessed her fascination with editing:

From the shot film material you can form any thought, accomplish any transposition or interpretation of the scenes; change their nature, complexity, unexpectedness. Editing shapes the general content, the character of the film. . . . In *The Long Farewell*, the love of editing became a principle. I filmed various scenes several times in order to be able to select the best take, and I used nearly all of that double material. I threw away very little. You will have noticed the many repetitions in the film. This wasn't planned in advance. The idea took shape during the editing. This way of working presented itself in one of the early scenes.²⁴

Muratova's words resonate with those of Theo Van Leeuwen: "Film editors [do not] impose their rhythm on images, the images and sounds impose their rhythms on the editors, restrict them as to where and how the film can be cut."²⁵ If the cinema of sincerity relies primarily on the profilmic to engage external reality and thus declare its candidness by claiming proximity to what is beyond the frame, then *The Long Farewell*, *When Almonds Blossomed*, *The Small Confession*, and other films in the category that can provisionally be described as "cinema of anxiety" submit to editing, particularly the abrupt cut. Unprepared by a film's narrative or visual information, the abrupt cut serves in these works to reconstruct material reality not into an orderly filmic whole but into a visual and sonic assemblage characterized by fragmentation. Its rhythms are akin to stuttering rather than to the continuous narrative unfolding.²⁶

The Long Farewell exemplifies an editing aesthetic that precludes forms of collective engagement and defers connection. The cut enacts the cutting off of the characters from each other and their shared reality, producing an effect of isolation. The joint between cuts can be thought of as a scar that needs tending. Indeed, the urgent note of this aesthetic mode, like the insistent piano phrase rehearsed in the background, is encapsulated by yet another interruption, this time of the awkward archery lesson, courtesy of Evgenia. Nikolai is about to release an arrow when the film cuts to a stranger on the beach; confused and possibly inebriated, the man interferes with the

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Stranger in *The Long Farewell*

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merrymaking: “Who? Who? Who? Where from? Where from? Where did you come from? Who are you? Who are you? Where did you come from? Who allowed this? Who allowed this?” Facing the camera, he utters the questions into space, at us, with varied inflections, as though practicing his lines or doing a screen test. It turns out that he is the groundskeeper, who is presumably worried about the guests damaging the athletic equipment.

Viktor Bozhovich has noted that although the man’s sudden appearance is rationally explained, his figure triggers a feeling of “metaphysical anxiety” that remains with the viewer for the rest of the film. The film, through this odd minor character—characteristically for Muratova, a nonprofessional actor—wants us to ask ourselves: “Indeed, who are we? And why? And what right do we have to be here?”²⁷ Although the development of Muratova’s singular style is already in evidence in *The Long Farewell*, it nonetheless shares with the films mentioned above the formal approach to discontinuity and interruption that leaves in its wake unfulfilled connections. The unexpected appearances, startling figures, displaced storylines that we encounter in *The Long Farewell*, *The Small Confession*, and other works seem to cry out for attention. If the cinema of sincerity modeled a form of a genuine, even harmonious sociality, then these new films, by foregrounding the persistent failure of verbal communication and investing in a discontinuous aesthetic as a film practice, seek to reconnect with their audiences on an existential level.

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Notes

Introduction

Chapter epigraph: Russian State Archive of Literature and Art (RGALI), f. 2936, op. 1, d. 1468, l. 65. Eldar Shengelaya and Aleksei Sakharov were among the directors of the younger generation interviewed in 1959 for a special issue of the French journal *Cinéma* 60. The interviews, however, ran afoul of the authorities and were never published.

1. Khrushchev's meetings with the creative intelligentsia, accompanied by other high-ranking party officials, took place in 1957, 1962, and 1963. N. G. Tomlina et al., *Apparat TsK KPSS i kul'tura 1965–1972: Dokumenty* (ROSSPĖN, 2009), 41.

2. In a series of meetings at Gorky Studio, *Ilyich's Gate* was frequently considered in relation to Remarque and Ernst Hemingway because Shpalikov and Khutsiev's characters were perceived to behave similarly to the characters found in these authors' books. In a discussion of a version of the so-called director's script (essentially, the shooting script) of *Ilyich's Gate*, Sergei Gerasimov, one of the older directors, noted that philosophically, the lone, tragic figure depicted by Remarque and Hemingway is "deeply alien to us" ("Zasedanie stsenarno-redaktsionnoi kollegii 1-go tvorcheskogo ob"edineniia po obsuzhdeniiu rezhiserskogo tsenariia Zatsva Il'icha," typescript, summer 1961, RGALI, f. 2468, op. 5, d. 43, l. 14). Erich Maria Remarque's 1936 novel, *Drei Kameraden*, was published in the Soviet Union in 1959. The journal *Inostrannaia literatura* (Foreign literature), established in 1955, published Remarque's 1954 novel, *Zeit zu leben und Zeit zu sterben*, in 1957. The literary critic and translator Lev Kopelev remembered the enormous popularity of the German author during the Thaw: "Baffled literary administrators talked about the Remarque flood, deluge, mass psychosis" (Raisa Orlova and Lev Kopelev, *My zhili v Moskve 1956–1980* [We lived in Moscow, 1956–1980] ["Kniga," 1990], 127). This popularity could compete only with that of Hemingway, whose work, after a sixteen-year interlude, appeared in *Inostrannaia literatura* in September 1955. It was "The Old Man and the Sea" (Orlova and Kopelev, *My zhili v Moskve*, 125).

3. N. Khrushchev, *Vysokaia ideinnost' i khudozhestvennoe masterstvo—velikaia sila sovetskoi literatury i iskusstva: Rech' na vstreche partii i pravitel'stva s deiateliami literatury i iskusstv 8 marta 1963 goda* (Gos. Izd-vo politicheskoi literatury, 1963), 13–14.

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4. A. Demenok, “Zastava Il’icha—urok istorii,” *Iskusstvo kino*, June 1988, 101.

5. I deliberately choose not to enclose *sincerity* in quotation marks to signal the validity of this category as such. Irony, for example, rarely gets put in quotation marks by literary and film scholars. Incidentally, this book does not view sincerity from an ironic distance, replicating how the filmmakers under study would approach the term in the specific historical context.

6. The term “Thaw” that gave the post-Stalin decade and a half its name derived from Ilya Ehrenburg’s eponymous novella, *Ottepel’* (The thaw, 1954), which caused much controversy. See Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd, “The Thaw as an Event in Russian History,” in *The Thaw: Soviet Society and Culture During the 1950s and 1960s*, ed. Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd (University of Toronto Press, 2013), 18. Examining the Soviet poetry of the early 1950s, Evgeny Margolit points out the persistence of the motif of impending spring. See “Peizazh s geroem,” in *Kinematograf ottepleri* (Materik, 1996), 1103. In the course of this period between 1953 and 1968, with its oscillations from comparable relaxation to retrenchment, most historians identify several smaller intervals of “warming” or “thaws”: 1953–54, most of 1956, 1961–62, and 1964. See Nancy Condee, “Cultural Codes of the Thaw,” in *Nikita Khrushchev*, ed. William Taubman (Yale University Press, 2000), 160; Polly Jones, *Myth, Memory, Trauma: Rethinking the Stalinist Past in the Soviet Union, 1953–70* (Yale University Press, 2016); Katerina Clark, *The Soviet Novel: History and Ritual* (Indiana University Press, 2000), 213–16; Clark, “‘Wait for Me and I Shall Return’: The Early Thaw as a Reprise of Late Thirties Culture?,” in Kozlov and Gilburd, *The Thaw*, 85; Aleksandr Prokhorov, *Unasledovannyi diskurs: Paradigmy stalinskoi kul’tury v literature i kinematografе “ottepeli”* (Akademicheskii proekt, DNK, 2007), 83–91; Roger D. Markwick, “Thaws and Freezes in Soviet Historiography, 1953–64,” in *The Dilemmas of De-Stalinization: Negotiating Cultural and Social Change in the Khrushchev Era*, ed. Polly Jones (Routledge, 2006), 173–92. It must be noted that the literary thaw did not always coincide with the film thaw.

7. On sincerity discourse in post-Soviet Russia, see Ellen Rutten, *Sincerity After Communism: A Cultural History* (Yale University Press, 2017), which examines the resurgence of sincerity politics in post-Soviet and contemporary Russian society. Rutten’s literary-sociological approach identifies three key functions of sincerity as the dominant cultural mode from perestroika to the present: a “curative” response to the trauma effected by the disintegration of the Soviet state and its values, a reaction to the meteoric rise of consumer capitalism, and a response to the increasingly media-tized culture, where values such as honesty and simplicity have taken on a singular urgency.

8. Hent de Vries, “Must We (NOT) Mean What We Say? Seriousness and Sincerity in the Work of J. L. Austin and Stanley Cavell,” in *The Rhetoric of Sincerity*, ed. Ernst van Alphen et al. (Stanford University Press, 2009), 92.

9. Anatoly Pinsky, “Znachenie iskrennosti: Fedor Abramov i pervaiia ottepel’, 1952–1954,” in *History and Subjectivity in Russia, Late 19th–20th Centuries*, Proceedings of the St. Petersburg International Colloquium, June 7–10, 2010, ed. Jochen Hellbeck and Nikolai Mikhailov (Nestor-Istoriia, 2013), 598; Anatoly Pinsky, “The Diaristic Form and Subjectivity Under Khrushchev,” *Slavic Review* 73, no. 4 (Winter

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2014): 805–27; Pinsky, “Soviet Modernity Post-Stalin: The State, Emotions, and Subjectivity,” *Kritika: Explorations in Russian and Eurasian History* 16, no. 2 (Spring 2015): 395–411.

10. Eleonory Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die: The Soviet Lives of Western Culture* (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press), 105.

11. Oksana Bulgakowa, “Cine-Weathers: Soviet Thaw Cinema in the International Context,” in Kozlov and Gilburd, *The Thaw*, 436.

12. Ernst van Alphen and Mieke Bal, introduction to Van Alphen et al., *The Rhetoric of Sincerity*, 2.

13. The films selected for analysis in this book by no means exhaust possible examples; rather, they represent a range of the characteristics that undergird the cinema of sincerity as I theorize it and, importantly, exemplify the aesthetic both in the center of the Soviet film industry and in its periphery.

14. Maya Turovskaya, interview with the author, June 23, 2016, Munich.

15. Annette Michelson, “The Man with the Movie Camera: From Magician to Epistemologist,” *Artforum* 10, no. 7 (March 1972). Describing a photograph from 1935, Michelson also includes in this list Sergei Eisenstein and cinematographer Eduard Tissé. When Georges Sadoul arrived in Moscow in August 1959 to work on a book about Soviet cinema, the report about his trip records separate visits with the filmmakers’ widows: Pera Atasheva, Elizaveta Svilova, Anna Pudovkina, and Yulia Solntseva. See RGALI, f. 2936, op. 1, d. 1394, l. 11–12.

16. Among other directors whose careers had taken off in the late 1920s and early 1930s and who continued to work into the post-Stalin period in the Moscow studios and at Lenfilm are Mark Donskoi, Iosif Kheifits, Mikhail Kalatozov, Yuly Raizman, Leonid Trauberg, and Grigory Kozintsev.

17. Maria Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan: Filmmaking Under Stalin* (Cornell University Press, 2018). In 1938, Belodubrovskaya writes, the cinema administration ranked all feature directors and grouped them into “directors,” “second directors,” and “assistant directors.” “Those in the first group were further assigned three categories: ‘highest,’ ‘first,’ and ‘second.’ Since then, only those in the ‘highest’ category (about 20 directors) were considered trusted ‘masters.’ Periodically, those who were not directing ‘quality’ films got fired, demoted, or moved to nonfiction filmmaking” (Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan*, 93).

18. RGALI, f. 2936, op. 1, d. 1, l. 16–17. The organization committee also had talented and sympathetic administrators such as Grigorii Mar’iamov. See V. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii: Upravlenie, kinoproizvodstvo, prokat,” manuscript, June 1, 2012, 1072–73, <https://culture.gov.ru/documents/istoriya-kinootrasli-v-rossii-upravlenie-kinoproizvodstvo-prokat/>.

19. Such groups were created on the model of 1920s workshops, where rigorous training of directors and actors often combined with film production. Lev Kuleshov’s workshop, famously, inaugurated the careers of Pudovkin, Boris Barnet, and actors Aleksandra Khokhlova and Vladimir Fogel. Even before the formation of the Filmmakers Union’s organizational committee, a newly formed creative workshop headed by Romm and Yutkevich at Mosfilm accepted its first class of aspiring filmmakers in 1954, among whom was thirty-three-year-old Grigory Chukhrai. Two

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years later, the director startled the audience and jury at Cannes with his debut feature, *Sorok pervyi* (*The Forty-First*, Mosfilm, 1956). Chukhrai was one of the four film directors in the workshop, which also included two scriptwriters, one stage director, and several cinematographers. The workshop unit would normally work on films by the young directors or assist the masters, pulling additional expertise from Mosfilm's talent. For example, the members of the Romm-Yutkevich workshop worked on Romm's *Murder on Dante Street* (1956) and Yutkevich's *Othello* (1955). See M. Romm and S. Yutkevich, "Sodruzhestvo dvukh pokolenii," *Iskusstvo kino*, July 1955, 23.

20. Naum Kleiman, *Formula finala: Stat'i, vystupleniia, besedy* (Eizenshtein-tsentr, 2004), 420.

21. The word "redemption" in the Soviet context would not have the theological connotation that it does in Kracauer's *Theory of Film*. See Gertrud Koch and Jeremy Gaines, *Siegfried Kracauer: An Introduction* (Princeton University Press, 2000), 107. Indeed, when the book was translated into Russian and published in 1974, "redemption" became "rehabilitation" (*reabilitatsia*).

22. Francesco Casetti, *Theories of Cinema, 1945-1995* (University of Texas Press, 1999), 35-36.

23. Lilya Kaganovsky, "Ways of Seeing: On Kira Muratova's *Brief Encounters* and Larisa Shepit'ko's *Wings*," *Russian Review* 71 (July 2012): 484.

24. Another piece that explores the notion of the *politiques des auteurs* and its echoes in post-Stalin film is Eugénie Zvonkine, "Auteur Cinema During the Thaw and Stagnation," in *A Companion to Russian Cinema*, ed. Birgit Beumers (John Wiley & Sons, 2016), 178-201.

25. Siegfried Kracauer, *Theory of Film: The Redemption of Physical Reality* (Oxford University Press, 1965), 71.

26. Due to the historical materialist doctrine, Soviet philosophical practice never questioned the legitimacy of the terms *real* and *reality*.

27. During 1957, in several speeches addressed to the creative intelligentsia, Khrushchev brought up "closeness of literature and art to the life of the people" (*Za tesnuiu sviaz' literatury i iskusstva s zhizn'iu naroda* [Gos. Izd-vo politicheskoi literatury, 1957]). The "truth of life" (*pravda zhizni*) in relation to literature and cinema was invoked like a mantra in the 1950s and early 1960s. For this phrase as connected to the evolution of realism in film, see A. Karaganov, "Vsegda v razviti" [Always in development], *Iskusstvo kino*, September 1957, 80-89. See also G. Kapralov's survey of Soviet films released in the last five years, "Meroi vremeni" [A measure of time], *Iskusstvo kino*, January 1961, 61-65; on the republican studios at the time that were "closer to the life of their people," see "Konferentsia tvorcheskikh rabotnikov respublikanskikh kinostudii" [Conference of Creative Workers at Republican Film Studios], *Iskusstvo kino*, September 1955, 108-12.

28. Kracauer, *Theory of Film*, 297.

29. Violeta Davoliūtė, for instance, notes that in the context of Soviet Lithuania, the sincerity mantra was crucial in creating a "new class of young Lithuanian artists, writers and musicians. . . . De-Stalinization, however, did not spell an end to the goal of Sovietization through individual and social transformation. . . . The cultural

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Thaw was not anti-Soviet in inspiration but aimed rather at creating an authentic, grassroots Soviet culture. The cult of sincerity, the expression of genuine feelings and emotions were part and parcel of what was described at the time as the ‘modernization’ of Soviet literature, with lyrical poetry taking centre stage” (*The Making and Breaking of Soviet Lithuania* [Routledge, 2013], 88). Officially, the cultural Thaw was meant to revitalize and restore the original values of the October Revolution, which many films of the period reflect, including a number belonging to the cinema of sincerity such as *Ilyich’s Gate*; however, some productions made in the union’s republics seem to resist or at the very least bypass this aspect.

30. Kozlov and Gilburd, “The Thaw as an Event,” 50.

31. For more on literature as the superior art form and cultural capital in the Soviet hierarchy of the arts, see Katerina Clark, *Moscow the Fourth Rome: Stalinism, Cosmopolitanism, and the Evolution of Soviet Culture, 1931–1941* (Harvard University Press, 2011), chap. 2.

32. Mikhail Iampolski, “Cinema Without Cinema,” in *Russian Critics on the Cinema of Glasnost* (Cambridge University Press, 1994), 12, 17. Iampolski excludes from his critique the Soviet avant-garde.

33. On the place of the writer in the Soviet film industry, see Zvonkine, “Auteur Cinema,” 178–201; more generally, on Soviet film scripting, see Maria Belodubrovskaya, “Soviet Cinema, Socialist Realism, and Nonclassical Storytelling,” *Film History* 29, no. 3 (Fall 2017): 169–92.

34. Stanley Cavell, *The World Viewed: Reflections on the Ontology of Film*, enl. ed. (Harvard University Press, 1979), 61.

35. Jones, *Myth, Memory, Trauma*, 23–25, 272. The Soviet Union incurred the greatest military losses. See also Tony Judt, *Postwar: A History of Europe Since 1945* (Penguin Books, 2005), 18.

36. Clark, *The Soviet Novel*, 37–41.

37. Jones, *Myth, Memory, Trauma*, 23.

38. Denis Kozlov, “The Historical Turn in Late Soviet Culture: Retrospectivism, Factography, Doubt, 1953–91,” *Kritika: Explorations in Russian and Eurasian History* 2, no. 3 (2001): 587–88.

39. Vladislav Zubok, *Zhivago’s Children: The Last Russian Intelligentsia* (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2011), 65.

40. For more on the range of discussions in literature during the Thaw, see Evgeny Dobrenko and Ilya Kalinin, “Literary Criticism During the Thaw,” in *A History of Russian Literary Theory and Criticism: The Soviet Age and Beyond*, ed. E. Dobrenko and Galin Tihanov (Pittsburgh University Press, 2011), 184–206.

41. Roman Jakobson, “On Realism in Art,” in *Language in Literature*, ed. Krysztyna Pomorska and Stephen Rudy (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1987), 19–27. Originally published in Czech in 1921. Jakobson’s understanding of realism in art as historically contingent is an apt framework for the process of cinematic renewal in the post-Stalin period. What is true to life changes relative to

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a number of different factors: an era, an author's aspiration, a beholder's perception. To take the first of these, a representation that was regarded as inarguably realist in one period will appear ineffective in another and yield to one that brings out something new, something striking, that had been untapped until now.

42. Andrei Zhdanov, *Pervyi Vsesoiuznyi s"ezd Sovetskikh pisatelei 1934, stenograficheskiĭ otchet* (Gos. Izd-vo "Khudozhestvennaia literatura," 1934), 4. See also Edward M. Swiderski, *The Philosophical Foundations of Soviet Aesthetics: Theories and Controversies in the Post-War Years* (Reidel, 1979), 8–10.

43. To an extent, this materialist, cognitive approach to art was derived from Georg W. F. Hegel's proclamation that "art liberates the true content of phenomena from the pure appearance and deception of this bad, transitory world, and gives them a higher actuality, born of the spirit" (*Aesthetics: Lectures on Fine Art*, 2 vols., trans. T. M. Knox [Oxford University Press, 1975], 1:9).

44. German Nedoshivin, *Ocherki teorii iskusstva* (Iskusstvo, 1953), 12.

45. Nedoshivin, *Ocherki*, 12.

46. See, for example, Karaganov, "Vsegda v razvitiĭ," 85–87.

47. Despite Ivan Pyr'ev's standing as a master director, he was one of the exemplars of "varnished" films. Mikhail Romm in a VGIK lecture in 1957 referred to Pyr'ev's other film, *Ispytanie vernosti* (*Devotion*, Mosfilm, 1954) when he talked about film art design under *lakirovka*: "Let's say the apartment of an old locksmith is divided by a solid glass wall. The wall is draped with silk. Through the wall, there is a winter garden that belongs to an old metal worker. An enormous, semiround divan is in the hall, borrowed from American pictures, from the home of the Vanderbilts" ("Itak, segodnia my zaimemsia istoriei Sovetskogo kino . . .," *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 50 [2001]: 130). Khrushchev himself criticized *The Cossacks of the Kuban*, calling it "saccharine, treacly" (*Za tesnuiu sviaz' literatury i iskusstva s zhizn'iu naroda* [Gos. Izd-vo politicheskoi literatury, 1957], 42, <http://www.rl-critic.ru/texts/xrush.html>).

48. André Bazin, "The Stalin Myth in Soviet Cinema," *Film Criticism* 3, no. 1 (Fall 1978): 22. Originally published in *Esprit* in 1950.

49. Iurii Khaniutin, "Reshaet khudozhnik," *Iskusstvo kino*, July 1956, 28.

50. Fredric Jameson, *The Ideologies of Theory* (Verso, 2008), 420.

51. Jameson, *The Ideologies of Theory*, 421.

52. For example, see the VGIK professor of art and film history Mikhail Grigor'ev, *Sotsialisticheskii realizm v bor'be s modernizmom* (VGIK, 1962), also his *K istorii bor'by za sotsialisticheskii realizm* (1959). Karl Radek at the First Congress of Soviet Writers in 1934 famously declared, "James Joyce or socialist realism" (Zhdanov, *Pervyi Vsesoiuznyi s"ezd Sovetskikh pisatelei 1934*, 372–73).

53. The key category in Lenin's epistemology is "reflection," which, roughly construed, refers to consciousness mirroring objective reality. The three main propositions of Lenin's theoretical framework stipulate that things exist independently of our consciousness; there is "no difference in principle between the phenomenon and the thing-in-itself"; and "we must think dialectically, that is, we must not regard our knowledge as readymade and unalterable, but must determine how knowledge emerges from ignorance, how incomplete, inexact knowledge becomes more

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complete and more exact” (Homer Hogan, “Lenin’s Theory of Reflection” [master’s thesis, McMaster University, 1966]). For a critical analysis of Lenin’s theory of reflection, see Slavoj Žižek and V. I. Lenin, *Revolution at the Gates: The 1917 Writings* (Verso, 2002), 179–81. In Lenin’s thought, the category of reflection likely derived from Hegel: “According to Hegel, *Mind* reflects itself in the external, material world, whereas for Marxism it is *Nature* that reflects itself by means of the human mind. Art is one of the forms of this reflection of nature in itself, viz. its reflection in artistic images” (Andrei Maidansky, “The Aesthetic Realism of Mikhail Lifshits: Art, History and the Communist Ideal,” *Studies in East European Thought* 68 [2016]: 258).

54. Devin Fore, *Realism After Modernism: The Rehumanization of Art and Literature* (MIT Press, 2012), 9.

55. See, for example, Karel Radek’s concluding speech at the First Congress of Soviet Writers in 1934 in Zhdanov, *Pervyi Vsesoiuznyi s’ezd Sovetskikh pisatelei 1934*, 372–74. See also Vladimir Kirshon’s speech, 396–416.

56. Kracauer, *Theory of Film*, 287.

57. Clark, *Moscow, the Fourth Rome*, 329–36. Clark discusses the lyric campaign during the purges. Although resembling Berggolts’s demands rhetorically, given a completely different sociopolitical moment, it could not pursue the same goals and share identical inflection of the “sincere” and the “authentic” as it would from 1953 onward.

58. Ol’ga Berggol’ts, “Razgovor o lirike,” *Literaturnaia gazeta*, April 16, 1953, 3.

59. Berggol’ts, “Razgovor,” 3.

60. Anatoly Pinsky has shown in his examination of diaristic writing during the early Thaw that this new subjectivity concerned a more critical approach to knowledge and truth, which could now diverge from the truth of the party. See Anatoly Pinsky, “The Diaristic Form and Subjectivity Under Khrushchev,” *Slavic Review* 73, no. 4 (Winter 2014): 808.

61. Vladimir Pomerantsev, “Ob iskrennosti v literature,” *Novyi mir*, December 1953, 218–45.

62. Several other writers followed Pomerantsev’s critical lead within a space of six months, also in *Novyi mir*, articulating concerns about the “truthfulness of depiction.” See Fedor Abramov, “Liudi novoi derevni v poslevoennoi proze,” *Novyi mir*, April 1954, 210–31; Mikhail Lifschits, “Dnevnik Marietty Shaginian,” *Novyi mir*, February 1954, 206–31; Mark Shcheglov, “‘Russkii les’ Leonida Leonova,” *Novyi mir*, May 1954, 220–41.

63. For a thorough analysis of Pomerantsev’s article and the surrounding polemic, see Denis Kozlov, *The Readers of “Novyi Mir”: Coming to Terms with the Stalinist Past* (Harvard University Press, 2013), 44–87.

64. Pomerantsev, “Ob iskrennosti,” 218.

65. Kozlov, *The Readers of “Novyi Mir,”* 63.

66. Svetlana Boym, *Common Places: Mythologies of Everyday Life in Russia* (Harvard University Press, 1994), 97.

67. Kozlov, *The Readers of “Novyi Mir,”* 63.

68. Consequently, the epistolary novel “degenerated into a common device. . . . History of art and the basics of psychology cry out against contrived [*delannye*] novels and plays” (Pomerantsev, “Ob iskrennosti,” 219).

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69. Pomerantsev, “Ob iskrennosti,” 219. The Russian *neposredstvennost’* can also be translated as “being unmediated” and “being artless.”

70. N. Lesiuchevskii, “Za chistotu marksistsko-leninskikh printsipov v literature,” *Literaturnaia gazeta*, June 24, 1954, 2.

71. Lionel Trilling, *Sincerity and Authenticity* (Harvard University Press, 1972). If one takes into consideration religion, the notion of sincerity goes farther back, at least to the Protestant Reformation of the sixteenth century and its turn away from the carefully staged ritual of the Eucharist. For that historical view, see Adam B. Seligman et al., *Ritual and Its Consequences: An Essay on the Limits of Sincerity* (Oxford University Press, 2008); for another useful view of the origins and subsequent development of sincerity in Western culture, see the introduction to *Romanticism, Sincerity and Authenticity*, ed. Tim Milnes and Kerry Sinanan (Palgrave Macmillan, 2010), 1–28.

72. Herbert Read, “The Cult of Sincerity,” *Hudson Review* 21, no. 1 (Spring 1968): 53.

73. Read, “The Cult of Sincerity,” 55.

74. Read, “The Cult of Sincerity,” 66.

75. Read, “The Cult of Sincerity,” 66.

76. Read, “The Cult of Sincerity,” 57.

77. Wordsworth quoted in Patricia M. Ball, “Sincerity: The Rise and Fall of a Critical Term,” *Modern Language Review* 59, no. 1 (January 1964): 1.

78. Trilling, *Sincerity and Authenticity*, 4.

79. In the project of Soviet cultural dominance launched in the early 1930s, modern European culture, literature, and philosophy in particular played key roles. Many texts had been translated during the decade, including the works of William Shakespeare, Lord Byron, Wordsworth, and Heinrich Heine, among others. Georg Lukács and his circle at the Literary Institute of the Academy of Sciences and then at the Philosophical Institute in Moscow had written introductions to and promoted translations of Hegel’s and Schiller’s aesthetic theories. For more on the appropriation of Western European literature and philosophy during the Soviet 1930s, see Clark, *Moscow, the Fourth Rome*, esp. the introduction.

80. Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die*, 105.

81. Belinskii quoted in Berggol’ts, “Razgovor,” 3. See also Olga Berggol’ts, “Pro-tiv likvidatsii liriki,” *Literaturnaia gazeta*, October 28, 1954, 3.

82. Ernst Gombrich, “Ritualized Gesture and Expression in Art,” in *The Image and the Eye: Further Studies in the Psychology of Pictorial Representation* (Cornell University Press, 1982), 63–77.

83. Gombrich, “Ritualized Gesture,” 73.

84. I expand Gombrich’s idea of single creator-genius in relation to the ritualized gesture to a more diffuse understanding of labor and authorship. In most forms of cinema, this makes most sense.

85. Exciting research has recently been conducted into mechanisms and structures of socialist film cultures, undermining the unitary and centralized nature of the industries. See Alice Lovejoy, *Army Film and the Avant-Garde: Cinema and Experiment in the Czechoslovak Military* (Indiana University Press, 2015); and Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan*.

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86. Liudmila Pustynskaia, "Kinematograf ottepli v sotsial'no-politicheskom i kul'turnom kontekstakh," in *Kinematograf ottepli, kniga vtoraiia*, ed. V. Troianovskii (Materik, 2002), 384.

87. During the Thaw, there were four ministers of culture: Panteleimon Ponomarenko, 1953–54; Georgy Aleksandrov, 1954–55; Nikolai Mikhailov, 1955–60; and Ekaterina Furtseva, 1960–74.

88. Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan*, 101.

89. Other activities that a studio's artistic council oversaw included which scripts to develop, who would be assigned to direct what film, and many others. In reality, however, as Mikhail Romm asserted, the function of the artistic council at the studio was rather perfunctory. None of this work, on which his colleagues spent hours, mattered in the end because the studio administrators made the final decisions, often ignoring the council's recommendation. See Mikhail Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia v 3-kh tomakh* (Iskusstvo, 1980–82), 1:239–40.

90. Kozlov and Gilburd, "The Thaw as an Event," 27.

91. Another exception in English-language scholarship is Zdenko Mandušić, "Camerawork: Soviet Film Experience and Visual Poetics After Stalin" (PhD diss., University of Chicago, 2016). In Russian, although not book length, see articles especially by Irina Izvolova, "Dialog s real'nost'iu" [Dialogue with reality], in Troianovskii, *Kinematograf ottepli*, 160–211; and Evgenii Margolit, "Proshchaniie s 'ukhodiashchei naturoi'" [Parting with "disappearing light"], in Troianovskii, *Kinematograf ottepli*, 211–28. Cinematographer Sergei Urusevsky's camerawork received considerable attention in Oukadero's excellent *The Cinema of the Soviet Thaw*, in which the author analyzes Urusevsky's collaboration with Kalatozov in *Neotpravlennoe pis'mo* (*The Unsent Letter*, 1959) and *Ia Kuba* (*I Am Cuba*, 1964). Josephine Woll as well talks in detail about Urusevsky's camerawork in *The Cranes Are Flying*. See Woll, *The Cranes Are Flying* (I.B. Tauris, 2003).

92. While I do not consider sincerity from the perspective of affect and affect theories, I take as a starting point Eugénie Brinkema's call for close reading in *The Forms of the Affects* (Duke University Press, 2014), preface.

93. I take a cue from Victor Fan's book on Chinese film theory, where Fan explores the term *bizhen*, best translated as "approaching reality," in his comparative investigation of Chinese theoretical and critical writings between the 1920s and the 1940s and European, largely Bazinian, theories of realism. See Victor Fan, *Cinema Approaching Reality: Locating Chinese Film Theory* (University of Minnesota Press, 2015).

94. Robert Pippin, "Authenticity in Painting: Remarks on Michael Friend's Art History," *Critical Inquiry* 31, no. 3 (Spring 2005): 580.

Chapter 1. "Cinema for Us Was a Way to Communicate with the World"

1. "Dialog o tvorchestve (Mikhail Romm—Lukino Viskonti)" [Dialogue about artistry], *Sovetskii ekran*, no. 17 (1961): 16.

2. The Soviet press published several articles about *La Dolce Vita*, focusing on the controversy it ignited, on the Catholic Church's campaign to ban the film, and on the Left's support of the film. See N. Vasil'eva, "Nekotorye techeniia v sovremennom

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burzhuaznom iskusstve” [Certain currents in contemporary bourgeois art], *Iskusstvo kino*, January 1962, 105–10; Ugo Casiraghi, “Boi vokrgu fil'ma ‘Sladkaia zhizn’,” [Battles around *La Dolce Vita*], *Iskusstvo kino*, October 1960, 147–51; Joyce Lussu, “Fil'm ‘Sladkaia zhizn’ i ee khuliteli” [Film *La Dolce Vita* and its detractors], *Literaturnaia gazeta*, April 28, 1960, 4. One of the younger critics, Neya Zorkaya, wrote a deep analysis of *La Dolce Vita* in her book about contemporary Western cinema, *Between Past and Future: Notes on Contemporary Western Cinema* (Moscow, 1961).

3. For more on the cultural exchange activities of these agencies and cultural diplomacy more generally in the Soviet Union during the 1950s and 1960s, see Eleonory Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die: The Soviet Lives of Western Culture* (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2018); Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd, eds., *The Thaw: Soviet Society and Culture During the 1950s and 1960s* (University of Toronto Press, 2013).

4. Eleonory Gilburd, “Picasso in Thaw Culture,” *Cahiers du monde russe* 47, no. 1 (2006): 75.

5. For more on modernism and the art scene during the Soviet Thaw, see V. N. D'iakov, “Obschestvennyie kholsty i chastnye iskazheniia: Politika SSSR i spory o modernizme v khudozhestvennykh sobytiakh ottepel'i,” in *Ottepel'*, ed. T.L. Karpova (Gos. Tret'iakovskaia galleriia, 2017), 264–77; on the Picasso retrospective as well as the polemic on realism in the art press, see Gilburd, “Picasso in Thaw Culture,” 65–108.

6. “Nedelia frantsuzskogo fil'ma,” *Iskusstvo kino*, November 1955, 113–17.

7. Vitalii Troianovskii, ed., *Kinematograf ottepel'i* (Materik, 2002), 386.

8. D'iakov, “Obschestvennyie kholsty i chastnye iskazheniia,” 267.

9. The premier particularly chastised students of Ely Beliutin, who in the mid-1950s had founded the painting school entitled the New Reality (Novaia real'nost') and promoted expressive abstraction through color in the spirit of Wassily Kandinsky. For more on the Manège scandal, see Iu. Gerchuk, “Krovoizliianie v MOSKH,” ili, *Khrushchev v Manezhe [1 dekabria 1962 goda]* (Novoe literaturnoe obozrenie, 2008); for more on the visual arts, realism, and the Thaw, see Susan Reid, “(Socialist) Realism Unbound: The Effects of International Encounters on Soviet Art Practice and Discourse in the Khrushchev Thaw,” in *Art Beyond Borders: Artistic Exchange in Communist Europe (1945–1989)*, ed. Jérôme Bazin et al. (Central European University Press, 2016), 257–95. For more on the group associated with Ely Beliutin as well as other similar artistic circles at the time, see A. Florkovskaia, “Tvorcheskiesodruzhestva epokhi ottepel'i: U istokov nezavisimogo iskusstva” [Creative association of the Thaw: At the origins of independent art], in Karpova, *Ottepel'*, 278–91. The Western press did not waste any time spotlighting the scandalous outburst. Khrushchev's behavior, the *New York Times* reported, “clearly showed that he had no present intention of allowing the arts to reject the Communist disciplines that require of them a propaganda functionalism” (Seymour Topping, “Khrushchev Scolds Abstract Painters,” *New York Times*, December 2, 1962, 9).

10. For more on African cinemas and their relationship with Soviet filmmaking practice during the Cold War, see Gabrielle Chomentowski, “Filmmakers from Africa and Middle East Trained at VGIK During the Cold War,” *Studies in Russian*

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and *Soviet Cinema* 13, no. 3 (2019): 189–98; Chomentowski, “L’expérience soviétique des cinémas africains au lendemain des indépendances,” in “Afrique(s), les médias entre histoire et mémoire,” ed. François Robinet and Jamil Dakhli, special issue, *Le temps des médias*, no. 26 (Spring 2016): 111–25; Chomentowski, “Going Abroad to Study the Craft of Filmmaking: African Students in the USSR During the Period 1960–70,” in *Saving Bruce Lee: African and Arab Cinema in the Era of Soviet Cultural Diplomacy*, ed. Rashā Saltī and Gabrielle Chomentowski (Haus der Kulturen der Welt, 2018), 27–31.

11. Among the films that received positive responses internationally in the immediate post-Stalin years were *Magdana’s Donkey* (Tengiz Abuladze and Revaz Chkeidze, 1955), *Othello* (Sergei Yutkevich, 1955), *The Cranes Are Flying* (Mikhail Kalatozov, 1957), and *The Forty-First* (Grigory Chukhrai, 1956). For the history of the Soviet presence at Cannes in the first dozen years of the festival, see, for instance, Pauline Gallinari, “L’URSS au festival de Cannes 1946–1958: Un enjeu des relations franco-soviétiques à l’heure de la ‘guerre froide,’” *1895*, no. 51 (May 2007): 23–43.

12. Tamara Lisitsian, “‘Nochnoi effekt’ ital’ianskikh kinotartiuffov,” *Sovetskaia kultura*, December 3, 1960, 3; E. Gromov and Iu. Martynenko, “Podlinnaia i mni-maia,” *Sovetskaia kultura*, January 11, 1962. The script for the film was published in *Inostrannaia literatura* 8 (1961).

13. Renzo Renzi, “Breaking the Vow,” in *Il cinema è stato la mia vita: Scritti scelti 1948–1986 = Cinema Has Been My Life: Selected Writings 1948–1986* (Cineteca Bologna, 2003), 233.

14. Leonid Novichenko, “Ob izobrazhenii narodnoi zhizni,” *Literaturnaia gazeta*, April 10, 1956, 2–4.

15. Novichenko, “Ob izobrazhenii narodnoi zhizni,” 4.

16. If there was any backlash to Renzi in the Soviet press and behind closed doors, it did not become obvious. In 1959 *Iskusstvo kino* published the screenplay proposal “L’armata Sagapó,” coauthored by Renzi and Guido Aristarco, for which both had been arrested and spent forty-five days in prison in 1953. See Renzo Renzi, “Armiia ‘S’agapó’: Zaiavka na tsenarii,” *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1959, 126–29.

17. Jean-Paul Sartre, *Situations, VII* (Gallimard, 1965), 337.

18. Sartre and Simone de Beauvoir were perhaps the most celebrated Western intellectuals who kept an eye on the Soviet Union and the Eastern Bloc after Stalin’s death. Sartre visited the USSR several times in 1954, 1962, and 1965. His 1962 visit partly overlapped with the World Congress for General Disarmament and Peace, held in Moscow on July 9–14, 1962. During this trip he was extensively interviewed by the Soviet press. In one interview, the French philosopher noted that Muscovites in 1962 appeared “more cheerful and uninhibited in displaying their feelings” (Jean-Paul Sartre, interview, “Fashizmu i voine dolzhno protivostoiat’ edinstvo demokraticeskikh sil,” *Sovetskaia kul’tura*, June 5, 1962). Sartre and Beauvoir’s weeklong visit to Lithuania in the summer of 1965 was of immeasurable importance, as Violeta Davoliūtė writes: It was seen “as the cultural event of the decade, as proof of the cultural achievements of Soviet Lithuania and most of all its integration into the larger universe of cosmopolitan culture” (*The Making and Breaking of Soviet Lithuania* [Routledge, 2013], 115–16). Beauvoir wrote about the trip in *Tout compte fait* (1972).

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19. Typescripts of speeches from the International Cinema Seminar at VGIK in the summer of 1957, RGALI, f. 2900, op. 2, d. 524, l. 25–26, Vsesoiuznyi gosudarstvennyi institut kinematografii (VGIK) fonds.

20. For a detailed account of the Soviet reception of Italian neorealism during the 1950s and 1960s in official quarters and among filmmakers, see Viktoria Paranyuk, “An Anxious Love Affair: The Presence and Absence of Italian Neorealism in Soviet Film Culture,” *Film History* 33, no. 1 (2021): 118–46.

21. It is important to note that neorealism’s Fascist legacy was never mentioned in the Soviet media or the writings of film critics and scholars of the time. See Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die*, 192; see also Masha Salazkina, “Soviet-Italian Cinematic Exchanges, 1920s–1950s: From Early Soviet Film Theory to Neorealism,” in *Global Neorealism*, ed. Saverio Giovacchini and Robert Sklar (University Press of Mississippi, 2011), 38–39.

22. For more on the relationship between Togliatti and Moscow in the postwar period until Togliatti’s death in 1964, see Elena Aga Rossi and Victor Zaslavsky, *Stalin and Togliatti: Italy and the Origins of the Cold War* (Woodrow Wilson Center Press, 2011).

23. Mikhail Romm, “O voprosakh rezhisserskogo masterstva: Doklad,” *Sovetskaia ku’tura*, March 4, 1958, 3; Georgii Mdivani, “Velikii pokhod,” *Sovetskaia kul’tura*, May 18, 1961, 1.

24. Turovskaya, interview.

25. “Ia i Rossellini: Rossiiskie rezhissery o neorealizme” [Rossellini and me: Russia’s directors on neorealism], *Iskusstvo kino*, November 2003, 139.

26. Sergei Urusevskii, *S kinokameroi i za mol’bertom* (Algoritm, 2002), 67–68.

27. “Ia i Rossellini,” 139 (Aleksandr Mitta).

28. As Millicent Marcus notes, the Marxist journal “had set itself up as the sole trustee of the neorealists’ truth” (*Italian Film in the Light of Neorealism* [Princeton University Press, 1987], 145–46).

29. Jacques Rivette, “Letter on Rossellini,” in *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s: Neo-Realism, Hollywood, New Wave*, ed. Jim Hillier (Harvard University Press, 1985), 202.

30. Rivette, “Letter on Rossellini,” 193–94.

31. Rivette, “Letter on Rossellini,” 193.

32. André Bazin, “In Defense of Rossellini,” in *What Is Cinema?*, vol. 2, ed. Hugh Gray (University of California Press, 2005), 100. Bazin elaborated his theory of realism while viewing Rossellini’s first neorealist films.

33. For more on the discourse around *Voyage to Italy*, see Angelo Restivo, *The Cinema of Economic Miracles: Visuality and Modernization in the Italian Art Film* (Duke University Press, 2002), chap. 6, esp. 95–100.

34. Bazin, “In Defense of Rossellini,” 99.

35. Bazin, “In Defense of Rossellini,” 99.

36. Gilles Deleuze, in his Cinema books, marks Rossellini as a figure who signals a turning point in the history of narrative fiction cinema, from the movement of narrative action to the cinema of narrative inaction and temporal instability (*Cinema 1: The Movement-Image* [University of Minnesota Press, 1986], 121).

37. Carlo Lizzani, *Ital’ianskoe kino* (Iskusstvo, 1956), 150–51, 176.

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38. As Millicent Marcus points out, the film became a huge cinematographic and political event in 1954 due to “Visconti’s audacity in challenging the received wisdom on the Risorgimento and offering his own, variant reading of this seminal chapter in modern Italian history” (Marcus, *Italian Film*, 166).

39. Lizzani, *Ital’ianskoe kino*, 143; Marcus, *Italian Film*, 19–20.

40. “Realta’ e metafore,” *Cinema nuovo*, December 1, 1953, 327.

41. Guido Aristarco, “Dal neorealismo al realismo,” *Cinema nuovo*, February 25, 1955, 127.

42. Marcus, *Italian Film*, 172–73.

43. Gosfilmofond, card catalog.

44. Rassadin quoted in Vladislav Zubok, *Zhivago’s Children: The Last Russian Intelligentsia* (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2011), 162.

45. Book expositions and exchanges occurred regularly during the Thaw in capital cities around the country with the approval of the Ministry of Culture. See, for example, “Literatura o kino na vystavke frantsuzskoi’ knigi i grafiki,” *Iskusstvo kino*, August 1956, 22.

46. Some of the most notable sites where less official exchanges could take place were, of course, international film festivals, especially the Moscow Film Festival, which at last reconvened in the summer of 1959 after its 1935 inaugural edition, the festival at Karlovy Vary, and the Leipzig Documentary Film Festival. Later, beginning in 1968, the Tashkent Festival of African and Asian Cinema was launched. See Rossen Djagalov and Masha Salazkina, “Tashkent ’68: A Cinematic Contact Zone,” *Slavic Review* 75, no. 2 (Summer 2016): 279–98; Salazkina, *World Socialist Cinema: Alliances, Affinities, and Solidarities in the Global Cold War* (University of California Press, 2023).

47. It is important to note that younger critics did not have the same recognition as their older colleagues. In addition, someone like Turovskaya, for instance, had a difficult time finding permanent work due to being a woman and a Jew.

48. There were, of course, other important critics who did not graduate from GITIS or VGIK and who also began their careers at this time. Two in particular should be singled out: Vera Shitova and Leonid Kozlov. Alumni of Moscow State University, they were instrumental in elevating criticism and film scholarship during the Thaw and beyond. Both started publishing around 1956. Leonid Kozlov became a distinguished film theorist, aiding Tarkovsky with his thoughts during the work on “Zapechatlennoe vremia” (Imprinted time), which was first published in the annual *Voprosy kinoiskusstva* (1967), where Kozlov was one of the editors.

49. Maya Turovskaya, interview with the author, June 25, 2016, Munich.

50. Turovskaya interview. For more about G. Avenarius, see “Kurs fil’mografii” [A course in filmography], *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 86 (2008): 59. In addition to his position at Gosfilmofond, for several years before his death Avenarius hosted a television program dedicated to the history of world cinema. Despite his unwelcoming conduct in the archive, Turovskaya credits Avenarius with formidable knowledge and describes his TV program as “crumbs” that nonetheless were very helpful to her film education. Yurii Greiding also credits Avenarius with giving him a much broader field of cinema from different cultures. See Yurii Greiding, “Otechestvo

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nam—Belye Stolby” [Our homeland—Belye Stolby], in Troianovskii, *Kinematograf ottepeli*, 312.

51. The enormous treasure trove brought back from Germany after the war consisted of predominantly American and European silent and sound cinema, with a smattering of prints from Latin America, the Middle East, and Asia, amounting to 3,730 titles. According to Gosfilmofond records compiled in August 1948, France represented the third largest loot of the sound-era feature films, 572 in total, after American (1,531) and German (906) pictures. See “Gosfilmofond: Ot rozhdeniia do zrelosti (1948–1970e),” *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 86 (2008): 224. All in all, counting newsreels, documentaries, and short films, the archive had 10,660 titles.

52. Maia Turovskaia, “Mikelandzhelo Antonioni: Pervoe znakomstvo” [Michelangelo Antonioni: First encounter], *Iskusstvo kino*, June 1962, 132–44.

53. Inna Solov’eva, *Kino Italii, 1945–1960* (Iskusstvo, 1961); Boris Zingerman, “Krugozor neorealizma,” *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1958, 152–68.

54. Naum Kleiman, “Intellectual’naia ‘pechurka,”” *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 86 (2008): 263–64.

55. Email conversation with Naum Kleiman, January 11, 2016. Georgian filmmaker Lana Gogoberidze, who studied at VGIK in the immediate post-Stalin period, also mentions the school as a place of relative freedom, where students and teachers could discuss different kinds of art. Lana Gogoberidze, conversation at goEast Film Festival, Wiesbaden, April 23, 2022, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eBilndlgHvk>.

56. Kleiman email.

57. Natal’ia Riazantseva, “Nezabyvaemyi 1958” [Unforgettable 1958], in *Kinematograf ottepeli: Dokumenty i svidetel’sтва* [Cinema of the Thaw: Documents and testimonies], ed. V. Fomin (Materik, 1998), 220–21.

58. Naum Kleiman, interview with the author, November 11, 2016.

59. Natalia Fokina, “Lev Kulidzhanov: Postizhenie professii” [Lev Kulidzhanov: Mastering the profession], *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 64 (2003).

60. Anna Mikonis-Railienė and Lina Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje: Sistema, filmai, režisieriai* (Vilniaus dailės akademija, 2015), 199.

61. Greiding, “Otechestvo nam—Belye Stolby,” 311.

62. Alexei Yurchak, *Everything Was Forever, Until It Was No More: The Last Soviet Generation* (Princeton University Press, 2006), 9.

63. Paranyuk, “An Anxious Love Affair,” 135–36.

64. John MacKay, “Montage Under Suspicion: Bazin’s Russo-Soviet Reception,” in *Opening Bazin: Postwar Film Theory and Its Afterlife*, ed. Dudley Andrew and Hervé Joubert-Laurencin (Oxford University Press, 2011), 291. MacKay separates the reception of Bazin’s theories in the Russian-Soviet context into three phases: from the mid-1960s to the mid-1980s, from the mid-1980s to the early 1990s, and the post-Soviet period.

65. Siegfried Kracauer was another theorist of realism whom the Soviets knew well before his official publication in Russian. Kracauer’s *From Caligari to Hitler* (1947) and *Theory of Film: The Redemption of Physical Reality* (1960) were published in the Russian language only in the mid-1970s.

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66. I'lia Vaisfel'd, "‘Ne obobshchaite konei!': Zametki o sovremennom iskusstve," *Iskusstvo kino*, January 1963, 108.

67. Vaisfeld wrote an extensive introduction to the first edition of Bazin's selection of writings translated into Russian and collected in the volume *Chto takoe kino* (Iskusstvo, 1972), published in French as *Qu'est-ce que le cinéma?* (Éditions du Cerf, 1958–62). In addition, it is clear that the Soviet critic, by quoting Kracauer, had read the original American edition of *Theory of Film*.

68. Vaisfeld also names in this company John Cassavetes and Lionel Rogosin. See his introduction to *Chto takoe kino*, 103.

69. André Bazin, "Evoliutsiia kinoiazyka," *Voprosy kinodramaturgii* 5 (1965): 311–25.

70. Viktor Bozhovich, "Andre Bazen i 'estetika nevmeshatel'stva,'" *Voprosy kinodramaturgii* 5 (1965): 309.

71. Bozhovich, "Andre Bazen," 310.

72. André Bazin, "The Evolution of Film Language," in *What Is Cinema?*, trans. Timothy Barnard (Caboose, 2009), 88.

73. MacKay, "Montage Under Suspicion," 294.

74. An important milestone in the history of the Soviet position on antimodernism and antiformalism, which the Thaw inherited, began with a series of *Pravda* articles about the music of Dmitry Shostakovich in the opera *Lady Macbeth of the Mtsensk District* and the ballet *The Limpid Stream*. The critics accused the composer of being too recondite in the first case and too lighthearted in the second. A sprawling editorial in *Iskusstvo kino* in April 1936, written in support of *Pravda*, recapitulated the key characteristics of socialist realism, emphasizing that "representational image [obraz] is the fundamental category of each art form. In representational images, the socialist realist method affirms truthful art, simple content, which has artistic clarity and legibility, and simple form, which has clarity and legibility, that is, an outward expression of the content of an artwork" ("Pervye itogi obsuzhdeniia statei *Pravdy*," *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1936, 16). See also "Sumbur vmesto muzyki," *Pravda*, January 28, 1936, 3; "Baletnaia fal'sh," *Pravda*, February 6, 1936, 3.

75. Modernities and modernisms have received a great deal of attention in connection with the Soviet avant-garde and its transformations through the precarious 1930s in Stalinist culture. Some of the more recent works include Maria Gough, *The Artist as Producer: Russian Constructivism in Revolution* (University of California Press, 2005); Christina Kiaer, *Imagine No Possessions: The Socialist Objects of Russian Constructivism* (MIT Press, 2005); Masha Salazkina, *In Excess: Sergei Eisenstein's Mexico* (University of Chicago Press, 2009); Emma Widdis, *Socialist Senses: Film, Feeling, and the Soviet Subject, 1917–1940* (Indiana University Press, 2017); Lilya Kaganovsky, *The Voice of Technology: Soviet Cinema's Transition to Sound, 1928–1935* (Indiana University Press, 2018).

76. For examples of 1930s definitions of "formalism," see L. Knipper, "Kino i muzyka" [Cinema and music], *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1936, 39; "Pervye itogi obsuzhdeniia statei *Pravdy*" [First results of discussion of the *Pravda* articles], *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1936, 16–17. In 1937 the press Izogiz published an anthology of these "anti-formalist" articles under the title *Protiv formalizma i naturalizma v iskusstve* (Against

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formalism and naturalism in art). For more on the antiformalist campaign, see Katerina Clark, *Moscow the Fourth Rome: Stalinism, Cosmopolitanism, and the Evolution of Soviet Culture, 1931–1941* (Harvard University Press, 2011), chap. 6.

77. Bertolt Brecht et al., *Aesthetics and Politics* (Verso, 2007), 49.

78. Analyzing the historical context of and discourse around Abram Room's film *Strogi iunoshia* (*A Strict Young Man*, Ukrainfilm, 1935), which was banned upon completion, Maria Belodubrovskaya argues that the antiformalist campaign concerned not so much style as story and message—in other words, content. See Maria Belodubrovskaya, "Abram Room, *A Strict Young Man*, and the 1936 Campaign Against Formalism in Soviet Cinema," *Slavic Review* 74, no. 2 (2015): 311–33. Nonetheless, it is form that makes a story or message accessible, that communicates the content in a particular way. The absence of a condemnation of style in the case of *A Strict Young Man* does not mean that cultural authorities paid no attention to formal aspects of cinema during the organized antiformalist attack.

79. Khrushchev's infamous outburst at the 1962 Manège exhibition of the Moscow Union of Artists is perhaps the best-known instance of the official attitude.

80. "Pervye itogi obsuzhdeniia statei *Pravdy*," *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1936, 16, emphasis added. *Obraz* is a difficult concept to translate into English. In the context of the cited article and theories of socialist realism more generally, *obraz* can be interpreted as a representational/figurative image. In Eisenstein's theory, however, there is a distinct difference between *izobrazhenie* and *obraz*. The first word refers to a depiction or representation, while the second may be understood as a synthetic image of what *izobrazhenie*/depiction, through its particular configuration, elicits in the beholder. On Eisenstein's explication of the two concepts, see "Montage 1938," in *Neravnodushnaia priroda*, vol. 1 (Muzei kino, 2004); Leonid Kozlov, *Izobrazhenie i obraz* (Iskusstvo, 1980), 97–103; on the distinction between the two concepts as regards Eisenstein's theory in the English language, see David Bordwell, *The Cinema of Eisenstein* (Routledge, 2005), 173–77. Another term that is related to *obraz* and *izobrazhenie* and that adds to the complex nature of their interpretation is *oblik*, for which the closest meaning in English is "appearance."

81. Bozhovich cites the original essay from *Qu'est-ce que le cinéma?*, vol. 1, *Ontologie et langage* (Éditions du Cerf, 1958). The Russian translation of this piece would appear only in 1972.

82. Bozhovich, "Andre Bazen," 303. Bozhovich also echoes the widespread line of thinking about cinema *verité* in Soviet film discourse. See Raisa Sidenova, "From Pravda to Vérité: Soviet Documentary Film and Television, 1950–1985" (PhD diss., Yale University, 2016).

83. Photographic objectivity had long been associated with naturalism, another anathema to social and socialist realism.

84. Gorky quoted in Bozhovich, "Andre Bazen," 309.

85. Bozhovich, "Andre Bazen," 308.

86. See, for example, Thomas Elsaesser and Malte Hagener, *Film Theory: An Introduction Through the Senses* (Routledge, 2010), chap. 1: "The notion of the window implies that one loses sight of the framing rectangle as it denotes transparency, while the frame highlights the content of the (opaque) surface and its constructed nature, effectively implying composition and artificiality" (14).

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87. For biographical information, see Elena Dolgopiat's introduction to "Teper' dlia menia Rossiia uzhe ne abstraktsiia, teper' u nee i vashe litso . . .": Pis'ma zarubezhnykh kinematografistov I. G. Epshtein" ["Now Russia is no longer an abstraction for me, now it has your face . . .": Letters of foreign filmmakers to I. G. Epshtein], *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 60 (2002): 91–121.

88. Turovskaya, interview.

89. Turovskaya, interview.

90. Zingerman, "Krugozor neorealizma."

91. Zingerman, "Krugozor neorealizma," 164.

92. Zingerman, "Krugozor neorealizma," 155.

93. "Interviews with Roberto Rossellini," in Hillier, *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s*, 212.

94. Zingerman, "Krugozor neorealizma," 156.

95. Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die*, 195.

96. André Bazin, "Cinematic Realism and the Italian School of the Liberation," in *What Is Cinema?*, trans. Timothy Barnard (Caboose, 2009), 235–36.

97. Amédée Ayfre, "Neorealism and Phenomenology," in Hillier, *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s*, 185.

98. Aleksei Bobrikov, "Surovyi stil': Mobilizatsiia i kul'turnaia revoliutsiia," *Khudozhestvennyi zhurnal*, no. 51/52 (2003), <https://moscowartmagazine.com/issue/57/article/1137>.

99. Zingerman, "Krugozor neorealizma," 152.

100. Masha Salazkina, "Italo-Soviet Cinematic Exchanges, 1920s–1950s," in *Global Neorealism*, ed. Saverio Giovacchini and Robert Sklar (University Press of Mississippi, 2011), 47.

101. Revisionism was associated with Jan Kott, Henri Lefebvre, Leszek Kołakowski, and Lukács, figures who were in great disfavor at the time. For an example of linking Zingerman to these scholars based on the criticism that he did not draw a sharp distinction between socialist realism and neorealism and establish a scientific, class-based differentiation between the two, see L. Kogan, "Chto zhe takoe neorealism?" [So what is neorealism?], *Iskusstvo kino*, September 1958, 144.

102. The antirevisionist wave arose in the Soviet Union after the uprisings in Hungary and Poland and unrest in Czechoslovakia in the summer and fall of 1956. The campaign's task was to thwart the voices in the intelligentsia advocating creative freedom and independence from the party line, or *partiinosť*. See M. P. Zezina, *Sovetskaia khudozhestvennaia intelligentsiia i vlast' v 1950-e-60-e gody* (Dialog MGU, 1999), 195–203.

103. Rivette, "Letter on Rossellini," 194.

104. Rivette, "Letter on Rossellini," 195.

105. The idea of the rehumanizing of realism comes from Devin Fore, *Realism After Modernism: The Rehumanization of Art and Literature* (MIT Press, 2012), 3.

Chapter 2. Montage mon amour, or a Thinking Film

1. Bertolt Brecht et al., *Aesthetics and Politics* (Verso, 2007), 39.

2. Jacques Rivette, "Letter on Rossellini," in *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s: Neo-Realism, Hollywood, New Wave*, ed. Jim Hillier (Harvard University Press, 1985), 193.

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3. Maria Belodubrovskaya writes about Romm and his involvement in the Soviet institution of cinema during the Stalin era in *Not According to Plan: Filmmaking Under Stalin* (Cornell University Press, 2018).

4. To take the most extreme example, author and functionary Aleksandr Fadeev, long-serving head of the Writers Union and a central force in the persecution of his colleagues Mikhail Zoshchenko, Anna Akhmatova, Andrei Platonov, and Boris Eikhenbaum in the 1940s, took his own life in May 1956. As far as it is known, Romm never participated in slanderous campaigns against his colleagues.

5. Romm was the only one among his generation of filmmakers—those born around the turn of the twentieth century—to criticize his own work openly and rather harshly and, by association, his own involvement in the creation of the cult of personality and of distorted depictions of history.

6. “Itak, segodnia my zaimemsia istoriei Sovetskogo kino . . .” *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 50 (2001): 129. Among the films Romm lists are Iosif Kheifits and Aleksandr Zharkhi’s *Baltic Deputy* and *Member of the Government*, Leonid Trauberg and Grigory Kozintsev’s *Maksim Trilogy*, Fridrikh Ermler’s *The Great Citizen*, Yuli Raizman’s *The Last Night*, and Vladimir Petrov’s *Peter the First*. Romm’s chronology—between 1935 and 1938—is not quite accurate: *Member of the Government* was made in 1940 and the first film of the *Maksim Trilogy* in 1934.

7. His feature film debut was *Pyshka* in 1934, based on Guy de Maupassant’s short story “Boule de suif.” On the hierarchy among film directors that was established during the Stalin era, see Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan*. “The Soviet industry,” the scholar writes, “did not have producers, and only directors had the creative and technical expertise to make films.” See also note 17 in the introduction of the current volume.

8. For more on the status and activities of Soviet directors as administrators during the Stalin years, see Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan*, chap. 3, 90–129.

9. Mikhail Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia v 3-kh tomakh* (Iskusstvo, 1980–82), 1:239–40. Romm also chaired the fiction cinema section of the Filmmakers Union, a role that allowed him to meet foreign film artists who visited Moscow and to travel abroad to international festivals, among other activities.

10. Romm saw *The Murder on Dante Street* as a failure. In 1962, in a lecture at the Higher Screenwriting Courses at Mosfilm, he admitted that the film was a professional dead end. Made in 1955, its script had been written in 1945, and Romm considered this film to be fully a product of the Stalin era. See Mikhail Romm, *Besedy o kino* (Iskusstvo, 1964), 282–85.

11. M. Zak, *Mikhail Romm i ego fil'my* (Iskusstvo, 1988), 184.

12. Mikhail Romm, “Posleslovie k kartine,” *Iskusstvo kino*, November 1962, 79.

13. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:290. Grigory Chukhrai directed *The Ballad of a Soldier*, Andrei Tarkovsky *Ivan’s Childhood*, and Georgy Daneliia and Igor Talankin made *Serezhka*.

14. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:290.

15. *Hiroshima mon amour* was never in commercial release in the USSR.

16. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:290.

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17. Recalling and paraphrasing Jean-Luc Godard's famous uttering about the tracking shot, we can say that for Romm, joining of shots, or montage, is also a question of morality.

18. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:273–74. By “customary way of joining shots,” Romm refers to something akin to continuity editing.

19. Romm could have watched Resnais's film again at Gosfilmofond, which probably owned a print.

20. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:274.

21. Romm, *Besedy o kino*, 275.

22. André Bazin, *What Is Cinema?*, trans. Timothy Barnard (Caboose, 2009), 131.

23. However, Romm's younger colleague Marlen Khutsiev innovated his style by engaging precisely with the other art forms in *Ilyich's Gate*, the subject of the next chapter.

24. On the status of film and film theories in postwar European debates, see Francesco Casetti, *Theories of Cinema, 1945–1995* (University of Texas Press, 1999).

25. The boom in literary adaptations during the Thaw is a topic that needs to be examined.

26. On censorship and Zhdanov's involvement in the affairs of cinema on behalf of the Central Committee, see Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan*, esp. chap. 5.

27. Due to the public's high demand for films, the insufficient number of Soviet contemporary productions, and in order to maximize profit, the Department of Literature and Art of the Central Committee devised a plan in 1952 to film twenty to thirty stage plays in the theaters in Moscow and other cities. In contrast to the standard budget of a feature, which was seven to eight million rubles, filming a theatrical production cost about four hundred thousand rubles. This plan, however, never materialized. See V. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii: Upravlenie, kinoproizvodstvo, prokat,” manuscript, June 1, 2012, 925, <https://culture.gov.ru/documents/istoriya-kinootrasli-v-rossii-upravlenie-kinoproizvodstvo-prokat/>.

28. “My ne khotim oporochit' ideiu s'emki luchshikh spektaklei strany dlia ikh popularizatsii. Odnako nel'zia predstavliat' sebe, chto takim sposobom mozno ischerpat' interes sovetskogo zritel'ia k kinoiskusstvu i tem bolee prodvinut' kinoiskusstvo vpered” (*Apparat TsK KPSS i kul'tura 1953–1957: Dokumenty*, ed. E. S. Afanas'eva et al. [ROSSPĖN, 2001], 51).

29. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:296.

30. Clement Greenberg and John O'Brian, *The Collected Essays and Criticism* (University of Chicago Press, 1995), 4:86.

31. Clement Greenberg, “Avant-garde and Kitsch,” in *Art and Culture: Critical Essays* (Beacon Press, 1989), 14–15.

32. Nancy Condee, “Cultural Codes of the Thaw,” in *Nikita Khrushchev*, ed. William Taubman (Yale University Press, 2000), 171.

33. Other films Romm talks about approvingly are Kaneto Shindo's *The Naked Island* (1960), Ben Maddow and Sidney Meyer's *The Savage Eye* (1960), Fellini's *La Dolce Vita* (1960), and Robert Bresson's *A Man Escaped* (1956). Romm praised the visual expressivity of *The Naked Island* in particular: The film is virtually without dialogue.

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34. RGALI, f. 844, op. 2, d. 57, l. 7.
35. K. M. Anderson et al., *Kremlevskii kinoteatr: 1928–1953; dokumenty* (ROSSPĖN, 2005), 1063.
36. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:197.
37. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:197.
38. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:198.
39. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:252. In addition to Eisenstein's films, Romm mentions the mass scenes in Oleksandr Dovzhenko's *Arsenal* and *Schors*, Georgy and Sergei Vasilyev's *Chapaev*, and Efim Dzigan's *We Are from Kronshtadt*.
40. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:248–49.
41. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:248.
42. The echo of the famous “Statement on Sound” in Romm's appeal to return to montage is not accidental. Signed by Eisenstein, Vsevolod Pudovkin, and Grigory Aleksandrov in 1928, the manifesto revealed anxiety about the coming of sound and, as a consequence, about montage losing its thought-generating and emotional power. The filmmakers fretted that montage, hitched to the voice and speech, would disappear into other cinematic devices. See “Statement on Sound,” in *Film Factory: Russian and Soviet Cinema in Documents 1896–1939*, ed. Richard Taylor and Ian Christie (Routledge, 1994), 234–35.
43. Dziga Vertov, of course, accomplished precisely that, but references to his films are not present in Romm's lectures and writings during this period.
44. During his nine-day visit to Paris, Romm evidently wished to meet with Resnais. Resnais, however, was very ill at the time, which he kept secret due to “gargulous spiders,” making everyone in Paris think he was away. By way of a private letter from Chris Marker to Izabella Epshtein, he sent his regrets about missing the opportunity to meet with Romm. See the letter from Chris Marker to Bella Epshtein, 1965, in *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 60 (2002): 97.
45. Jean Domarchi et al., “Hiroshima, notre amour,” in *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s: Neo-Realism, Hollywood, New Wave*, ed. Jim Hillier, ed. (Harvard University Press, 1985), 60–61.
46. Domarchi et al., “Hiroshima, notre amour,” 61.
47. Domarchi et al., “Hiroshima, notre amour,” 61.
48. Sam Di Iorio, “The Fragile Present: *Statues Also Die* with *Night and Fog*,” *South Central Review* 33, no. 2 (2016): 16.
49. In an interview after the release of the film, Romm said that “the development of this picture is the development of thought” (*Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 3:492). This work was originally published in *Sovetskaia kul'tura*, September 27, 1962, 3.
50. “Itak, segodnia my zaimemsia istoriei Sovetskogo kino . . .,” 133. Implicitly, his Lenin duology is included in this checklist.
51. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:235.
52. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:235.
53. Paula Amad, “Film as the ‘Skin of History’: André Bazin and the Specter of the Archive and Death in Nicole Védres's *Paris 1900* (1947),” *Representations* 130, no. 1 (Spring 2015): 84.

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54. Romm's list is reminiscent of Khrushchev's enumeration at the Twenty-Second Party Congress of "the imperialist forces of war and aggression" between 1956 and the date of the congress, October 1961. See Nikita Khrushchev, "Report of the Central Committee of the 22nd Congress of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union," in *Documents of the 22nd Congress of the CPSU* (Crosscurrents Press, 1961), 1:42–43.

55. Amad, "Film as the 'Skin of History,'" 87.

56. Antoine de Baecque, *Camera Historica: The Century in Cinema* (Columbia University Press, 2012), 2.

57. Baecque, *Camera Historica*, 3.

58. Baecque, *Camera Historica*, 3.

59. The look into or at the camera has a long history in film studies. It is of course especially central to analyses that delve into politics of representation, such as theories of gender and race and postcolonial theories. For more on looks at the camera, see, for example, Marc Vernet, "The Look at the Camera," *Cinema Journal* 28, no. 2 (Winter 1989): 48–63; Paula Amad, "Visual Riposte: Looking Back at the Return of the Gaze as Postcolonial Theory's Gift to Film Studies," *Cinema Journal* 52, no. 3 (Spring 2013): 49–74.

60. Baecque, *Camera Historica*, 45.

61. Romm thought of *Nine Days of One Year*, *Ordinary Fascism*, and his third film, which he did not finish, as a trilogy that delved into questions of scientific and technological progress. See Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:496–97.

62. Mikhail Romm et al., *Obyknovennyi fashizm: [sbornik]* (Seans, 2006), 19.

63. We must keep in mind that however tempting it is to say that Romm's creative searching alone led him to nonfiction, the institutional circumstances of being a Soviet director, even one as distinguished as Romm, cannot be overlooked. Romm had been working on a script for another fiction film but reportedly could not make the story come together. Around the same time, he was invited to collaborate on a Soviet-American coproduction for which permission from top authorities, presumably the Central Committee, was denied. When Turovskaya and Yuri Khaniutin, the two critics who had coauthored the script for *Ordinary Fascism*, brought their script to Mosfilm, they specifically asked for Romm to direct it. According to Turovskaya, Mosfilm bosses and other powers that be gave their consent relatively swiftly because it did not look good to the outside world that a director of Romm's stature remained idle. See Romm et al., *Obyknovennyi fashizm*, 253. Nonetheless, these circumstances do not diminish the production process (which involved trips to a number of concentration camps), creative decisions concerning form and structure, and the resulting film.

64. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:492.

65. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:273.

66. On the Marxist concept of totality in the milieu of Western Marxists and on totality's many pre-Marxian sources, see Martin Jay, *Marxism and Totality: The Adventures of a Concept from Lukács to Habermas* (University of California Press, 1984).

67. Lukács was an important figure in formulating socialist realism when he lived in Moscow between 1933 and 1938 and worked at the Institute for Philosophy,

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Literature, and History for much of this time. For more, see Katerina Clark, *Moscow the Fourth Rome: Stalinism, Cosmopolitanism, and the Evolution of Soviet Culture, 1931–1941* (Harvard University Press, 2011), 128–35.

68. Brecht et al., *Aesthetics and Politics*, 33.

69. East German director Gottfried Kolditz made *Weißes Blut* (*White Blood*) in 1959, a film about atomic radiation that Romm thought rather inferior. But he was impressed by the excitement and anxiety with which the audience watched Kolditz's film. See Romm, *Izbrannnye proizvedeniia*, 1:268.

70. The setting was an allusion to Akademgorodok, which was a science city built south of Novosibirsk in the 1950s.

71. Petr Vail' and Aleksandr Genis, *60-e-mir Sovetskogo cheloveka* (Novoe literaturnoe obozrenie, 1996), 100. For the first time, Soviet scientists received the Nobel Prize in 1958 (and then in 1962 and 1964).

72. See V. Surin, V Komitet Gosudarstvennoi bezopasnosti pri Sovete ministrov SSSR [To the State Security Committee in the Council of Ministers of the USSR], June 23, 1961, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, d. 1078, l. 31; V. Surin, Prikaz General'nogo direktora ordena Lenina kinostudii Mosfilm [Resolution of the director general of Mosfilm], February 22, 1961, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, d. 1078, l. 38. Once the literary script became the director's script, it was renamed "I Walk into the Unknown." See "'Ia idu v neizvestnoe'—rezhisserskii stsenarii M. I. Romma po literaturnomy stsenariiu '365 dnei' M. I. Romma i D. IA. Khrabrovitskogo" ["I Walk into the Unknown," director's script by M. I. Romm based on the literary script "365 days" by M. I. Romm and D. Ya. Khrabrovitsky], 1961, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, f. 1077. Romm mentioned at least once another possible title, "Oderzhimyi" (The obsessed), referring to the main character and his total devotion to science.

73. Mikhail Romm, "Posleslovie k kartine," *Iskusstvo kino*, November 1962, 80.

74. Josephine Woll, *Real Images: Soviet Cinema and the Thaw* (I.B. Tauris, 2000), 128.

75. Viktor Demin, "Bunt podrobnostei," *Voprosy kinodramaturgii* 5 (1965): 59.

76. Romm, "Posleslovie k kartine," 80. It is unclear from the archival materials when the title officially changed to *Nine Days of One Year*.

77. It is possible that Fellini's *La Dolce Vita* (1960), whose narrative is built around seven erratic evenings and nights of the hero, served, at least partially, as a structural model for Romm. He considered this film an important work of art.

78. Brecht et al., *Aesthetics and Politics*, 47.

79. Romm, *Izbrannnye proizvedeniia*, 1:297.

80. I use Michel Chion's definition of "acousmatic," or the "acousmetre," which possesses four principal characteristics, "ubiquity, panopticism, omniscience, and omnipotence" (*The Voice in Cinema* [Columbia University Press, 2008], 24).

81. Chion, *The Voice in Cinema*, 49.

82. Mary Ann Doane, "The Voice in the Cinema: The Articulation of Body and Space," *Yale French Studies* 60 (1980): 42.

83. For more on the rhetorical function of speech in documentaries, see Bill Nichols, *Introduction to Documentary* (Indiana University Press, 2017), chap. 1.

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84. Typescript of the fourth version of the so-called director's screenplay of "Ia idu v neizvestnoe" [I walk into the unknown], Mosfilm, 1961, RGALI, f. 844, op. 2, d. 18, l. 4.

85. Typescript of the fourth version, l. 22-23.

86. Transcript of a discussion by the artistic council of a rough cut of *I Walk into the Unknown*, November 24, 1961, Mosfilm, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, d. 1017, l. 39.

87. Lilya Kaganovsky, "Soviet 1960s Cinema and the Nuclear Catastrophe: Mikhail Romm's *Ordinary Fascism* and *Nine Days of One Year*," in *Critical Memory Studies*, ed. Brett Ashley Kaplan (Bloomsbury Academic, 2023), 268.

88. Kaganovsky, "Soviet 1960s Cinema," 267.

89. Romm's narrator went against the trends in contemporary documentary, particularly in North America and western Europe. As Nichols points out, filmmakers working in observational mode in the 1960s rejected voice-over. See Bill Nichols, *Introduction to Documentary* (Indiana University Press, 2017), 11.

90. For another analysis of Lyolya and her place in *Nine Days*, including her interior monologues, see Marina Rojavin, "'What Can Be Done About It? I'm a Woman, Not a Pet': The Non-Heroic Heroines in Romm's *Nine Days of One Year* and Shepit'ko's *You and Me*," in *Women in Soviet Film: The Thaw and Post-Thaw Periods*, ed. Marina Rojavin and Tim Harte (Routledge), 155-75.

91. Doane, "The Voice in the Cinema," 41.

92. Mary Ann Doane has argued that the close-up as a cinematic device manages to respond to modernity's desire for proximity and possession while at the same time demonstrating a sense of transcendence, a spectacle of scale that is allied with unattainability. According to Doane, the close-up can be understood as both part of a whole and a whole. See Doane, "The Close-Up: Scale and Detail in the Cinema," *differences: A Journal of Feminist Cultural Studies* 14, no. 3 (Fall 2003): 89-111.

93. "Pervye itogi obsuzhdeniia statei *Pravdy*," *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1936, 16.

94. Ia. El'sberg, "Realizm i modernizm (osnovnye linii bor'by)," in *Realizm i ego sootnosheniia s drugimi tvorcheskimi metodami* (Izd-vo Akademii nauk SSSR, 1962), 247.

95. El'sberg, "Realizm i modernism," 254. For Lenin, crucially, this chaos was only *kazhuiushcheisia* (seeming) and therefore could still be apprehended and tamed, while for modernists, it was absolute. See Lenin quoted in El'sberg, "Realizm i modernizm," 248. This "seeming chaos" referred to the crash of the falling down of structures of the bourgeois world.

96. See, for example, Stanisław Lenartowicz, "Organizatsiia vremeni i prostranstva v proizvedenii kinoiskusstva," *Voprosy kinoiskusstva* 2 (1957): 323-57.

97. Siegfried Kracauer, *Theory of Film: The Redemption of Physical Reality* (Oxford University Press, 1965), 297.

98. Brecht et al., *Aesthetics and Politics*, 44.

99. "Mne chasto kazhetsia, chto slishkom tonka, pochnti neulovima v stikhe Vashem sviaz' mezhdu vpechatleniem i obrazom. Voobrazhat'—znachit vnesti v khaos formu, obraz. Inogda ia gorestno chuvstvuiu, chto khaos mira odolevaet silu Vashego tvorchestva otrazhaetsia v nem imenno tol'ko kak khaos, disgarmonichno."

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Maxim Gorky quoted in El'sberg, "Realizm i modernism," 249. For an explanation of the word *obraz*, see note 80 in chapter 1 of the current volume.

100. Transcript of a discussion by the artistic council of a rough cut of *I Walk into the Unknown*, November 24, 1961, Mosfilm, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, d. 1017, l. 38.

101. The three protagonists are played by Aleksei Batalov (Mitya), Innokenty Smoktunovsky (Ilya), and Tatiana Lavrova (Lyolya). Batalov starred in *The Cranes Are Flying* (1957). Smoktunovsky starred as the Danish Prince Hamlet in Kozintsev's 1964 adaptation of Shakespeare's tragedy and gave Soviet ordinary protagonists in films such as *Neotravlennoe pis'mo* (*The Unsent Letter*, 1959) and *Beregis' avtomobilia* (*Beware of the Car*, 1966) "the right to speak . . . with low, intimate, quiet voice[s]" (Oksana Bulgakowa, "Cine-Weathers: Soviet Thaw Cinema in the International Context," in *The Thaw: Soviet Society and Culture During the 1950s and 1960s*, ed. Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd [University of Toronto Press, 2013], 467).

102. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:492.

103. Transcript of a discussion by the artistic council of the footage shot for *I Walk into the Unknown*, September 29, 1961, Mosfilm, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, d. 1016, l. 49–50.

104. A feature of the aesthetic renewal of Thaw fiction cinema was the partial abandonment of soundstages and pavilions in favor of shooting on city streets or in natural environments. This strategy inserted characters into real-life locales and had the camera move with and around them, thereby allowing the air of these places to fill the projected world. Several important films from the period espoused this approach and redefined Soviet filmmaking practice, most notably, Marlen Khutsiev's *I Am Twenty* (1965) and *Iiul'skii dozhd'* (*July Rain*, 1966), Georgy Daneliia's *Ia shagaiu po Moskve* (*I Walk the Streets of Moscow*, 1963), Mikhail Kalatozov's *The Unsent Letter* (1959), and Larisa Shepitko's *Krylya* (*Wings*, 1966).

105. RGALI, f. 844, op. 2, d. 18, l. 22–23.

106. One of the few outdoor scenes on the streets of the Siberian science town has an exceedingly studio look, complete with a wooden fence that could have been imported from Mikhail Chiaureli's *The Fall of Berlin*.

107. The staging of *Gas Masks* was experimental rather than the traditional, naturalist kind of theater associated with Stanislavsky, which Romm rejected during this time. During the Thaw, Romm evidently identified the once innovative stage director Stanislavsky and his system with the conservative Stalin-era realist theater exemplified by the Moscow Art Theater. For more on the treatment of Stanislavsky's theories during the Stalin era, see Sharon Marie Carnicke, "Stanislavsky: Uncensored and Unabridged," *Drama Review* 37, no. 1 (Spring 1993): 22–37. On Romm's thoughts on this matter, see *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:271.

108. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:318.

109. Romm also wanted to open the film with an establishing aerial shot of the Institute for Nuclear Research in Dubna. Most likely, the powers that be denied his request. See the Mosfilm director Vladimir Surin's letter to the Committee for State Security (KGB), June 23, 1961, RGALI, f. 2453, op. 4, d. 1078, l. 31.

110. Baecque, *Camera Historica*, 37–39.

111. Baecque, *Camera Historica*, 26.

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112. Kracauer, *Theory of Film*, 305.
113. Romm, *Izbrannye proizvedeniia*, 1:102.

Chapter 3. Staging Sincerity and a Promise of Community

1. Viktor Nekrasov, “Slova ‘velikie’ i prostye,” *Iskusstvo kino*, May 1959, 59. Nekrasov refers to *The Poem of the Sea* exclusively as Dovzhenko’s film despite the fact that Solntseva actually directed it. Nekrasov touches only on the linguistic register of *The Poem*, neglecting the film’s other elements, notably, its fluid, dynamic camerawork and unusual story structure.

2. Nekrasov, “Slova,” 59.

3. Other films in which the idea of a different kind of family figures centrally include *A Person Is Born* (dir. Vasily Ordynsky, Mosfilm, 1956), *Other People’s Children* (dir. Tengiz Abuladze, 1959), which is the subject of chapter 4, *Me, Grandma, Ilike, and Ilarioni* (dir. Tengiz Abuladze, Georgia Film, 1962), *The Story of Asya Klyachina* (dir. Andron Konchalovsky, Mosfilm, 1966), and *Brief Encounters* (Kira Muratova, Odesa Film Studio, 1967).

4. Svetlana Boym, *Common Places: Mythologies of Everyday Life in Russia* (Harvard University Press, 1994), 102.

5. On the trend of the deheroization of male film characters, see Marko Dumančić, *Men out of Focus: The Soviet Masculinity Crisis in the Long Sixties* (University of Toronto Press, 2021), chapter 5 in particular and chapter 6 on the broader trend as seen in 1960s European cinema.

6. An author who was eternally at the center of Soviet schools’ curriculum, Pushkin would be very familiar to the characters of the film. They would know many of his stanzas by heart from rote learning.

7. Such interlinking of poetry and mundane speech happens in another sequence in *Ilyich’s Gate* when Sergei confesses his feelings to Anya through the poetry of Pushkin’s novel in verse, *Eugene Onegin*, when the two visit the Pushkin Museum of Fine Arts.

8. Gennadii Shpalikov, *Izbrannoe: Stsenarii, stikhi i pesni, razroznennye zametki* (Iskusstvo, 1979), 36.

9. Michael Fried, *Absorption and Theatricality: Painting and Beholder in the Age of Diderot* (University of Chicago Press, 1980).

10. Fried, *Absorption and Theatricality*, 7–70.

11. Fried, *Absorption and Theatricality*, 131–32.

12. Fried, *Absorption and Theatricality*, 154.

13. Anne Eakin Moss, *Only Among Women: Philosophies of Community in the Russian and Soviet Imagination, 1860–1940* (Northwestern University Press, 2020), 185.

14. The unmasking of enemies became routine practice during the show trials in 1936–39, perhaps the most theatricalized feature of Soviet life at the time. For more on the show trials during the Great Purges, see Katerina Clark, *Moscow the Fourth Rome: Stalinism, Cosmopolitanism, and the Evolution of Soviet Culture, 1931–1941* (Harvard University Press, 2011); Sheila Fitzpatrick, *On Stalin’s Team: The Year of Living Dangerously in Soviet Politics* (Princeton University Press, 2015), esp. chap. 5.

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15. Lilya Kaganovsky, “Postmemory, Countermemory: Soviet Cinema of the 1960s,” in *The Socialist Sixties: Crossing Borders in the Second World*, ed. Anne E. Gorsuch and Diane P. Koenker (Indiana University Press, 2013), 235. Khutsiev did not fight in the war due to health problems, but Shpalikov and the actors playing the main characters represented the generation that was too young for the front.

16. Katerina Clark, *The Soviet Novel: History and Ritual* (Indiana University Press, 2000), 40.

17. Alexander Prokhorov, “The Myth of the ‘Great Family’ in Marlen Khutsiev’s *Lenin’s Guard* and Mark Osep’ian’s *Three Days of Viktor Chernyshev*,” in *Cinepater-nity: Fathers and Sons in Soviet and Post-Soviet Film*, ed. Helena Goscilo and Yana Hashamova (Indiana University Press, 2010), 31.

18. Khutsiev’s own father died in the Stalinist purges.

19. In *Ilyich’s Gate*, the person playing Sergei’s father was a gaffer from Khutsiev’s film unit. In *I Am Twenty*, this scene was reshot with a professional actor, cut to six minutes, and rewritten to make the father more understanding and edifying. In this version, he reassures the doubting Sergei about life rather than “abandoning” him.

20. Boym, *Common Places*, 100–101.

21. Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd, “The Thaw as an Event in Russian History,” in *The Thaw: Soviet Society and Culture During the 1950s and 1960s*, ed. Denis Kozlov and Eleonory Gilburd (University of Toronto Press, 2013), 52.

22. “The Pier” concerns a ménage à trois and takes place in part on a barge traveling down the Moskva River. Leaving the barge in an act of rebellion, the heroine encounters a range of characters and takes various modes of transportation. Such an open structure suggests a range of narrative possibilities. The script was in production at Mosfilm as the graduating project of two VGIK students from Romm’s workshop; it was never completed due to the suicide of one of the filmmakers. The efforts to realize “A Summer Break,” another script of Shpalikov’s by several directors, including Shpalikov’s friend Yuly Fait in 1962, came to naught. See Gennadii Shpalikov, *Ia zhil kak zhil: Stikhi, proza, dramaturgiia, dnevniki, pis'ma* (Izdatel'skii dom “Podkova,” 2013), 155, 205. Shpalikov’s only directorial effort, *A Long, Happy Life* (1967), contains the potential for several storylines as well.

23. Alexander Prokhorov points out that Shpalikov’s contribution to the screenplay—rejecting the plot-motivated narrative and “emphasizing atmosphere and characters’ emotional ties”—made the film “the new generation’s self-portrait” (“The Unknown New Wave,” in *Springtime for Soviet Cinema*, ed. A. Prokhorov [Russian Film Symposium, 2001], 15). See also Josephine Woll, *Real Images: Soviet Cinema and the Thaw* (I.B. Tauris, 2000), 144–50.

24. Anatolii Grebnev, “On obladal pronzitel'noi iskrennost'iu,” in *Segodnia vecherom my prishli k Shpalikovu: Vospominaniia, dnevniki, pis'ma, poslednii tsenarii*, ed. A. Khrzhanovskii (Ruthenia, 2018), 395.

25. Naum Kleiman and Bernard Eisenschitz, “Drugaiia istoriia sovetskogo kino,” *Locarno*, 2000, *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 53 (2001).

26. M. Khutsiev, “Stenogramma zasedaniia tvorcheskogo ob'edineniia S. Gerasimova po obsuzhdeniiu literaturnogo tsenariia Khutsieva i Shpalikova ‘Zastava Il'icha,’ 16 dekabria 1960,” typescript, RGALI, f. 2468, op. 2, d. 278, l. 42.

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27. In a 1967 essay, Bulgarian film critic Nedelcho Milev argued that the real innovation of late 1950s and 1960s European cinema was the appearance of interior monologue, citing Ingmar Bergman's *Wild Strawberries* (1957), Alain Resnais's *Hiroshima mon amour* (1958), Federico Fellini's *8 ½* (1963), and a number of Soviet films, among them Andrey Tarkovsky's *Ivan's Childhood* (1962), Romm's *Ordinary Fascism* (1966), and Khutsiev's *I Am Twenty*. Taking his cue from Sergei Eisenstein's theories, Milev saw interior monologue as the most promising medium for the synthesis of the visual and the aural/verbal in film form. Nedelcho Milev, "O razvitii zvukoztritl'nogo kinematografa (Eisenshtein, Bazin i sovremennoe kino)," *Voprosy kinoiskusstva*, no. 10 (1967): 129–52. Milev's chronology is inaccurate, likely because he had no opportunity to see certain films: Already in 1949, Jean-Pierre Melville's *La silence de la mer* (*The Silence of the Sea*), to say nothing of Robert Bresson's *Journal d'un curé de campagne* (*Diary of a Country Priest*, 1951), explored the inner voices of on-screen heroes and heroines. René Clement's *Monsieur Ripois* (1954), about a French philanderer having a good time in London, is another film that utilizes interior monologue as its protagonist wanders the streets of London. Another film from this period worth noting in its use of interior voice is Harald Braun's *Der gläserne Turm* (*The Glass Tower*, West Germany, 1957).

28. For a feminist perspective on the inner female voice, memory, and space in Soviet cinema, see Lida Oukaderova, *The Cinema of the Soviet Thaw: Space, Materiality, Movement* (Indiana University Press, 2017), chap. 4.

29. RGALI, f. 2468, op. 2, d. 278, l. 36.

30. Prokhorov, "The Unknown New Wave," 15.

31. Alexander Etkind, *Warped Mourning: Stories of the Undead in the Land of the Unburied* (Stanford University Press, 2013), 140. Maya Turovskaya noted that Hamlet was a character with "a stretched-out diapason of inner life," a quality that would be particularly prized in Thaw culture ("Gamlet i my," *Novyi mir*, no. 9 [September 1964]: 218).

32. "Russkii Gamlet," interview with Aleksei Bartoshevich, *Kommersant*, April 25, 2014, <https://www.kommersant.ru/doc/2458233>.

33. Dumančić, *Men out of Focus*, 138. Dumančić also refers to the scene between father and son in terms of "Hamlet's superfluous masculinity" in the 1960s (see the introduction).

34. Dumančić, *Men out of Focus*, 17.

35. Nikolai Okhlopkov, "Traditsii i novatorstvo" [Traditions and innovation], *Sovetskaiia kul'tura*, May 13, 1954, 2.

36. Okhlopkov, "Traditsii i novatorstvo," 2.

37. On the Okhlopkov production of *Hamlet*, which was considered the first Russian staging of a Shakespearean play after World War II, see Laurence Senelick, "Thus Conscience Doth Make Cowards of Us All': New Documentation on the Okhlopkov Hamlet," in *Shakespeare in the World of Communism and Socialism*, ed. Irena R. Makaryk and Joseph G. Price (University of Toronto Press, 2006), 136–56.

38. Grigorii Kozintsev, "Chernoe, likhoe vremena . . .": *Iz zapisnykh tetradei* ["Dark, rakish times . . .": From notebooks] (Izd-vo Artist. Rezhisser. Teatr, 1994), 89.

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39. Boris Pasternak, "Zametki k perevodam shekspirovskikh tragedii" [Notes on translations of Shakespeare's tragedies], *Literaturnaia Moskva* (1956): 796.
40. Lionel Trilling, *Sincerity and Authenticity* (Harvard University Press, 1972), 13.
41. Turovskaia, "Gamlet i my," 217.
42. Kaganovsky, "Postmemory, Countermemory," 238.
43. This scene was excised for fear on the part of cultural authorities that Soviet youth would cause a conflagration across the nation by emulating the romantic scene.
44. Prokhorov, "The Myth of the 'Great Family,'" 34.
45. The expulsion of Stalin's embalmed body from the Kremlin Mausoleum occurred following the Twenty-Second Communist Party Congress, October 17–31, 1961.
46. It is worth noting that the film was frequently compared to Federico Fellini's *La Dolce Vita* (1960), which was never widely released in the Soviet Union but was known to a small circle of professionals, including Khutsiev. A filmmaker present at the discussion of the literary script of *Ilyich's Gate* said that finally Soviet cinema had an answer to *La Dolce Vita*. See "Stenogramma zasedaniia," 1. 13.
47. Prokhorov notes that "the son's commemoration establishes a different kind of utopian time—that of intimacy and what Mikhail Bakhtin would identify as 'deep time,' which offers timeless, transcendent insight, as opposed to Stalinist teleological progressive time" ("The Myth of the 'Great Family,'" 36).
48. This play with dreamlike states and character consciousness would be fully explored by Andrei Tarkovsky in *Ivan's Childhood* (1962), a film that, as I mentioned earlier, ended up at the center of the controversy on realism.
49. Viktor Nekrasov, *Both Sides of the Ocean: A Russian Writer's Travels in Italy and the United States* (Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1964), 116–17.
50. Maria Belodubrovskaya, "Abram Room, A Strict Young Man, and the 1936 Campaign Against Formalism in Soviet Cinema," *Slavic Review* 74, no. 2 (Summer 2015): 311–33.
51. The other two tenets were to uphold ideological commitment and to serve the goals of the party. See the introduction.
52. Stanley Cavell, *The World Viewed: Reflections on the Ontology of Film*, enl. ed. (Harvard University Press, 1979), 229.
53. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 146.
54. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 133.
55. Jennifer Fay, "Must We Mean What We Film? Stanley Cavell and the Candid Camera," *Discourse* 42, nos. 1–2 (Winter/Spring 2020): 112.
56. Fay, "Must We Mean," 120.
57. Cavell gives several examples where this is the case. One of the films whose "assertions of techniques" he discusses at some length is François Truffaut's *Jules and Jim* (1962) (*The World Viewed*, 137–41).
58. Fay, "Must We Mean," 118.
59. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 132.
60. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 189.
61. He briefly discusses Vertov's *Man with a Movie Camera* and the Odesa steps sequence from *Battleship Potemkin*. As Fay notes, Cavell's candid canon is not exclusively American or classic. Among the films he considers in *The World Viewed* are

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The Grand Illusion (Jean Renoir, 1937), *Rules of the Game* (Jean Renoir, 1939), *Seven Samurai* (Akira Kurosawa, 1954), *L'Atalante* (Jean Vigo, 1934), and *Jules and Jim*.

62. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 96–97. He specifically talks about Godard's characters in his films after *Breathless* (1960).

63. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 62.

64. The poetry scholar and literary critic Vladislav Kulakov considers the new generation of poets, those who began their careers during the Thaw (Evtushenko, Akhmadulina, Rozhdestvensky, Voznesensky), to be largely conformist and only marginally innovative. They fully shared and therefore were implicit in “the foundational myths of the system,” which supported them. Although Mayakovsky served for many as the guiding light, for Kulakov, none was able to write with the originality of the 1920s avant-garde; instead, the Thaw poets had already absorbed “socialist realist eclectics with an ‘amorphous faithfulness to classical tradition’” (Vladislav Kulakov, *Poeziia kak fakt* [NLO, 1999], 7–8). See also Kulakov, “‘Vypustili svet na svezhii vozdukh’: Poeziia ottepel’,” in Karpova, *Ottepel’* (Gos. Tret’iakovskaia galereia, 2017), 147–65.

65. Beth Holmgren, introduction to *The Russian Memoir: History and Literature* (Northwestern University Press, 2011), xxix.

66. E. Iu. Zubkova, *Obshchestvo i reformy, 1945–1964* (Rossiia molodaia, 1993), 138–39.

67. Clark, *The Soviet Novel*, 211. Incidentally, the French film star Yves Montand, on his visit to the USSR in December 1956, entertained a packed stadium as well. Film stars and poets were on equal footing as celebrities.

68. Kulakov, “‘Vypustili svet na svezhii vozdukh,’” 152–53; L. B. Brusilovskaia, *Kul'tura povsednevnosti v epokhu “ottepel’”: Metamorfozy stil'ia; uchebnoe posobie* (Izd-vo URAO, 2001), 61.

69. Brusilovskaia, *Kul'tura povsednevnosti*, 61–62. For more on the tumultuous history of and eventual clampdown on the gatherings at Mayakovsky Square, see Liudmila Polikovskaia et al., *My predchustvie—Predtecha: Ploshchad' Maiakovskogo, 1958–1965* (Zven'ia, 1997).

70. Denis Kozlov points out several sources of inspiration in the search for new linguistic standards: the past, “revolutionary romantics, lyrical poetry, irony, youth slang, Western borrowings, or any combination of the above” (*The Readers of “Novyi Mir”: Coming to Terms with the Stalinist Past* [Harvard University Press, 2013], 67).

71. Kozlov, *The Readers of “Novyi Mir,”* 67. Kozlov refers to one of the participants in sincerity in language debates, Kornei Chukovsky, who “noted that, although passions about the insincerity of words had run high in early Soviet culture as well, in the 1950s and 1960s language-related polemics became especially widespread, commanding attention from mass audiences ostensibly unconnected to such esoteric issues” (67).

72. In *Phaedrus*, Plato has Socrates tell his titular interlocutor that writing does not offer “true wisdom . . . but only its semblance . . . and as men filled, not with wisdom, but with the conceit of wisdom, they will be a burden to their fellows” (275b). And although Plato famously attacked poetry in *The Republic*, the target of his criticism was not necessarily the oral form of expression itself.

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73. For more on the biographical genre during Stalinism, see Clark, *Moscow, the Fourth Rome*, 114–15.

74. Evgeny Dobrenko, *Stalinist Cinema and the Production of History: Museum of the Revolution* (Yale University Press, 2008), 65. For more on the biopic, see chap. 2.

75. The biopic was also “the safest genre” in Stalinist culture. See Maria Belodubrovskaya, *Not According to Plan: Filmmaking Under Stalin* (Cornell University Press, 2017), 43.

76. Dobrenko notes, “The more politically topical a person, the more inevitable that person’s ‘biographical’ isolation and arrest. . . . The person literally pays with his or her own life in order to remain ‘among the living’ after death and function as a product of ‘writing’” (*Stalinist Cinema*, 65).

77. Dobrenko, *Stalinist Cinema*, 114.

78. Andrei Voznesenskii, “Fire in the Architectural Institute,” trans. Stanley Kunitz, *Encounter* 115 (April 1963): 54.

79. In an interview, Khutsiev mentioned that they shot nine reels of the poetry scene, which amounted to about one and a half hours. Svetlana Khokhriakova, “Tak rozhdalsia legendarnyi fil’m Marlena Khutsieva *Zastava Il’icha*,” *Moskovskii komсомоlets*, August 1, 2014, 7.

80. Naum Kleiman, email message to the author, July 17, 2018. According to another version of events, recounted on the Polytechnical Museum’s site, free tickets were given out by Moscow’s chapter of the Young Communist League, or *Komsomol*. “Kak v Politekhničeskome muzei snimali kino,” <https://150.polymus.ru/media/kak-v-politekhničeskome-muzei-snimali-kino/>.

81. The auditorium of the Polytechnical Museum had an illustrious past. In the 1920s it accommodated jam-packed poetry slams of exceedingly divergent poetic styles that often ended in heated arguments. See Varlaam Shalamov, “Zametki o stikhakh,” in *Sobranie sochinenii v chetyrekh tomakh* (Vagrius, 1998), 2:33. The institution’s walls also witnessed equally popular court inquests and public tribunals. Marina Shimadina, “Sto let Bol’shoi auditorii,” accessed November 19, 2024, <http://oteatre.info/sto-let-bol-shoj-auditorii-politehnicheskogo-s-1907-po-2007/>.

82. Tat’iana Khlopiankina, *Zastava Il’icha* (Soiuz kinematografistov SSSR, 1990), 36–38.

83. Zdenko Mandušić examines this turn in Soviet film aesthetics in “Camera-work: Soviet Film Experience and Visual Poetics After Stalin” (PhD diss., University of Chicago, 2016), focusing on Andron Konchalovsky’s *The Story of Asya Kliachina* (134–75).

84. Khokhriakova, “Tak rozhdalsia,” 7.

85. Kristin Roth-Ey, *Moscow Prime Time: How the Soviet Union Built the Media Empire That Lost the Cultural Cold War* (Cornell University Press, 2011), 237.

86. Roth-Ey, *Moscow Prime Time*, 238.

87. The phrase “media of indexical traces” is Philip Rosen’s. For Rosen’s discussion of the liveness of a news broadcast and documentary cinema, see his *Change Mummified: Cinema, Historicity, Theory* (University of Minnesota Press, 2006), chap. 6.

88. Cavell, *The World Viewed*, 128–29.

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89. Elena Stishova, “Kosmos kak stradanie,” *Iskusstvo kino*, February 2009, 30; Khokhriakova, “Tak rozhalsia,” 7.

90. For example, the poetry scene was intended to be inserted in the anthology film *Beginning of an Unknown Century* (1967).

91. Stishova, “Kosmos,” 30.

92. To my question of whether or not these television cameras did indeed record, Naum Kleiman hypothesized that quite possibly they did. But due to the banning of this version of the film, the television recording, ostensibly for a future program, was probably likewise censored. Naum Kleiman, email message to the author, July 16, 2018.

93. Angela Esterhammer, “The Scandal of Sincerity: Wordsworth, Byron, Landon,” in *Romanticism, Sincerity and Authenticity*, ed. Tim Milnes and Kerry Sinanan (Palgrave Macmillan, 2010), 117.

94. My idea of retheatricalization in the context of Soviet cinema is indebted to Robert Pippin’s analysis of Courbet’s and Manet’s paintings as employing “complexly dialectical theatrical strategy to achieve antitheatrical results” (“Authenticity in Painting: Remarks on Michael Friend’s Art History,” *Critical Inquiry* 31, no. 3 [Spring 2005]: 584–85).

95. Prokhorov, “The Myth of the ‘Great Family,’” 32.

96. The term “mass ornament” was coined by Siegfried Kracauer. He also writes about a special relationship between the camera and the masses in *Theory of Film: The Redemption of Physical Reality* (Oxford University Press, 1965), 50–51.

97. Some examples where crowds are arranged in such formations and drained of any insurrectionary potential include Grigory Aleksandrov’s *The Circus* (1936) and in certain scenes Chiaureli’s *Fall of Berlin* (1949).

98. In a discussion of *Ilyich’s Gate*, Evgeny Margolit makes a similar point, noting that in Soviet cinema there are two kinds of crowds: “a crowd as a chaotic-pulsating organism, extremely vulnerable in its naturalness (the scene on the stairs in *Battleship Potemkin*), and an organized mass, an instrument of transformation of the world, striving for proper, geometric forms” (“Peizazh s geroem,” in *Kinematograf otpepli* [Materik, 1996], 1:112–13). For me, the insistence on crowds in *Ilyich’s Gate*, on placing the protagonists within large masses, is an indication of the formal sincerity in that fiction is attempting to get as close as it can to its subject of interest, that is, reality.

99. Kracauer, *Theory of Film*, 50.

100. Other noteworthy crowd sequences in the film are those of the May Day parade, which was the first that the crew shot on May 1, 1961, and of the art exhibition at the Pushkin Museum, which I discuss elsewhere.

101. For all of Sergei Urusevsky’s camera prowess in *The Cranes Are Flying* and *The Unsent Letter*, his work came across as academic, as carefully calculated.

102. Khlopliankina, *Zastava Il’icha*, 46–47. The loud footstep would be associated with the footsteps of secret police agents, who conducted their arrests at night during the purges in the 1930s.

103. The sequence at the Pushkin Museum of Fine Arts was likewise staged for the film. Similarly to the poetry reading at the Polytechnical Museum, Khutsiev and

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Pilikhina used a handheld camera for much of the sequence, deftly meandering through the crowd, creating an active space in which the art objects, particularly sculptures, seem to move around the bodies of the museumgoers. Instead of the TV broadcast filmed during the poetry evening, here there is a radio correspondent amid the visitors in the process of conducting a live radio program.

104. The 1962 original is almost never screened. Peter Bagrov, email message to the author, October 26, 2019.

Chapter 4. Child's Play on the Periphery

1. Referring to Bulat Okudzhava and his lyrics, historian Denis Kozlov says, "Among his objects of nostalgia were the Russian classics, especially Pushkin; the unhurried 19th-century style; and, above all, the bygone Russian nobility as the bearer and keeper of the country's cultural tradition, educational standards, and ethical values" ("The Historical Turn in Late Soviet Culture: Retrospectivism, Factography, Doubt, 1953–91," *Kritika: Explorations in Russian and Eurasian History* 2, no. 3 [2001]: 588).

2. "Audio-visual polyphony (zvukozritel'naia polifoniia)" is Eisenstein's term; the theorist-filmmaker used it in his essay "Vertical Montage," in *Neravnodushnaia priroda: Chuvstvo kino* (Eisenshtein-Tsentr, 2004), 1:84–163.

3. Rusudan Tikanadze, *Gruzinskoe kino: Problemy, iskanii* (Khelobneba, 1978), 98.

4. I use the term "peripheral" and its derivatives to refer to the hierarchy established by the Soviet regime's centralized rule and to think about distinct film cultures in the Soviet republics in relation to the context of the highly uneven balance of power. On the work that engages postcolonial methodologies and revises cinematic analysis concerning former parts of the Soviet Union, see cluster "Decolonising the (Post-)Soviet Screen" I and II, *Apparatus: Film, Media and Digital Cultures in Central and Eastern Europe*, nos. 18 and 19 (2024); and Nino Dzandzava, "Georgian Cinema Studies: Observations, Challenges, and the Colonial Legacy," *Apparatus: Film, Media and Digital Cultures in Central and Eastern Europe*, no. 19 (2024), <https://www.apparatusjournal.net/index.php/apparatus/article/view/371/678>; "Forum: Ukrainian Cinema: An Invitation to Historians and Cinephiles," *Slavic and East European Journal* 68, no. 3 (Fall 2024).

5. In June 1936 the Central Committee of the Communist Party dissolved Mezhrabpomfilm, a studio that had been around since the 1920s and produced some of the most iconic films of the era, among them Vsevolod Pudovkin's *Potomok Chingizkhana* (*Storm over Asia*, 1928), and one of the first Soviet sound films, *Putevka v zhizn'* (*Road to Life*, 1931), directed by Nikolai Ekk. Because of Mezhrabpomfilm's material resources, an organization was formed that was dedicated to producing films for kids and young adults, Soiuzdetfilm. See V. Fomin and A. Derabin, *Letopis' Rossiiskogo kino, 1930–1945* (Kanon-plius, 2016), 473–75.

6. On the distinction between films made for child audiences and films about children, see Noel Brown, *The Children's Film: Genre, Nation, Narrative* (Columbia University Press, 2017), chap. 1.

7. I thank John MacKay for bringing Ilya Frez's *I Bought a Dad* to my attention.

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8. Fomin and Deriabin, *Letopis' Rossiiskogo kino*, 239–40.
9. See, for example, “Iz pis'ma gruppy kinematografistov o neobkhodimosti izmenenii v sisteme proizvodstva i vypuska khudozhestvennykh fil'mov,” in *Apparat TsK KPSS i kul'tura, 1953–1957: Dokumenty*, ed. E. Afanas'eva et al. (ROSSPĖN, 2001), 51–62.
10. “Iz pis'ma gruppy kinematografistov,” 55–56.
11. Joshua First, *Ukrainian Cinema: Belonging and Identity During the Soviet Thaw* (I.B. Tauris, 2015), 46.
12. “Iz pis'ma gruppy kinematografistov,” 55.
13. Here I am concerned with the national cinemas of the fifteen republics that comprised the Soviet Union. There were also regional studios across Soviet Russia proper.
14. Fomin and Deriabin, *Letopis' Rossiiskogo kino*, 241; V. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii: Upravleniia, kinoproizvodstvo, prokat,” manuscript, June 1, 2012, 1111–13, <https://culture.gov.ru/documents/istoriya-kinootrasli-v-rossii-upravlenie-kinoproizvodstvo-prokat/>.
15. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii,” 1113.
16. The reform to centralize the Soviet film industry began in 1930 and continued throughout the first half of the decade. See Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii,” 341–90.
17. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii,” 1195.
18. For example, film composer and sound designer Algimantas Apanavičius recalled “meetings with Sniečkus [the first secretary of the Communist Party of Lithuania between 1940 and 1974] during presentations of TV programs and films at the Lithuanian Film Studio, where the communist leader would frequently invite the entire production staff, including light and sound technicians, for a glass of cognac in a relaxed, ‘completely non-Soviet’ atmosphere” (quoted in Violeta Davoliūtė, *The Making and Breaking of Soviet Lithuania* [Routledge, 2013], 99). Petro Shelest, the first secretary of Soviet Ukraine's Communist Party between 1965 and 1972, is another such example. Shelest was often sympathetic to Ukrainian artists and filmmakers. His personal approval of the controversial film *Bilyi ptakh z chornoyu oznakoyu* (*The White Bird Marked with Black*, Dovzhenko Film Studio, 1971) helped the film avoid the ban. Ana Hedberg Olenina, “Imposed Provincialism: Recovering Ukrainian Cinema from the Shadows of Russo-Centric Frameworks: An Interview with Dina Iordanova,” *Slavic & East European Journal* 68, no. 3 (2024): 300.
19. Other films produced by Georgia Film during this period are *Magdana's Donkey* (1955), *Our Yard* (1956), and *Last Day, First Day* (1959). This kind of cultural syncretism benefiting from geographic remoteness can also be observed in the films by the young director Mikhail Kalik made at Moldova-Film and the work by Lithuanian and Latvian filmmakers at their respective studios.
20. Naum Kleiman, *Formula finala: Stat'i, vystupleniia, besedy* (Eizenshtein-tsentr, 2004), 424–25. Much work on the state of the Soviet republican studios remains to be done.
21. Miron Chernenko, “Problema etnicheskogo kinematografa i ‘kazus’ Paradzhanova,” *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 6 (1990): 94–99. For more on the issue of national

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self-expression in Soviet cinema, see Elizabeth Papazian, “Ethnography, Fairytale, and ‘Perpetual Motion’ in Sergei Paradjanov’s *Ashik-Kerib*,” *Literature/Film Quarterly* 34, no. 4 (2006): 303–12; Joshua First, *Ukrainian Cinema: Belonging and Identity During the Soviet Thaw* (I.B. Tauris, 2015); James Steffen, *The Cinema of Sergei Parajanov* (University of Wisconsin Press, 2013).

22. Chernenko, “Problema etnicheskogo kinematografa,” 95.

23. For more on these tensions, see Erik R. Scott, *Familiar Strangers: The Georgian Diaspora and the Evolution of Soviet Empire* (Oxford University Press, 2017). On the relationship between the Ukrainian film industry and Moscow, see First, *Ukrainian Cinema*.

24. For more on how the Bolsheviks, including Lenin and Stalin, borrowed the European notions of empire and nation-state and transformed them for their own ends as they embarked on the creation of a new, multiethnic socialist state, see Francine Hirsch, *Empire of Nations: Ethnographic Knowledge and the Making of the Soviet Union* (Cornell University Press, 2014). On the early debates of Soviet nationality policy, see Yuri Slezkine, “The USSR as a Communal Apartment, or How a Socialist State Promoted Ethnic Particularism,” *Slavic Review* 53, no. 2 (1994): 414–52.

25. Hirsch, *Empire of Nations*, esp. chaps. 4 and 5.

26. Scott, *Familiar Strangers*, 12, quoting Jane Burbank and Frederick Cooper, *Empires in World History: Power and the Politics of Difference* (Princeton University Press, 2010), 11–13.

27. Harsha Ram, “Decadent Nationalism, ‘Peripheral’ Modernism: The Georgian Literary Manifesto Between Symbolism and the Avant-Garde,” *Modernism/modernity* 21, no. 1 (2014): 344. This is not dissimilar to Hollywood films of the 1930s and 1940s fueling the French New Wave.

28. Harsha Ram, “Towards a Cross-Cultural Poetics of the Contact Zone: Romantic, Modernist, and Soviet Intertextualities in Boris Pasternak’s Translations of T’itsian T’abidze,” *Comparative Literature* 59, no. 1 (Winter 2007): 63. The Russian Empire annexed eastern Georgia in 1801.

29. Claire P. Kaiser, *Georgian and Soviet: Entitled Nationhood and the Specter of Stalin in the Caucasus* (Cornell University Press, 2022), 7. Of course, it must be remembered that the most elevated of positions was held by Russia, including the Russian language and culture. According to Harsha Ram, “Promulgated in 1935, Stalin’s policy of ‘friendship between peoples’ guaranteed ethnic diversity and Russian ascendancy within the Soviet Union” (“Towards a Cross-Cultural Poetics,” 67).

30. Kaiser, *Georgian and Soviet*, 7.

31. Scott, *Familiar Strangers*, chap. 1.

32. Scott, *Familiar Strangers*, 3.

33. Scott, *Familiar Strangers*, 3. Jeremy Smith makes a similar claim with an emphasis on the changing dynamics between the Georgians’ sense of national identity and accommodation to the imperial center. Jeremy Smith, “Georgian Nationalism and Soviet Power: Between Accommodation and Revolt,” in *Identities and Representations in Georgia from the 19th Century to the Present* ed. Hubertus Jahn (De Gruyter, 2021), 70–82.

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34. Mary Louise Pratt, “Arts for the Contact Zone,” in *Ways of Reading*, ed. David Bartholomae and Anthony Petrosky (St. Martin’s Press, 1999), 584.

35. Larisa Shepitko, for example, made her feature debut, *Znoi* (*Heat*, 1963), at Kyrgyzfilm in the republic of Kyrgyzia; local filmmakers dubbed her “the mother of Kyrgyz cinema.” For more on the blossoming of national cinemas, see Evgenii Margolit, “Proshchanie s ‘ukhodiashchei naturoi,” in *Kinematograf ottepli, kniga vtoraiia*, ed. V. Troianovskii (Materik, 2002), 211–28.

36. Before setting off for Moscow, Abuladze had studied in 1943–46 at the Rustaveli Theater Institute in Tbilisi, where he returned as professor in the 1970s. During the years at the Rustaveli Institute, he and his peer Rezo Chkheidze had seen *Ivan the Terrible* and been so taken with it that they wrote Eisenstein a letter, imploring him to let them become part of his crew. Apparently, Eisenstein answered the letter. See Giorgi Gvakharia, “La nouvelle vague: Les années cinquante-soixante,” in *Le cinéma géorgien*, ed. Jean Radvanyi (Éditions du Centre Georges Pompidou, 1988), 71.

37. During the brief period of the First Georgian Republic (1918–21), the leading producer of documentary chronicles was Germane Gogitidze (<https://kolga.ge/exhibitions/1920s-georgian-cinematography>). On Georgian early cinema, prior to the October Revolution, see Nino Dzandzava, “Simon Esadze and Early Film Culture in Georgia,” *Apparatus: Film, Media and Digital Cultures of Central and Eastern Europe*, no. 15 (2022), <https://www.apparatusjournal.net/index.php/apparatus/article/view/280/617>.

38. Irina Ratiani, *U istokov gruzinskogo kino: Vzaimosviaz’ literatury, teatra i kino v kul’ture Gruzii* (Rossiiskii in-t kul’turologii, 2003), 37–84.

39. Ratiani, *U istokov gruzinskogo kino*, 38–39. In 1921 Ivan Perestiani and the studio produced *Arsen Dzhordzhiashvili*, a film about a real-life metal caster who in 1905 threw a hand grenade at a Russian general, was arrested, and was soon executed by the tsarist authorities in Tbilisi. The role of the title’s hero was played by the young Mikhail Chiaureli.

40. Ratiani, *U istokov gruzinskogo kino*, 44.

41. Quoted in Ratiani, *U istokov gruzinskogo kino*, 47.

42. For more on *My Grandmother*, see Denise J. Youngblood, “My Grandmother (Chemi bebia) (1929),” *Moving Image* 10, no. 1 (Spring 2010): 157–59.

43. Gvakharia, “La nouvelle vague,” 96–97.

44. Chiaureli’s showpiece of Stalin-era filmmaking, *The Vow* (1946), and Kalatozov’s *Jim Shvante* (*Salt for Svanetia*, 1930) were shot at the Tbilisi Studio. Before taking the reins as directors, Chiaureli and Kalatozov had first been involved with writing and photographing, in the case of Kalatozov, and production design and acting, in the case of Chiaureli. Kalatozov, then Kalatozishvili, had coauthored the script of and then lensed *Giuli* (dir. Nikoloz Shengelaia and Lev Push, 1927), while Chiaureli worked as production designer on *Saminishvili Dedinatsvali* (*Saminishvili’s Stepmother*, dir. Kote Mardjanishvili and Zakro Berishvili, 1927) and starred in *Khanuma* (dir. Aleksandre Tsutsunava, 1926). See <https://kolga.ge/exhibitions/1920s-georgian-cinematography>.

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45. Tikanadze, *Gruzinskoe kino*, 21–22. For this period, Tikanadze singles out a popular comedy, *Chrichina* (*The Dragonfly*, dir. Siko Dolidze, 1954), which touched on, albeit superficially, contemporary life (27–28).

46. Interview with Lana Gogoberidze, *Libération*, quoted in Gvakharia, “La nouvelle vague,” 106. A witness described the experience of watching *Magdana's Donkey* at Cannes thus: “Nothing attracted the attention of the press and jury—not the location, not the fact that it was a short, nor the names of the debutants. . . . And suddenly, after two or three simple shots, viewers of both East and West sensed that certain changes had taken place in Soviet cinema. The film was screened for the second time and received the main prize” (quoted in Kora Tsereteli, “Sovremennoe gruzinskoe kino,” in *Gruzinskoe kino: Stranitsy istorii* [Reklamno-izdatel'skii otdel Goskino, 1979], 82).

47. The Palme d'Or for the short that year went unanimously to Albert Lamorisse's *Le ballon rouge*. See Festival de Cannes, 1956, <https://www.festival-cannes.com/en/retrospective/1956/#competition-courts-metragés>.

48. For more on *Magdana's Donkey*, see Tikanadze, *Gruzinskoe kino*, 37–51.

49. Abuladze returned to the image of the dusty road in his 1962 film, *Me, Grandma, Iliko, and Ilarioni*. Chkheidze set *Chveni ezo* (*In Our Courtyard*, 1956), his solo debut, in the courtyard of a Tbilisi apartment complex. The courtyard serves as a stage from which to explore a diverse set of ordinary city inhabitants and is conducive to an episodic narrative structure.

50. Neia Zorkaia, “Tengiz Abuladze,” in *Molodye rezhissery sovetskogo kino*, ed. E. Dobin et al. (Iskusstvo, 1962), 163.

51. Due to censorship, the film came out only in May 1959. See Gvakharia, “La nouvelle vague,” 107.

52. Levan Paatashvili, *Polveka u steny Leonardo: Iz opyta operatorskoi professii* [Half a century by Leonardo's wall: From the cameraman's experience] (Izd-vo 625, 2006), 39. Paatashvili writes that he watched several Georgian films in preparation for *Other People's Children*, but he names only two specifically: Mikhail Chiaureli's *Arsen* (1937) and David Rondeli's *Lost Paradise* (1937).

53. There is also an obvious connection with so-called literature of fact, or factography, a model of realism elaborated by Sergei Tretyakov and his colleagues in the journal *Novyi lef* in the late 1920s. See, for example, Leah Dickerman, “The Fact and the Photograph,” *October* 118 (Fall 2006): 132–52; Devin Fore, and “The Operative Word in Soviet Factography,” *October* 118 (Fall 2006): 95–131.

54. Cesare Zavattini, “Nekotorye mysli o kinoiskusstve” [Some thoughts about film art], *Iskusstvo kino*, July 1957, 107. Also in David Overbey, “A Thesis on Neo-Realism by Cesare Zavattini,” in *Springtime in Italy: A Reader on Neo-Realism*, ed. David Overbey (Archon Books, 1979), 71.

55. Revaz Japaridze, “Velikoe sorokaletie,” *Literaturnaia gazeta*, November 2, 1957, 2.

56. Solov'eva, *Kino Italii*, 5–6.

57. Mark Shiel, *Italian Neorealism: Rebuilding the Cinematic City* (Wallflower Press, 2006), 55; Roberto Rossellini, “Ten Years of Cinema,” in Overbey, *Springtime in Italy*, 94–98.

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58. “Interviews with Roberto Rossellini,” in *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s: Neo-Realism, Hollywood, New Wave*, ed. Jim Hillier (Harvard University Press, 1985), 212.

59. Angelo Restivo, *The Cinema of Economic Miracles: Visuality and Modernization in the Italian Art Film* (Duke University Press, 2002), 24.

60. Paatashvili, *Polveka u steny Leonardo*, 33.

61. Paatashvili, *Polveka u steny Leonardo*, 34–35.

62. For more on the distribution of films throughout the country, especially to small and far-flung corners, see Eleonory Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die: The Soviet Lives of Western Culture* (Belknap Press of Harvard University Press), chap. 4, esp. 202–6.

63. It is instructive to note that it is a De Santis film that Abuladze and his crew chose to reference and not a Rossellini, for example. Besides being best known to Soviet audiences, De Santis’s films represent the most programmatic streak of neorealism, and one that endorsed a carefully arranged mise-en-scène. As for, specifically, *A Husband for Anna*, French and Italian critics thought this work inferior to earlier films by De Santis.

64. Oleg Kovalov mentions that this film was a love letter to Italian neorealism. See *Noveishaia istoriia otechestvennogo kino* (SEANS, 2001), 35.

65. Boris Zingerman, “Krugozor neorealizma,” *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1958, 152. See chapter 1 of this book.

66. André Bazin, “Cinematic Realism and the Italian School of the Liberation,” in *What Is Cinema?*, trans. Timothy Barnard (Caboose, 2009), 236.

67. Amédée Ayfre, “Neorealism and Phenomenology,” in Hillier, *Cahiers du cinéma, the 1950s*, 185.

68. The extensive loot of international films that the Soviet army brought back from Germany after World War II included a large number of French titles. See note 51 in chapter 1. Among these were films by the key exponents of poetic realism, Marcel Carné and Julien Duvivier, as well as Jean Renoir’s *The Grand Illusion* (1937) and *The Rules of Game* (1939). Anonymous, “Gosfilmofond: Ot rozhdeniia do zrelosti (1948–1970e),” *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 86 (2008): 224. Never destined for the big Soviet screen, these films were very likely shown by VGIK pedagogues to their students.

69. For more on the practice of dubbing, see (in Kazakh film) Peter Rollberg, *The Cinema of Soviet Kazakhstan 1925–1991: An Uneasy Legacy* (Lexington Books, 2021), chap. 4.

70. Steffen, *The Cinema of Sergei Parajanov*, 79.

71. During film festivals, films were often accompanied by live translation with interpreters present in the theater. For more on this practice, see Elena Razlogova, “The Politics of Translation at Soviet Film Festivals During the Cold War,” *Sub-Stance* 137 (2015): 66–87.

72. S. Krasnova, “Otvetsvennyi uchastok kinematografii: O dublirovanii inostrannykh fil’mov” [Crucial sector of cinema: On dubbing of foreign films], *Sovetskoe iskusstvo*, February 9, 1952, 3.

73. See, for example, Krasnova, “Otvetsvennyi uchastok kinematografii”; V. Legoshin, “Iskusstvo dubliazha” [The art of dubbing], *Iskusstvo kino*, July 1953, 100.

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74. Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die*, 180. For a detailed account of the dubbing practices of foreign films in the USSR, see chap. 4, esp. 178–88.

75. Legoshin, “Iskusstvo dubliazha,” 100–101.

76. Italian filmmakers in the postwar years, as is well known, were champions of dubbing. The immediate, extemporaneous, unvarnished quality of early neorealist films was in good measure indebted to the fact that their creators left behind cumbersome sound equipment and used only cameras on location to shoot action. They attended to sound later, in postproduction.

77. Legoshin, “Iskusstvo dubliazha,” 102–3; Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die*, 182–83.

78. Gilburd, *To See Paris and Die*, 183.

79. “Ne govorite dereviannymi golosami!,” *Iskusstvo kino*, September 1962, 82–83.

80. Many Soviet films in Russian that were deemed important were also translated and dubbed in the languages of the republics.

81. Dušan Radunović, “Incommensurable Distance: Versions of National Identity in Georgian Soviet Cinema,” in *Cinema, State Socialism and Society in the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe, 1917–1989: Re-Visions*, ed. S. Bahun and J. Haynes (Routledge, 2014), 50.

82. Antje Ascheid, “Speaking Tongues: Voice Dubbing in the Cinema as Cultural Ventriloquism,” *Velvet Light Trap*, no. 40 (Fall 1997): 33.

83. Ascheid, “Speaking Tongues,” 33.

84. For more on dubbing practices and film translation in general, see Ella Shohat and Robert Stam, “The Cinema After Babel: Language, Difference, Power,” *Screen* 26, no. 3–4 (1985): 35–58.

85. On the practice of self-stereotyping and self-exoticization in the context of Georgian cinema during the Soviet period, see Nino Dzandzava, “Georgian Cinema Studies: Observations, Challenges, and the Colonial Legacy”; on Georgian identity formations throughout history, see Nutsa Batiashvili, “The Liminal: Colonial Identity on the Margins of an Empire,” in *Identities and Representation in Georgia from the 19th Century to the Present*, ed. Hubertus Jahn (De Gruyter, 2021), 39–51.

86. On representation of the Caucasus and its peoples in Russian literature, see Susan Layton, *Russian Literature and Empire: Conquest of the Caucasus from Pushkin to Tolstoy* (Cambridge University Press, 1995).

87. Sergei Gerasimov, “Poddel’noe i podlinnoe,” *Iskusstvo kino*, May 1960, 17. Imitation of neorealism appears to be a not uncommon accusation in the late 1950s and early 1960s.

88. Gerasimov, “Poddel’noe i podlinnoe,” 18.

89. Abuladze and his film may have been hit particularly hard by the establishment also due to the fact that the director praised contemporary Polish cinema in an interview in the Georgian and Russian language newspaper *Zaria Vostoka* at a time when anti-Kremlin protests in Poland rendered Polish cultural products highly suspect. Evgenii Margolit, “Ottepel’ kak dialog,” in *Kinematograf ottepli* (Materik, 1996), 1:122.

90. Neia Zorkaia, “O iasnosti tseli” [About clarity of purpose], *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1959, 37.

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91. In her memoir about growing up in Tbilisi in the mid-twentieth century, critic and film historian Kora Tsereteli describes the Georgian capital in terms of sociality, which was encouraged by the particularities of the architecture: Many old houses had shared balconies where neighbors “lived as one huge family,” including hanging up washing and rugs. See “*Mne Tiflis gorbatyi snitsia . . .*” (*Iskusstvo-XXI vek*, 2017), 34–35.

92. Miron Chernenko, “Problema etnicheskogo kinematografa i ‘kazu’ Parajanova,” *Kinovedcheskie zapiski* 6 (1990): 97.

93. B. Galanov, “Ital’ianskie fil’mi” [Italian films], *Literaturnaia gazeta*, December 12, 1953, 4.

94. V. Karen, “Dva fil’m a v odnom” [Two films in one], *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1959, 28–29; see also Zorkaia, “O iasnosti tseli,” 38.

95. Zorkaia, “Tengiz Abuladze,” 171.

96. After the approval of the literary script by the studio’s artistic council in Moscow, there were seven more stages (ending with the chair of Goskino) through which a film had to pass in order to be allowed to be released. Liana Polukhina, *Inna Gulaia, Gennadii Shpalikov* (Aloritm, 2007), 56.

97. In this respect, the young Georgian characters can be linked to Truffaut’s Antoine Doinel.

Chapter 5. A Space for Experimentation

1. The age of the young heroine in *The Girl and the Echo* is contested and of a delicate nature. Anna Mikonis-Railienė identifies her as being eight years old. However, actress Lina Braknytė would have been twelve during the shooting of the film in the summer of 1964. In the short story, Nagibin does not specify the heroine’s age. When the narrator of the story asks her if she is embarrassed to be sunbathing and swimming naked, she replies, “Mom says that it doesn’t count with small children [*u malen’kikh*]. She doesn’t let me swim in a bathing suit because I can catch cold” (Iu. Nagibin, *Sobranie sochinenii v 4 tomakh* [Khutzhestvennaia literatura, 1980], 1:299).

2. Jonas Gričius graduated from VGIK the same year as Paatashvili and a whole constellation of cinematographers who shot some of the most innovative films of the Soviet Thaw.

3. Žebriūnas’s other films that focus on young protagonists are *The Last Shot* (1960), *Grazuole* (*The Beauty*, 1969), *Naktibalda* (*Nightbird*, 1973), and *Velnio nuotaka* (*Devil’s Bride*, 1974).

4. Anna Mikonis-Railienė, “Poezja, mitologia i ideologia: Obraz dziecka w twórczości filmowej Arūnasa Žebriūnasa,” *Kwartalnik filmowy* 81 (2013): 152.

5. Violeta Davoliūtė, *The Making and Breaking of Soviet Lithuania* (Routledge, 2013), 79.

6. For more on the program of Sovietization of the Baltic states and especially on the methods the Soviet regime used to suppress insurgency in the western frontier lands, see Alexander Statiev, *The Soviet Counterinsurgency in the Western Borderlands* (Cambridge, 2010); on the use of cinema as a tool for conversion, see Violeta Davoliūtė and Lina Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė, “Sovietization and the Cinema in the

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Western Borderlands: Insurgency, Narrative, and Identity in the Lithuanian Film *Marytė* (1947),” *Jahrbücher für Geschichte Osteuropas* 64 (2016).

7. Anna Mikonis-Railienė, “History and Symbols: Lithuanian and Central European Cinema of the 1960s,” *Images: The International Journal of European Film, Performing Arts and Audiovisual Communication* 16, no. 25 (2015): 237.

8. It is unclear whether all films made in the languages of the respective republics and sent to represent the USSR at international festivals would be dubbed into Russian. While widespread and the norm rather than the exception, the dubbing practice might have varied depending on a festival, and it needs to be researched with respect to specific cases. For example, Zdenko Mandušić writes that when Larisa Shepitko’s film *Heat* (1962), made at Kyrgyzfilm Studio with the local talent, was presented at the Karlovy Vary Festival and the Frankfurt Asian Film Week, it was overlaid with a Russian soundtrack. See “Methods of Conquest: Larisa Shepitko’s *Heat*, Soviet Russian Colonialism, and the Representation of the Virgin Lands Campaign in Soviet Cinema of the 1950s–60s,” in *ReFocus: The Films of Larisa Shepitko*, ed. Lida Oukaderova (Edinburgh University Press, 2024), 181. The main body in charge of both purchases of foreign-made films and distribution of the Soviet product was the Association for the Export and Import of Films (Sovexportfilm). A catalog of dubbed films published by Sovexportfilm and targeting foreign markets contains, in addition to Russian-language productions, includes a dozen or so films made by the republican studios in their respective language. While the catalog’s title suggests that the pictures were dubbed, at the back the catalog states, somewhat contradictorily, “Feature films are supplied in the original version in the languages of the peoples of the USSR with or without subtitles in foreign languages. For dubbing feature films abroad, Sovexportfilm supplies a black-and-white dupe negative, a positive print, a magnetic soundtrack, and a positive soundtrack of music and effects” (*Katalog dublirovannykh fil'mov* = *Catalogue of Dubbed Films* = *Catalogue des films disponibles* [Sovexportfilm, 1975?]), 301.

9. Hamid Naficy, *An Accented Cinema: Exilic and Diasporic Filmmaking* (Princeton University Press, 2018), 4.

10. My claim does not dispute the presence of many Lithuanian films at this time with abundant dialogue and conventional narratives; likewise, there were films that displayed innovation while relying on the traditional use of language. I am pointing out a strand of productions whose sparse dialogues place them in a separate category.

11. Statiev, *The Soviet Counterinsurgency*, chaps. 2 and 3.

12. The establishment of the film industry, an incontrovertible marker of progress, was emphasized to be a consequence of Lithuania’s integration into the Soviet Union. See, for example, the article by politician, author, and screenwriter Romas Gudaitis, “Stupeni k novomu,” *Iskusstvo kino*, April 1972, 34.

13. Davoliūtė and Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė, “Sovietization and the Cinema,” 395.

14. Davoliūtė and Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė, “Sovietization and the Cinema,” 392–93. Anna Mikonis-Railienė notes that *Aušra prie Nemuno* (*Near the Nemunas*), a film produced at the Lithuanian studio in 1953, was made by Soviet director Aleksandr Faintsimmer. See Mikonis-Railienė, “History and Symbols,” 234.

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15. Davoliūtė and Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė, “Sovietization and the Cinema,” 395.
16. Claire P. Kaiser, *Georgian and Soviet: Entitled Nationhood and the Specter of Stalin in the Caucasus* (Cornell University Press, 2022), 5.
17. The other western borderland territories that were annexed at the same time by the Soviets at the end of World War II were western Ukraine and western Belarus.
18. Stanley V. Vardys, “The Role of the Baltic Republics in Soviet Society,” in *The Influence of East Europe and the Soviet West on the USSR*, ed. Roman Szporluk (Praeger, 1975), 152.
19. See Vardys, “Role of the Baltic Republics,” 159; Karsten Brüggemann, “An Enemy’s ‘Outpost’ or ‘Our West’? Some Remarks about the Discourse of Russian *Pribaltika* in the Russian Empire and the Soviet Union,” in *Ethnic Images and Stereotypes—Where Is the Border Line? Russian-Baltic Cross-Cultural Relations: Proceedings of the III International Scientific Conference on Political and Cultural Relations Between Russia and the States of the Baltic Region, Narva, October 20–22, 2006*, ed. J. Nõmm (Tartu Ülikooli Narva Kolledž, 2007), 83.
20. Vardys, “Role of the Baltic Republics,” 159.
21. Brüggemann, “An Enemy’s ‘Outpost,’” 83.
22. The phrase “discursive perceptions” is Brüggemann’s, “An Enemy’s ‘Outpost,’” 83. Further, Brüggemann writes: “In essence, Russian rule of the coast of the Baltic Sea in the long run was an important means to prove elementarily that Russia was a European country. . . . [T]he region has always played the role of the ‘bearer of culture’ for Russia” (89). Such a perspective calls into question the imperial dichotomy of the civilized colonizer and the “other” in need of civilizing.
23. These include both features produced for theatrical release and, increasingly in the 1970s and 1980s, films and series made for television. Among the most notable examples are *Adventures of Kalle the Detective* (dir. Arūnas Žebriūnas, 1976), the TV series *An American Tragedy* (dir. Marijonas Giedrys, 1981), *Rich Man, Poor Man* (dir. Arūnas Žebriūnas, 1982), *Chameleon’s Games* (dir. Arūnas Žebriūnas, 1986), all produced at the Lithuanian Film Studio; and *Rafferty* (dir. Semen Aranovich, 1980), which, although produced by Lenfilm, was mostly shot in the Lithuanian resort town of Palanga, which stood for the United States. All of these are based on literary works by Western authors.
24. For more, see Dzmitry Pravatorau, “The Chameleon West: Lithuania as a Set for Soviet Cinema,” *Deep Baltic*, March 17, 2020, <https://deepbaltic.com/2020/03/17/the-chameleon-west-lithuania-as-a-set-for-soviet-cinema/>.
25. Writing decades later about the abandoning of socialist realist narrative conventions and aesthetics, Bolesław Michałek and Frank Turaj stated that in 1956 in Poland, socialist realism was dead, unlike in other Eastern Bloc states, where it continued to linger. See *The Modern Cinema of Poland* (Indiana University Press, 1988), 21.
26. Evgenii Margolit, “Dialog pokolenii,” in *Kinematograf otteperi*, ed. V. Troianovskii (Materik, 1996), 1:122. Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė concur, noting that, in addition to Italian neorealism, Lithuanian students absorbed other cinematic traditions closer to home: Polish and Czech. See Anna Mikonis-Railienė

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and Lina Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje: Sistema, filmai, režisieriai* (Vilniaus dailės akademija, 2015), 555.

27. Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 258.

28. Mikonis-Railienė, “History and Symbols.”

29. Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 142, 260.

30. Mikonis-Railienė, “Poezja, mitologia i ideologia,” 150–51.

31. Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 195–96.

32. Žalakevičius already had under his belt a comedy short, *Kol nevēlu* (*Before It's Too Late*, 1957), and a feature, *Adomas nori būti žmogumi* (*Adam Wants to Be a Man*, 1959), by the time he embarked on *The Living Heroes*. The cinematographers that lensed the shorts—Donatas Pečiūra, Robertas Verba, Algirdas Araminas, Viktoras Kriaunevičius, and Algimantas Mockus—were all of the new generation of Lithuanian filmmakers.

33. The four chapters that comprise *The Living Heroes* are *Mums nebereikia* (*We No Longer Need*, dir. Marijonas Giedrys), *Lakštingala* (*Nightingale*, dir. Balys Bratkauskas), *Paskutinis šūvis* (*The Last Shot*, dir. Arūnas Žebriūnas), and *Gyvieji didvyriai* (*The Living Heroes*, dir. Vytautas Žalakevičius).

34. For details on the history of the production and reception of *The Living Heroes*, see Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, esp. 193–203.

35. Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 196.

36. G. Kapralov, “Masshtabom epokhi,” in *Molodye rezhissery sovetskogo kino*, ed. E. Dobin et al. (Iskusstvo, 1962), 12.

37. For instance, see the Russian critic Vera Shitova in “Kino, kotoroe est’,” *Iskusstvo kino*, August 1965, 37. Raimondas Vabalas, a young director at the start of his career, said in an interview, “With the appearance of *The Living Heroes*, the new Lithuanian cinema began” (Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 186).

38. In 1965 Vytautas Žalakevičius, who by then had become the artistic director of the Lithuanian Film Studio, produced *Niekas nenorėjo mirti* (*Nobody Wanted to Die*), perhaps the most famous film that focuses on the same themes and period of Lithuanian history. The film garnered international success.

39. According to Alexander Statiev’s research, while urban intellectuals comprised a sizable portion of the resistance movement, the vast majority of guerrilla fighters were farmers (*The Soviet Counterinsurgency*, 98–99). For more on the social profile of various resistance groups in the Baltic states, see Statiev’s chapter 4.

40. Davoliūtė, *The Making and Breaking*, 39–47; Statiev, *The Soviet Counterinsurgency*. In Lithuania, guerrilla war lasted the longest in comparison with its neighbors Estonia and Latvia.

41. In the contemporary Soviet film press, the partisan fighter was referred to as a bandit. See, for example, Shitova, “Kino, kotoroe est’.”

42. Statiev points out: “The Communists always claimed that ‘kulaks are the social basis of nationalist resistance and its armed bands,’ whereas Western scholars typically stated that ‘the poorer population strata were better represented among the partisans than the rich.’ However, the reality on the ground was much more

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complex. In Lithuania, only 6.4 percent of farmers were qualified as *kulaks* by the Communists, and yet Lithuania saw the strongest anti-Soviet resistance than its neighboring Estonia and Latvia that counted substantially more well-to-do peasants” (*The Soviet Counterinsurgency*, 99–100).

43. Shitova, “Kino, kotoroe est’,” 43.

44. Davoliūtė and Kaminskaitė-Jančorienė, “Sovietization and the Cinema,” 405.

45. Tarkovsky’s *Ivan’s Childhood*, made three years later, bears some aesthetic similarities to *The Last Shot* as well as another short in the anthology, *Nightingale*, based on the short story by Lithuanian writer Petras Cvirka. But, to use Dina Iordanova’s phrase, “Not all roads lead to Tarkovsky.” Ana Hedberg Olenina, “Imposed Provincialism: Recovering Ukrainian Cinema from the Shadows of Russo-Centric Frameworks: An Interview with Dina Iordanova,” *Slavic & East European Journal* 68, no. 3 (2024): 294. These Lithuanian films should be incorporated in the larger history of European cinema and considered alongside such films as *The White Dove* (*Holubice*, dir. František Vlácil, 1960, Czechoslovakia), *Valerie and Her Week of Wonders* (*Valerie a týden divů*, dir. Jaromil Jireš, 1970, Czechoslovakia), and *Silence* (*Milczenie*, dir. Kazimierz Kutz, 1963, Poland), among others.

46. Marek Haltof refers to two generations comprising the Polish School: the first includes filmmakers like Andrzej Munk, Andrzej Wajda, Jerzy Kawalerowicz, Kazimierz Kutz, and Wojciech Has, who were concerned with politics and national history, World War II in particular; among the key figures of the second generation are Roman Polański, Jerzy Skolimowski, and Krzysztof Zanussi, who are “preoccupied with reality, skeptical about the world, suspicious of the national romantic tradition, and interested in personal cinema.” Marek Haltof, *Polish National Cinema* (Berghahn Books, 2002), 125.

47. Bolesław Michałek, “The Polish Drama,” *Sight and Sound* 29, no. 4 (1960): 198.

48. Michałek, “The Polish Drama,” 198.

49. Mikonis-Railienė, “Poezja, mitologia i ideologia,” 152.

50. See, for example, “Zakliuchenie stsenarno-redaktsionnoi kollegii o stsenarii A. Chernenko i A. Zhebrunasa ‘Ekho na asfal’te,’” typescript, March 14, 1964, RGALI, f. 2944, op. 4, d. 318, l. 1.

51. Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 265. Prior to a film’s release, Goskino assigned a category to each film that was usually based on its artistic and ideological quality. Very often it was easy to predict, depending on the director, which category a film would be assigned. For much of the existence of the Soviet cinema industry, there were four categories: the highest, first, second, and third. The number of prints made depended on the category, with the highest receiving the most prints and with the third receiving the fewest. See V. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii: Upravlenie, kinoproizvodstvo, prokat,” manuscript, June 1, 2012, 1215–16, <https://culture.gov.ru/documents/istoriya-kinootrasli-v-rossii-upravlenie-kinoproizvodstvo-prokat/>.

52. Iurii Nagibin, “Iz zapisok stsenarista,” *Iskusstvo kino*, January 1967, 31.

53. “Zakliuchenie stsenarno-redaktsionnoi kollegii Glavnogo upravleniia khudozhestvennoi kinematografii po literaturnomu stsenariiu ‘Ekho’/avtory A. Chernenko

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i A. Zhebriunas,” typescript, March 28, 1964, RGALI, f. 2944, op. 4, d. 318, l. 16. See also Mikonis-Railienė and Kaminskaitė-Jačorienė, *Kinas sovietų Lietuvoje*, 264–65.

54. Lida Oukaderova, *The Cinema of the Soviet Thaw: Space, Materiality, Movement* (Indiana University Press, 2017), 49–85.

55. Oukaderova, *The Cinema of the Soviet Thaw*, 63.

56. The film shoot took place near the town of Köktöbel, which in Crimean Tatar means “the land of the blue hills.” The Devil’s Finger is part of the Kara Dag (or Karadag) Nature Preserve. Kara dag, or Qara dag in Crimean Tatar, means “black mountain.”

57. “Zakliuchenie stsenarno-redaktsionnoi kollegii o stsenarii A. Cherchenko i A. Zhebriunasa,” l. 1.

58. Constantin Parvulescu, *Orphans of the East: Postwar Eastern European Cinema and the Revolutionary Subject* (Indiana University Press, 2015), 5.

59. I thank Elizabeth Papazian for bringing *You Are Not an Orphan* to my attention.

60. This assertion, however, might apply to other Soviet films of sincerity that feature unsupervised or barely supervised children, for example, Khutsiev’s *Two Fyodors* (1958), Revaz Chkheidze’s *In Our Courtyard* (1956), and, to an extent, Abuladze’s *Me, Grandma, Iliko, and Illarioni* (1962).

61. Helena Goscilo, “The Thorny Thicket of ‘Children’s Literature,’” *Russian Review* 73 (July 2014): 541.

62. Herbert Read, “The Cult of Sincerity,” *Hudson Review* 21, no. 1 (Spring 1968): 53.

Coda

1. Evgeny Margolit notes that *Ilyich’s Gate* is the last utopian film of Soviet cinema. See “Peizazh s geroem,” in *Kinematograf ottepeli* (Materik, 1996), 1113.

2. S. Muratov, “Pristrastnaia kamera,” *Iskusstvo kino*, June 1966, 110.

3. Siegfried Kracauer, *Theory of Film: The Redemption of Physical Reality* (Oxford University Press, 1965), 71.

4. Evgenii Margolit, “Proshchanie s ‘ukhodiashchei naturoi,” in *Kinematograf ottepeli, kniga vtoraiia*, ed. V. Troianovskii (Materik, 2002), 214.

5. Elizabeth Papazian, “Ethnography, Incongruity, History: Soviet Poetic Cinema,” *Russian Review* 82, no. 1 (January 2023): 2.

6. Papazian, “Ethnography, Incongruity, History,” 3.

7. Ernst van Alphen and Mieke Bal, eds., *The Rhetoric of Sincerity* (Stanford University Press, 2008), 5.

8. Angela Esterhammer, “The Scandal of Sincerity: Wordsworth, Byron, Landon,” in *Romanticism, Sincerity and Authenticity*, ed. Tim Milnes and Kerry Sinanan (Palgrave Macmillan, 2010), 102.

9. V. Fomin et al., “Istoriia kinootrasli v Rossii: Upravlenie, kinoproizvodstvo, prokat,” manuscript, June 1, 2012, 1192, <https://culture.gov.ru/documents/istoriya-kinootrasli-v-rossii-upravlenie-kinoproizvodstvo-prokat/>.

10. V. Fomin, ed., *Kinematograf ottepeli: Dokumenty i svedel’sstva* (Materik, 1998), 94–99.

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11. V. Fomin, *Kino i vlast': Sovetskoe kino, 1965–1985 gody: Dokumenty, svidetel'stva, razmysleniia* (Materik, 1996), 11–12.

12. Nearly all of these films ran afoul of censorship.

13. Mikhail Iampolski, "Cinema Without Cinema," in *Russian Critics on the Cinema of Glasnost* (Cambridge University Press, 1994), 13.

14. On Kira Muratova's film and her status as an outsider filmmaker in the Soviet industry, see Jane Taubman, *Kira Muratova* (I.B. Tauris, 2005); Eugénie Zvonkine, *Kira Mouratova: Un cinéma de la dissonance* (L'Âge d'Homme, 2012); Mikhail Iampolski, *Muratova: Opyt kinoantropologii* (Seans, 2008). The film had a difficult production history and an even more arduous path to the screen. The film was banned for sixteen years, although VGIK students were able to watch it surreptitiously, thanks to their professors. For more on the history of the film's production and censorship, see Taubman, *Kira Muratova*, 21–26.

15. Helen Ferguson, "Silence and Shrieks: Language in Three Films by Kira Muratova," *Slavonic and East European Review* 83, no. 1 (January 2005): 40.

16. For Zvonkine's development of the concept of cinematic dissonance, see her *Kira Mouratova*, esp. pt. 2.

17. Eugénie Zvonkine, "The Unfinished Gesture: Kira Muratova's *Long Farewells* (*Dolgie provody*, 1971)," *East European Film Bulletin* 98 (October 2019), <https://eefb.org/retrospectives/kira-muratovas-long-farewells-dolgie-provody-1971/>.

18. Zvonkine, "The Unfinished Gesture."

19. Ferguson, "Silence and Shrieks," 57. On the haptic and embodied aspects of Muratova's cinema, see Emma Widdis, "Muratova's Clothes, Muratova's Textures, Muratova's Skin," *KinoKultura* 8 (April 2005), www.kinokultura.com/articles/apros-widdis.html; Irina Schulzki, "Touch and Sight in the Films of Kira Muratova: Towards the Notion of a Cinema of Gesture," *Frames Cinema Journal* 18 (June 2021), <https://vimeo.com/manage/videos/566789380>.

20. The boy belongs to the multitude of "minor" characters that populate Muratova's films.

21. This particular scene presages a later one at home, during which Sasha projects on the wall slides of birds and plants.

22. Lilya Kaganovsky refers to instances of repetition in the Muratova corpus as "stutter" that occurs "at the level of the film body" ("Dysphonia as an Art Practice," paper presented at the Conference on Cinema & Poetry at the University of Maryland, College Park, April 21–22, 2022).

23. Ferguson remarks that Evgenia "as a translator . . . is merely a mouthpiece for an absent other while she herself is effectively silent; she does not form the ideas which she helps to express" ("Silence and Shrieks," 42).

24. Mart Domincus and Mark-Paul Meyer, "I Embrace Every Coincidence," a conversation with Kira Muratova, 1988, trans. Veva Leye, accessed November 23, 2024, <https://sabzian.be/text/%E2%80%99Ci-embrace-every-coincidence%E2%80%9D>.

25. Van Leeuwen quoted in Michael Frierson, *Film & Video Editing Theory: How Editing Creates Meaning* (Routledge, 2018), 263.

26. This approach to editing diverges from Eisenstein's associative montage or from Alain Resnais's editing operations in *Hiroshima mon amour*, which likewise

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relies on associative montage, which this time includes the soundtrack. Kaganovsky writes that “Muratova’s cinema as a whole is a cinema of stutter—the meaningless noise, sound produced without and against intentionality—no longer a homogeneous system in equilibrium, but a cinema that vibrates, that refuses to stand still to allow itself to be fully grasped and understood” (“Dysphonia as an Art Practice”).

27. Viktor Bozhovich, “Rentgenoscopia dushi,” *Iskusstvo kino*, September 1987, 61.

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